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Web Novel
Volume



Re:ゼロ

Re: Life in a different world from zero

から始める異世界生活

Manifesto

Hello, this is Phantaminum. This is a continuation of a project that aims to standardize nomenclature and formatting, while dividing Web Novel chapters in the same way the Light Novel does. Colored illustrations have also been added where possible for maximum enjoyment. You may find a list of all volumes I have already finished, or plan to work on, at the [final chapter of this document](#).

This document is a compilation of Re: Zero Web Novel chapters that correspond to Volume 29, spanning Web Novel Arc 7 Chapters 40 to 54. Witch Cult Translations ([website](#)), was used as a source of the translations for all the Chapters. Chapters 40 to 46, and 48 to 54 were produced with use of Machine Translation tools.

For the sake of completeness, I leave you with the same wall of text detailing what I did using the available translations. Feel free to skip it if you don't care/have already read it.

The original translations have been proofread, edited and reformatted by myself, on top of whatever original editing and proofreading work was done by Witch Cult Translations. This means that the formatting should remain consistent no matter which source is used.

I have tried to follow naming conventions present in the Light Novel as much as possible, only diverging when community-given names differed greatly. I have also tried to conserve as many of the original translator notes by Witch Cult Translations as much as possible.

As a fun quirk, I have done something which I admit is probably not consensual: to flip the languages whenever someone speaks what is colloquially coined as Engrish. This means, that in the case where the story uses English, where possible, Japanese will be written as Romaji (Japanese in Latin script). When this happens, a note was added with the original expression (and its translation), and the new expression that was converted to Romaji. Basically, I made everyone using Engrish look like weeaboos.

I hope you enjoy this as much as I did. If you have anything to point out, I'm often lurking in pretty much every Re: Zero discussion site, be it the Reddit Discord Server, the Subreddit, or 4chan's /a/ board. Alternatively, feel free to use [this document](#) to suggest corrections or other changes.

P.S.: Much thanks to Joy Kirbs from Discord for aiding me in redesigning the covers.

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Arc 7 Chapter 40 - *Natchuki Subawu*

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 29, Chapter 1 “Beast of Ambition”, Part 1

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Edited Machine Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Original by Goldkills, Translation checked by Averitius, MaskedBook, PaperKaminari) — [Complete](#)

Subaru: “———”

Subaru’s throat froze upon regarding his own face reflected in the mirror.

It was a face he recognized, but a face he felt reluctant to say he was used to seeing— which came as no surprise, as his face reflected in the mirror was a relic of the past, no more than a fading memory.

—For that which was reflected there, was the face of a young Natsuki Subaru.

Subaru: “What, is, this...”

The hand grasping the mirror trembled, the pale face of the young boy rocking minutely and repeatedly.

His other hand, the one not holding the mirror, reached for his face as if to check it, and fingers that were smaller than those in his recollections, ones befitting the young face, came into view through the mirror.

Judging from the facial features and height, that was a roughly ten-years-old Natsuki Subaru.

Subaru was a mischievous boy whose stature was slightly over average, having reached the average height for a Japanese person only once his limbs had fully developed; with certainty, he had been a pipsqueak back then, at the time of elementary school.

To speak of his perspective at the time, he had wished to grow up as fast as he could—

Subaru: “What the hell is this— Hk!?”

In the mirror, his lips and eyes appeared to shake, and not just because his hands were trembling.

It was also a clear sign that his soul was rejecting the abnormal situation reflected in his eyes.

It was a sight worth being dubbed a nightmare.

Were this simply “rejuvenation”, then more than a few people who dreamed of such a thing existed. Unfortunately, Subaru, as a flowering teenager, had nothing to do with such desires.

Even if it was a great wish of his, however, he would probably attach the condition that he wants to choose the right time and place.

That was how absurd this state of emergency was.

Subaru: “I-I can’t stay like this... Hk.”

After a long time, Subaru came to himself and rushed to his bedroom door.

By no means would the inn’s lodgings have a perk such as “rejuvenation”. It was natural to think that this was an attack from someone hostile.

He had to hurry and share the information with his friends staying at the same inn, to come up with a plan to overcome this obstacle—

Subaru: “Guys, we’re in trouble! You may be surprised by the suddenness of this...”

???: “Oh, I knew it, Subaru-chin got smaller too!”

Subaru: “Wha?”

The moment he twisted the doorknob, which felt as if it were higher and heavier than usual, and opened the door with great force, he was greeted by an unexpected sight— Nay, it was a sight he should have expected.

Outside his bedroom, in the living room where several people had gathered, Subaru was greeted by a girl with a lovely face and a cheerful smile, waving her hand.

Her clear blue eyes and golden hair with its characteristic weave— her unmistakable sunny clarity allowed Subaru to connect the girl to the woman in his recollections.

Subaru: “M-Medium-san...?”

Medium: “That’s right~! When I woke up, I was so surprised to see how tiny I was! But I’m relieved to see Subaru-chin’s tiny too. Buddies, buddies!”

The one who spoke these words with her hands in the air in jubilation, was a girl of about twelve or thirteen years of age, wearing a thin cloth wrapped around her bare skin— she had declared herself to be Medium O’Connell.

Albeit she was quite tall for a woman, having been caught up by the same phenomenon as Subaru, her size had shrunk considerably. However, she was still half a head taller than the shrunken Subaru. Anyhow—

Subaru: “Not a situation in which you can simply be happy that you’ve found a buddy... Uwah!?”

???: “Uuk!”

As Subaru tried to swallow his initial shock, his body was blown away by an impact to his side, and someone pressed down on his upturned chest.

At the feeling of pressure, Subaru unconsciously raised a shriek like that of a squashed frog.

Medium: “Ahh! Louis-chan, you can’t do that! Because Subaru-chin’s so tiny!”

Louis: “Aa, uu!”

Medium: “Kya! I can’t lift Louis-chan because I’m too tiny~.”

Medium desperately tried to pull away the fierce beast flailing on Subaru’s chest. However, her shrunken arms were not enough to stop the savagery of this evil and tyrannical being.

With that, the young Natsuki Subaru was about to be laid waste to, with no way to do anything about it—

???: “Louis, *don’t*! Subaru’s going to be *crushed*!”

Louis: “Aahk.”

Along with a sharp reprimanding voice, the heavy monster on his chest was removed. When he looked, Louis, now away from Subaru laying on his back, for some reason had a sad look on her face.

The one to put her hands under Louis’s armpits and lift her up was Taritta— her appearance, with her blue-dyed black hair, was no different from what Subaru knew.

Medium: “Haa~, Taritta-chan, thanks! I wasn’t strong enough~.”

Taritta: “*N-no*, it wasn’t *much*... Subaru, are you *okay*?”

Subaru: “Oh, yeah, you saved me... I’m so glad you’re the same, Taritta-san. And...”

He took the hand that Medium offered him and raised himself up, then looked at the back of the room.

There, sitting on the sofa, silently observing the flurry of events that had just taken place, was the dark-haired man whose face was covered by an oni mask— Abel.

Subaru was relieved to see him unchanged, but he also had a few thoughts on how he had not tried to help at all.

Subaru: “Nothing happened to Abel...”

His appearance, the fact that he was hiding his face included, had not changed since yesterday.

Whether it should be called a blessing or not could not be gauged at this point.

However, the fact that Abel, whose face he could not see, did not welcome this situation could be seen from the displeased air that came through the oni mask without a hitch.

In fact, as proof of his unsettled state of mind, he turned his gaze to Subaru and said,

Abel: “This is a disgrace.”

And with a mere sentence, he was able to disregard the situation.

Subaru: "...I think I'm rather cute and charming."

Having received a blunt remark, Subaru's gut reaction was to spit out a retort. However, Subaru himself knew very well that this was nothing more than a sarcastic remark.

The abnormal situation that had befallen him and Medium, which did not seem to affect Abel, Taritta, and Louis—

Subaru: "If that's the case, the other one's..."

???: "—Oh, I'm glad you're paying attention, bro. I was afraid you'd forgotten about me."

Subaru: "—Hk!"

Just as Subaru was wondering about the last of his companions staying at the inn, the answer was presented to him.

Eyes wide open, Subaru turned around to see a dark-haired figure in front of him, one that had come out of another bedroom. He was a boy around the same age as Subaru, around ten years old— his strange appearance was quite eye-catching.

After all, the boy was wearing a suitably torn cloth wrapped around his face, as to hide his appearance.

Subaru: "Al, right...? What's with the covering?"

Al: "...My helmet doesn't fit anymore. The only thing I could think of was to wrap a cloth around my head instead. Don't mind it too much."

Subaru: "Even if you tell me not to mind it, it's going to be on my mind..."

Then the young Al, his face hidden, waved his right hand at Subaru.

Because less was covered compared to the helmet he usually wore, his tied black hair, habitually hidden, was exposed. It reminded Subaru of the way Abel used to conceal his face with a piece of cloth before sporting the oni mask, but the way Al had wrapped his was looser.

He looked just like a cheap-looking killer in a movie.

Subaru: "...I know you can't wear your helmet, but do you have to cover your face?"

Al: "Oh, that's a statement without *mehashi*¹, bro. I ain't wearing the helmet for style or as a whim, but as the manifestation of a *rettoukan*². Even if I'm now a child in appearance with the intellect of an adult, it doesn't make it any less real— It ain't like my arm's grown back. That means the scars on my face haven't disappeared either. It's the same for you bro, right?"

Subaru: "That's..."

As Al said this, he showed his left arm— which was unchanged, his upper arm still in a state of having been lopped off, proving that Al's perception of the current situation was correct.

Those three people, made up of Subaru and Al, as well as Medium, were unintentionally rejuvenated. It was not that time had rewound; however, it was a clear change in their bodies.

Subaru: "——"

In response to Al's words, Subaru also flipped up his own loose-fitting shirt, and confirmed that the old scars all over his body had not vanished. His small child body was covered with all sorts of scars that made him want to look away— The years he had spent in this other world had not disappeared.

He had never really thought that there would be a day when he would be relieved by the existence of those scars.

Despite that, the scars had taught him something. That this was a situation in which his limbs had simply shrunk. However—

Al: "A misfortunate destiny such as having our limbs shrunken doesn't just happen at random."

Medium: "Right-. Hmm, this might mean I'm not gonna be able to help big bro with his work. He's way too weak, so this is a big problem!"

Subaru: "It's definitely true that it's a big blow to the O'Connell siblings' business, but..."

¹ English flip. Means "tact/sensitivity" (目端), originally "デリカシー" (delicacy).

² English flip. Means "inferiority complex" (劣等感), originally "コンプレックス" (complex).

It spelt trouble for long-term business plans for sure, however there was certainly also a heap of troubles short-term.

Currently, Subaru's problem was that, due to him being misshapen, he did not have any clothes that fit. Such was not the case for Al and Medium, though.

Subaru: "Al, you mentioned that your helmet doesn't fit, what about your weapons?"

Al: "Good catch. I can't wield one with my cute lil' arm."

Medium: "It might be hard for me to hold both of them. But I should be able to manage one... Ah!"

Subaru: "Watch it!"

Medium drew one of her twin swords from the scabbards at her side, but the blade slipped through her grip and nearly sliced Subaru's knee.

Albeit barely, the tip of the blade almost grazed Subaru then stabbed into the floor, bringing him horror.

Medium: "Wow, Subaru-chin, I'm sorry..."

Subaru: "I-it didn't cut me, so... but that's pretty bad."

With a sullen sigh, Medium pulled out the stuck sword and carefully put it back in its sheath.

The weapons she had been able to use so freely just the previous day were now in a wholly unusable state. To Medium, whose expected active role was that of a fighter, this was a crisis that shook her to her core.

The same could be said for Al, though not in terms of his military prowess.

Subaru: "This means that Taritta-san's the only one with any legitimate fighting strength at the moment, right?"

Medium: "What? I'll do my best even if I'm small, you know!?"

Subaru: "I appreciate the spirit, but you don't meet the labor standards..."

Medium's undampened attitude was nice, but a realistic view of the situation was also required.

With both Al and Medium in this state, the only one able to fight properly was Taritta— And even if she was assured of her abilities, it would be a lonely endeavor amidst enemy territory.

Taritta: "It's only *me*...?"

In fact, Taritta was evidently accepting the pressure herself.

The reason for this was that the roles that would otherwise have been shared could no longer be divided, and must now be carried on her two shoulders.

He felt guilty to her for that, but—

Subaru: "It's going to be quite a burden. But what do we do from here? It seems like they'd have eyes on us, but should we escape from Chaosflame?"

Al: "...So, you think it was that sexy lady castle owner who did this, bro?"

Subaru: "The three of us were the only ones affected."

Having been asked that by Al, Subaru quietly nodded his head.

It went without saying that Subaru, Al, and Medium had a single thing in common: all of them had gone to the Crimson Lapis Castle as messengers the previous day. That being the case, it was perfectly legitimate to suspect Yorna's involvement in the circumstances of their shrunken limbs.

Abel: "It seems that you are not as distraught as I had expected."

Abel, who had been quietly ruminating about the contents of Subaru and Al's conversation, interrupted them.

Sure, Subaru had been quite distraught right after waking up, but now that he had run into Al and Medium in the same situation, his agitation had lessened considerably.

In a way, it was possible to say that "buddies", as Medium had put it, truly existed. And yet—

Subaru: “Perhaps I just missed the *ari*³ to be surprised and panicked. Maybe after I find more inconvenient things with this body then I’ll realize the importance of my lost height and weight.”

Abel: “Even though you have shrunk, you are a man who always feels the need to talk.”

Subaru: “Adaptability and cleverness are two of my few selling points, that’s why.”

He was being increasingly scorned for ceaseless chatter, but Subaru still retorted without regard. Sure enough, Abel’s gaze from behind the oni mask became sharper, and he muttered with visible exasperation, “You talk too much”.

However, he did not stop at that, and resumed his words.

Abel: “You can discard your suspicions about Yorna Mishigure. Your transformations differ from the principle of the techniques employed by that thing.”

Subaru: “Are you sure...?”

Abel: “As far as I can surmise, yes. It is up to you to decide whether this is worth believing.”

Abel directly denied the suspicions held by Subaru just before.

However, it seemed that the basis for this denial lay only within Abel. Subaru’s mouth curved in frustration as he was told that he was free to decide whether it was to be trusted or not.

Despite this, it did not take him long to mull it over.

Subaru: “—I understand. But if it wasn’t Yorna, then who was it?”

Abel: “Perhaps it was Olbart Dunkelkenn who caused it.”

Subaru: “Olbart... That old man from yesterday?!”

Abel mentioned the name of the architect of this situation to Subaru, who, swallowing his dissatisfaction, placed trust in his speculation.

³ English flip. Means “opportunity” (折), originally “タイミング” (timing).

What had come from his mouth, was the name of the false Emperor's companion they had run into at the Crimson Lapis Castle the previous day, a diminutive old man who was said to be one of the Nine Divine Generals.

Among the Empire's strongest and labelled a General First-Class, he was a person who had been bestowed with the third rank from the top. Naturally, Subaru had anticipated him to be a man possessing might which was not to be taken as trivial, but—

Subaru: "I didn't expect him to be such a freaky person who can bring about such nonsensical situations..."

Abel: "I know not the depths of his abilities. But you cannot deny what has happened... There are other possibilities aside from Olbart when it comes to forging one's external appearance."

Subaru: "...Unfortunately, it doesn't look like a hallucination or anything."

He had already tried pinching his cheeks and waking up from what seemed like a dream.

The possibility that magic or drugs were messing with his perception and making him hallucinate was null. The fact that his arms and legs were actually short, and that he had been unable to push back against Louis's strength and weight, posed as pretty good evidence.

The physical effects on the body, such as the size of Subaru's clothing and Al's helmet, could not be overlooked.

Abel was probably also regarding it as unlikely. As he had not made any special effort to object to Subaru's insistence that it had an actual, real effect.

Subaru: "First of all, it's good that we don't have to run away with our tails between our legs... How troublesome. Even the Emperor, Abel, doesn't know how that old man fights? Who the hell is he?"

Abel: "He is the head of a group called the *shinobi*, who are masters of peculiar techniques."

Subaru: "*Shinobi*... A *ninja*?"

Abel: "—What is that?"

Abel questioned Subaru while raising his eyebrows, the latter having blurted something out unintentionally.

When one heard of the word “*shinobi*”, their first reflex would be to think of “*ninja*”, which had the same meaning. However, it appeared that the latter word sounded new or strange to Abel.

But to Subaru, much like when he had first learned about Kararagi dialect and Wafuu-style architecture, he thought it seemed to be knowledge of the world Subaru knew, or felt like a slight remnant of it.

Subaru: “These *shinobi*, do they use *ninjutsu*, or do they go undercover in the darkness of night to spy on or assassinate people?”

Abel: “I have never heard of *ninjutsu*, but you understand the main function of the *shinobi*... That too, is not supposed to be information that reaches the public easily.”

Subaru: “There’s something similar in my homeland, they’re called *ninjas*. Right, Al?”

Al: “Hmm? Yeah, right. They’re a quartet of turtles with a great sense of humor.”

Perhaps he felt the same tug as Subaru, but Al’s answer was a bit off the mark as Subaru thought about it. They were characters from a popular cartoon of yesteryear, though Subaru did not dislike them⁴.

Anyway, even if he explained the details, Abel would not comprehend it; and it seemed the latter viewed it as a pointless topic to delve into as he did not make any attempt to ask him about the details.

Instead, Medium let out a “Oh!” with her big eyes open wide,

Medium: “If it was that Gramps of yesterday who did it, it could be that! You know, when we escaped from the Castle...”

Subaru: “When we escaped...? Ah.”

⁴ Translation note from Witch Cult Translations: “Teenage Mutant *Ninja* Turtles reference.”

Medium: “When me and you were both struck in the chest!”

Medium’s cry was a bit misleading, but Subaru had an inkling of what was up.

It had come to pass the previous day, during their escape from the Crimson Lapis Castle— in the middle of the life-threatening battle to fulfill Yorna’s nasty conditions.

Subaru and his group had escaped from the false Emperor’s bodyguard Kafma’s thorns, and broken through the walls of the castle in an attempt to escape, only for each of them to be pierced by the blow of the pursuing Olbart.

However, that Divine General’s attack had not caused any damage to Subaru’s group.

—At that time, that had gone alright. But it could not have been harmless.

Subaru: “That said, it’s normal that something like this couldn’t have been predicted...! I mean, that explains me and Medium-san, but Al? Why did you shrink?”

Al: “Sorry, bro. I had a few run-ins with the old man before I jumped out. It wouldn’t be surprising if he’d hit me at some point. I figured that if the wound didn’t kill me, it’d be a no-count⁵.”

In a low tone— or, at least, in as much of a low tone as a boy whose voice had yet to drop could muster, Al blamed himself for his lapse with a grumble.

But it was wrong for Al to blame himself. Al had done his part and allowed Subaru and Medium to survive in that desperate situation. The same can be said for Medium.

So, it was Subaru who should have known.

If he could not be of use in a battle, he should have been aware of every eventuality.

The result of failing to do so was this “disgrace”, as Abel had said.

⁵ Translation note from Witch Cult Translations: “The loanword employed by Al here is commonly used in sports, when a point is disallowed/not counted.”

Subaru: "I can't let Rem see me like this... If I'm the same size as Beako, Emilia will treat me like I'm younger than she is even more."

Al: "Even if I've been shrunken down, I don't think it likely that the Princess'll treat me affectionately like she does Schult-chan, so I wonder who benefits from this development."

Taritta: "I'm surprised that everyone is so *calm*... I'm still *confused*..."

A pale Taritta revealed her innermost thoughts, as Subaru and Al discussed their shrunken bodies.

With Louis flopping in her arms, Taritta's bewilderment was palpable, due to being the sole remaining fighting force. It was almost as if she felt guilty for having escaped harm.

Of course, Taritta was the one who was physically and mentally normal in this situation.

Subaru: "Honestly, I feel like I'd start screaming if I didn't joke about it a bit."

Taritta: "I-is that so?"

Subaru: "Yeah... It's that revolting."

It was not his young body.

His own body had been unintentionally remade. The disintegration of the definition of the self was sickening.

Subaru: "———"

Subaru was rather proud of himself for having faced a variety of experiences in this other world thus far.

Although the experience of death was the most extreme, it was quite possible to say that the dense experiences of the past year and a half were incomparably richer in color, taste, and density than that of an ordinary person.

Compared to any of these experiences, the inexpressible disgust that came with the feeling of being remade stuck out.

Subaru: “This is what it feels like, to be one of Lust’s victims...”

The sound of wings echoed in Subaru’s mind as he hugged his thin, small shoulders and clenched his teeth.

It was the sound of the wings of those who had fallen victim to the Authority of the Sin Archbishop of Lust in the Watergate City—the memory of the victims whose bodies had been morphed into that of flies, and were still waiting to be saved.

The tragedy of these people, who had been transformed into something else, easily transcended Subaru’s flimsy understanding of their situation.

The very act that had compelled such a sensation was—

Abel: “—Vicious, I would state.”

With arms crossed, Abel accurately guessed Subaru’s innermost thoughts, causing the latter’s breathing to hitch.

Meeting Subaru’s unsteady gaze with his own,

Abel: “Olbart’s nickname is Vicious Old Man... And as befits his name, he makes use of the *shinobi* arts to carry out all kinds of special tasks, vicious and otherwise.”

Al: “Special operations, huh? So does he get ridiculous requests like go make the target into a baby?”

Abel: “What kind of absurd instructions are those? —But witnessing this disastrous scene, I would guess that would not be impossible.”

Al: “———”

Abel’s response to Al, however, had a weight to it that could not be laughed off as a joke.

As a matter of fact, since Subaru, Al, and Medium were made this young, it was impossible to even guess the capabilities of Olbart’s techniques, and their extent.

And with that as their grasp of the situation, the thing that made them most anxious at the moment would be—

Subaru: “This can be undone, right...?”

Abel: “I cannot state with certainty, but I believe it reasonable to assume a way to return you to normal exists.”

Subaru: “W-what makes you say that?”

Abel: “The only pretext for poisoning someone and not have them die immediately, is to negotiate with them.”

Hearing Abel’s speculation and their justification, Subaru was also convinced with no further words.

This phenomenon— which may be called “infantilization” for the sake of convenience, could be likened to the act of poisoning, and the other party’s intention would be to avoid immediate death.

This was a strategy to extract some kind of concession.

Taritta: “*Then*, if there’s some kind of contact from the other *party*...”

Abel: “I shall reiterate. I cannot state it with certainty. But—”

Abel looked over at Taritta, who was holding her breath, and said that her high hopes were poisonous. And just as Abel was about to resume speaking.

—From outside, there was a knock on the door of the room.

Subaru: “—Hk.”

Because of the previous conversation, everyone’s attention and tension turned to the door.

Subaru also stiffened, thinking of it as a possible sign of contact from Olbart, who had brought about the “infantilization”. However—

???: “—My apologies for disturbing you this morning. I am Yorna Mishigure-sama’s messenger.”

The voice that came through the door was a disappointing one at this point in time.

That disappointment was the reason as to why the tension that had been building up loosened at a sluggish pace. On the other hand, Subaru belatedly understood that a messenger from Yorna signified a reply to yesterday's letter.

In addition to that, he also noticed the owner of the voice bringing the reply.

Medium: "This voice's that of the deergirl from yesterday, isn't it? See, it's Tanza-chan."

Subaru: "Looks like it. Good. Then I can let her come in... right?"

With a nod to Medium, who held up a finger, Subaru asked Abel if he wanted her to enter the room. At Subaru's gaze, Abel paused for a moment, then nodded slowly.

Having received this cue, Subaru turned to go to the door and greet his visitor.

Taritta: "*No, I will.*"

Interrupting Subaru, Taritta took the initiative and stepped forth. She left Louis in Medium's hands and ushered Subaru and the others back, away from the door.

As far as this matter was concerned, it must be said that Subaru was the one who lacked a sense of danger. Even if it had not passed his mind, he could not just open the door devoid of any protection.

And currently, the shrunken Subaru's vigilance was no different from being defenseless.

Tanza: "My apologies for disturbing you. I have come to deliver the words of Yorna-sama."

The one to bow and step over the doorsill to reveal herself was, just as they had thought, Tanza, the deergirl.

Just like yesterday, once the *kimono*-clad girl stepped into the room, she met the gazes of those greeting her and paused.

It was unclear what the expressionless girl thought of the unusually large number of children in the room. However, it should be noted that her gaze had lingered the longest on the suspicious man wearing an oni mask.

Anyway, after the girl surveyed the room,

Tanza: "What happened to the messengers from yesterday?"

Subaru: "Uh... They've left for a bit, should I go get them?"

Tanza: "—No, if you could tell them later."

On and off, Tanza's attention would be drawn to Abel at the back of the room.

He thought she, as a child, was too good a servant, but there were some unexpectedly cute aspects to her, like the way she could not take her eyes off something interesting.

Nevertheless, the report she brought would have a tremendous impact on the future of Subaru and the others.

With quiet tension, they waited for Tanza's words. And then—

Tanza: "After reading the letter, Yorna-sama will reply formally. Therefore, I would like to request you all to report to the Crimson Lapis Castle."

Subaru: "She read it...?"

Subaru felt relieved after Tanza had spoken so with a bow.

Albeit rude, after everything that had passed, he suspected that Yorna tearing up the letter on a whim was not an impossible outcome.

It could be said to be the same sense of insecurity as dealing with a high-strung cat, or Priscilla. As if he could not find the precise approach, that was the impression he got.

Al: “I ain’t denying that the Princess is hard to deal with, but even she discerns TPO⁶... Well, I ain’t too sure about that actually.”

Reading Subaru’s inner thoughts from his expression, Al tried to defend Priscilla, but gave up halfway through. It was a sign that he, too, was having a hard time dealing with Priscilla, whom he had known for a long time.

Anyway, he was relieved that one side of the impending situation seemed to be going smoothly.

With this, the only major problem at hand was the infantilization of Subaru and the others—

Tanza: “I hope that the Master who wrote the letter and all the messengers from yesterday will come to the castle tower.”

Subaru: “—Gueh.”

Tanza: “—?”

Hearing the unintentional moan that spilled out, Tanza lowered her round eyebrows and tilted her head.

In order not to allow her to notice his inner turmoil, Subaru smiled amiably and shook his head, “Nothing, nothing”, forcibly deceiving Tanza’s suspicions.

Whether she was satisfied or not, Tanza straightened her tilted head and said,

Tanza: “We will be waiting for you at the Crimson Lapis Castle, at the time the bell of Fire Time rings.”

Abel: “I understand the details. Well done. You may leave.”

Tanza: “—Yes, excuse me.”

The time specified— the bell of Fire Time, could be taken to mean roughly noon.

⁶ Translation note from Witch Cult Translations: “Loan-word abbreviation meaning «(appropriate) time, place and occasion».”

After informing them of the setting of the meeting with Yorna, Tanza performed a curtsy, and turned away to leave the room. “Excuse me”, Subaru called out towards her back,

Tanza: “Yes, what is it?”

Subaru: “I want to make sure just in case, but the main person invited is the person who wrote the letter, and the messengers from yesterday are an extra, right? In other words, if the messengers are unable to attend due to various circumstances...”

Tanza: “Yorna-sama has said to invite the messengers as well.”

Subaru: “———”

Tanza: “I hope that in this Demon City, you will not fail to follow Yorna-sama’s words.”

Tanza’s voice was plain, but it was a reminder of her absolute and unshakable will.

Leaving that behind, he watched the departing messenger girl and shut the door. After doing that, Subaru took a deep breath and turned around. And then——

Subaru: “...Do you think we, in this state, meet the conditions she just mentioned?”

He stretched out his changed arms, and posed that question.

Arc 7 Chapter 41 - A Chat Over Tea

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 29, Chapter 1 “Beast of Ambition”, Parts 2-4

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Edited Machine Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Original by Goldkills, Translation checked by Averitius, MaskedBook) — [Complete](#)

Subaru: “—Strategy meeting!”

In a room so quiet a pin being dropped could be heard, Subaru raised his short arm along with this suggestion.

There was no rebuttal to that remark. They all felt the need to discuss their situation.

The topic of discussion was, of course, the matter of making an appearance at the Crimson Lapis Castle.

Subaru: “Abel, who wrote the letter, and us, who went to the Castle yesterday, are indispensable...”

Looking down at his clothes with their sleeves and hems wrinkled, Subaru ruminated on the request from Yorna that had been left behind by Tanza, who had come as an envoy; a frown formed between his brows.

He was willing to accept the risk of sending Abel directly to the Castle, but his biggest concern was the condition that he should be accompanied by the messengers from the previous day.

Would Yorna appreciate it if he took along the shrunken Subaru, Al and Medium, he wondered. Worst-case scenario, there was a good chance that it would be considered a prank.

Alternatively, there was the option of telling Yorna all about their situation and appealing to her heart with sincerity, but—

Abel: “It is completely devoid of reason to show your hand when you do not know the future actions of your opponent.”

Subaru: “I see... I can’t say for sure Yorna’d even listen to me either, considering yesterday’s exchange...”

Abel refused to reveal all his cards, and Subaru agreed with him on that point.

Although he had avoided saying so yesterday, if Subaru wished to describe the impression he had of Yorna, the expression “evil woman” would be a valid choice. The way she spoke and acted like a courtesan seemed to Subaru to be that of a temptress with excellent skills in toying with men in the palm of her hand.

The danger posed by Yorna went without saying, as, in addition to her position as the Lord of the Demon City, she possessed the aptness to be bestowed the title of Divine General.

She was the one they had first set their sights on as a potential ally among all of the Nine Divine Generals, however, as Abel had warned, she was not the kind of person to whom they could easily disclose their situation to.

Al: “If we spammed her full with our circumstances and she then asked about you, we’d be screwed. Considering the crossdressing and all that, what should we do if she asks something like, «You dare lie to me»?”

Subaru: “I don’t want to think I’ll be blamed like that, but if that’s the case, why don’t I just pretend to be Natsumi Schwartz in *loli* form...?”

Taritta: “Wait, please *wait*. I’m afraid I’ll get more and more confused *too*...”

The dilemma of making up a lie to cover up another one was a common one, but the dilemma of having to cover up crossdressing by still crossdressing after being “infantilized” would probably be unprecedented.

Unlike Al’s helmet, the size of the wig could be adjusted, so crossdressing itself was possible, but whether it was necessary to go that far depended on how the story proceeded.

Medium: “So, what are we gonna do? The bell of Fire Time’s in about three hours, remember?”

Subaru: “...Pretty sure we should go to the Crimson Lapis Castle.”

Medium tilted her head and asked, having hold Louis in her arms while listening.

While the two of them were the same size, and Louis was tilting her head to match Medium’s, Subaru had to consult with his inner scales.

Taritta: “First of *all*, we don’t have the option of not accepting Yorna’s *invitation*, do we?”

Al: “Well, we went to a lotta trouble to have the letter read. If we don’t accept it, the meaning of yesterday’s hard work and us here having been shrunken would all disappear.”

Taritta: “If *anything*, all that’d be left would be the damage *incurred*...”

Nodding at Al and Taritta’s words, Subaru believed that retreat was not out of the question.

Not returning home until the money spent was recouped; this kind of mindset was a cliché for people losing everything through gambling. Cutting one’s losses would be important, in some cases.

However, what would be lost in this “loss-cutting”, was Subaru and the others’ statures.

Subaru: “Should we see this as serious or trivial...?”

???: “Gettin’ younger’s better than growin’ ol’. Isn’t that like the secret to eternal life?”

Subaru: “Yeah, for sure—”

In a sense, “rejuvenation” meant an increase in chances, just like Return By Death.

If one could return to their childhood holding the knowledge and experience of an adult, they would be capable of training their physique in the most fitting way possible over time, and so, would be able to retry achieving the goals once given up on.

With those as the circumstances, it seemed like they’d found some situations which could be leveraged as an advantage, however—

???: “—That’d be what you’d think, right? But it’s not that simple, is it? It’s not something that ya can easily use, ya know?”

At that moment, a third party interrupted the discussion, and Subaru’s breath stopped.

—No, Subaru’s was not the only to stop. Everyone present in that room went rigid, unable to move at that moment, and froze at the presence of the owner of the voice.

However, the person in question was unconcerned about the growing tension in the room,

???: “I’ve taken the liberty of makin’ tea for myself, does anyone else want some?”

With that question made in a casual tone, he lifted his steamy teacup.

Taritta: “—Hk!”

Immediately after, Taritta moved with a bouncing motion, like a spring-loaded doll.

She drew her bow in an instant and aimed her arrow at the person who had just appeared— Olbart Dunkelkenn.

Her target was extremely close, there was zero chance she would miss or that he could dodge.

But Olbart shrugged his shoulders with a nonchalant, “Whoa, whoa”.

Olbart: “Don’t do it, don’t do it. I don’t like havin’ pointy things aimed at me. Ya know, ol’ people go ta the bathroom more often than not, and ya wanna scare ‘em into pissin’ their pants? I’m shakin’ in my boots here, yeah?”

Taritta: “You’re kidding *me*...! Who are *you*...”

Abel: “—Olbart Dunkelkenn.”

Taritta: “———”

The old man’s hostile but unconcerned stature made Taritta’s face flush with anger. Yet, in response to her question, the man in the oni mask, the one who had called out Olbart’s name, as if to reign her in.



Illustration from Volume 29, coloring by Setowi ([source](#))

The only one who had not moved at all, Abel, sitting on the sofa while donning his oni mask, exchanged glances with the man. To this, Olbart narrowed his eyes hidden by his thick eyebrows.

Olbart: “Well, I already confirmed yesterday that I’m a celebrity, so I’m not surprised, but ya got a pretty impressive face, ya know. Where’s that souvenir from?”

Abel: “Spare me the nonsense, old tree. What are you here for?”

Olbart: “It’s lonely these days ‘cause young people don’t wanna listen to ol’ people’s idle chatter. The people in my village are gettin’ better and better at ignorin’ me every day... Kakakakka!”

As he talked about the lonely circumstances of his old age, Olbart opened his big mouth and smiled cheerfully.

At the dialogue between Abel and Olbart, the confusion of Subaru and the others on the sidelines slowly melted away. However, it was impossible for them to completely let their guard down.

Medium: “But, Gramps, how did you get in here? It’s not like we weren’t keeping watch...”

Olbart: “Oh, doesn’t this lil’ thing look just like the dancer from yesterday. So if Gramps has ta answer, that’s just how it is. Ya let the deergirl thro’, right? And I came in with her.”

Medium: “Together? With Tanza-chan?”

Olbart: “Kakakakka! How I got in here’s a secret. *Shinobi* arts are like my tools of the trade.”

Medium’s simple query was laughed off by Olbart with the purpose of confounding them.

It was uncertain how serious he was about this, but in any case, the word “*shinobi*” had been mentioned by him himself, and he seemed to have no intention of hiding his true identity.

In that case, asking him directly about his true intentions for coming to their camp alone would be faster compared to probing him.

Subaru: “So...”

Olbart: “Hmm?”

Subaru: "So, what are you really doing here?"

Olbart's gaze turned to Subaru after the latter asked the purpose of his visit. With that, the old man wrinkled his brow as if thinking for a while,

Olbart: "Ah, ya, was that'cha? Were ya the girl in red from yesterday? I couldn't possibly mistake the dancer-like girl and the one-armed man, so I was really worried."

So he confessed, he'd had a hard time figuring out who Subaru was.

Hearing this, Subaru's eyes widened, and Al, casually repositioning himself, sneered. He cleared his throat through his mask, his voice more hushed than usual,

Al: "...That's my bro. Even the *shinobi* head honcho didn't know who you were."

Olbart: "Oh, how impressive, how impressive! I wish the people in my village could learn from that transformation. How 'bout bein' a lecturer? You'd be welcome."

Subaru: "Unfortunately, Natsumi Schwartz's schedule's quite full... Maybe I could make some time for you, though."

Olbart: "Hoho, what'cha mean, «maybe»?"

He moistened his lips at how crossdressing had unexpectedly landed quite the catch, and then, noticing the sensation of thirst in his throat, Subaru narrowed his eyes.

Regardless of how much he believed in this nonsense, he had to take full advantage of the opportunity to speak directly with Olbart. For the time being, about the abnormal situation that had befallen Subaru and the others.

As per Abel's guess, the mastermind behind this phenomenon was none other than the old man in front of him.

Subaru: "If you got any idea who's the reason we're like this, be honest..."

Olbart: "Oh, that. I've done that myself. They're interesting, aren't they, the *shinobi* arts?"

Subaru: “———”

Without any bargaining, Olbart admitted that he had been the one to do it.

His statement drowning out the rest of his words, Subaru took a small gulp. And the old man laughed viciously as he watched Subaru stiffen,

Olbart: “If I killed’cha by accident, I wouldn’t be able ta hear anythin’ ya got ta say, and I’d be left with a lotta trouble, ya know? That bein’ the case, there are many ways to squeeze info outta someone without killin’—— Interestin’, isn’t it?”

Olbart bluntly spoke those words, and sipped his warm tea.



——The “infantilization” that had struck Subaru, Al, and Medium.

From the testimony of the one acquainted with the Nine Divine Generals, Abel, it was almost certain that the offender was Olbart.

However, for it to be affirmed directly by the person himself was a different kind of surprise. Especially if the other party was not offended at all and was proud of it.

Everyone: “———”

Olbart: “Oioi, we shouldn’t look at each other all scary. Didn’t’cha learn that ol’ people are to be cared for, not tortured?”

The tension in the room was rising again, and both Al and Medium, as well as Taritta, who had not lowered her bow from the onset, were gradually changing their positions.

In particular, Al was prepared to block the entrance door and obstruct Olbart’s escape route.

However, Al, with his shrunken body, could not handle his cherished sword at will, and so could not aspire to go far in stopping the *shinobi* head honcho that was always on the prowl.

Louis: “Uu...”

Olbart: “You’re a lil’ girl who’s got nothin’ ta do with me, aren’t’cha? Havin’ ya lookin’ at me like that’s kinda hurtful then. Don’t’cha like the sweet smell of ol’ men?”

Abel: “Do not play games with me, Olbart. I shall ask you once more. What brings you here?”

Abel hurled a few words at the side of Olbart, who was trying to win over the snarling Louis. Taking a glance at Olbart, the latter looking over his shoulder, Abel expressed a sharp spirit that could be transmitted even through the oni mask,

Abel: “You have heard the thoughts of Yorna Mishigure, Lord of this Demon City. She recognized them as envoys. She has made it clear that they shall not be touched.”

Subaru: “T-that’s right! Don’t touch us, that’s what yesterday’s game was about! We were risking our lives too! And yet, this treatment’s different from what was promised to us!”⁷

Olbart: “Oioi, you’re gettin’ all excited and mixed up, ya know.”

Taking advantage of Abel’s aggressive move, Subaru also reiterated Yorna’s statement from the previous day. It was as Olbart had said, Subaru had gone as far as to even return to the state of mind of yesterday; regardless, that still did not change the truth.

Yorna had recognized Subaru’s group as messengers, and Tanza had made it clear that she would not allow anyone to interfere with them.

To disregard that, was to express hostility toward Yorna.

Abel: “Of course, if your intent is to destroy the Demon City, you shall not give that the slightest consideration.”

Subaru: “...Now that you mention it.”

With Abel’s additional words, Subaru’s heated blood ran cold.

⁷ Translation note from Witch Cult Translations: “Subaru slips into his Natsumi Schwartz style of speech for a second here.”

In fact, the fake Emperor's faction, to whom Olbart belonged, had given up the right to negotiate with Yorna to Subaru and his party. Should they view it as a bad move, to just flip the table out of anger was also within their possibilities.

In that case, it would be inevitable that he would clash head-on with Yorna, who was esteemed as one of the Nine Divine Generals, in several senses of the meaning—

Abel: "If you are to challenge it with the intent of destroying it, you shall avoid destruction. Of course, you shall come out of it with some damage."

Olbart: "...Well, that foxgirl can be tricky ta deal with. However, it's no fun ta have that masked young'un see right through ya."

Subaru: "Masked, young'un..."

Olbart scratched his chin with his fingers and pretended to be in pain. Overhearing some of his words, Subaru looked at Abel out of the corner of his eye.

Abel's attitude was unchanged, but Subaru was at the very edge of his seat at every step of this exchange— After all, Olbart was one of the Nine Divine Generals.

Of course, they must have seen Vincent Vollachia, aka Abel, many times.

Even though he was hiding his face with a mask, if Olbart were to exchange words with Abel, who had not changed his speech or tone of voice, it would not be surprising for the former to realize his true identity.

Olbart: "——"

However, Abel, who responded in a dignified manner, did not display any such anxiety.

Olbart, too, showed no signs of having perceived Abel's true identity. With that as the case, Subaru was unable to identify him, and had no choice but to act by hiding his inner fears. Anyway—

Subaru: "I still don't have your answer, Olbart-san."

Olbart: “—Feels like I’m bein’ treated better like this, compared to bein’ just called an ol’ man. So I’ll let’cha off the hook for pretendin’ ta be a girl.”

Subaru: “Olbart-san!”

Subaru’s gaze sharpened on the old man, who had lost his nerve and dodged the question. Seeing this, Olbart raises his hands and says, “Okay, okay”,

Olbart: “The rewards for yer actions are just as ya said. The foxgirl and His Excellency both have told me ta stay out of it.”

Subaru: “If that’s the case...”

Olbart: “It’s just that, ya know. I poked ya folks before yesterday’s game was over, right? Then ya know what? If ya can’t complain ‘bout dyin’ from a sword wound ya got while fightin’, ya can’t complain ‘bout a shrinkin’ technique ya got hit with while fightin’ me.”

Subaru: “That’s quibbling...!”

Olbart: “Well, is it really quibbling? —But ya can’t change it, can ya?”

Raising an eyebrow at Olbart, who was laughing at his own cunning, Subaru was at a loss for words.

Olbart’s argument was quibbling, as he himself had admitted. But on the other hand, his argument was correct as well.

Even if someone lost their life because of a wound inflicted during battle, were the wound inflicted before the negotiation of a ceasefire, it would make no sense to hold someone responsible for the tragedy after the ceasefire began.

However, Subaru had the impression that there was a large difference between a wound, and “infantilization”.

Olbart: “That’s why I think that bringin’ ya back and the foxgirl’s order are two different things. Do ya get me?”

Subaru: “———”

Olbart: “Kakakakka! Don’t look so stern. Yer cute face’s ruined... That pretty face was just a sham made with cosmetics! Ya got me there, hook, line and sinker.”

Olbart played with the teacup with his fingertips and showed some acrobatic skills to keep the contents from spilling. His words themselves could not be easily fought off; they had been chosen with deliberate care attained by experience.

However, even if Taritta, who was becoming more and more nervous, and Al and the others, attempting to block the escape route, were to fight their best, subjugating Olbart by force was nowhere in sight.

If there was someone here capable of defeating this cunning, it would be—

Abel: “Do not get carried away, Olbart.”

Indeed, only the man donning the oni mask tried to cut through his brimming ambition and cunning.

Abel, without changing his posture, shot Olbart with a look even sharper and colder, and made him stop playing with his teacup.

Abel: “I have already inquired you as to your purpose. How many more times must I ask until you feel like doing it?”

Olbart: “Whenever there’s a young’un whose expression I can’t see, I can’t help but wanna see the wrinkles between their eyes. I hope ya don’t mind.”

With one eye closed, Olbart mischievously responded to Abel’s domineering spirit. The old man scratched his head and voiced, “You’re a man with no time to spare”,

Olbart: “The foxgirl aside, His Excellency also told me not ta lay a hand on ya folks, so I didn’t come here to deal with’cha. But if we’re gonna be yer enemies anyway, it wouldn’t hurt ta weaken ya a wee bit, would it?”

Al: “...That may have been the reason as to why you shrunk us, but you didn’t come all the way here to drink tea.”

Olbart: “Looks like you’re havin’ a hard time now that yer helmet doesn’t fit anymore, boy. Anyhow, guess you’re right about that. Ah well, the reason I’m here’s that I’m here ta listen ta what ya got ta say, honestly.”

Subaru: “...What we got to say?”

While fiddling with his ear with the hand not holding the teacup, Olbart nodded to Subaru as the latter ruminated over the question, then spoke, “That’s right”.

With that, he then pointed out the window using the same finger that had been picking at his ear,

Olbart: “That performance at the Castle yesterday, darn it if it didn’t make me giddy. But there are a lotta people who’ve tried ta mess with His Excellency, and so far, they’ve all failed. So, I’d like ta ask ya why ya decided ta cross that dangerous bridge as well.”

Subaru: “...What are you going to do once you hear it?”

Olbart: “Oh? Obviously, I’ll make a decision after hearin’ it. And I’m gonna do somethin’ ta make sure ya can’t lie.”

With Olbart’s mouth open wide as he sent saliva flying along with his hearty laugh, Subaru’s scrunched up into a scowl.

It was easy to dismiss his attitude, as was heard just a while ago, as just bad taste. But it was clear that the conversation could not just be shut down on him.

He was one of the Nine Divine Generals required to help Abel regain the throne, or to dispel the *shinobi* technique that had infantilized Subaru and the others. Rather—

Subaru: “...A *kikai*⁸, is it?”

The position of the Nine Divine Generals was such that it was difficult to even contact them, nevertheless to get them on their side.

⁸ English flip. Means “chance” (機会), originally “チャンス” (chance).

But presently, for whatever reason, Chaosflame was occupied not only by its Lord, Yorna, but also by Olbart in front of him, and Chisha, who seemed to be posing as a false Emperor.

Of course, even if cajoling the opposition posed by Chisha, who had taken the initiative, was an impossibility—

Subaru: “If Abel’s reasoning from yesterday was correct, it doesn’t mean that Olbart-san’s confirmed as an enemy.”

Abel’s view was that hope remained regarding Olbart, who stood as one of the Divine Generals considered to already be the enemy’s pawns. At the moment, Subaru had to say that Abel’s judgement was a correct one, as he had managed to get to the point of negotiating with Yorna.

If they were to believe his speculation, there should be room for negotiating Olbart’s position.

However, in order to get Olbart on their side here—

Subaru: “———”

In silence, Subaru glanced at Abel’s profile.

Revealing the identity of the man sporting the oni mask and keeping his dignified stance, Abel— That was the absolute most important piece of information that they must disclose in order to conquer Olbart.

And frankly, Subaru did not have any further information that could resonate with Olbart.

Subaru: “———”

The oni-masked Abel did not even wince, as he met Subaru’s gaze towards his side.

His face was hidden behind a mask, making it impossible to observe any of his emotions. However, there was no way that the intelligent man could not have thought of what Subaru had come up with.

At this juncture, just how much of his own heart could he bare to the other party, Olbart?

Subaru's thought was that this would be the focal point, but since Abel had not stirred, was he premature in his thinking? Or was he waiting to see what came to pass?

In any case, if they could get Olbart on their side, they would find a way to solve the problem of Subaru's "infantilization", their lack of strength, and the battle for the Nine Divine Generals.

Then, this would be the right time to play—

Olbart: "—Ya know, funny thing is, people's faces do say more than you'd expect, don't they?"

Subaru: "Hmm...?"

Olbart: "Yer gaze, the way yer face tenses up, the way yer muscles contract just a little... Ya don't actually gotta move yer mouth ta talk a lot."

Thumping his two fingers against his temples, Olbart spoke. The old man nodded as his gaze fell on Subaru, whose breath had been taken.

Olbart: "For example, the girl who looks like a dancer relies on the girl usin' the bow. The young'un with the cloth wrapped 'round his head and the wee one rely on ya. And, as for the one usin' the bow and ya... Well, both of ya rely on that masked young'un."

Subaru: "—Hk."

Olbart: "Ya can see the general direction of each pair of eyes— When you're weak, it's even more obvious, isn't it?"

The words of Olbart, who flashed his white teeth as he said them, pierced Subaru's mind.

And Subaru belatedly realized that he had greatly misjudged Olbart's fundamental nature, a man who had even appeared seemed to be a good-natured old man.

Olbart had made it clear that he was the one who had "infantilized" them, and that he had done so in order to talk to Subaru and the others.

—He had never stated that it was to "negotiate" with Subaru and the others.

Subaru: “Didn’t you come here to, talk...”

Olbart: “Comin’ here ta «talk» and comin’ here ta «listen» are similar but slightly different, aren’t they? I don’t mind chattin’ like this, ya know? But...”

Subaru: “-----”

Olbart: “Ya see, I’m also the *shinobi* head honcho, and I spend my time actin’ as a representative of the people of my village. That’s why... I can’t trust the words of someone I haven’t even tortured, ‘cause it’s too dangerous.”

Without losing the air of an old man with an understanding of what he spoke about, Olbart expressed his thoughts in accordance with the *shinobi*’s unwritten rules.

The bleakness and harshness of this world were certainly similar to that of the “*ninja*” world known to Subaru.

However, the feeling of enjoying it as a fiction was very unlike the feeling of being exposed to it first-hand in such a manner. And—

Olbart: “So, with his uppity attitude of havin’ no one to rely on, the masked young’un’s the leader, right? Lemme ask ya, what was it that made ya come ta seduce that foxgirl.”

Abel: “—If that does not work, what will?”

Olbart: “Then you’ll just have ta find another way, won’t’cha? But since I’m forced ta stay out of it, there’s not much I can do ‘bout it.”

Olbart shrugged his shoulders, his gaze and attention were turned towards Abel. Of course, it was hardly believable that Olbart, the head honcho of the *shinobi*, would not be paying attention to the others.

Even if his head was not turned, his attention had not been diverted from Al nor Taritta.

However, even though a bow was being pointed towards him, to display any intention of attacking Olbart would be unwise for Subaru and the others surrounding him.

As per Yorna's command, they were to be welcomed into Chaosflame as messengers.

Whether this would still apply after causing a disturbance in Chaosflame, and how she would deal with ill-mannered visitors, was a complete unknown.

In other words, the situation here was a stalemate for both Subaru and Olbart.

Both had no choice but to stare each other down, declaring their readiness to do harm.

And in such an extreme limbo—

Subaru: "...But, on the other hand, in these conditions, where can I even prepare it?"

Reflecting on the established situation, Subaru once again cast a question to the white space that had been born within his mind.

And once again, the thought arose, "Isn't this an opportunity?"

Bound by Yorna and the false Emperor, Olbart was unable to take any additional actions of hostility.

Subaru was judging which side Olbart was leaning; Supposing he was closer to the enemy's side, they would have to act on this timing, they would not get any other situation like the one they had here.

Everyone: "——"

At a slow pace, time progressed.

Along with this tense situation, there was also the matter of the time at which the bell of Fire Time would ring, as presented by Yorna.

Time was precious— The more he wasted, the more his life diminished.

In silence, Taritta's fingers trembled as she gripped her bow, and Al and Medium too muffled their breaths. Even Louis miraculously was only letting out growls, perhaps instinctively sensing the danger posed by Olbart.

Perhaps they could not decide to stir. If someone could, it would be—

Subaru: “—Abel.”

Abel: “———”

Quietly, Subaru called out Abel’s name.

It was visible that his consciousness had turned towards him through the oni mask, upon hearing it. His eyes were invisible, as the oni mask blocked his gaze, but his attention was directed at Subaru.

The feelings there could not be seen— However, Subaru could guess its intent, as he had felt it.

Subaru: “This is the Emperor, Vincent Vollachia.”

Olbart: “...Ahhn?”

In reply to Abel’s gaze, Subaru made that assertion, prompting Olbart to raise an eyebrow.

His eyes hidden by his long, rich eyebrows went open wide, as the old man was suspicious of Subaru’s words. It was a natural reaction, but it was far from the reaction he was looking for.

So, in order to elicit the desired response, they would go deeper.

Subaru: “You want to know who’s the faceless young’un, and what we’re here for. Why did we come to see Yorna? The answer is...”

Olbart: “Oioi, that’s not very funny, is it?”

Subaru: “I wasn’t trying to be funny— Abel.”

At a loss for words for an instance, Olbart’s voice was laced with a hint of surprise.

Perceiving that with clarity, Subaru called out to Abel at the back of the room. This far in the game, Abel did not try to refute Subaru’s words and actions.

Just inaudibly, his gentle fingers reached for his face. And then—

Olbart: “—This is one hell of a thing.”

A concealed visage was revealed in front of Olbart, the latter letting out a voice of astonishment. Before his eyes, the one gazing back at Olbart as his face was tense, was a dark-haired beauty— none other than the Emperor, Vincent Vollachia.

Olbart: “Your Excellency? But that’s too weird, isn’t it? But then, who’d I come wi—”

Abel: “Let your old wits run wild, Olbart Dunkelkenn. You possess the answers. All that remains is to draw them out.”

Olbart: “With the face of Your Excellency, sayin’ things that sound like Your Excellency... Ah, so that’s it.”

At first he had been taken aback, but the old *shinobi* soon regained his composure.

Having revealed his face, Abel passed an order as the Emperor, and doing as he had said, Olbart seemed to come to a conclusion of the situation he was in with the information he had.

Olbart put his hand on his chin, and,

Olbart: “Then that’d be Chisha. He’s got it all under control... There’s another matter, tho’. It’s not like ya, Your Excellency, ta let somethin’ like that happen ta ya, is it?

Abel: “You think your eyes can peer into the depths of my mind?”

Olbart: “Oh, very scary, very scary.”

Waving both his hands in the air, he let out a parched sound at Abel’s answer.

In fact, as Olbart had stated, Abel’s situation was definitely a groggy one, but his overwhelming bluff did not show any of that.

Upon seeing the change in Olbart’s expression, however, the tension left Subaru’s shoulders as well.

Olbart understood the situation.

Abel had been ousted from his position as Emperor, and Vincent, the man he was accompanying, was a false Emperor.

Olbart: “A lotta things that’d been confusin’ me have become clear. No, I was wondering why ya suddenly came ta see the foxgirl in person.”

Subaru: “All of that... was to stifle the actions of our side.”

Olbart: “Hahaa, it’s hard for ol’ people ta keep up with the ideas of ya smart folks, actually. Young, smart, good lookin’, I guess that’s bein’ super-greedy. Don’t’cha think so, too? Don’t’cha think? Since you’re also so young. Oh, that’s because of what I did! Kakakakka.”

Olbart roared with laughter, trying to get a laugh out of them with what he had said, even though it was not funny.

Subaru’s cheeks tightened at the sight, and he exhaled a long breath, suddenly looking at Taritta.

The Shudraq warrior still kept a wary eye, her bow trained on Olbart. He was attempting to get her to break her battle stance, and regain control of the situation.

Subaru: “Taritta-san, you can put your bow down now. Olbart-san’s...”

Olbart: “Oh? No, ya don’t have ta put it down, do ya? I think it’s impossible for that girl ta lower her guard in front of someone she’s not sure isn’t an enemy.”

Subaru: “Huh?”

Olbart himself, the target of Taritta’s bow, was the one to halt Subaru’s effort to get her to lower her guard and talk to him.

The old man took Taritta’s caution as something natural, furthermore he did not do anything to try to deny the “naturalness” that was incomprehensible for Subaru— In other words, the danger stemming from himself had not lessened.

However, then it would be as if—

Subaru: “Let’s talk about this...”

Olbart: “Didn’t’cha hear me? I said I’d make a decision after I listened ta ya. And I did.”

Subaru: “———”

Subaru’s throat clogged up, yet, faced with that, Olbart’s attitude did not alter.

There was merely a quiet click of the tongue, and,

Abel: “This was one of those cards I did not know which way it would tend towards, but that is what you have decided, huh.”

Olbart: “That doesn’t sound like ya, Your Excellency. No, it’s fatal that you’re seriously outta cards ta play... And ta boot, ya weren’t lucky on the draw here. Ya know, I’ve always wanted ta try it.”

Abel: “Ho, and that would be?”

Olbart’s plan was set, and the *shinobi* head honcho laughed at the words of the ousted Emperor.

A laugh, suitable for the man holding the title of “Vicious Old Man”,

Olbart: “With me being an ol’ man with not long left ta live, I’ve always wholeheartedly wanted ta try and kill the Emperor, ta have a glorious death.”

Everyone: “—Hk.”

The moment that vicious wish was spoken, movement occurred amidst that highly-strung environment.

That very moment, Taritta, Al, and Medium all moved to frustrate Olbart’s purpose, overriding the “no fighting” rule given to each one of them. However—

Olbart: “Yesterday, I couldn’t understand what trick ya were usin’, one-armed one. But it stopped workin’ since ya turned little, didn’t it?”

Al: “Ka... Hk.”

Olbart: “Can’t use the skills ya learned at a later age when you’re young.”

Having spoken those words, Olbart twisted his neck and swung his hands.

Blood splattered from his fingertips, and a tragedy unfolded in Subaru's field of vision, his eyes open to their utmost.

Medium and Al, who had stepped in and tried to subdue Olbart, had their necks gouged out and blood spouted out. The blood scattered within the room like a fountain, making a person wonder where had so much blood flowed within a small child's body.

Al: "Tch, ah... Hk."

Olbart: "Judgin' from this, looks like ya aren't able ta use yer last ray of hope. Still, I ended up doin' ya in before finding out how yer trick works, that's how it was, huh. I messed up, I messed up."

Al crouched there, holding the gushing wound. Medium's eyes went blank and she fell backward, motionless.

It was obvious that what they had suffered, was a fatal wound that could not be recovered from.

And Taritta, the only one ready to take on Olbart head-on—

Subaru: "—Ah."

Subaru had been wondering why a shot had not been loosened from the bow.

However, the suspicion that the attack that was supposed to take place did not, made Subaru direct his gaze in that direction.

Taritta was pinned to the wall.

Tall for a woman, Taritta's slender frame was rested against the wall, her body pinned in place. The reason for her immobilization was a throwing weapon protruding from the center of her cleavage— a *shuriken*⁹.

As if some kind of joke, the star-shaped projectile had pierced Taritta's chest, skewering her back and pinning her to the wall. Her heart had been destroyed, it was clear she had perished instantly.

⁹ Translation note from Witch Cult Translations: "A *shuriken* is a concealed weapon originally used as a hidden dagger or as a diversion, used as supplementary weapons. For more information, see [here](#)."

Abel: “—Even though you were told not to interfere, you could not help yourself.”

Suddenly, a man’s voice echoed in that room rife with death.

It had come from Abel, standing in a room that had become full of corpses terrifyingly fast. Having left his seat, the man looked down with a penetrating gaze at Olbart, the architect of all this death.

Bathed in that glare, Olbart wiped the blood splattered on his cheek with his finger,

Olbart: “Yeah. I wanna set off some big fireworks before I die. I’d be completely satisfied ta murder the greatest Emperor of all time, and be executed for it.”

Abel: “I couldn’t read your destructive tastes. My oversight.”

Olbart: “Kakakakka! No, no, no, if my dreams of growin’ old were known, I’d be so ashamed that I wouldn’t be able ta live.”

Al had ceased moving, and Medium and Taritta had stopped breathing.

Under such circumstances, that conversation between Emperor and vassal seemed, to Subaru, to be something from another world. However, it was not another world. It was real. Real, overwhelming reality.

This was the reality that Subaru had arrived at, after making the wrong choice.

Olbart: “Once I’m done with Your Excellency, I’ll go back ta Chisha. I’m sure he’ll be able ta handle my death just fine.”

Subaru: “Im... Hk.”

Olbart: “Oh? Oh, you’re still there.”

To Subaru, who had spoken up too late, Olbart turned around, the latter plunging into the atmosphere that marked finality.

The old man turned his neck with a snap to keep Subaru, his own face rigid, in check. Then, pointing to those fallen, Al, Medium and Taritta in turn,

Olbart: “That’s that. These guys tried ta kill me, so I killed ‘em back, but there really isn’t a reason for ya ta die, right? I don’t have the intention ta become a fugitive, so there’s no reason ta silence ya as well.”

Subaru: “Da, ah...”

Olbart: “Oh, guess I went ahead and spoke a lot again. It’s obvious that ya got somethin’ to say, so open yer mouth. I’m an ol’ man with a short life ahead of me, so I can’t wait that long tho’, ya know?”

As Olbart continued to speak leisurely at his own pace, Subaru’s thoughts turned white— No, his thoughts were being dyed a bright-red. Whether it was anger or the color of the blood that Al and the others had shed, even Subaru himself could not tell.

But even so, whatever, at any rate, never, here—

Abel: “—Fool.”

And so, those contemptuous words came from Abel.

Currently, his gaze must be piercing the back of Subaru’s head. Feeling the pressure of his sharp gaze, Subaru was made keenly aware of the accuracy of his words.

There was no point in standing up for Abel now, with this.

If he had been able to act in such a manner before Al, Medium and Taritta had fallen, perhaps it would have been possible to change something,

Louis: “Uu...!”

Olbart: “Oioi, you’re even usin’ a lil’ girl that’s got no connection to me? Your Excellency’s method of doin’ things must have been somethin’ that women and young children hated for sure.”

In front of Olbart, who was putting his hand on his forehead, stood Louis— No, Louis was not standing in front of Olbart, but in front of Subaru.

Subaru was shielding Abel, and Louis was shielding Subaru, the three of them standing in a straight line.

It was just some absurd form of a meat shield.

Olbart: “I thought Your Excellency was supposed ta die alone.”

Abel: “—Not everything goes according to one’s calculations.”

Olbart: “Kakakakka!”

Abel’s inability to keep his mouth shut at this point was met with a sneer and a loud laugh from Olbart.

Within the eyes of the elderly *shinobi*, neither Subaru’s nor Louis’s presence were reflected. But he was not so kind as to overlook those who stood before him with hostility. Henceforth—

Subaru: “—I’ll never forgive you.”

Natsuki Subaru’s young body spurted blood and sank into a cold pool of blood, searing into his mind the face of the *shinobi* as the latter guffawed viciously during his attempt to satisfy his ambition.

And so—



Blood flowed and a hot sensation gushed from the wound.

The hotness that overflowed endlessly, however, instantly drained the heat from his body.

That which had flowed out rapidly swallowed him, drowned him, rendered him invisible, and then, after he had sunk to the depths of the ocean, he would, he would—

Subaru: “———”

Instantly, the lost blood coursed through Subaru’s body, producing a loud noise in his ears.

Accompanying the sensation of having his hearing sharpened to the extreme, came the cacophony of blood flowing through him in a quiet space. While being struck by it over his whole body, Subaru let out a ragged exhalation.

With violence he bit his back teeth, his vision flickering on and off due to the distant pain and sense of loss.

He wished to find out where he had returned to—

???: “I’ve taken the liberty of makin’ tea for myself, does anyone else want some?”

A moment later, a vicious, unforgettable voice announced the overture of a new battle for Natsuki Subaru.

Arc 7 Chapter 42 - Beast of Ambition

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 29, Chapter 2 “Hidden Behind Your Eyelids”, Parts 1-2

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Edited Machine Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Original by Goldkills, Translation checked by Averitius, MaskedBook) — [Complete](#)

Olbart: “I’ve taken the liberty of makin’ tea for myself, does anyone else want some?”

The moment he heard the shrill old voice, the blood flow in Subaru’s body began flowing backwards.

His skin covered in goosebumps started aching, the air he had taken in froze over within his lungs. As if a heavy, sharp object had been buried deep in his chest, Subaru’s soul was urged to awaken.

—Return by Death had activated, and he had been thrust into this most terrible of situations.

Taritta: “—Hk!”

A moment later, before Subaru could react in any way, Taritta took aim with her bow.

The target was, of course, the uninvited visitor who had suddenly appeared in the room— Olbart Dunkelkenn. One of the Nine Divine Generals, and the old man who had murdered Subaru and the others just ten seconds ago.

Even without knowing the circumstances, the unmannered way in which he broke the ice would make one wary.

Nevertheless, in the same room, Olbart, while having an arrow pointed at him from ultra-point-blank range, as if to ridicule the caution displayed by Subaru and the rest, shrugged his shoulders and,

Olbart: “Whoa, whoa, don’t do it, don’t do it. I don’t like havin’ pointy things aimed at me. Ya know, ol’ people go ta the bathroom more often than not, and ya wanna scare them into pissin’ their pants? I’m shakin’ in my boots here, yeah?”

Taritta: “You’re kidding *me*...! Who are *you*...”

Abel: “—Olbart Dunkelkenn.”

Taritta’s face flushed with anger as Olbart ignored her piercing hostility. But it was the man with the oni mask, Abel, who drew the attention to him as if to interrupt her, calling out the old man’s name.

Unphased by his appearance, Olbart’s gaze turned to the man concealing his face, the one who had spoken his name.

And so it began, a gut-wrenching battle that left him with an awfully thirsty impression—

Subaru: “———”

While keeping the conversation between Olbart and Abel on the perimeter of his consciousness, Subaru matched the unchanging scenes of this world to that of his own memories. Just before, the events of around merely ten minutes prior— In those was where he must search for a breakthrough in fate.

???: “*Can you do it?*”

Subaru: “—Hk.”

While in those thoughts wishful of a breakthrough, a cold voice wedged itself in, catching him off-guard. Born of impatience and frustration, it was none other than the feeble voice of Natsuki Subaru himself.

Subaru: “Can you do it? He wiped out all your friends just a moment ago, ending in that mess.”

The more he tried to remember what had just happened, the more the voice whispered to Subaru devoid of mercy.

Subaru’s failure, his blunder, his irreparable mistake.

This second chance granted by Return by Death was not to make up for his mistakes.

The mistakes he had performed were irreversible. The only thing granted to Subaru was atonement which he could not really atone for. Because that was the sole product of the Authority in Natsuki Subaru's possession—

Subaru: “—Hk!”

Olbart: “Oh! What's up with'cha all of a sudden?”

Medium: “Whoa! What, what, what?”

Louis: “Uu!? Aa, uu!”

He slapped his cheeks as hard as he could with both hands, trying to shake off the snide remarks that had been whispered in his ear.

A dry sound echoed through the room. Olbart, Medium and Louis screamed at Subaru's sudden action.

Although they had not raised their voices, Al and Taritta were just as surprised.

Of course they would be. It was unfortunate, but it just was necessary.

Subaru: “———”

Once Subaru opened his closed eyelids, his vision, which had seemed wobbly and unsteady, became clearer. Within his field of view, in the midst of the people who had been surprised by Subaru's strange behavior, a single gaze was trained on him in silence.

Only the oni mask-wearing Abel was as unfazed and composed as he had been at the time of Olbart's first appearance— What lay within his heart, was wholly unknown.

Subaru: “Sorry for surprising you... I had to motivate myself.”

Olbart: “A lil' kid with red cheeks and a big smile on his face, how nice... Hmm? Aren't'cha that one? Aren't'cha perhaps the girl in red from yesterday? Ya startled me.”

Detecting the eccentric-behaving Subaru's real identity, Olbart raised his thick eyebrows in interest.

Just like in the previous loop, Olbart had again now made the connection between Subaru and Natsumi for the first time. Going along this line, having confirmed that Olbart was the mastermind behind the “infantilization”, it was possible to bring about negotiations.

However, they would be committing the same mistake, then— Olbart was a dangerous man.

At the very least, Abel’s circumstances could not be relayed as to get Olbart on their side.

As soon as he found out that Abel was the real Emperor, that Abel was Vincent Vollachia, he would disclose his own long-held ambitions and make an attempt on his life— He was a potential enemy already. The rest—

Al: “...That’s my bro. Even the *shinobi* head honcho didn’t know who you were.”

Olbart: “Oh, how impressive, how impressive! I wish the people in my village could learn from that transformation. How ‘bout bein’ a lecturer? You’d be welcome.”

Subaru: “———”

Olbart: “Guess it’s impossible ta talk peacefully. Seems I’ve put’cha on yer guard a tad too much and made a tad too grand an entrance. I messed up, I messed up.”

Olbart stuck out his tongue and admitted he had made a mistake.

However, the situation in which this would warm up or soften the atmosphere had long passed. Subaru had not the slightest intention of relaxing his vigilance toward the old man.

—Prior to his assault, Olbart had stated that human faces said a lot.

Probably, the combination of his good-natured attitude and casual behavior, as well as the surprise produced by his silent intrusion into the unprotected room, were all techniques to elicit the other party’s true reaction.

If the *shinobi* of this world and Subaru’s perception of “*ninjas*” were of the same nature, then the entirety of Olbart’s conduct should consist of traps, poison and all kinds of *ninjutsu*.

He would spare no effort to achieve his goal.

Olbart: “Ya best not take me lightly ‘cause I’m an ol’ man with a short life ahead of me and all that, tho’. Gonna have ta get a lil’ rough, takin’ into account how much time I got left in me.”

Taritta: “*Rough...* Are you going to fight us in this *situation*?”

Olbart: “Kakakakka! Well, it’s true I might get a lil’ jumpy with a bow pointed at me, don’t’cha think? But fightin’ isn’t the only method for me ta get my way, is it?”

Medium: “Weeell~, what do you mean? What are you trying to say, Gramps?”

Taritta and Medium cast a question towards the sincerely-muttering Olbart, who shrunk his small body even further. The old man’s cheeks twisted into a smile at the pair’s questions, their height difference had been flipped around.

Then, with his hand, he pointed at Medium and then at Al, the two trying to block his exit route,

Olbart: “It’s hard ta do this and that havin’ been shrunk, isn’t it? I did that. It’s a kind of *shinobi* technique. Strange and interestin’, right?”

Al: “Old man...!”

Olbart: “Don’t be angry, one-armed young’un. In fact, ya can thank me. I’d be miffed if I killed ya by accident before I could’ve asked ya any, so I just shrunk ya.”

With Al closing in on him for an answer, Olbart spoke and stopped his advance.

Upon understanding that the words spoken to him were indeed true, Al’s breath caught, and he fell silent.

Indeed, this statement of Olbart’s was both true and factual.

Had he so desired, he could have killed Subaru’s group during the battle of the previous day, at the Crimson Lapis Castle. He could have pierced their hearts with a simple thrust of his hand, instead of this infantilization technique.

The fact that Subaru and the others were still alive, even after becoming small, came down to nothing more than the whim of the old man.

So Subaru thought, but—

Olbart: “Well, even if I’d tried ta kill ya for real, you’d’ve blocked all my attempts at doin’ it, so I just did it outta desperation, ya know? Right, young’un?”

Al: “...I wonder what you’re talking about.”

Olbart: “Kakakakka! Ya won’t tell me ‘bout yer trick? I can’t really blame ya. If I could tho’, I’d ask ya how ta do it in detail and leave it in my book of secrets.”

Al: “It doesn’t matter how many times you say it— I wonder what you’re talking about.”

His face covered by a piece of cloth, Al answered in a muffled voice.

That response should not match his expectations, yet Olbart nodded with a “Is that so, is that so”, seemingly enjoying Al’s reaction.

Subaru: “—?”

On the other hand, Subaru had no idea what could be the meaning of the current exchange between the two.

During that fierce battle in the castle tower of Crimson Lapis Castle, Al had done the work of several people to save the lives of Subaru and Medium. Or perhaps the one who had squared off against Al there, Olbart, had noticed something shimmering in his fighting style.

However, even if Olbart’s words were true, Al’s technique, influenced by the “infantilization”, would not work on the *shinobi*.

Subaru had already been witness to the results of that, with his very eyes.

And derived from that, came about an absolute truth.

—That would be: under no circumstances whatsoever should they ever wage battle against Olbart. It was that simple.

Everyone: “———”

Olbart was lazily playing with his teacup using both hands. Taritta trained her bow and arrow on him, and Al and Medium likewise were ready for battle—but they would be killed helplessly.

There was a tremendous gap in strength between Subaru's group and Olbart.

If they fought Olbart, they would be annihilated— No, even if they attempted to escape, one or two people may be able to escape, but the chances of that were incredibly small.

They needed to get Olbart to leave peacefully, at all costs. However, there was no time to have a discussion regarding that.

Subaru: "Why...?"

He could not help but lament that he had been forcefully returned to this moment.

He was aware of it being a thought terribly filled with pride and selfishness, as he had been granted a second opportunity by Return by Death. Had he at least returned before Olbart's appearance, he would have been able to consult with his companions at least.

Most recently, he had Returned by Death repeatedly when facing Todd in the Fortress City of Guaral with little time to deal with him; remembering this brought Subaru much suffering.

At that time, he'd had to restart while already being in the sight of the threat.

Currently, while the circumstances were different, the conditions were similar. In other words, the restart point had placed him in the same cage as the bloodthirsty beast.

Originally, the time traveled by Return by Death had not been consistent, but this was quite serious.

Or, perhaps, the Authority that had been bestowed upon Subaru had been compromised in some manner—

Subaru: "—Let's put that aside for now."

He should not curse the lack of time, and commit the folly of wasting what little time he had.

Subaru would not be the only one to pay for his own stupidity.

Subaru: “Olbart-san. You’re...”

Abel: “—You claimed your technique shrunk these people.”

Subaru: “Oh...”

Subaru forced himself to change his mind and attempted to call out to Olbart.

In order to get out of this situation, he had to be careful about every word he said, every action he performed. He wanted time to discern the best choice of words or to put it another way, so he had spoken with the intent of buying time.

However, Abel interrupted him, covering Subaru’s voice with his own.

His words discouraged Subaru at the outset. Now in an embarrassed state, Subaru looked at the man donning the oni mask, and then came to realize his aim. Abel did not even glance back; his real intention was to substitute for Subaru’s role— That would be, to give Subaru the time required, and draw Olbart’s attention.

Olbart: “Oh, that’s right, that’s right. I forgot we gotta talk ‘bout that too. Ol’ people always go off on tangents. It puts a strain on my flesh and bones.”

Abel: “You? Cease with the droll humor. If you claim your old age is weakening you, you should relinquish the rank of General First-Class as soon as possible. If you do not, you have already made up your mind.”

Olbart: “Well, ya got a point. The mask makes it hard for ya ta see my body, but ya can peer into my thoughts just fine.”

Abel: “Of course.”

Devoid of hesitation, Abel nodded, and Olbart’s eyes took on a curious look.

There was no longer any doubt that Abel’s true intention was not to expose Olbart’s true nature, but to buy time, considering his posture of dragging the conversation.

Subaru did not know how Abel had realized that he needed time, but—

Subaru: “This isn’t the time to be distracted.”

Putting aside his displeasure at having been seen through, Subaru thought about what to do.

If Olbart came to know of Abel’s true identity, he would fulfill his ambition to murder the Emperor. Therefore, he could not disclose his hand to Olbart.

However, there was no way he would leave without seeing what they had to offer.

Abel: “You are a General First-Class, your rank presently that of Third, so it may be said that you rest at the top of the Empire. However, your nature is a greedy one. Even that position is far from satisfactory.”

Olbart: “Well, bein’ treated as a witherin’ ol’ man isn’t quite that bad, but I get the feelin’ bein’ called a greedy ol’ man isn’t all that nice. Kakakakka!”

Abel spoke of Olbart’s character, as seen through his own eyes.

Olbart listened happily, wearing a broad smile, but the darkness hidden in the depths of the *shinobi* was something that Abel, of all people, had misjudged.

—No, it would be more appropriate to say that he had not obtained an accurate reading.

Olbart: “So? What does a disgruntled man like me want?”

Abel: “—The seat of First.”

Olbart: “———”

Abel’s words were uttered in a quiet yet unwavering voice.

As soon as he heard this, the sound of Olbart’s breath disappeared, like dead leaves rubbing together. The old man’s eyes narrowed under his long, thick eyebrows, as he locked gazes with Abel.

Subaru did not know what was going through the *shinobi*’s mind, but he was sure what Abel had pointed out had made Olbart’s thoughts buzz. But that—

Olbart: “One-armed young’un, don’t make any strange moves. Ya too, archer girl, you’re also makin’ it obvious ‘cause of yer breathin’.”

—Did not mean that Olbart’s attention had been diverted, or that any chance had been created.

With Olbart’s face still turned toward Abel as he spoke, Al and Taritta gulped.

They had been most likely searching for a faint opportunity the moment Olbart focused on Abel. But even that probing gesture did not go unnoticed by the seasoned observational prowess held by Olbart.

Al: “—Hk, you’ve got eyes in the back of your head?”

Olbart: “What I’m sayin’ isn’t that you’re not diligent enough. Difference’s in experience, experience. But from my point of view, most people are inexperienced. It’s an ol’ man’s theory that cannot be beaten.”

While displaying a toothy grin in response to Al’s groaning, Olbart’s gaze never left Abel’s.

He could deal with any of Al and Taritta’s tricks without even looking— Even if he did not say it in actual fact, from this transcendental being’s posture, it was clear that he was thinking it.

Moreover, they currently did not possess the ability nor the cards in their hands to overturn that.

Subaru: “Al.”

Giving a shake of his head, Subaru advised Al to stay out of it.

Although Subaru did not have a complete grasp of Al’s abilities and skills, he was probably a skilled fighter who specialized in defense. As showcased by the battle with Arakiya, and the previous day at the castle tower, his ability to survive the enemy’s attacks despite being on the defensive was something that even Subaru had to admire.

And yet, in this state of having been “infantilized”, he would not be able to wield it to the fullest and would end up being killed.

Olbart: “Ya surprised me by tellin’ me I was aimin’ for First, tho’. Why are ya blurtin’ out somethin’ that crazy, masked young’un?”

Abel: “It is evident. Your ambition is not so shallow that it shall dry up just because of your old age— The *shinobi* push their bodies and minds to the extreme, and merely a scant few can reach such states. Goes without mention that you are their leader... And the hour upon which you are complete shall not come till the day you die.”

Olbart: “Hmm.”

Crossing his arms, Olbart nodded briefly at Abel’s words.

It could be taken as missing the point, but the lack of response only made its credibility stronger.

In actual fact, Subaru knew that Abel’s point was incorrect.

Olbart’s true intentions, and the ultimate goal of the *shinobi* head honcho, was to “murder the Emperor”. Different from rising to the top of the Nine Divine Generals.

However, Olbart’s reaction was proof that Abel’s point was not far off the mark.

Ultimately, what Abel was pointing out, was the “thirst” within Olbart.

What Abel had speculated as a way to fulfill that craving was to take the title of First, the absolute most important rank in the Nine Divine Generals, of which Olbart was a part of as well— But it was not unreasonable.

He was a General First-Class, with plenty underlings as the *shinobi* head honcho, having lived a long, long life, now burdened with the typical fetters of old age— How had he come to notice that desire, of having his name go down in history as the *shinobi* who had murdered his own liege the Emperor, even if it meant abandoning everything he had gained in life?

Abel was arrogant and self-centered and had zero consideration for others, nevertheless he was the Emperor of Vollachia— as an existence upon the Imperial throne, the preservation of his own life held precedence.

He possessed the self-awareness to know that, with his loss, the Empire would become greatly unstable.

That was the inevitable awareness that possessed by the Vollachian Emperor, by Abel. And on the other hand, that should be a sense of responsibility held by everyone, even if not as strong as his.

—This was, that which Olbart Dunkelkenn did not have.

He did not mind dying, if so fulfilled his ambition. Even if it meant bringing trouble upon the people around him as a result, that did not matter.

That extraordinary thought of destruction was Olbart's darkness, and that which Abel had not been able to read. However—

Subaru: “—Olbart-san, you're not after the seat of First, what you're after is the Emperor, isn't it?”

—Natsuki Subaru did know, the darkness of Olbart Dunkelkenn.



—A moment later, the color, smell, and feel of the air changed.

Olbart: “———”

Olbart did not even turn his line of sight towards Al and Taritta, whose hostility was accompanied by their ability to get things done. Olbart's gaze reacted to the infantilized Subaru's words.

While holding a teacup in one hand and stroking his chin with the other hand, the old man turned to look at Subaru.

That was because he could not allow what Subaru had just said pass by.

Olbart: “Boy, you've come outta nowhere again, I'm surprised.”

Subaru: “Are you surprised because I spoke up suddenly? Or was it...?”

Olbart: “Are you askin' me if I'm surprised ya guessed right? If that were true, I'd be a very dangerous guy, kakakakka!”

Subaru: “———”

Opening his mouth wide, Olbart tried to laugh off Subaru’s words with gusto. However, Subaru was convinced that his inner thoughts were not as calm as they seemed.

Subaru had done nothing else but to recite to him his own long-held ambition.

In addition, this was a darkness that even Abel’s eyes had not been able to see through until the moment it was about to be acted upon.

Al: “Aiming for the Emperor and killing him? Bro, that’s a leap, even for you.”

Subaru: “It doesn’t make sense. Yeah, I know that. There’s no *kasa*¹⁰ other than notoriety, isn’t that right?”

Olbart: “Well, can’t say I don’t understand the idea of bein’ infamous over not bein’ known. Like the one-armed young’un said, that idea’s a bit of a leap.”

Subaru: “But you’re not denying it outright, Olbart-san.”

Olbart agreed with Al’s doubting voice, but Subaru pressed Olbart on.

Honestly, he knew that he would be jumping into the danger zone, but even then, he couldn’t not do so.

Abel had prolonged his conversation with Olbart, while Subaru had pondered it over.

As long as Olbart’s ambition was to murder his own liege, the Emperor, Abel’s true identity could not be disclosed, nor could he be told that the Emperor was Chisha, a fake. It was inevitable that this bargaining chip of theirs had disappeared.

Once this happened, in order to prevent Olbart’s hands from unmasking Abel, Subaru had come up with a method of warfare that diametrically opposed the original negotiation——

——Namely, forgoing the disclosure of their own hand, but instead disclosing Olbart’s own.

¹⁰ English flip. Means “merit/worth” (価値), originally “メリット” (merit).

Subaru: “Our objective is as I told you yesterday in the castle tower. We’re going to overthrow Emperor Vincent Vollachia, who currently sits on the throne of the Emperor. This should also align with your goal.”

Olbart: “Wait wait, don’t make me out ta be some kinda traitor! This is treadin’ on thin ice, boy, you’re makin’ me so scared that I’m ‘boutta piss myself.”

Subaru: “But you aren’t denying it nor stopping me from saying it for real. You’re one of the Emperor’s Generals of the First-Class.”

With that future possibility caught with just his fingertips, Subaru moved forward in an attempt to fully reach it.

Of course, that did not mean that the threat posed by Olbart had diminished, nor that the danger had lessened. He was fully aware that with one wrong move, this place would become a bloodbath.

But Subaru was convinced that this was the kind of talk that was possible as of now.

Only after Abel’s true identity had been revealed had Olbart decided to take action.

It was akin to some sort of suicide mission for Olbart, in which killing Abel would fulfill his life’s purpose.

Without that conviction, Olbart would not be quick-tempered during the negotiations.

Even if he was a beast of ambition, devoid of the slightest sense of responsibility or loyalty, he would play the role of a Divine General who faithfully obeyed the order of “no interference” given by the false Emperor.

Olbart: “That’s, His Excellency’s ordered me ta stay out of it even tho’ you’ve declared war right ta his face. I’m not like Kafma, who gets mad all the time when it comes ta the Emperor. Not wise ta turn the foxgirl into an enemy, in this city.”

As expected, despite Olbart hearing Subaru’s appeal that could have just as well been derogatory, he nevertheless did not attempt to use force.

However, he did not take kindly to Subaru's insistence, and his attitude naturally made Abel, Al and the others put into question whether the *shinobi*'s absurd ambitions were true, or not. And---

Abel: "—So would that be the ulterior motive dwelling within your heart that I was unable to conjecture?"

Olbart: "Good grief, these guys just don't get it. At this rate, I'll just have ta give up and acknowledge it's no use talkin' ta 'em."

Among those who were skeptical, Abel was the first to accept the unbelievable details.

Pierced by the glint in his eyes, Olbart blurted out some excuse as if he didn't feel like it. There had been no reason for Olbart to open his heart to Subaru and the others in earnest at this juncture from the get-go.

Naturally, Al and the rest of the fighters were getting more tense due to Olbart's attitude---

Olbart: "Stop it, stop it, you'll only end up losin' if ya start a fight. I'm tellin' ya, the reason I won't use violent methods with'cha isn't 'cause I'm nice, it's 'cause I was told not to, aight? I'm prepared ta get even with'cha if ya folks make a move on me first."

Taritta: "*Guh...* That may be *true...*"

They hadn't fought yet, but they'd be back at square one if they tried to start something. Taritta's cheeks tightened at Olbart's warning, her narrowed eyes darting a glance at Subaru and Medium.

Seeing this, Olbart nodded his head as if to speak affirmatively,

Olbart: "Bring back the shrunken ones, ya say. That's a tad greedy, don't'cha think? I'm thinkin' of leavin' without doin' anythin', okay?"

Medium: "But Gramps, you made us small, didn't you? Or is there anyone else besides Gramps who can bring us back to normal?"

Olbart: "I've never really thought 'bout it... Girl, how old are ya, really?"

Medium: "Me? I'm what, twenty?"

Olbart: “Then maybe if ya wait ten years, you’ll go back ta normal? Dunno, tho’.”

Medium raised her hand and asked a question, her cheeks reddening at his blunt answer. Albeit it was just Olbart’s bewildering attitude, his answer was troubling for Subaru and the others.

But it was a fact that there was no way to get answers out of him by force, and no other method to undo what had been done. And yet—

Subaru: “You know you can’t just pack up and go home. Olbart-san, I’m going to have to ask you to stay with us a little longer...”

Olbart: “I don’t wanna, tho’. Since you’re treatin’ me like an ol’ man and all that. I’m an ol’ man with a short life ahead of me, and I got the right ta choose who I talk ta with the lil’ time I got.”

Abel: “—Then, I shall present you with the opportunity to kill the Emperor.”

Immediately after that, Subaru gasped at yet another change in atmosphere, and gazed the one who had spoken, Abel.

Abel had done nothing else than put his own life on the scales, that statement causing Olbart to scratch his head with an “Oioi”,

Olbart: “How many times do I gotta tell ya folks that yer premise’s wrong? Isn’t it pretty bad if ya can’t remember things better than me?”

Abel: “If your goal is the Emperor’s life, you have had many opportunities in the past. But you have not actualized it— Because the Flame of the Yang Sword protects the Emperor.”

Olbart: “Oh...”

Abel: “I can divulge how to overcome the Flame.”

Olbart’s expression underwent a shift, becoming distinctly different from the facade he had held up until that point.

The old man raised his eyebrows and stared at the oni mask-wearing Abel with clear surprise. Abel, on the other hand, had risen from his chair, standing there majestically.

Subaru: “The Flame, of the Yang Sword...”

What that meant, Subaru did not know for certain.

However, it was true that for Olbart, the shock was such that it made it possible to see through to the other side, breaking through the ostensible emotions that he had put up to this point.

Based on the conversation, it was some sort of secret that protected the Emperor of Vollachia, and it was because of this that Olbart’s ambition had not come to fruition thus far.

A method to remove those fetters and overcome them, that was what Abel had claimed.

Olbart: “—I thought all ya did was hide yer face and not care for the elderly, who the hell are ya? Ya shouldn’t joke ‘round ‘bout such things.”

Abel: “Is your belief really that someone who weaves sophistry and jokes in a place like this can raise a rebellion against this mighty Empire? If so, they would have to be either a madman bereft of sanity, or a great man with a lot of nerve.”

Olbart: “You’re neither of those things, are ya?”

Abel: “Naturally.”

Consisely, Abel responded to Olbart’s question.

Whether it was serious or just sophistry, Subaru could not decide. Or perhaps the man named Abel was the real deal, a madman, a great man, or all of those simultaneously.

Olbart: “———”

In reaction to Abel’s reply, Olbart fell silent for a moment.

He raised his bushy eyebrows and brought his now utterly cold cup of tea to his lips. Then, once he gently placed the empty teacup on the desk beside him,

Olbart: “I believe you were talking about the bell of Fire Time.”

Subaru: “Huh?”

With that sudden question, Subaru let out a stupid-sounding voice.

However, the one to reply immediately with “That’s right~” and a nod was Medium. Her body now smaller, she pointed out the window, indicating the majesty of the Crimson Lapis Castle,

Medium: “Yorna-chan’s calling us, so we’ll be in trouble if we stay small.”

Olbart: “Yorna-chan! Kakakakka! You’ve got real balls, lass.”

Medium: “—?”

He tilted his head, amazed by Medium’s boldness in addressing Yorna with “chan”¹¹.

At the same time, Olbart did the same, now calmed down, gazing towards the Crimson Lapis Castle, pointed to by Medium, as he muttered “Right”,

Olbart: “Putting aside the topic of whether I’m aimin’ for His Excellency’s life or not, I sure am curious ‘bout how ta get past the Yang Sword that protects the Emperor of Vollachia.”

Subaru: “—Hk! If that’s the case...”

Olbart: “Oh, com’on, it’s too early ta tell. I’m the one who got yer hopes up, but I got a lotta things on my mind— So, why don’t we play a game?”

Subaru: “...A game?”

Olbart: “Yes, a game. Ya like that, don’t’cha? Boy.”

Thrusting his finger right in front of Subaru’s nose as the latter leaned forward, Olbart so declared.

As his eyes had been wholly unable to follow that movement, Subaru went stiff, stuck in place.

Olbart presented some kind of condition, or a “game”, as he called it as a preface.

¹¹ The honorific “ちゃん” is usually employed for people one is familiar/friendly with. Medium here is using it for a person she doesn’t know all that well, and is higher in the pecking order to boot, which can be seen as disrespectful, hence why Olbart reacted in this manner.

Subaru was not sure if this was the way he wanted to avoid complete annihilation and improve this stagnant situation, but—

Subaru: “What if I said no?”

Olbart: “Then ya won’t be able to get anythin’ ya want.”

Subaru: “———”

Olbart: “By the way, since ya folks got what’cha think I want, the *shinobi*’s techniques’ll be comin’ down on ya folks without relent.”

As if it were an obvious answer, Olbart made that ruthless announcement.

The old man was smiling; the sight of the dark emotions stirring in the depths of his pale, cloudy eyes brought chills.

He may be having a peaceful and harmonious conversation on the surface, but under it, he was concealing a *shinobi* style of mercilessly reaping others’ lives.

Abel: “What shall the game be?”

Avoiding a bout with Olbart had been made impossible once he presented his conditions. Abel had sensed the same thing, and made his question in Subaru’s stead, the latter unable to open his mouth.

Olbart nodded his head to that appeal, and said, “Right”,

Olbart: “We don’t have much time before the fox girl calls ya, and I’ve been told not ta mess with’cha folks, so I’m in a bit of a pickle... Oh, that one’s perfect.”

Subaru: “Perfect for who, Olbart-san? For us?”

Olbart: “For both of us, me and ya.”

With a toothy grin at Subaru’s drawn-out question, Olbart showed his hands.

Then turning to Subaru and the others bracing themselves, he spoke,

Olbart: “—Tag.”

Everyone: “———”

Olbart: “I’m used ta playin’ it with the young peeps from my village. Easy ta understand, isn’t it?”

Arc 7 Chapter 43 - Hidden Behind Your Eyelids

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 29, Chapter 2 “Hidden Behind Your Eyelids”, Parts 3-6

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Edited Machine Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Original by Goldkills, Translation checked by Averitius, MaskedBook) — [Complete](#)

—That proposal spun by the hoarse voice greatly befuddled Subaru and the others.

Everyone: “———”

The “infantilization” that had assailed Subaru’s group, and its mastermind, Olbart Dunkelkenn.

Subaru and the others, who sought to negotiate with Olbart in order to get him to release his infantilization off them, were presented a condition that was befitting of the old man— no, befitting of the monstrous old man who was toying with their bodies and minds alike; a strange condition, which would lead one’s heart astray upon being heard.

After all—

Subaru: “Playing, tag...?”

Subaru, who had been dreading what kind of unreasonable request was going to be posed, ruminated on the words he had just been told.

At the sound of Subaru’s voice, Olbart, his hands up in the air, frowned quizzically.

Olbart: “What’s with the question mark? You’re not gonna tell me ya dunno how ta play tag, are ya?”

Subaru: “Of course I know what it is. It’s just that, it’s not a word that should come up in this situation.”

No matter how it was framed, it was merely a child’s game of “tag”.

It was hard to imagine that there was another meaning to it. Although, since it would be the kind of game of tag played in a *shinobi* village, there was a good chance that it would have a unique set of rules.

For example, something like---

Subaru: “«Killin’ isn’t against the rules while playin’, tho’», something like that.”

Olbart: “Kakakakka! Of course not. If that kinda nonsense were popular, the *shinobi*’d be extinct in no time flat. And that by my hands, with me bein’ their leader. That’d be bad, wouldn’t it?”

Although Olbart denied Subaru’s concerns, Subaru believed him to be a man willing to stain his own hands with the blood of his own people if necessary, taking into account his violent behavior and the things he had said and done so far.

To be honest, he would not have been that surprised if that *shinobi* village of his had already been destroyed.

Abel: “---That tag thing, how does it function?”

Rather than Subaru, who was burning with suspicion, it was Abel who urged him to go ahead.

His cheeks twisting into a smile, Olbart let out an “Oh”,

Olbart: “You seem ta be more enthusiastic than I’d expected, masked young’un.”

Abel: “Foolishness. We have already passed the point of not getting into this game, as soon as we divulged that we possess the information you covet.”

Olbart: “Kakakakka! Well, guess you’re right.”

Opening his mouth so wide that it looked like his jaw was about to come off, Olbart gave a hearty laugh without reservations.

In fact, Abel’s point was correct. Olbart’s idea was vicious. Regardless of whether he won or lost this game of tag, Olbart would obtain the information he desired.

The purpose of this game of tag was to allow them to choose how they wished to give up that information, whether after negotiations, or after torture.

Olbart: “So, there’s nothin’ really special about how «tag» works. One side runs away, and the other side catches the other... Oh, it’d be better if I were the one runnin’ away. Ya know, since chasin’ a large group of people ‘round’s too much for an ol’ man’s stamina.”

Medium: “So, if we catch Gramps running away, we win? That’s easy to understand.”

Taritta: “It’s easy to *understand*, *but...*”

To Olbart’s explanation of the rules, Medium reacted optimistically, and Taritta pessimistically.

Subaru’s opinion was also leaning more towards Taritta’s. Indeed, the rules were simple and there was no room for uncertainty to interfere— In other words, it was all up to one’s ability.

And on the topic of ability, the total sum of the ability of Subaru’s group was nowhere near that of Olbart’s.

Olbart: “Well, might be hard with all the lil’ ones. Then we can loosen the conditions a tad.”

Taritta: “And the person who did it, doesn’t even feel guilty...!”

Olbart: “Don’t get so upset, ya know. If yer finger comes off the bowstring, I’ll have a good reason ta defend myself, and it’ll all become a lot easier.”

Taritta: “———”

As Olbart glanced at the faces in the room and shrugged his shoulders, Taritta clacked her molars together.

It was as the monstrous old man had pointed out; Taritta’s bow still remained trained on Olbart. However, the person in question, Olbart, ignored it with a straight face, and rather used it as a bargaining chip.

One could only imagine the mental turmoil Taritta was feeling. But the priority right now was——

Subaru: “What do you mean, loosen the conditions?”

Olbart: “Talkin’ ‘bout the way we’ll be playin’ tag, here. How ‘bout, ya don’t have ta catch me, but instead, if ya find me, ya win. But you’d have to do it thrice.”

Subaru: “Thrice...”

Olbart: “I’ll hide thrice. Ya folks’re gonna have ta try and find me three times. If ya can’t, ya lose. In this case, it’s no game of tag, it’s a game of seek... which sounds kinda weird.”

“It don’t sound quite right”, said Olbart, cocking his head in puzzlement.

Taking in the old man’s suggestion, the words that came from within Subaru, were—

Subaru: “—Hide-and-seek?”

Olbart: “Oh yeah, that’s a good name. We’ll just use that.”

With a snap of his fingers, Olbart clicked at the sound of “hide-and-seek”.

As he did so, Olbart held up one finger on each of his outstretched hands, and flashed them to the left and right on the spot for all to see.

Olbart: “In tag, ya only gotta catch me once. In hide-and-seek, ya gotta find me thrice— I don’t think I need ta tell ya which one you’ve got a better chance of winnin’, do I?”

Once Olbart posed that question, shutting one eye, Subaru let out a gasp.

Olbart was right, this was a question that required no further thought— Given Olbart’s ability as someone transcendental, something Subaru was already aware of, there was no reason for them to opt for a game of tag.

There shouldn’t, yet—

Al: “Ain’t that so kind of you. Can’t help but wonder if there’s more to it, since you went to the trouble of suggesting a method that’d give us a better chance of winning.”

With Olbart attempting to pass on the odds of victory to them, Al snapped at him.

As a substitute for the helmet he had taken off, Al now had a cloth wrapped around his face. His voice, now high in pitch as he had become younger, was a bit muffled through the cloth, albeit not to the point that it was difficult to understand.

Olbart, having listened to Al's words, shrugged his shoulders.

Olbart: "Oioi, don't make the mistake of thinkin' that I'm an ol' man who wants ta win at all costs, young'un. As far as I'm concerned, it'd be better if ya folks win, okay? I'm doin' this 'cause I wanna know if ya folks're worth listenin' to."

Al: "——"

Olbart: "As for me, I'm quite interested in what ya folks have ta say. But is it wrong for me ta be worried 'bout my retirement savings if I'm caught in some random lie and my loyalty to His Excellency's questioned? Ta prevent that from happenin', I'm usin' my sluggish brain ta come up with this plan."

Waving his left and right indexes, Olbart answered Al aloofly.

Hearing that answer did not dispel Al's suspicions. But it was a reasonable answer, and he seemed hesitant to pursue the matter further.

Subaru was not so easy-going as to believe that Olbart was being truthful.

However, there was too little time and not enough information to uncover what was within the mind of this accomplished *shinobi* mastermind.

During all of this, the time limit that Yorna had given was fast approaching, second-by-second.

With Olbart's two inconvenient choices— neither of which was the best option, the chances of coming up with a way to recover from this were close to zero.

To put it another way, Subaru had done everything in his power and still arrived at this situation.

Abel: "—If we are to take up on your offer, we shall need to be clear about some matters."

Olbart: "Oh, whaddya mean?"

Abel: “You yourself have said so. If you wish to give us a higher chance at victory, you should not leave too much room for pointless exertions— What is desired from one another must be made clear.”

Olbart: “—Kakakakka.”

Seemingly having reached the same conclusion earlier, Abel proceeded, one eye trained on Olbart.

Clarification of the rules of the game— what laid behind the demand for clarification was clear. It served as a sign that the decision was to accept the game, and its content.

Abel nodded, staring back at Olbart, who gave a low chuckle, his eyes bright and blazing.

And then finally—

Abel: “—Hide-and-seek it is.”



—Following that, there were three major agreements made between the two sides.

The first commitment was, “do no harm to each other”.

Olbart was capable of murdering everyone if he wished so, to begin with. What discouraged him from doing so were the false Emperor’s orders and his wariness towards Yorna.

But this assurance was essential, because he would break this ban if the situation warranted it.

The second was, “limit the places of hiding to the city’s boundaries”.

If they were to believe in the pretense of leaving the odds in their favor, limiting the area was also essential to maintain fairness. Of course, even if it were limited to the city, the play area was quite large.

However, the conditions that Subaru had made him accept should do the job in this regard.

The third was, “clarify the conditions for victory”.

They had opted to play hide-and-seek because they believed that meant a better chance of winning. Then, no one would be able to say that it would be wrong to pursue victory. So—

Subaru: “I know the odds are different for us in tag compared to hide-and-seek, but why three times? Don’t be stingy, can’t we only do this once?”

Olbart: “Kakakakka! That’s a tad greedy, young man. Tell ya what. If it happens once, it’s prolly a fluke. But if it happens thrice, it’s skill.”

Subaru: “Some people think luck’s part of skill, you know?”

Olbart: “Hate to tell ya, but I don’t believe in luck. I mean, that’s what most of the Empire’s people believe. Ya say some darned things, don’t’cha?”

It was an unavoidable school of thought, typical of an empire based on the supremacy of merit.

There was no such thing as luck or misfortune, and everything was the result of one’s own abilities. This attitude was seemingly suffocating for those unable to live without a refuge.

For example, the Subaru of his days as a truant had no place in the Empire.

Olbart: “In addition, why not do it thrice ‘cause there are three among ya who’ve been shrunken? Sounds reasonable for a technicality I just came up with on the spot.”

Abel: “Then, every time we find you, you shall undo the technique on one person?”

Olbart: “Oh, and now you’re tryin’ ta take advantage of me. Well, let’s just forget that technicality.”

Waving his hands in the air, Olbart refused to confirm Abel’s statement.

Anyhow, with that matter settled, there was presumably nothing else left that required closer examination. That meant—

Olbart: “Well, let’s play.”

Subaru: “Olbart-san, just double-checking a small detail... No hiding where we can’t physically get to. There’s nothing we can do if you’re hiding in the middle of nowhere.”

Olbart: “You’re a real stickler for detail, ya know that? —Well, I would’ve done it if ya hadn’t said that.”

Subaru: “———”

Olbart: “Tell ya what, I was serious when I said I don’t need ta win at all costs, ya know? Don’t forget tho’, this is yer test.”

In other words, he was looking at them for their adroitness, shrewdness and intelligence too.

Olbart appeared to be generous and easy-going, but he was severe when it came to cutting someone off. Were he to deem someone unworthy of his attention, he would rip their vitals out without mercy.

Even now, if Subaru had not butted in, he would have done so in earnest. But——

Olbart: “——I didn’t think the masked young’un would’ve overlooked that.”

Indicating Abel by cocking his chin, Olbart displayed him a cunning smile that did not hide his elderly age.

Despite this annoyance, Subaru signaled Abel and Al with his eyes, and once he made sure of their assent, he prepared himself to throw down the gauntlet.

Subaru: “If we win, I’ll have you put us back to normal.”

Olbart: “If I win, you’ll have ta wait ten years ta get back ta normal. Well, if His Excellency and the foxgirl get any second thoughts, I’ll go ask ya for yer secrets my own way.”

That would be, a *shinobi* technique passed down in his *shinobi* village—— Subaru felt a surge of fear as he regarded Olbart’s dark eyes, feeling that the method the old man had suggested could lead to torture.

Then, before the old man headed to his first hiding place, he would ask a question,

Subaru: “—So what’s the first *jogen*¹²?”

It was a question that would be dismissed as ridiculous if this were a serious game.

However, Olbart did not laugh at this. Because this was a condition for victory that Subaru had forced Olbart to accept for their game of hide-and-seek.

Now that Subaru had been “infantilized”, Olbart wanted to evaluate them not in terms of their fighting prowess or physical abilities, but in terms of their mindset and creativity, as mentioned before.

To put it simply, it was none other than the natural feeling called “not wanting to deal with idiots”.

Olbart: “First of all, a tryout... Near this inn, I’m gonna hide «behind the eyelids».”

Subaru: “—Behind, the eyelids.”

Olbart: “Well, hang in there, young man. Let this ol’ man have some fun in what’s left of his short life, at least.”

With a fluttering wave of his hand, Olbart turned his back to Subaru and the others— At that moment, Subaru felt the tension in the room rise as the man walked away leisurely.

Everyone: “———”

Who among them had not wished that they could pounce on Olbart and solve the problems of the “hide-and-seek” and the “infantilization” at once, in that very moment?

But nobody carried out that reckless act. And it was the right thing to do.

Olbart: “Kakakakka.”

Just before the door closed, Olbart laughed because he knew what Subaru’s hesitation was about.

His behavior lived up to the title of “Vicious Old Man”, his shrill laugh included, right to the end.

¹² English flip. Means “hint/tip” (助言), originally “ヒント” (hint).

And so, once Olbart exited the room, and it was once again occupied only by Subaru and his allies—

Abel: “Taritta, lower your bow. There is no one to point it at anymore.”

Taritta: “...Okay.”

After the enemy had left the room, Abel had Taritta lower her bow.

Taritta’s face, as she followed the instructions, was filled with shame. Naturally so. Olbart had kept a cool face as she pointed her bow at him.

As one of the Shudraq— No, as someone who had already been entrusted with the role of being the next Chieftain, for Taritta, the old man’s attitude was a mockery of the power of the Shudraqians.

Subaru had allowed Olbart to underestimate the People of Shudraq.

This too, was due to his own lack of strength.

Originally, Taritta had accompanied Subaru to the Demon City to seek a pillar of support for her resolve to take over as Chieftain.

—This would only have the opposite effect, rather than her gaining the needed confidence.

Al: “Are you seriously gonna play along with that old man’s games, bro?”

And so, Al spoke up towards Subaru, who could not find any words to say to Taritta.

Al was wearing a face covering that did not quite fit, and his tone was filled with frustration and disapproval at this interaction with Olbart. He always had the impression of accepting everything rather easily, and of letting things go, so it was surprising to see him react that way.

However, since Olbart keeps outmaneuvering them, it was understandable as to why he would be frustrated.

Subaru: “I don’t feel good about being put through the wringer like that either. But we left some possibilities open at the last minute, right?”

Al: “Possibilities, you mean...”

Medium: "There's a chance our original bodies can be restored, right? Subaru-chin."

Medium was sitting on the floor, holding Louis down as she struggled. She was restraining Louis, the latter's size now almost the same as hers, with her skills, not her arm strength.

Perhaps it was a skill she had developed at the orphanage where she had grown up.

As she calmed Louis, Subaru looked into her blue eyes and nodded, "Yes",

Subaru: "If we got him in a bad mood, our bodies would stay small... And that isn't something we can afford considering future plans, and our current course. It's a must that we return to normal."

Al: "...Well, that's exactly what we could've done, we could've surrounded the old man and beaten him."

Subaru: "Don't be stupid. The only reason we didn't die is because Olbart-san was intending to follow the Emperor's orders. We wouldn't be able to do anything about it if he felt like it."

Al: "—You say that like you've seen it before."

Looking away from Subaru, Al sounded like he wanted to say that that should be impossible.

Al's remark was not off the mark, since Subaru's insight was because of a cheat transcending worlds. He had indeed seen it with his own eyes.

Events that he had thought to be impossible had happened, even if he wished not to admit it. Nevertheless—

Al: "——"

Averting his gaze, Al did not argue further.

Due to the previous day's visit to the castle keep, Al had also grasped a part of Olbart's strength. Naturally, he would know that the old man had not been serious back then, and that the odds of victory would be slim were he to demonstrate his true ability.

That was why Al had made the decision to keep watching Olbart's back as he left.

Subaru: “Whatever, we don’t have much time. If we’re going to meet with Yorna, I need time to do my makeup. I need thirty minutes for everything, so... the grace period’s a little over two hours.”

Taritta: “Is it really necessary to wear women’s clothes...”

Subaru: “It is, because the three of us from yesterday are being requested, too. And...”

As he said this, Subaru looked at Abel, who was silent.

As long as he did not interfere, Subaru guessed that he had the same basic policy as himself. Subaru did not believe he was getting lost in the emotions of having gone through a deadly situation. Or maybe—

Subaru: “Shocked that Olbart-san’s trying to kill the Emperor, huh?”

Abel: “Nonsense. I knew he had ambitions beyond his size. Albeit, I did not think it would be the Emperor’s head. I thought there was nothing to be gained by such an attempt. But what he really seeks is a final sense of accomplishment and the posthumous notoriety.”

Abel shrugged his thin shoulders as if to say he couldn’t fully grasp it.

Regardless of even having been forced out of his position as Emperor and being driven into the most unfavorable situation, Abel never knew when to give up.

From his point of view, it was incomprehensible to give up his own life and seek posthumous fame, as it would be best for him to return to the throne alive.

On this point, Subaru agreed with him, though it was a very mixed bag of feelings. He did not want to be praised after death.

Subaru wished to be forgotten by his remaining loved ones after he passed away.

It was in Subaru’s nature that he would rather be made a memory of and forgotten about in the moment of his death, than for everyone to grieve or suffer for it.

However, he had no intent to share that feeling with Abel.

Subaru: "...But Olbart-san's a bit of an outcast, isn't he? He's got all that ambition, but he doesn't even realize who you are in front of him."

Therefore, Subaru deceptively changed the subject.

But as soon as he heard that, however, Abel's eyes showed a suspicion that was clearly visible even through the oni mask.

Abel: "—What in the world are you talking about?"

Subaru: "Huh?"

Abel: "I am wearing this mask. Hence why Olbart's reaction is justified."

Tracing the oni mask's cheek with his finger, Abel made that declaration nonchalantly.

Subaru raised an eyebrow at his words, his expression showing that he did not understand. Promptly, Abel's puzzlement turned into disappointment visible through his oni mask.

With that look in his eyes, Abel sighed deeply, and,

Abel: "This mask has the effect of distorting the perceptions of others. It is an effect that conceals the true identity of the wearer."

Subaru: "—! Is that really cognitive disruption? But that mask was originally supposed to be from the Shudraqian's village..."

Taritta: "Yes *yes*, that's *right*. It's said that in the *past*, when the Emperor and Shudraq formed friendly *ties*, the Emperor used it to visit the Jungle without being *recognized*."

Subaru: "That mask has actual history...?"

With the revelation of that surprising fact, Subaru's mouth was left agape. To that shocked Subaru, Abel's disappointment still lasted,

Abel: "You, did you really believe that I have been wearing this mask all this time for show, or due to madness?"

Subaru: “———”

Abel: “At last, your stupidity has reached its pinnacle. In the first place, there is plenty good reason to conceal my face. I believe we did not come to the Demon City for tourism.”

Subaru: “You didn’t have to say it like that, you could have just explained that at the start...!”

Certainly, it was Subaru’s fault for thinking it was part of Abel’s odd behavior and not asking anything, but Abel was also at fault for thinking it would be understood without explaining anything.

Thanks to that, he had to unnecessarily embarrass himself, and to worry himself without it being needed.

Anyway, he was now aware of the mechanism as to why Olbart had not realized Abel’s true identity.

Abel had no intention of covering up his pompous speech and arrogant attitude, so Subaru’s fears that he would reveal himself were unfounded.

Medium: “Heyhey, Al-chin, Al-chin. That’s what Abel-chin’s reason is, but is there a reason why Al-chin’s hiding his face?”

Al: “In my case, I have a *rettoukan* about my facial scars... But let’s not talk about me. Hide-and-seek’s already begun. We gotta get a move on.”

As he said this, Al pointed out the window to the streets of the Demon City.

Chaosflame was one of the largest cities in the Empire, amounting to probably five times the size of the Fortress City of Guaral.

To find the *shinobi* head honcho hidden among all that was no easy task.

Find him three times, in just two hours and with only six people.

Al: “I know he said he was gonna do a tryout first, but there are a lotta possible hiding places just around the inn, man. Bro, do you or Abel-chan have some kind of plan?”

Subaru: “It’s not much of a plan, but...”

At least, there were some things Subaru had thought of that he wanted to try.

A “hide-and-seek” tryout— unsurprisingly, he’d had the same idea Olbart did. An idea that should be tried at least once to gauge the mindset of their opponent, the old man.

Just as Subaru thought that, Abel crossed his arms and nodded, “Of course”,

Abel: “There are a few possible moves. Although, my idea is probably different from that of the clown here.”

Subaru: “You’re demoting me from a military strategist to clown, you’re too uptight about that mask thing from earlier... No, it’s not like I cared about being your military strategist or anything.”

Subaru could only curve his lips in a snarl at the sound of Abel’s cold voice. It was as if the fact that Subaru had treated the oni mask’s disguise as an oddity was really upsetting the latter.

Anyway, throughout that discussion here, time was being wasted.

Subaru: “I’ve got to get moving before I forget what having long limbs felt like.”

Al: “Well, dunno if there was ever a time when me and you had long legs, bro...”

Subaru: “I meant compared to the current situation.”

The group pushed aside Al as he teased that they were all short-legged, and prepared the minimum amount of gear.

Al carried his *dao*¹³ in its sheath on his back, Medium carried only one of her twin swords on her hip. For now, Subaru would also carry his whip. However, he was not confident he could handle it in all honesty.

All that was left was Abel and Taritta, who were in top condition, plus—

???: “Aa, uu!”

¹³ This sword is called a “青竜刀”, literally translated as “Blue/Azure Dragon Sword”, but a more accurate, and neutral name would be a “Chinese dao”. The literal name could perhaps have certain implications, however.

Medium: “Oh, Louis-chan, you’re so motivated! Alright, let’s work hard and find Gramps!”

Louis: “Uu!”

Medium raised a small fist at the sound of Louis’s voice, not wanting to leave her behind.

In the end, Louis was likely to slow everyone down. Olbart had been forbidden to change his hiding place in the meantime, so they would like to believe that, even if he sensed the approach of the noisy Louis, he probably would not do anything of the sort.

Al: “Isn’t it possible that he’ll change his hiding places from time-to-time and claim that he’s been hiding in one place the whole time?”

Abel: “I already corrected you on that, but Olbart’s goal is not his own victory. The reason he is performing such a roundabout move is to measure our capabilities through this game.”

Al: “Measuring our capabilities? That means...”

Abel: “He wishes to know if I am capable of making such a big claim to the Emperor’s throne.”

Abel made it clear to Al, who doubted Olbart’s true intentions.

Subaru also saw no falsehood there. It was hard to believe Olbart’s own words, but since his goal was the Emperor’s life, being able to believe the aim of Subaru’s group, and the information in their hands being the real deal would be convenient.

Olbart wanted to be convinced by their party’s demonstration of capabilities. And for that reason—

Subaru: “I didn’t ask before, but what was that about the Flame of the Yang Sword...?”

Abel: “I am afraid I do not have the leisure to give a lengthy lecture on the history of the Emperors of Vollachia. Your shallow wisdom notwithstanding, my plan is not something that can be set in motion in a room at an inn.”

Subaru: “Tch, okay.”

Subaru clucked his tongue at this manner of saying that he did not want to reveal anything.

Nevertheless, if the exchange with Olbart were indeed true, it seemed to him that the Emperor of Vollachia, or rather Abel, had some kind of protection. As long as he did, no harm would befall him.

Subaru: “On second thought...”

So far, Subaru had never seen Abel lose his life with his own eyes.

Since arriving in the Vollachian Empire, Subaru’s life had been threatened quite frequently, having actually lost his life and Returned by Death. However, Abel’s death was an event that had never occurred— Although Subaru had been in situations which seemed like they should have resulted in Abel’s death.

When Olbart revealed his true nature the very previous loop, or when Todd had the Buddheim Jungle burnt down, Shudraquian village included, the life of the imprisoned Abel should have been lost.

But that was only because of the circumstances, not because Subaru had directly confirmed his death— So, he wanted to confirm one thing.

Subaru: “That thing called the Flame of the Yang Sword, is it still protecting you?”

Abel: “How insistent. Will you perhaps turn against me as well, if you do not hear it?”

Subaru: “...There’s no *kasa* in me doing that.”

His cheeks contorting due to that mocking remark, Subaru gave up the pursuit this time.

Then, Subaru looked around at the faces of his companions as they prepared to leave the inn,

Subaru: “Unexpectedly, we have to play a game. But if the condition is that we just need to find a person, then we should be able to compete even in a situation where half of our *touin*¹⁴ have shrunk. In fact, since it’s a game of hide-and-seek, that we’ve returned to our childlike minds and bodies might even be better for us in this game.”

Taritta: “W-what’s the logic behind *that*...?”

¹⁴ English flip. Means “party member(s)” (党員), originally “メンバー” (members).

Abel: "Ignore him. It is nonsense, meaningless to listen to."

In fact, that was right, since it was nothing more than banter, but he just expressed his regret with a wrinkle between his eyebrows.

After doing that, Subaru shouted "Anyway!", louder than he should have.

Subaru: "I want everyone to pay maximum attention to their surroundings— Ok then, let's go!"

Medium: "Oh!"

Louis: "Auu!"

Al: "...You're really into this, bro."

The enthusiastic Subaru was dressed in the clothes he had on hand, his figure looking quite unsightly. Al sighed as Medium and Louis followed Subaru's lead, pumping their fists in the air.

On the other hand, Taritta, who had become the strongest fighter, had nervousness and anxiety in her eyes, while Abel was as irreverent as ever, with no expression behind his oni mask and no thing in his hands.

All of their members left the inn together.

First item of order, was to locate Olbart's first hiding place. Full of eagerness, Subaru slammed the door with a loud bang and stepped out with great vigor—

Subaru: "—Then, we'll return right away."

Al: "Huh?"

With a hard step, he kicked the floor directly with his foot, and Subaru's body made a half-turn. Al let out a dumb-sounding voice upon seeing the other side of door he had just gone out of.

With this in mind, Subaru pushed open the door of the room with force.

Then Subaru pointed into the room from which he and the others had just left—



Illustration from Volume 29, coloring by Floating ([source](#))

Subaru: “—Found yooou~, Olbart-san.”

???: “Kakakakka! Oioi, com’on, don’t’cha have a bad personality, for ya ta notice this right away? I’m blushin’ here, bein’ spotted this right outta the blue, it’s so embarrassin’!”

And Olbart, who had snuck into the room in Subaru and the others’ stead, laughed heartily at Subaru’s first declaration, as the latter pointed at himself.



Al: “Seriously, bro...!”

Al was surprised to see Olbart in the room, who was about to refill his cup with cold tea.

Much to his surprise, Medium and Louis followed suit, with an “Oh, it’s Gramps!” and an “Aa!”, respectively. Taritta widened her eyes, having peeked into the room as well.

Delayed by those reactions, Abel narrowed his eyes once Olbart’s figure finally came into view.

Abel: “«Behind the eyelids», I see.”

He looked down at Subaru’s young profile and muttered.

Abel: “Did you know from the start that this was the place?”

Subaru: “The expression «behind the eyelids» and the surroundings of the inn made this the first place I thought of. The type of person who offers you this kind of game’s definitely going to try to do this at least once.”

A distant, nostalgic memory came to Subaru’s mind with that answer— the memory of his first meeting with Beatrice, at the old Roswaal mansion.

Beatrice had attempted to have Subaru endlessly walk in the same space by creating a looping corridor using her magical ability. Unfortunately for Beatrice, Subaru had seen through her scheme at a glance and quickly figured out that the starting point was also the goal.

Now that Subaru thought about it, he was sorry that he had not gone along with the cute Beatrice's ruse. But his opponent now was not the mischievous Beatrice, he was a monstrous old man, now wasn't the time for holding back.

Therefore, he would distort his young face into a big grin and boast of his victory mercilessly.

Subaru: "Honestly, I saw right through you, Vicious Old Man."

Olbart: "Oioi, don't kick me while I'm down. This is an embarrassment I can't let the young people of my village see at all. Why don't'cha call yerself the Vicious Lil' Boy?"

Subaru: "I'll pass on that. I haven't done anything to be called vicious, after all."

Olbart: "Well, that's just bein' humble— Ya even went ta the trouble of speakin' in a loud voice for me ta hear as ya left the inn. It was some great actin'."

Subaru scratched his cheek at Olbart, who raised one eyebrow and sneered at him.

As expected, his intentions could be seen through after such an exaggerated act. However, even if he had been able to notice Subaru's true intentions, Olbart had no way to change his hiding place.

That was because this game was played by determining the hiding place they used first, and then giving clues accordingly.

Subaru: "I know it's really early in the first round to be discovered, but you're going to count it as one, right? You're not going to be in a bad mood just because I refused to take on the name «Vicious», are you?"

He wanted to avoid being dismissed "because these were anticlimactic results", or something like that.

To Subaru's request for confirmation born out of concern, Olbart closed one eye and said, "Of course",

Olbart: "My fault that the results were brought in so quickly. It's a bit unreasonable ta expect ya folks ta mop up my mess. Twice more, as agreed."

Medium: "Oh-! You did it, Subaru-chin! We got the first win in about ten seconds!"

Subaru: “Yeah, it’s good news.”

With Medium to his side overjoyed, Subaru patted his chest in relief.

For now, this concluded the first riddle from Olbart— indeed, it was a trial of sorts, borrowing the name “hide-and-seek”. It could be said that they were being asked to solve a problem on a test.

They were being tested to see if they were worthy of Olbart’s attention.

Subaru: “All of it is because of Beako’s...”

Help, he was about to say, as Subaru attempted to picture the adorable girl in his mind.

However, for a moment, that thought was bleached white, coming to a full stop.

Subaru: “———”

A feeling of slight discomfort and a slight tugging created a ripple in his heart.

Before he could pursue a definitive answer to what it was——

Olbart: “Well, I gotta redeem myself, so I’ll hurry ta the second hidin’ place.”

Subaru: “Oh, yeah, you’re right. So, what’s the next *jogen*?”

Olbart: “Hmm... The next hidin’ place’s gonna be somethin’ like...”

Folding his hands behind his back, Olbart leaned his head and body in thought. However, he did not spend much time pondering, and so the old man contorted his cheeks.

Olbart: “——«An abyss with a great view», ya might say.”

Al: “An abyss...”

Taritta: “With a great *view*?”

The words of Taritta and Al completed each other, as they ruminated on the bizarre hint left regarding the next hiding place.

But Olbart had no intention of leaving any further hints.

Olbart: “Ya were better than expected the first time ‘round, but the real game’s ‘bout ta begin.”

The old man smiled, his white teeth in full view, and then leapt backwards nimbly and gallantly. With that, Olbart opened the room’s window and put his foot on the windowsill without a care in the world.

Then, right before Subaru and the others looking on with eyes open wide, he jumped outside.

Olbart: “Next time, I’ll be sure ta hide a lil’ better!”

Al: “Wait, old man...! Shit, he’s gone!”

With haste and a yell, Al rushed to the window and looked around outside as he held his covered head.

In fact, it would be difficult to catch Olbart when he was dedicated to escape. His overwhelming ability to run away convinced Subaru that changing the game from “tag” to “hide-and-seek” had been the right call. Anyway—

Taritta: “Subaru, that man’s next hiding *place*...”

Medium: “Hmhm, Subaru-chin, did you understand? Do you know what it is?”

Subaru: “Uhh... That’s...”

Taritta and Medium turned to look at him expectantly, yet Subaru was at a loss for words.

As for the second hiding place’s hint, “an abyss with a great view”, Subaru honestly found no clue that could lead to an answer.

Subaru: “Sorry. Can’t think of anything right away. It’s not like I can read minds or anything, I just can read the situation.”

Medium: “I see~, I’m sorry! We can’t keep just relying on you! We’ll figure it out together!”

Taritta: “Yes, you’re *right*. I’m not very good at using my *head*, but I’ll keep thinking about *it*.”

Subaru bowed due to his uselessness, to which Medium and Taritta responded.

The initial hiding place could also be called the starting point, a typical development of sorts that had been realized.

Even if that had been off the mark, they could have easily tried it out in part because it was a location so close that there was almost no time loss. However, from here on—

Subaru: “It’s *tanni*¹⁵ going to be a race against time.”

Al: “—Bro also doesn’t have an idea of where he’s gonna hide next. Well, it isn’t anything surprising though.”

Subaru: “That’s right... Maybe I can’t be depended on, but it’s depressing to be told that in such a clear way.”

At the start of the real game of “hide-and-seek”, his allies stabbed him in the back.

Of course, Subaru took that as a fair assessment, but he really wished he would have been a bit less direct. Even close friends have some sense of consideration.

However, in response to Subaru’s words, Al waved his hand and said, “Oh, that’s not it”,

Al: “Well it isn’t unreasonable for you to not get it, bro. After all, I’m here with you.”

Subaru: “Hmm? I’ve got no idea what you’re talking about. Is it something like, my IQ goes down when you’re around, Al? What kind of *kej*¹⁶ is that?”

Al: “That ain’t what I’m talking about, but it’s hard to explain... right?”

Subaru: “Even if you ask me to agree, I still won’t get it.”

As he spoke, Al’s way of speaking, holding neither confidence nor certainty, was curious.

¹⁵ English flip. Means “simply” (単に), originally “シンプル” (simple).

¹⁶ English flip. Means “system” (系), originally “システム” (system).

He put Al aside, who was tilting his head, as he did not see how this topic could go any further in a constructive direction. The highest priority right now, was to figure out the “abyss with a great view” clue Olbart had left them with.

Subaru: “«Behind the eyelids» was the room where we started. «An abyss with a great view», another way to phrase it would be...”

Taritta: “«With a great view» means it’s probably considered a high *place*, *no*?”

Medium: “But an abyss is a hole, right? If it’s a hole, wouldn’t it be in the ground?”

Alternatively, it was possible that there was a spot in Chaosflame described as such.

In any case, it was unlikely that they would be able to reach the answer with the amount of information they could get from their room at the inn. At last, they would have to go into the city.

Al: “...I can’t get my head around this. Which reminds me, what’s Abel-chan’s plan?”

Abel: “It is not something that can proceed here, as I have told you. It would be convenient to have as many people as possible... And in addition to that, a place where outsiders come and go.”

Al: “You mean a place where strangers come and go? I wonder where in this city...”

The implementation of Abel’s plan caused Al to tilt his head.

The true meaning behind the idea of looking for a place where outsiders entered and exited was unknown to Subaru, but there was a good chance that Abel would not tell him even if he asked him to until they actually reached the execution phase. It could not be called an act that benefited their opponent, but it was difficult to deal with.

Of course, he was a man who would even discard the cards in his hand without a second thought for the sake of winning.

Subaru: “If it’s a place with a lot of people coming and going, that should be... a place to drink.”

Taritta: “A *tavern*?”

Subaru: “Yeah, there. I think we should try to go there or somewhere similar.”

It was debatable whether it was more beneficial to search for Olbart without taking any detours or to help Abel’s plan come to fruition, but for now, it seemed like a good idea to prioritize Abel first.

With that in mind, Subaru and the others headed out of the inn with a renewed spirit.

Abel: “Attracting the attention of the public with this crowd of children is not ideal.”

Subaru: “Don’t complain because four-sixths of us are children. In the first place, you’re not one to talk about public perception because of that oni mask you’re wearing. Or maybe, the perception... Uhh, does the effect of the mask make it look like it has a different face?”

Abel: “The mask does not alter its appearance from an oni’s face, it merely hides my identity.”

Subaru: “Then you’ll definitely stand out...”

With a small shrug of his shoulders, Subaru sighed, parrying aside Abel’s misguided frustration.

After greeting the shopkeeper at the entrance of the inn and asking them about the locations of some taverns, they went into the street. With that, they all walked towards a tavern to accomplish Abel’s aim.

And suddenly, in the middle of it all,

Subaru: “Instead of having all of us going to the tavern, wouldn’t it be better if we split up? One group goes to look for Olbart-san, and the other goes to the tavern with Abel—”

It happened just as he was about to suggest that they split up.

Subaru: “—Huh?”

Suddenly, a scarlet light scattered at the edge of his field of vision, dazzling Subaru’s eyes.

And then—



???: “Oh yeah, that’s a good name. We’ll just use that.”

Subaru: “Ueh?”

An unexpected voice struck Subaru’s eardrums as he blinked, his eyes simmering from the vermilion light.

The sound and its suddenness made a silly voice leak out, and a giggle broke out right in front of Subaru. A low chuckle it was, causing Subaru’s eyes to widen at its sound.

???: “Kakakakka! What’s with the dumb voice? I was just complimentin’ ya on the good name.”

Subaru: “...Olbart, san?”

An old man stood in front of him, clearing his throat and shaking his thin shoulders as he laughed.

It had happened so suddenly that Subaru had to blink his eyes a few times, unable to understand it. Then, he swallowed his saliva, and said what he had to declare,

Subaru: “Oh, found you, Olbart-san.”

Olbart: “—? Why’s that? Ya already feelin’ like you’re playin’ the game?”

Subaru: “Huh...?”

He noticed a sense of incongruity upon taking that chance at the unexpected second discovery.

Olbart’s attitude as he tilted his head and spoke that, coupled most of all with the discomfort regarding the scene around him— he was supposed to be out in the streets of the Demon City, but Subaru was in a room somewhere else.

—No, not in some room.

Subaru: “...No way.”

Subaru was in a room at an inn— The same lodgings they had just come out of.

And finally, there was the fact that Subaru was there, facing Olbart and talking to him.

Subaru: “———”

He had no choice but to accept that he had Returned by Death in contradiction to the rule that should have prevented that.

Arc 7 Chapter 44 - Shrinking Vision

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 29, Chapter 3 “Konkon”, Parts 1-3 (halfway)

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Edited Machine Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Original by Goldkills, Translation checked by Averitius, MaskedBook) — [Complete](#)

—The incomprehensible situation overwhelmed Natsuki Subaru’s small brain.

The situation was that shocking, it couldn’t be said in any other way.

Without being aware of his death, Subaru had returned to the time of the rule bantering with Olbart—even if he did not want to admit it, he had to.

Subaru had lost his life, and had Returned by Death back to this moment. Even so—

Subaru: “...It was in the middle of a game of hide-and-seek, in which death shouldn’t happen.”

Covering his mouth with his small palm, Subaru struggled desperately to recall what had happened.

The game of “hide-and-seek” with Olbart had begun, and, overcoming the monstrous old man’s predisposition for wickedness, within the first room— there, he had succeeded in finding the *shinobi* hidden “behind their eyelids”.

Going off that momentum, Subaru and the others had stepped out of the inn to identify the next hiding place of the mysterious old man. And then, suddenly, the world went dark.

The next thing he knew, he was back in this place.

Subaru: “———”

Abel: “—If we are to take up on your offer, we shall need to be clear about some matters.”

Olbart: “Oh, whaddya mean?”

Abel: “You yourself have said so. If you wish to give us a higher chance at victory, you should not leave too much room for pointless exertions— What is desired from one another must be made clear.”

Olbart: “—Kakakakka.”

While Subaru was having those thoughts, the negotiations with Olbart continued on to the next step one their own.

The next step in the conversation between Abel and Olbart would be the selection of the game, and after that was the premise of the rules. In other words—

Abel: “—Hide-and-seek it is.”

And so, Abel once again declared that.



—After that, the terms of the “hide-and-seek” game were exchanged with Olbart.

It also ended up being exactly as Subaru knew it would be. No new conditions were added, and no necessary details were cut. Inevitably, it stayed the same. Although—

Subaru: “Just to be completely sure, you’re only hiding, Olbart-san. You’re not going to sneak around and try to attack us...”

Olbart: “Oh, com’on now, you’re worryin’ too much, boy. Lemme tell ya, what I wanna test ya on’s yer quick thinkin’ and cleverness. If I wanted ta test yer strength, I could’ve done so yesterday at the castle tower.”

Subaru: “———”

Olbart’s words had the intention to reassure him, but he could not accept them as honest ones.

As a matter of fact, there was no doubt that Subaru had lost his life and Returned by Death. And the most immediate threat to Subaru's group was none other than the one in front of them, Olbart.

Had he perhaps broken the rule that forbid him from interfering, and targeted Subaru and the others?

Olbart: "Good grief, you're suspectin' me plenty, aren't'cha?"

Al: "You're in no position to be trusted, old man. That's rather impertinent of you."

Olbart: "Kakakakka! That's a good point. We got along so well eight years ago, and now you're so cold."

Having sensed a strong sense of caution in Subaru's silence, Olbart shrugged. After that, he gave a toothy grin at Al's remark, followed up by a smug retort.

Naturally, Al seemed to be dissatisfied with the way Olbart was talking to him, and fell silent. Anyhow—

Abel: "Olbart, this goes without saying, but there your hiding place is senseless if we cannot physically reach it. Do not attempt any of your petty tricks."

Olbart: "I gotcha, I gotcha. They're a wee bunch, aren't they? I wouldn't've done it even if ya hadn't told me."

Abel pointed out the same thing Subaru had in the previous loop. With Olbart's agreement on that, the start of the game was declared again.

In other words, the hint for the first hiding place would be presented.

Al: "So, where are you gonna hide first, old man?"

Olbart: "First of all, a tryout... Near this inn, I'm gonna hide «behind the eyelids»."

For a moment, Subaru felt an unpleasant tension in his heart, but it ended up being unneeded.

He feared that Olbart would designate a hiding place different from last time's, but that did not happen. After that, the flow of events was followed to a T, including the fact that Taritta and Al

resisted the urge to pounce on Olbart, his dignified back turned to them. They could not do anything other than just seeing him off. And so---

Al: "What's up, bro? You're looking a little pale."

Taritta lowered her bow at Abel's instruction, and in between studying her profile, Al called out to him. Those statements followed a slightly different flow compared to the previous loop.

Originally, he would have complained about the frustration of competing against Olbart, but this time he seemed to be concerned about Subaru's complexion— Or rather, it seemed to be concerned about Subaru's lack of talking.

That was only natural. Subaru himself was still confused and disoriented.

Since he himself was unable to recover from that sudden Return by Death and its psychological shock.

Subaru: "No, my bad. During that talk, I suddenly felt... really tired."

Al: "Oioi, get a grip, please. Mine and Medium-chan's abilities were halved because we were shrunkened, but unlike ours, your strong points should still be intact despite being small, right bro?"

Subaru: "My strengths..."

Medium: "Of course! The great thing about Subaru-chin's that he's smart! Big bro's amazing, but isn't Subaru-chin amazing too? It's all fine and dandy even if your boobies are small!"

Following Al's encouragement, Medium also joined in with good spirits.

While holding Louis in her arms, she patted her chest, her own breasts now gone. Observing the state of those two, Subaru then let out a long sigh.

Those two people who had encouraged him were right.

There were almost no situations in which Subaru would be physically useful to begin with, regardless of whether he had been made smaller. Because of that, Subaru was the one least affected by having been made smaller.

This was not the time for Subaru to be dragging out his mental exhaustion on and on.

Subaru: "...I've told you already, don't look at me like that. If you're going to show off the full effect of the oni mask, that «cognitive disruption» feature alone should be enough."

Abel: "You have regained some of your good judgement. But you have surprised me beyond my expectations. I took you as a fool on whom the effects of this mask had gone unnoticed for certain."

Subaru: "...I wouldn't have been surprised if you were just wearing the mask because of your eccentric behavior though."

Encouraged by Al and Medium, Subaru raised his face and sent a retort straight back to Abel.

Abel, who had been patronizing him and regarded him as a useless man, saw that Subaru had regained the strength to raise his head, which seemingly made him refrain to use any further sarcasm.

The fact that he felt this was a concession led one to believe that Abel's communication skills were not up to snuff, but there was no time to discuss it at this point.

Al: "So. I know he said he was gonna do a tryout first, but there are a lotta possible hiding places just around the inn, man. Bro, do you or Abel-chan have some kinda plan?"

With the purpose of moving the state of affairs along, Al turned his focus to Subaru and Abel.

As an answer to this, Subaru could present Olbart's first hiding place—the very room they were talking in at the moment was where the old man would return to, in fact.

Given that the hint left by Olbart was the same, there was no need to worry about that having changed.

The problem was that after they found Olbart, they would have to go outside the inn.

Subaru: "It's not a plan per say, but I can guess where «behind the eyelids» is referring to."

Al: "Oh, seriously? That's awesome, bro."

Subaru: "...It's just that there's a good chance that another problem's turned up besides this «behind the eyelids»."

Some sort of threat had assailed Subaru— No, not just Subaru, it had affected their entire group. And it was necessary to share it with Al, Abel, and the others who were unaware of it.

However, Subaru himself had gotten so little information that he did not have many reliable ideas to share. If there was something could say with certainty, that would be—

Subaru: "The agreement we made with Olbart-san... that he would not interfere, is there any chance that he'd break it?"

Abel: "Oh? Are you trying to say that, since the beginning, he was planning on violating the preconditions?"

Subaru: "Yeah, I'm thinking it's possible..."

Abel: "—No, that is impossible."

Due to the fact that he had been attacked as soon as he left the inn, Subaru tried to draw the attention of his friends to Olbart. However, that was denied by a very adamant Abel.

Once Subaru's eyes widened at his reaction, Abel folded his thin arms, and,

Abel: "Olbart would have nothing to gain with such a deed. Henceforth, that is impossible."

Subaru: "B-but Olbart-san had even been thinking about killing the Emperor! Even you said you had not imagined that at all... If so!"

Abel: "What you speak of, is the fact that the notion of posthumous fame is something I do not possess. But I do comprehend that such a thing does exist. And that there are those who desire it. However, this and that are two different stories."

Being shot with a sharp gaze through the oni mask, Subaru felt like his internal organs had been paralyzed by fear.

It was not as if Abel was emitting a special energy, one sharper than before. In spite of this, the feeling of being targeted did not disappear, and Subaru's breathing was disturbed.

While Subaru was struggling with this feeling, Abel continued with "May I?"

Abel: "It is as you yourself have spotted, and as per the rebuttal to that masked clown, there is no reason for Olbart Dunkelkenn to harm us himself. If his target is the Emperor's head, then he shall desire the intelligence I possess desperately. There is no basis for any such hypothesis whatsoever."

Al: "Ah, I'm with Abel-chan, bro. The old man's been ordered by the Emperor to leave us alone. If he was gonna break that promise, whether he does it inside or outside of the inn doesn't matter. Right?"

Subaru: "Uhh, does it...?"

Al: "Bro?"

Subaru: "Oh! No, you're right! Yeah, I think so too. That's for sure."

Abel and Al's continued talk caused Subaru's comprehension to fall behind for a few seconds.

However, once explained in a solid argument, it was something that Subaru could agree with.

Abel and the others were unaware of it, but Olbart had a history of killing Subaru and the others.

Nevertheless, Olbart's act was one that was driven by a logical train of thought for him, so Subaru was able to agree with the general argument presented by them. In that place, the only thing that had gone wrong had been the timing.

With that as the basis— that Subaru and the others had been killed as soon as they had left the inn was certainly strange according to the game rules Olbart had agreed to.

According to Al, if Olbart intended to kill them no matter what, it would have been better to murder them before they even left the inn, so that it would not be seen. Maybe he had a desire to kill them in a public place, but that would not make sense either.

Perhaps, though, he thought Subaru's group would be in for a more painful surprise were he to kill them once they obtained some peace of mind due to his intent to not kill them.

Subaru: “If that was the case, then he’d make more of an appearance, right?”

If Olbart was aiming to disrupt Subaru and the others’ moods because of the badness of his character, would not he want to see their disappointment and despair with his own eyes?

Aside from that, he could not think of any reason for Olbart to kill everyone outside the inn. Meaning—

Subaru: “What’s this supposed to mean...?”

Medium: “Hey, hey, Subaru-chin, what are you worried about? Are you worried about going outside?”

Subaru: “Huh?”

Then, Medium peered into Subaru’s face, who had fallen silent in his haste to sort out the situation.

Right in front of him was a pair of round blue eyes, and Subaru involuntarily turned away with a “Whoa!”. As an immediate reaction to his own, Medium let out a “Wow!”, and quickly grabbed his hand. And so—

Medium: “There there, Subaru-chin, calm down, calm down.”

Subaru: “—Ah.”

Medium then pulled his hand, and held Subaru’s head to her chest.

As she slowly stroked his back, he could feel the beating of her heart on his forehead and cheeks. Her heart beat in a steady rhythm, tenderly smashing Subaru’s frozen consciousness.

Medium: “When my head gets all messed up, I ask big bro to do this for me too-. Big bro also used to have people do this for him.”

Subaru: “...It calms me down, I can feel it.”

Medium: “Yeahyeah, good! So, we can stay like this and you can tell me what’s going on, ok? What’s Subaru-chin worried about outside?”

Medium’s voice, coming down from directly above him, did not rush Subaru to answer.

Subaru wished to be spoiled by Medium's generosity and kindness that did not change even though she had been made younger. But he knew that the current time would not allow that.

So, as a trade-off, while having his head held by Medium like that, with difficulty he developed a thought.

Subaru: "It's just that... I feel, like there's a dangerous situation, outside the inn..."

Medium: "Is it dangerous out there?"

Subaru: "Yeah, that's right. I think, someone's trying, to kill us..."

Nodding her head, Medium listened to Subaru's overly vague idea. To be honest, even he could notice that the statement was too unconvincing and unfounded.

Without being able to better word himself, he would never be able to convince Abel and Al, Medium regardless. Like, as an example—

Subaru: "Actually, if we go outside the in, that's where we die—"

—At that moment, the world stood still.

Subaru: "——"

The clear, audible pulse of Medium faded into eternity, and her face and breathing, which were right in front of him, went out of reach.

Anything and everything, was faraway.

Color was lost, sound was lost, the flow of time was lost, the freedom to move was lost.

He could not move. He did not move. He was not moved. He was not allowed to move.

And then, with his voice, his breathing and even his eyes prohibited of freewill, something repulsive, terrifying, frightening slowly loomed towards the edge of Subaru's consciousness.

Why, was he violating the Taboo; as if it were lamenting that, the sable shadow crept closer towards him.

Why, did he forget this; slender dark-pigmented fingers slid into his chest without effort.

Why, would he repeat this so many times; the voice of the Witch arrived, blotting out anything and everything.

???: *"I love you."*

A voice that had not been heard in a very, very long time, dragged Subaru to hell.

His heart was gripped, and a tremendous pain tore Subaru's motionless body to shreds. It tormented him. It violated him. Humiliated him— Marked him, so he would never forget it again.

And then—

Subaru: "—Hk."

Medium: "Subaru-chin?"

Suddenly, sound, color, the flow of time returned, and he felt the fierce flow of blood throughout his body.

His head remained pressed against Medium's chest, but what he picked up was not her tender heartbeat, but the resumption of his own blood flow and his own unusual, frightened, racing heartbeat.

The Witch's anger at having broken the Taboo was immense, to the point of losing his voice, to the point of breaking his understanding, to the point of violating his soul. Subaru cursed himself.

Why, had he put himself through so much pain and suffering, he wondered.

By no means, could he confide in others about Return by Death.

He could not even inadvertently speak of it in something like an analogy.

If he attempted to convey those intentions of his to anyone, that dark-colored evil hand— that of the Witch of Envy, would overcome any obstacle and reach for Subaru's heart. Not to mention—

Subaru: "That was a close one..."



Illustration from Volume 29, coloring by DdukaE ([source](#))

Muttering so, Subaru checked the presence of the one holding him, Medium, and that of the ones surrounding him, Abel, Al, Taritta and Louis.

The feeling of heat rising in the corner of his eyes was one of relief that they had not been harmed—
The confession of Return by Death carried alongside a risk utmost feared by Subaru.

That was, the possibility that the evil hand would lay harm on someone other than Subaru and that, unlike the threat Subaru faced, it would not dispel its power until it severed their thread of life.

If that possibility were not actualized, and the only one to suffer were Subaru, that would be the next best outcome.

Of course, it was undeniable that the optimal would have been if Subaru had not been subjected to any pain.

Subaru: “Medium, san... Thank you, I’m okay now.”

Medium: “Really? Like, you look even more pained than before...”

Subaru: “If I’m the only one feeling miserable, that’d seriously be the best thing in this situation.”

Raising his face towards her, Subaru was released from Medium’s embrace. Although Medium looked somewhat hesitant about it, she was unable to say anything more at Subaru’s insistence.

As much as her concern was appreciated, the situation did not allow for it. And without exaggeration, the fact remained that Medium had helped a lot.

Subaru: “I’m sorry if I sound weird and unsettling. But I really feel it’s... dangerous outside. So.”

Al: “Don’t go out there, you say? But then we wouldn’t play the game with Olbart. Of course, there’s always the option of not playing the game with him.”

Subaru: “———”

Abel: “In that case, we shall have no choice but to cancel our negotiations with Yorna Mishigure. This trip has been a long one, and you, the clown, and Medium have all shrunk as a result.”

Al: “Well, some people might desire the result of being rejuvenated for the rest of their lives, you know?”

He followed up Abel’s cold-hearted statement with an impotent tease; Al’s point, however, was squarely contradicted by Olbart’s statement.

Albeit the details were unknown, it seemed that the “infantilization” that had befallen Subaru and the others had some disadvantages. It was not just simple rejuvenation, it seemed.

In other words, this “infantilization” was, without a doubt, a bomb.

Al: “In any case, I can’t stay small. Since we chose not to surround the old man and beat him, we gotta win the game of hide-and-seek.”

Subaru: “I know. I’m not going to forfeit the game. It’s just that it’s really dangerous out there. So...”

Abel: “And so?”

Subaru: “Well, I want to be careful if we go out there. Also, I want you to believe me when I say very strange things.”

Abel: “———”

Subaru appealed, looking straight ahead and up at the man standing before him.

He could see Abel’s eyes narrowing through the oni mask at the off-hand remark. He could tell that Al was also subtly baffled, as well.

Certainly he was not persuasive, and he lacked the trial-and-error of trying to persuade them.

Taritta: “*Nevertheless*, Subaru does speak some *truth*. We’ve been caught in an enemy *trap*, and this is a place that should be considered enemy *territory*. So, there’s no harm in raising our *guard*.”

Medium: “Yesyes, I agree with Taritta-chan! Let’s be careful! If I get any smaller, I won’t be able to stop Louis-chan.”

Louis: “Auu.”

However, Taritta and Medium agreed with Subaru's opinion. It was unclear what Louis's intentions were as of her shout at the end, but it appeared that there had been no hostility towards Subaru there.

Taritta and the others who were in tune with him were not talking about anything difficult. They were just trying to increase their own awareness of the need to be careful, because there was no such thing as too much caution.

Subaru could not think of any reason for Abel's reluctance, aside from the fact Abel just didn't like him.

Subaru: "If you don't accept it, well then, I'll show you some proof."

Abel: "Proof, is it?"

Subaru: "Proof that my ideas shouldn't be ignored. I'll tell you where Olbart-san is. I'll tell you where he's hiding, where that «behind the eyelids» is."

Abel: "Do you believe that to be enough of a bargaining chip? One way or another, you must reveal it. It is you who shall suffer the disadvantage of concealing it."

Subaru: "Ugh..."

However, stubborn as he was, Abel refuted Subaru's opinion, which provoked a spontaneous groan from the latter, lost for words. Before he could say anything else, Al interrupted with "Now now",

Al: "Abel-chan, bro said he's gonna give us something to base a decision out of. In fact, what he said was so outta nowhere, that I can't get rid of the *gimonfu*¹⁷ over my head. But it's not the first time he's said something outrageous. Right?"

Abel: "-----"

Al: "If you ain't listening to bro's opinion here, there's no point in bringing him along. And if you're still gonna say you'll disrespect him, well, then you're just gonna ruin my mood too."

¹⁷ Engrish flip. Means "meaning" (疑問符), originally "ハテナマーク" (question mark). The "ハテナ" isn't really Engrish, but it's difficult to get an expression that doesn't feel weird without replacing that as well.

Abel: “Ho.”

As Al tried to cover Subaru with his back they changed positions, Al’s voice, as he confronted Abel, dropped in tone.

Even though it was a deep voice at the level of a young boy, it was low enough to change the mood. Abel’s gaze, looking down on him, also turned cold, causing Subaru to gulp.

Abel’s relationship with Al was much more fragile than Subaru had expected, although he had not paid much attention to it so far.

Originally, Al had accompanied Subaru to the Demon City with the intention of going along with him. And, like Subaru, he was a human being belonging to the Kingdom of Lugunica, so he was not too concerned about Abel’s return to the throne.

In blunt terms, it was the desire of Al’s master, Priscilla.

Therefore, Al personally had no reason to support either Abel’s cause or Abel himself.

Here it was manifesting itself as a distinct crack in their relationship.

Physically, Al had shrunk to a ten-year-old him, but could Abel really beat Al? Al’s true capabilities in this state were unknown to him, and there was no benefit in letting this stare-off continue for long. So—

Subaru: “Stop fighting! All right, I lost! I give up!”

Wrapping around his protector, Al, to put himself in front, Subaru raised his voice.

There was nothing good to be gained here in a disagreement among allies. It would be much better for Subaru to become the bad guy, than to continue such a useless struggle.

Besides, either way, he had been able to warn them.

Taritta, Medium, and even Al must have heard Subaru’s plea. They would be very careful once they left the inn.

The problem would be, when death loomed in a way that made caution scarce.

At that point, Subaru would have to put his body on the line and do something about it.

Subaru: “We can’t be wasting time here! Everyone, ready up!”

Abel: “—So, where do you believe «behind the eyelids» is?”

Subaru: “It’s...”

At any rate, Subaru insisted that they should avoid wasting time in this place. Abel finally responded positively to Subaru’s words.

The fact that this alone led to relief spoke volumes about the flawed people skills His Excellency the Emperor had.

Anyway, Subaru decided to answer with honesty.

Olbart’s first hiding place, that would be—



Olbart: “Next time, I’ll be sure to hide a lil’ better!”

Al: “Wait, old man...! Shit, he’s gone!”

Opening the room’s window, Olbart jumped out of the inn.

Al hurriedly followed the nimble-footed old man, but by the time he reached the window, the skilled *shinobi* had long since disappeared into the hustle and bustle of the city.

The speed with which he escaped was peerless, you could only be amazed by it or utterly frustrated.

Taritta: “Subaru, that man’s next hiding *place*...”

Medium: “Hmhm, Subaru-chin, did you understand? Do you know what it is?”

Everything has developed as it had before; with Subaru having found Olbart's first hiding place without trouble, Taritta and Medium both looked at him with expectation.

However, unfortunately, the second hiding place—the answer to “abyss with a great view”, was unknown.

He was unable to give them a suitable answer, and Medium and the others slumped their shoulders, although they collected themselves again, following the same flow as last time.

Al: “So, how's it going, Abel-chan? Bro did a great job guessing right where that old man was, didn't he?”

Abel: “He deserves credit for his accomplishments.”

Al: “...That's all?”

Abel: “As usual, we have no time to spare. We must uncover Olbart's whereabouts twice more. What else is there?”

Al: “...Is that so.”

Perhaps because of the earlier conversation, Al, prodding Abel, drooped his shoulders due to the latter's answer.

Al's sentiment was nice, but that Abel would react like so was predictable. Subaru did not recall getting any comments on the results or anything in particular from Abel the last time around.

In fact, it was difficult to imagine him praising others, not just Subaru, honestly.

This time, it was just another act that did not betray Abel's character.

Taritta: “«With a great view» means it's probably considered a high *place*, *no*?”

Medium: “«But an abyss» is a hole, right? If it's a hole, wouldn't it be in the ground?”

Subaru: “I think you're both on the right track. To answer that question... Abel, I believe you wanted to go to a place with a lot of people?”

Abel: “———”

Taritta and Medium speculated on Olbart’s next hiding place.

To move that discussion forward, Subaru wanted to implement the plan from Abel that had not come to pass in the previous loop. As per his memories, Abel had originally planned to go to a crowded tavern.

As soon as they left the inn, a sudden “death” had befallen Subaru and the others amidst the street.

Putting it in another way, the moment in question was fast approaching.

Subaru: “Oi, Abel?”

Abel: “—Your thoughts are not erroneous. A location with many people coming and going... It would also be preferable to be in a place with a lot of people.”

Al: “A place where people come and go...”

Subaru: “A place to drink... A tavern, was it?”

The conversation proceeded at a brisk pace, and Abel nodded in agreement once Subaru used that word.

And so, once they were all settled on leaving the inn and head for a tavern—

Abel: “We shall avoid the front, and leave using the inn’s backdoor.”

And it was Abel, of all people, to speak so.

Subaru let out a dumbfounded “What?” to that change in opinions. Al and Taritta raised their eyes too.

Medium: “Huh? Abel-chin, does that mean you believe what Subaru-chin said?”

Abel: “There is nothing better than staying vigilant. Now that we have pinpointed Olbart’s whereabouts, there is room for consideration. What I am saying is nothing more, yes?”

Subaru: “...You, really are a piece of work.”

To those words laced with resentment from Subaru, Abel merely responded with a snort from his nose.

However, his haughty attitude aside, Abel's decision was helpful to Subaru. Subaru was similarly hoping to somehow lead everyone to the backdoor.

Al: "I think, that means he has the intention to properly give you credit, bro."

Subaru: "...Looks like it. Rather, that's the way it's always been."

Somehow, he also doubted Abel's attitude of "definite punishment or reward".

If he could understand that aspect, it should help him to get a rough idea of a way to deal with Abel; Subaru himself was already supposed to start grasping him this way.

It was as if he were learning how to deal with Abel all over again.

Al: "But I'm still stunned that you were able to guess the old man's location. I dunno how you did it— It's like, you read a strategy guide for this."

Subaru: "A strategy guide, that sounds so damn nostalgic. Well, it'd be useful to have something like that, but that's not remotely it. That was just experience coming into play."

Al: "Experience? Of playing hide-and-seek?"

Subaru: "It's similar, you know. Like before... Like before?"

As he responded to his achievement of finding Olbart being probed, Subaru's thoughts ground to a halt.

One of the reasons as to why Subaru had been able to tell that Olbart was hiding in the starting room, was because that was a typical development for the kind of behavior a person like him would have.

Still, someone must have done something similar to that predictable event before Olbart.

So, Subaru should remember it clearly.

Al: "Forgetting things? Forgetfulness's something old people do. Funny that, contrary to what you'd expect, although you're young now, you're forgetful too, bro."

Subaru: “Forgetful...”

Al: “That’s it, isn’t it? If it was someone else, it was someone close to you, bro. It shouldn’t be the silver-haired girl, maybe the *loli* that was always with you...”

Subaru: “—Beatrice!”

Al: “Whoa.”

Al’s shoulders trembled as Subaru looked up and gave a powerful shout.

But Subaru had no time to deal with Al’s surprise. Of course not.

Subaru: “Stop joking...”

No matter what he made of it, it was strange.

It was Beatrice, Beatrice. Subaru’s partner, a Great Spirit both pretty and sweet. The clue to finding Olbart had been the first prank she played on Subaru.

If there was anyone that could take credit for that, it should be earned by Subaru and Beatrice.

And yet, it was impossible that he’d just let that slip away.

It was something that shouldn’t have happened.

Taritta: “Subaru, Al, please come *here*!”

Suddenly, Taritta’s sharp voice called out to the stunned Subaru.

Looking up at her in reflex, he saw Taritta at the back door of the inn, peeking out the crack of the slightly-open door to the outside. Her face, seen from the side, had a look of intense alarm.

The reason for this alertness was probably nothing other than the death that had struck Subaru and the others—

Taritta: “—We’re already *surrounded*. There’s probably close to a hundred of *them*.”

Arc 7 Chapter 45 - Konkon

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 29, Chapter 3 “Konkon”, Parts 3 (halfway)-5 (halfway)

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Edited Machine Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Original by Goldkills, Kiln, Translation checked by Averitius, PaperKaminari) — [Complete](#)

—Tiger at the front gate, wolf at the back gate¹⁸.

Strictly speaking, his situation was different, but it was a saying that crossed Subaru’s mind.

The fact that it had taken him a while to come up with even that saying really showed the difficulty of Subaru’s circumstances.

Al: “Nearly a hundred enemies!?”

Looking out the back door of the inn, Al’s voice cracked as Taritta told them the startling news.

In response, Taritta nodded quietly saying,

Taritta: “Yes. We’re *surrounded*. It seems more likely out of caution than *hostility*...”

Abel: “Sure, merely one or two people would be one thing, but it is difficult to ignore when they number close to a hundred.”

Keeping his voice low, Abel spoke to Taritta, who shut the back door.

As Taritta lowered her chin at his words, Abel’s gaze turned from her towards Subaru. His black eyes narrowed through the oni mask, his sharp glare pinning down Subaru’s heart. And then—

¹⁸ Translation note from Witch Cult Translations: “A Japanese idiom for a situation in which it is obvious that even if one difficult problem or disaster is solved or avoided, another difficult problem or disaster will be faced, henceforth making it extremely difficult to escape danger.”

Abel: “—You have problems aside from being surrounded, do you not?”

Subaru: “—Ah.”

Abel: “Against all reason, your limbs have shrunk. Anything could happen.”

Mixed with a faint sigh, Abel spelled that out, having guessed the abnormality with Subaru.

Because of his words, Subaru felt his cheeks become warm with shame. From the knowledge that Abel had been able to notice his disorder, and also from the awareness that he was holding them back.

He would rather even pretend that there was nothing wrong with himself. However—

Medium: “Subaru-chin, are you okay?”

The voice of Medium, which had comforted the troubled Subaru just before, made him stop.

Being stubborn in this situation would not solve anything. In addition, not only Subaru, but also his friends, Medium included, would suffer the consequences of his stubbornness. So—

Subaru: “Actually, I feel like... My memory’s getting weird. I’m having trouble remembering things that I should remember, and that’s probably not good.”

Al: “...That’s why you were so strange a moment ago, huh?”

Subaru swallowed his frustration and frankly spoke to Al, who was struck speechless.

Al, too, must have felt there was something strange about Subaru’s earlier behavior. Talking about the details made him feel uneasy as well.

What had happened to Subaru was no stranger to Al.

Abel: “—Anything specific?”

Subaru: “...I couldn’t remember the name of an important family member. No! Uh, it’s just that it took a while before I could recall it.”

Al: “Bro, this ain’t the time to pretend you’re fine...”

Subaru: "I'm not trying to pretend I'm..."

Subaru was about to reflexively answer, "Fine", but then he stopped himself, wondering whether he was or not.

He really didn't want to say it so plainly that he'd forgotten the name of someone so important. Subaru remembered Beatrice, remembered Emilia, and remembered Rem.

He also remembered the friends he had left behind at the mansion.

Subaru: "So it's not like I was trying to..."

Abel: "Tell me exactly what your condition is."

Subaru: "Huh?"

Abel: "Have you forgotten? Or does it take you a long time to remember? Which is it?"

Upon being asked this question, Subaru clammed up.

Abel's question, as he neared one step closer to him, was firm, and had a sharpness that did not allow for lies.

There was a numbing sensation in his brain, and he was unable to pull his consciousness away from the man in front of him. As Subaru fell silent, Abel asked again, "Which is it?",

Abel: "You cannot see what is occurring in your environs, and now you cannot see what is occurring inside your own head."

Subaru: "—N-no! It's not that I forgot, it's just that I'm having trouble remembering! That's right, just because I can't recall quickly, doesn't mean I forgot!"

Abel: "...It takes a while to remember, huh?"

Subaru quickly responded to the cruel inquiry, and Abel quietly accepted his answer.

It was an explanation that Subaru himself didn't know what to make of. So it was surprising that Abel did not outright dismiss it.

In fact, annoyed with Abel's behavior, Al intervened with "Hey",

Al: "What's the difference? Why's that a big deal to you in this situation?"

Abel: "There is a big difference. There is a world of difference between forgetting and having difficulty remembering."

Al: "Huh?"

Al grumbled in displeasure, but Abel did not answer any further.

He looked back at Taritta listening to what was happening outside, leaving the bewildered Subaru and Al to their own thoughts.

Abel: "What is happening outside? They have yet to move, correct?"

Taritta: "For *now*, they're just concealing their *breath*. Even though their encirclement should be complete by *now*."

Abel: "Then that signifies we have not met their requirements."

Taritta: "*Requirements*, is it...?"

Abel stroked his chin thoughtfully, without responding to Taritta's puzzled look, and then looked back at Subaru once more.

Unable to keep up with the speed of his thoughts, Subaru flinched as Abel turned back. Closing the distance between him and the one taken aback, Abel put his face close to Subaru's and asked,

Abel: "—What do we do for those outside to attack us?"

Subaru: "Eh..."

Abel: "Answer. The conditions for those outside to attack us are..."

Subaru: "T-that, even if you ask me..."

The question was repeated through the oni mask, and Subaru caught his breath, tensing up.

“I don’t understand it, even if you ask me”, he thought. At any rate, even if he remembered what had happened before he Returned by Death, it had been such a sudden and unexpected death that he could not comprehend it at all.

If only he had more information, he’d be able to give Abel a better idea of what to do—

Abel: “Answer.”

However, Abel trampled on Subaru’s hesitation and confusion, directing him a question. With Subaru unable to answer, the man donning the oni mask grabbed him by his young shoulders in a fit of rage.

Abel: “Answer! Natsuki Subaru!”

Subaru: “I-I don’t know! A-as soon as we go outside, they’ll attack us! That’s all I know!”

Replying upon being threatened, Subaru opened his eyes and clutched his chest.

Once again, he impulsively revealed the information he had obtained through Return by Death. He was afraid that the penalty for violating the Taboo might come back to haunt him. But nothing happened.

Neither the stoppage of time around him, nor the evil hand that made him pay for his stupidity, manifested. But instead—

Louis: “Uu!”

Having gotten between Subaru and Abel with a snarl, Louis protected Subaru with her back towards him as she glared directly at Abel, who had adopted a hardline attitude.

Abel’s arm was forced away from Subaru’s shoulder by Louis, sending her a disapproving look. However, Louis was soon joined by a reassuring ally, Medium.

Medium: “Abel-chin! Don’t bully Subaru-chin! I’ll tell big bro!”

Abel: “...What should I do, being told that? In the first place, he just gave me necessary information—
Going outside is the trigger, huh?”

Abel shrugged his shoulders at Medium’s reproachful glare, without even feeling remorse.

His thoughtful expression caused Medium to say, “Geez!” as she put her hands on her hips, directing her eyes at Subaru rather than Abel.

Medium: “Subaru-chin, are you okay? Abel was scary, wasn’t he-?”

Subaru: “It’s not like I was scared. I was just a little surprised... Yeah.”

Medium: “Really? I hope so. You’re a strong boy, a strong boy, Subaru-chin.”

As she said this, Medium’s hand stroked Subaru’s black hair with gentleness.

The kindness of her touch, and the fact that he was being praised as a “strong boy”, made him feel ashamed once again. But in fact, he couldn’t deny that his racing heart was slowly calming down.

He thought he really was losing it.

The relief he felt at being comforted by Medium aside, more troubling were the unspeakable feelings of reluctance and fear he felt towards Abel.

He couldn’t resist Abel’s will, and so, he kept getting pushed around. It was like---

Al: “It’s like a child and an adult. And I’m not just talking about looks.”

Subaru: “Ugh...”

Al’s voice came from beside the downcast face of Subaru, as the latter gripped his chest.

Subaru’s face tightened as he felt he was being judged by Al, whose tone of voice was harsh, still reeling from his earlier conversation with Abel.

Because of his words, “a child and an adult”, Subaru’s doubts were cleared up.

Yes, Al was right, that was the appropriate way to describe it. In fact, the current interaction between Subaru and Abel was similar to the power dynamic between a child and an adult.

Not just in appearances, but also in mind, as if the latter were being pulled along by the former.

Abel: “---Listen. I think I know who we are up against.”

Taritta: “D-do you *really*...!?”

While Subaru was experiencing an unfathomable sense of dread, Abel spoke in a low voice.

Abel’s words made Taritta’s eyes widen in surprise. It was not only her who was surprised, but also everyone else present. To be more precise, everyone except Louis, who was not following the conversation.

At any rate, Abel got everyone’s attention and nodded with a “Yes”.

Abel: “From the conditions presented by Olbart, and the hundred enemies identified by Taritta... If we exclude those possibilities that cannot be, we can, naturally, narrow down the options.”

Al: “So, what do you think, oh clever Abel-chan? Who’s after us?”

Abel: “—It is Chaosflame.”

Al & Medium: “Chaosflame... this city?”

In response to Al and Medium’s question, Abel nodded grimly.

He then looked over at Subaru and the rest, whose expressions showed that they still hadn’t put his answer together, and continued,

Abel: “Chaosflame... That is, the residents of the Demon City. Those standing outside poised to attack, I am sure they are the very people residing in this city.”



—Abel made a clear statement that the inhabitants of Chaosflame were the enemy.

Subaru: “———”

At Abel’s declaration, Subaru opened and closed his mouth in disbelief— No, not only Subaru, but Al and the others had their own reactions of astonishment as well.

That would be natural. Considering they had suddenly been told that the people of the city had turned against them.

Al: “Are you sure, that can’t be right. What gave you that idea?”

Abel: “It is quite the natural thought. In the first place, there are only a limited number of people capable of mobilizing a force of a hundred men to surround the inn. At this point, there are only two choices... The Emperor’s group, and the Demon City’s forces. However, Chisha is disguised as me. Furthermore, he does not possess the leeway to do what I would not do.”

Al: “So that others won’t find out he’s not Abel-chan. So, what wouldn’t you do?”

Abel: “Brazenly sending my forces to the Demon City.”

Subaru nearly nodded at the conclusive statement, but he couldn’t decide if it was definitive information or not. If a hundred soldiers accompanied the ruler, would that be too many or too few?

He did not believe it strange at all, if that many were present.

Medium: “I dunno much about it, but how many soldiers are there at Abel-chin’s castle?”

Abel: “Are you inquiring about the number of troops at the Imperial Capital? If so...”

When Medium raised her hand to ask a question, Abel glanced at Subaru. He was unable to understand the meaning of his gaze; Abel touched the forehead of his oni mask, and after a moment of contemplation said,

Abel: “Some insignificant thirty-thousand. But this talk is not about the forces at his command. Whether or not the Emperor would allow them to accompany him, is the topic of this conversation. And—”

Taritta: “The real Emperor would never do such a *thing*.”

Abel: “That is what I meant.”

Abel nodded his head. He denied the possibility of the false Emperor making such a careless decision.

Subaru felt that there was a possibility that the other party could have been careless, but he kept his mouth shut. He would not be listened to, even if he had said it. In any case—

Abel: “The Emperor declared it forbidden to touch us, and Olbart displayed an approach that adhered to that order. With that case as valid, dispatching a force at us would make no sense.”

Al: “...What about a theory like, he didn’t do it himself, or something like that?”

Abel: “Now, I shall ask you, do you believe I would ever allow that line of reasoning?”

Taritta: “I don’t think so.”

Synchronized with Taritta’s answer, Al similarly denied it with a shake of his masked head.

As long as the fake Emperor was disguised as Abel, his lines of thought must be the same as Abel’s as an Emperor. In other words, what Abel would not allow, the fake Emperor could not allow.

And so, the false Emperor would have to continue a pretense of being very narrow-minded.

Abel: “Kafma Irulux would not permit it, even if an attempt was made to reason with him. He is inflexible. And therefore, he is a valuable asset, but I am certain General Second-Class Kafma would not condone this crooked interpretation.”

Subaru: “Kafma... Would that be the straight-laced guy we saw yesterday?”

Abel: “He might be meek towards the Emperor, but he shall opine without hesitation even against a General First-Class. Even Olbart’s cunning shall be unable to bend Kafma’s principles.”

Al: “That lil’ bro’s got that much power?”

Abel: “At one time, he was approached for a promotion to Divine General. For a variety of reasons, he passed up on it.”

As a response to Abel’s answer, Al let out a frustrated “Ugh”.

If this was true, then two Divine General-class people had been present in the Castle yesterday— Nay, three, since the fake Emperor was one of them.

That may indeed be more reliable manpower compared to bringing in unskilled troops.

Subaru: “But if the false Emperor’s not the enemy, then...”

Naturally, the conjecture that Abel had proposed became more and more realistic.

In other words, the inhabitants of the Demon City of Chaosflame were the ones waiting for them outside, and the leader who had made them move was—

Medium: “Are you saying Yorna-chan’s making them attack us?”

Al: “...It’s hard to think of anyone else, isn’t it? There’s no one else who knows about us and has a good reason to target us to begin with.”

Subaru: “—What does Abel think?”

Someone within the Demon City of Chaosflame who could move its inhabitants as pawns; naturally, the first person that came to mind was Yorna Mishigure, the ruler of the Demon City.

However, was it possible that she, being as unpredictable as Olbart— No, perhaps even harder to predict, was the mastermind behind the whole situation?

In response to Subaru’s suspicion, Abel tapped his finger on the forehead of his oni mask,

Abel: “That is asinine.”

And his reply was brief.

Subaru: “Asinine? Errr, does that mean you don’t agree? Why?”

Abel: “It would be pride to believe that if you ask, you shall receive an answer for everything— The missive.”

Subaru: “The missive?”

Abel replied to Subaru’s question while adding an unnecessary sentence.

The missive was the letter they had delivered to Yorna the previous day. Delivering that letter had been the purpose of the previous day's visit and was bound to be the reason for the current day's summons.

Abel had not told them in detail what he had written in the letter, though.

Abel: "In the missive, I wrote that I would reward her with that which she desires."

Al: "The thing that lady wants... In other words, the position of Empress Consort?"

Medium: "To be your wife?"

Once Abel mentioned the contents of the missive, Al and Medium spoke in quick succession.

As they had been told the prior day, Yorna wanted the Emperor. Not necessarily Abel, but the Emperor's status.

So if it were true that he had written that he would give Yorna what she coveted, it should be like that.

Subaru: "How the heck did you decide to convey something like that in a letter?"

Abel: "Do not trivialize the problem using your own standards. Whatever it is, she shall achieve what she desires. Hence why we were summoned to the Castle. It is illogical for her to send her forces against us in spite of that."

Al: "Ahhh~, what if she hates being Abel-chan's wife so much that she wants to kill him..."

Or perhaps, the letter was so rude that she wanted to kill them.

Subaru thought that there was a very good chance that he would be treating the person he was going to marry in a pompous manner, because he behaved that way in person.

But Abel scoffed at the idea Subaru and the rest had.

Abel: "What she must do, she shall. Emotions are secondary. She is not like Priscilla."

Al: "I did think that lady was just as troublesome as the Princess!"

Subaru agreed to that. Priscilla and Yorna were both scary.

He was afraid of Priscilla and Yorna both, but he felt that Abel had a point because it had been stated with such conviction— Also, he recalled his memories of Yorna from the previous day.

Yorna: “As the Lord of the Demon City, I won’t speak lies in front of my attendants.”

So Yorna had said, her words spoken with a bewitching smile regarding the matter of the letter that Subaru and the others had present her with, a promise that she would not throw it away without reading it.

Subaru and the others fell into the stables afterwards, and then, Tanza, Yorna’s attendant, had declared that Yorna had recognized Subaru and his companions.

At the very least, Subaru did not take her as a woman who would change her previous statements at will.

He did not, so he wished to believe what Abel had said.

Taritta: “In any case, those outside should be getting impatient right about *now*. What should we *do*?”

Keeping an eye on the outside, Taritta questioned them about their next move.

Abel had spoken of a trigger for an assault— as in, the conditions that would make the other party attack them, but, so far, they could only guess that it would be them going outside. But with the other side prepared to attack them, they did not know when they may force their way in.

In addition, Subaru and the rest were in the middle of a game of hide-and-seek.

Subaru: “Even if we know the people outside are coming in, we can’t just not leave, right?”

Al: “Well, unless the old man outplayed our outplaying, and hid in the inn for a second time... Just in case, should we take another look at the room?”

Abel: “I would have considered that if we did not have the clue, «an abyss with a great view».”

So Abel dismissed him, and Al hung his head in disappointment.

In fact, Subaru'd had the thought that Olbart would be hiding in the first room once more as well. But no matter how much he thought about it, he could not connect it to "an abyss with a great view". So he had not touched on it.

In the meantime, their group's course of action was being finalized.

Of course, there was no other choice for them but to make their debut. The question was, what kind of strategy should they use to make that option work?

Abel: "—Taritta, draw their attention."

Subaru: "Abel!?"

A moment later, Abel gave what seemed to be the cruelest instruction of all.

Hearing this, Taritta's cheeks hardened, and Subaru criticized Abel in a shrill voice. But Abel ignored Subaru's voice, keeping his gaze on Taritta, and continued,

Abel: "Make a great ruckus and capture the attention of those outside. Meanwhile, we shall sneak out."

Al: "Abel-chan, a better, understandable plan would be..."

Abel: "There is none. This is the best we can muster with the cards in our possession. If you had not been shrunk, we might have been able to find another method."

Subaru: "That's going too far!"

Louis: "Auu!"

Abel dismissed Al's concern for Taritta's safety.

Along with Subaru snapping at him for his cruelty, Louis voiced her righteous indignation as well. However, as a reaction to Subaru and the others—

Taritta: "Yes, *understood*. I'll draw the attention of the group *outside*."

Subaru: "Taritta-san! No matter how you look at it..."

Shaking her head sideways, Taritta was prepared to accept Abel's reckless instructions.

Subaru wanted to find a better method that could ensure her safety, somehow. However, the only two things that came to Subaru's mind at this moment were caution and anxiety towards the very dangerous enemies outside.

Abel: "Taritta, hand me that package. We shall need it later."

Taritta: "Here it *is*. Once I have their full *attention*, please take advantage of the opportunity and *escape*. *However*, I don't think I'll have a chance to give you a *signal*..."

Abel: "I shall allow Medium to decide that."

Medium: "Eh, me?"

Abel received the package Taritta was carrying, his slender form shouldering the bag. As Abel continued with the preparations, Medium, having been designated by name, widened her eyes.

Turning to face her, Abel nodded, together with a "Yes",

Abel: "Shrunken or not, you still have eyes to watch for an opportunity. Out of everyone, you are the most competent."

Medium: "Hmmm, gotcha. I'll watch carefully! So be careful, Taritta-chan."

Taritta: "Yes."

The discussion was moving along at breakneck pace, leaving Subaru behind.

Putting Abel aside, Taritta and Medium had nerves of steel. Especially Taritta, who was being entrusted with the most dangerous role.

Taritta: "So, I'm *off*."

Clutching her bow, Taritta put her hand on the back door. Facing her back, Subaru couldn't help but shout, "Taritta-san!",

Subaru: "Um, d-don't die...!"

Taritta: “——”

He was disgusted with himself for saying something so obvious and discouraging. If he was unable to offer any useful opinions or winning strategies, he should at least say something that would boost Taritta’s morale.

And yet, all he could offer was a quavering plea— But Taritta’s eyes relaxed slightly and,

Taritta: “*Yeah, I’ll see you guys later.*”

With a thin smile, Taritta’s body flew outward like a bullet.

Just before that, Abel hurled his final words towards Taritta’s back, as she headed for enemy territory. Those were—

Abel: “Taritta, there is no need to hold back. Spare no quarter— No matter who they are, no person in this city is easy to kill.”

It was ominous advice, which could not be called either encouragement nor a winning strategy.



—The moment she stepped outside, hostility swelled mightily quickly.

Tasting it on her brown skin, Taritta’s narrowed eyes scanned left to right over the entire area in one go.

For the People of Shudraq, who lived as hunters in the jungle, understanding the terrain and situation at a moment’s notice was an essential skill. Taritta was no exception.

—No, Mizelda, her sister, had entrusted Taritta with the role of chieftain.

Therefore, Taritta must excel in these skills, more so than her fellow Shudraqians. And indeed, she did.

Taritta: “—Ah.”

With a light gasp born at the back of her throat, Taritta assessed the number of hostile forces directed at her.

Around her, there were about a hundred people with the will to fight, but less than twenty of them had seized their hostility onto Taritta, who had rushed out the back door.

In addition, the number of those able to move quickly among them would be even smaller.

First thing would be to get the feet of those who turned around to—

Taritta: “—No *good*.”

Her mind flashed back to the advice given by Abel just before she had taken off, to spare no quarter.

Abel was a prideful, good-looking man. He met all the requirements of Mizelda’s taste in men, and Taritta was not good at dealing with him. She was weak to pressure and went along with the flow without resistance. Plus, when confronted with someone with a nature like that of her sister or Abel, she would be rendered unable to express any of her opinions.

That was why Taritta preferred someone who would listen to her. Particularly because she would take time to settle on an opinion, and would reel at being rushed.

From that perspective, Flop, who had stayed behind at Guaral, was quite—

Taritta: “—*Hk*, what am I *thinking*?”

Blushing red with momentary shame, Taritta drew her bowstring as if to vent.

A moment later, arrows were released from the bow— three, at the same time. Taritta’s archery skills manifested, with each arrow aiming at a different prey.

One flew straight and two flew in a curve, as they cut the wind along the alleyway outside the inn, and pierced their targets.

Three men who had turned to face the rushing Taritta and made an attempt to step towards her, were shot in the neck and chest respectively, instantly robbing them of their fighting power.

Taritta: “Hunting is *comfortable*.”

It suited Taritta, because she was not required to talk to anyone.

The prey did not expect Taritta to speak, nor did she want to communicate with them. The only dialogue that occurred was that of her arrows and their meeting the enemy.

Even so, the result dubbed life and death need not be produced at the end of a conversation.

???: “—ROHH!”

With a roar, several shadows rushed into the alley, replacing the men who had been shot through.

The first thing that entered Taritta’s field of vision was an oxman; his body so massive that, to gaze upon it all, she had to look up. A man with short, thick horns at the top of his head was ferociously using his frame to charge, all while unleashing a battle cry.

A direct frontal hit would pulverize every bone in Taritta’s thin body.

However, there was no way to escape to her back, or to her side. Even if she jumped upwards, there was a good chance she would be grabbed by the legs.

With that in mind, Taritta lowered herself and darted forward.

Oxman: “Wha—!?”

Perhaps because those actions were unexpected, the oxman’s eyes widened and his throat tightened. Taritta extended her legs towards the oxman’s face and used it as a foothold, punting him in the snout.

Bending her knees to stifle her momentum, Taritta’s body revolved with ease in midair, using the face of the oxman, spewing blood from his nose, as a foothold. Then performing a half-turn, she adopted an upside-down position while airborne.

Taritta: “———”

As she spun around, she secured a three-sixty-degree view, including the area behind her, which she had not been able to see previously. She was able to assess the shadows of buildings, the rooftops and scaffolding present in the city, and even those attempting to attack her from these positions.

Taritta: “These won’t not be enough *arrows*.”

As she said this, she pulled out the arrows from the quiver on her back, put them on her bow at a dizzying pace, and repeatedly fired three shots in rapid succession to reduce her enemies.

The number of arrows was disproportionate to the number of enemies she had assessed. With no choice but to cut down the enemies with the highest priority, Taritta used her intuition of many years to target the ones with the most ability.

Ignoring the uncomfortable feeling she felt at the sight of those who entered her field of vision—

???: “Woaaa—?!”

The raging arrows glided through the air akin to a tempest, and those pierced through were blown away by the impact.

Following Abel’s advice, Taritta attacked about thirty enemies with merciless attacks to the vitals, aiming for everyone’s chest and neck, and the eyes and mouth of those she could, hoping to inflict a fatal wound.

After this first engagement, however, she had already run out of arrows.

The only thing she could do now, to retrieve the arrows that had been utilized, and to continue serving as a decoy as long as possible—

Taritta: “...Well this *is*, a bit *unexpected*.”

As she moved to retrieve the arrow from the downed enemy, Taritta stopped in her tracks.

Taritta, as a warrior of Shudraq, had killed countless beasts in her life. Even if the beast’s shape was slightly different, the creature’s feedback to having its vital point pierced could be witnessed at the moment of her bow firing.

And based on that experience, she was confident that she had sowed the lives of those she had shot through.

???: “Guhgu...”

And yet, none of those who groaned and rose to their feet had lost their lives.

Even if they had not flat-out perished, they should have been on the verge of death. However, those that stood up stared at Taritta with eyes that were not bereft of the will to fight, let alone on the verge of death.

In those eyes that gazed at Taritta, a change occurred.

Taritta: “*What*, in the world is *that*?”

Taritta frowned and questioned the oxman as he stood up. The man did not reply, but the change that had occurred to him was so alien that it seized her attention.

—A scarlet flame was covering his right eye.

Oxman: “———”

Those whose pupils were ablaze were not restricted to just the oxman.

All those who had fallen after being shot by Taritta regarded her with a scarlet flame in one of their eyes, be it the right or the left one.

Those whose eyes were burning were not restricted to just those who had been shot by Taritta.

Those who had come to the scene later to surround Taritta had scarlet flames in their eyes as well. Flickering flames that burnt, all the while scattering sparks.

And amazingly, flames similar to those burned away and healed the wounds of the oxman.

The kicked and smashed nose of the oxman, and the arrow wounds of those who had been shot through, had all been undone, completely.

Taritta: “...A few words were not *enough*, Abel.”



Illustration from Volume 29, coloring by Norvak ([source](#))

The scene and Abel's earlier advice came together, and Taritta let out a sigh.

Although she did not know for certain, her belief was that that Abel had thoroughly anticipated this situation. If that were the case, he should have endeavored to make his words more understandable.

And beyond that, her head pounded with the desire for purely convenient thoughts, as she was not good with someone who hurried the conversation forward. However—

Taritta: "My role is to be a *decoy*, not to annihilate the *enemy*."

Hence, in terms of focusing on her role, it was safe to say that it was working well. And then—

Taritta: "...They're breaking the *arrows*, it *seems*."

The arrows that had shot through them were breaking one after another, as they slipped out of their bodies. The arrowheads that she was supposed to retrieve were lost, and Taritta became unable to use her archery skills.

However, it would be a mistake to think that this would leave her with no options.

Taritta: "Both daggers and throwing stones can be used for *hunting*."

As she said this, Taritta dropped low and held the dagger she had tucked inside her formal dress and the bow she had lost the arrows to shoot with together.

Taritta's battle to fulfil her role had only now begun.



Subaru: "—Hk, Taritta-san, awesome...!"

Subaru's voice trembled as he ran, at the sight of the people whose eyes and wounds were ablaze.

Taritta had been sent out for a fierce struggle, but her skill was far beyond Subaru's imagination.

In all honesty, it was safe to say that Subaru had underestimated Taritta's ability to be an effective member of Shudraq, given her reserved and quiet nature as a late bloomer.

Just before, he had also seen how helpless she had been against Olbart.

Of course, because Mizelda had nominated her to be the next Chieftain, he knew there would be no gap in ability between her and Kuna or Holly.

But the precision of her aim, the speed of her shots, and the way she was able to take on an overwhelmingly large number of people made it seem like she could be as good as, or even better than, Mizelda.

Subaru: "But still..."

Even evaluating Taritta to have a high level of skill, it was hard to shake off the strangeness of those attackers.

In the first place, their appearance was strange. After all, none of them wore armor, nor did they have any sort of weapons. They were unarmed.

From the looks of it, they were pretty much the same as many of the people they had been passing by since the previous day, in Chaosflame— they were just another citizen of the Demon City with an appearance that stood out somewhat.

These citizens had surrounded Subaru and the others, and after being on the other end of Taritta's transcendental bow-and-arrow technique, they stood up without a hitch despite being mortally wounded.

From a distance, it could be seen that the attackers included women and children, and Taritta must have been disturbed that they were not actually a group of strong warriors.

She had done a great job of attracting attention, and at Medium's signal, Subaru and the others ran out into the city. But should they really escape, and not back up Taritta?

Unsure of what was the right thing to do, those options kept spinning around and around in Subaru's mind.

Next to Subaru, Abel, carrying a bag on his back, witnessed the same scene.

Abel: “So indeed, the entire city is covered by the Soul Marriage Technique.”

Al: “*Konkon*¹⁹...? Oioi, Abel-chan, the hell’s that?”

Abel: “It is the mechanism of the collective that faces Taritta without backing down.”

Al, who was running in a daze, asked a question to which Abel gave an inadequate answer.

Although Subaru couldn’t quite wrap his head around what was going on, one thing was clear— Abel had a clue about the relationship between those burning eyes and the attackers.

Subaru: “Abel! Don’t keep secrets from us! Tell us everything!”

Abel: “—It is one of the supposedly lost secret arts spoken of in ancient literature. It is called the Soul Marriage Technique; by sharing a part of one’s soul with others, value is added to it.”

Al: “I don’t get it! The fuck’s that supposed to mean?”

Abel: “To put it another way, souls united via the Soul Marriage Technique share a fraction of their power. And in this city, there is merely a single wielder of the Soul Marriage Technique—”

Urged on from both sides by Subaru and Al, Abel gave them the most abridged answer possible.

Despite that, the content was still difficult for Subaru to understand, but, somehow, he managed to pick up its nuance. In other words—

Abel: “—It means that everything that composes this Demon City shares the power of Yorna Mishigure. Therefore, this city is a land that shall not fall easily, no matter how many armies you dispatch against it.”

¹⁹ Translation note from Witch Cult Translations: “«Konkon» is usually an onomatopoeic word used to refer to the cry of a fox. In this case, however, this word is used for the technique employed by Yorna to make the citizens of Chaosflame stronger, the Soul Marriage Technique, read in Japanese as «konkon jutsu». Seeing how Yorna is a fox demi-human, the pun should be obvious. Abel here uses the Kanji in writing for Soul Marriage, “魂婚”, which is also pronounced «konkon». However, Al doesn’t really get what he’s referring to, hence his reaction, and saying the pronunciation out loud.”

Arc 7 Chapter 46 - Childish Recklessness

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 29, Chapter 3 “Konkon”, Parts 5 (halfway until end)

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Edited Machine Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Original by Goldkills, Translation checked by Averitius, MaskedBook) — [Complete](#)

Subaru: “The people of this city share the same power as Yorna...!?”

While running with effort along the alley, Subaru’s eyes widened at the words Abel spoke.

Subaru had no idea of the power of the foxwoman he had met atop the castle tower of the Crimson Lapis Castle, a woman who seemed to have an unfathomable presence— an existence that could also be called the Empress that ruled over the Demon City.

However, since she had been chosen as one of the Nine Divine Generals, and had been allowed to remain alive, maintaining her life, despite rebelling against the Emperor many times, she was definitely very strong.

Yorna was very strong, and to think that the whole city shared the same amount of power as her.

Subaru: “Just imagining it is scary enough! Soul Marriage Technique, you’ve got to be...”

Abel: “You think I am merely lining up words without pondering them over? Then, how do you explain the events that caused your limbs to shrink? The Kingdom and the Empire are different in the foundation of their techniques and the studies they have cultivated. Of course, there are certain phenomena you cannot possibly imagine. There is no end to the number of techniques that have been lost.”

Subaru: “Even if you say that...”

After all those difficult words, Subaru bit the inside of his cheek in frustration and turned his head.

His feet almost got tangled, nearly causing him to fall, but he held it together so that he wouldn't be left behind by his friends. Because of their shrunken bodies, none of them, Subaru, Al, or Medium, had shoes that fit their feet perfectly. So their feet were wrapped in cloth, like improvised *tabi*²⁰.

Were it to come untied, making him fall, they would have to stop. That'd be no good.

Even if Subaru could not keep up with the conversation, at least his body should keep up.

Abel: "Albeit, while I was thinking of it as a possibility, I thought it was an unlikely one."

Al: "...So you're saying that you didn't know that that lady was a lady of the Soul Marriage Technique as well?"

Abel: "Even now, I am doubting if that truly is the case. It is that mad of a deed."

Abel replied, lightly breathing as he ran, his oni mask's gaze directed to their front. Al growled at those words, and Medium's face turned to Abel.

Even though she was smaller, Medium seemed to be the one with the most physical energy. Subaru was still doing fine, but he would probably run out of breath before too long. It was difficult for him to keep running.

Abel: "—Halt. It appears we have managed to shake off the ones around the inn for the moment."

Abel suddenly brought everyone to a stop, though he probably didn't do that, because he cared about their well-being.

With the exit of the alleyway in sight, the five of them ducked behind a collection of scrap wood and caught their breath while keeping a watchful eye on the street.

Medium: "I wonder if Taritta-chan's okay. Although she's a lot more mobile than I thought she'd be."

Subaru: "Eh? Y-yeah she was like jumping and bouncing up and down and shooting her bow and arrows going like «pewpew»..."

²⁰ Translation note from Witch Cult Translations: "*Tabi* are traditional split-toed Japanese socks meant to be worn with footwear like zori. For more information, see [here](#)."

Al: “Bro, are you doing that on purpose? Or...”

Subaru: “Doing what on purpose?”

He tilted his head and frowned at Al’s question.

Had he said something strange, he wondered. He was just praising Taritta’s efforts in his own way, to match Medium’s admiration.

In response, Al shook his head and replied with “Never mind” as if it were nothing, and then turned his head towards Abel. And then,

Al: “What did you mean earlier, by calling it «that mad of a deed»?”

Abel: “—As I stated. The Soul Marriage Technique involves ceding a portion of one’s soul to another. By soul, that would be the very root of one’s self, the Od.”

Al: “Ceding... Od.”

Ruminating on the words, Al’s voice trembled at the realization.

Od was, as Abel had stated, the root of one’s being— the center of not only the body, but also the more spiritual part of the being, the origin of one’s Mana.

In this world, it was often treated as it was the same as the soul. So, perhaps the Soul Marriage Technique could also be called the Od Marriage Technique. Although Subaru wasn’t too sure of this.

Subaru: “But why do souls become stronger when they’re joined together?”

Abel: “A similar example would be the relationship between a Spiritual Arts User and a Spirit. By entering into a contractual relationship, User and Spirit connect to each other’s essence. Thus, those connected can be said to draw power from one another. Physical separation has nothing to do with it. This ought to ring a bell.”

Subaru: “A connection in which they draw power from each other, yeah, I get it, but...”

As he heard Abel speaking of Spiritual Arts Users, Subaru’s chest tightened.

Subaru didn't have power strong enough to take pride in, but he was still a Spiritual Arts User. He had contracted with a pretty girl in a cute dress— Beatrice, and was able to do many things with her help. Though a bit limited.

And then, there was Emilia too, yes, she was a Spiritual Arts User as well. Although he hadn't seen that little cat for a while.

Medium: "What's the matter, Subaru-chin?"

Subaru: "Oh, uhh, it's just... making promises with Spirits is an awful lot of work, and doing something like that, and with a lot of people! That's a bit..."

Medium: "Hmhm."

Subaru: "I-I was just thinking of how difficult it must be."

Subaru was able to honestly convey his thoughts to Medium, who, as a good listener, did not rush him, hearing what he said with care.

Respecting a Contract with a Spirit was very important, and it was difficult to do the same with many people. At least, Subaru could not do that with anyone but Beatrice.

It wasn't only down to the fact Beatrice was a girl he held such a promise with from the get-go, but also, even if that was not the case, he wouldn't have been able to do it.

Hearing Subaru's doubts, Abel nodded, voicing a "That is correct",

Abel: "Hence why I claimed it to be that mad of a deed."

Subaru: "So, the Soul Marriage Technique is dangerous, that's what you're saying?"

Abel: "The Soul Marriage Technique itself can be thought as something much like the forging of a contractual relationship with a Spirit. However, it is difficult to believe that it can be performed on an unlimited number of people."

Subaru: "———"

Abel: “Albeit I stated it was a portion, it is nonetheless the ceding of the soul. It is nothing more than tearing apart the very foundation of one’s being, and handing it over in an indiscriminate manner. Keeping one’s ego intact is not something that can be done, usually. Or rather... No, talking about this will bring us nowhere.”

With a slow shake of his head, Abel spoke of the unusual nature of Yorna’s Soul Marriage Technique.

To be honest, Subaru didn’t understand the situation as clearly as Abel did, but he managed to understand that it was very scary.

For Subaru, it’d be like sharing his soul with a bunch of people other than Beatrice. Of course, there were people with whom Subaru felt he could give away part of his soul as they wouldn’t do any mischief.

He didn’t think that Medium or Al here would do anything wrong. But if someone asked him if he could give it to Abel, his reply would be no.

And aside from that—

Louis: “Uu...”

Subaru: “—Ah.”

She plucked at the bottom of Subaru’s shirt, causing him to be distracted by the owner of that small, groaning voice.

Louis, with her long golden hair tucked behind her head, had been following Subaru and the others in their escape so far without a word— No, it was not just this far.

Louis was surprisingly good at listening and didn’t even raise her voice, which Subaru had been worried about. She did not attract the attention of the enemy, and did what needed to be done in a timely manner. And—

Louis: “———”

Even now, she pulled at Subaru’s hem, as if looking for a way to help him cope with his anxiety, not to make him deal with her own.

Subaru: “You’re...”

A horrible person. A scary person. An unforgivable person.

He had no doubts about it, having thought about that for a long time, more than enough time.

The reason why he couldn’t dump her on the spot after being sent to the Vollachian Empire with her was because that girl, Rem, was trying to take care of Louis.

Even now, Subaru didn’t want Rem to hate him, and that was the only reason why he stayed with Louis. And yet—

Al: “—But hey, doesn’t this clear things up?”

Al suddenly said this to a worried Subaru, who did not shake off Louis’s hand.

Al’s gaze turned to Abel, the two of them, masked and covered in cloth, adult and child, facing each other. As Abel looked down at him, Al pointed his thumb to his own chest,

Al: “The people who attacked us are under the influence of Yorna-nee-chan’s Soul Marriage Technique. Then it must’ve been Yorna-nee-chan who made them attack us, and that’s QED²¹.”

Abel: “—That surely is an answer accepting the things at face value.”

Al: “I don’t like the way you’re saying that. If these people are using Yorna-nee-chan’s power, there’s no other option.”

Subaru: “Yeah, that might not be quite right...”

Al: “Huh?”

Al reacted to Subaru’s gentle interruption with a harsh voice. Seeing Subaru’s shoulders tremble at the sound of his voice, Al touched the sheath of the *dao* on his back and,

²¹ Translation note from Witch Cult Translations: “An initialism of the Latin phrase «quot erat demonstrandum». Usually, the abbreviation is placed at the end of mathematical proofs and philosophical arguments, to indicate that the proof or argument is complete.”

Al: “My bad. Didn’t mean to freak you out... Bro, you’re saying there’s another possibility?”

Subaru: “...Beatrice and I have a Contract, but I’m not connected to her all the time. No, we’re connected, but I don’t know what she’s doing right now or anything, so.”

Al: “So you’re saying someone can just borrow her power and secretly go on a rampage?”

Although reluctantly, Subaru nodded to Al’s blunt statement.

Even though he wasn’t aware of the scope and conditions of the Soul Marriage Technique in full, it was possible that causing such mischief is possible. And if so, it was not possible to say with certainty that Yorna was a bad person, right now.

Abel: “Worst case, if the enemy turns out to be Yorna Mishigure, we shall have no other option but to flee the Demon City. Our competition with Olbart shall not be able to continue.”

Al: “We’re being targeted by the whole city, y’know. I agree with you, but...”

Abel: “—If we capture just one person it would change things.”

Abel muttered to himself as he touched his cheek over the oni mask.

Hearing this, Subaru opened his mouth with a “Oh”.

Subaru: “S-sure! If we can just get one of the people from the other side to talk to us, it’d be a lot clearer! Why didn’t I think of that!?”

Medium: “Oh, it’s true~! Abel-chin, you’re a genius! That’s it, that’s it!”

Subaru: “Right!”

Subaru and Medium jumped for joy at the answer, which seemed to clear the cloudy sky. They clapped their raised hands together and looked back at Abel and the others with great joy.

However, their delight was interrupted by Abel and Al, whose true faces could not be seen.

Directing his gaze at the excited duo, Al slumped his shoulders,

Al: “Well, if we could do that, we wouldn’t have any trouble. But that’s what makes it so hard, y’know. After all, everyone on the other side’s receiving Yorna-nee-chan’s power.”

Subaru: “Ah, I see...”

Medium: “Um~, we could’ve done it if only Taritta-chan was here.”

Stomping her feet on the ground, Medium was feeling a great sense of regret about her lack of ability.

Subaru also felt frustration at her words. He lacked the information to take this one step further, and he had no means at hand to obtain it.

Subaru: “Something, anything at all...”

Putting a hand over his mouth, Subaru strived hard to remember what he had done so far.

Since arriving in Chaosflame, various events and troubles had occurred in this Demon City. The encounter they had with Yorna and the false Emperor at the Crimson Lapis Castle. Then the next morning, the sudden “infantilization”, the hide-and-seek game proposed by the Vicious Old Man, and the scary people waiting for them—

They had to find a way out of this while Taritta was stalling for them.

If not, no matter how capable Taritta was, with that many people there, they would catch her and something terrible would happen—

Subaru: “—That.”

Medium: “Subaru-chin?”

As he pondered over this and that, Subaru blinked his eyes as he felt something strange. Noticing this, Medium looked into his face.

But he didn’t have the time to answer her call. He had to find out just what he’d caught on just now, such was his impatience. He needed to get to the bottom of it.

What he was worried about was Taritta, doing her best— No, not Taritta herself, but the people who were facing Taritta, the scary hundred people who were after Subaru and the others.

He watched from a distance as the hundred of them fought Taritta. There was something strange about it. It was probably—

Al: “Thing is! I don’t understand if it’s really the Soul Marriage Technique, or if the enemy’s Yornaneechan or not, or if Old Man Olbart’s lying or not, I just don’t get anything anymore!”

Subaru: “—Hk.”

Subaru was surprised to see Al barking at him, while violently scratching his own neck. However, Al did not seem to notice Subaru’s surprise and kicked the wall impatiently.

Al had been getting less and less composed at an alarming pace. His original posture of being like an aloof willow branch that could take anything in stride seemed to be an illusion.

And Al, in his frustration, continued to pester Abel,

Al: “What are you gonna do, Abel-chan? I can’t keep going along if it’s gonna continue like this, y’know. I’m telling you, I got bigger priorities than getting you back on your seat. So...”

Abel: “What you wish interests me not. But there is a method to be certain of it.”

Al: “Be certain of what?”

Abel: “Of whether their strength is due to the Soul Marriage Technique.”

Pointing towards the exit of the alleyway, Abel declared so to Al, who pressed him for an answer.

Outside in the darkness, the sounds of people passing by, footsteps, and talking could be heard from the street. However, it didn’t mean that any of those people had noticed and were looking in.

Just the hustle and bustle, that was all there was.

Subaru: “The street? What are we supposed...”

Abel: “Pick one passerby at random, and harm them. Then we can ascertain if Yorna Mishigure’s Soul Marriage Technique envelops everyone in the city or not.”

Subaru: “———”

Abel: “If the wound heals, then they are under the influence of the Soul Marriage Technique. If they remain wounded or lose their life, they are outside the influence of the technique— Meaning, the assumption they are a user of the Soul Marriage Technique can be dismissed as incorrect.”

Abel continued nonchalantly, pointing to the street.

The content of the speech was so disturbing and outlandish that Subaru could not say anything. His brain was numb, he had given up even thinking.

No one would take such a stupid theory seriously——

Al: “I see... But there’s also the *moyou*²² of inhabitants not being eligible, just like us. What if we drew one of them?”

Abel: “You can tell the difference between a resident and an outsider by looking at their footwear. Of course, it is possible that only those surrounding the outside of the inn are under the influence of the Soul Marriage Technique. If such is the case, it shall be proof that Yorna Mishigure has consciously set her sights on us.”

Subaru got that Abel was nodding as if saying that either way they would gain information, as well as Al sinking into silence, as if to say there was still room for more consideration.

That discussion was difficult for Subaru to understand because it was based on complicated logic. However, even amidst the incomprehensible discussion, there were things that he understood.

That was, if things continued like that, someone was going to get hurt.

Subaru: “But that’s just——”

²² English flip. Means “pattern” (模様), originally “パターン” (pattern).

Abel: “—If you reject it, then what? Try presenting an alternative.”

Subaru: “...Hk.”

Abel looked down on Subaru as he anticipated him trying to retort out of reflex.

After feeling that his thoughts were being read, and that he had been called foolish, Subaru’s face grew hot. But he couldn’t be silenced. He didn’t want to just shut up and back down.

Subaru: “Y-you don’t have to hurt anyone else, there are other ways...”

Abel: “If you have one, say it. If it is something that merits consideration, I shall listen— Although it would be unreasonable to expect that from you, presently.”

Subaru: “Well, that’s!”

Abel: “—You are particularly afraid of sacrifices.”

As if cutting through him, a ruthless voice pierced Subaru as he was getting worked up.

Feeling a pain like that of having been shot through, Subaru gritted his teeth and looked down.

Sacrifice, someone getting hurt or dying.

The less people died or were hurt, the better. This was a matter of course for allies, but he felt the same for enemies. The reason why Subaru thought so was because he was weak, naive, and immature.

Subaru: “But why’s that a problem?”

Abel: “That is not a repudiation. It is merely a fact. If you are to obtain what you desire, you shall require either ingenuity or strength. If you lack those, you must compromise by cutting back on the desired results. Such is what occurred with the process and the results brought about by the bloodless siege you spoke of.”

Subaru: “———”

Abel: “If you want neither deaths nor wounded, you must possess the ability to bring about that result— If you truly desire it, it would be a contradiction to refuse to pay the toll.”

Subaru's cheeks stiffened, his eyes blinked.

Abel's intentions were unclear. However, the black eyes looking through the oni mask were fixed on Subaru, attempting to find out the true intentions behind Subaru's eyes, which had an incomparably weak light in them.

I don't understand. I don't understand. I don't understand.

Really, I don't understand. What was that supposed to mean, Subaru not willing to pay the toll. Subaru was trying his utmost to use his good-for-nothing brain to think, but nothing came out.

With his short limbs and small lungs, he could not jump or leap as well as Taritta. The whip he had brought with him was too thick and heavy for him to handle.

Still, if he didn't want anyone to get hurt, he should—

Subaru: “—If that's how it is, it'd be better if only I get hurt!”

His head a mess, Subaru shouted at Abel.

He knew very well he wasn't strong enough and that he didn't think things through. But that was a problem that had always existed, even before Subaru had become small.

Something hot came up from behind his closed eyes.

Before that could clearly turn into tears, Subaru turned his back and started running away.

Al: “Bro!?”

Medium: “Subaru-chin!”

Al and Medium let out a scream at the sudden movement.

However, not stopping at the calls of those two, Subaru threw himself out of the alleyway and into the street.

He didn't want anyone to get hurt. He didn't want them to die.

Subaru lacked both the ability and the smarts necessary for that. If something was to be traded to make up for what was missing, it was Subaru himself.

He would find it out. He would bring back information that could change the situation with him at the moment he got himself back. For that reason—

Subaru: “Come on! I’m here!”

Subaru ran out into the street, arms raised, shouting at the top of his lungs.

A high-pitched child’s voice drowned out the noise of the street, drawing the attention of those surprised. Being noticed by a number of wide-open eyes, Subaru felt a pain that made his heart shrink.

Subaru: “—Ah.”

Only after having done so, would someone regret doing something prematurely.

The eyes of the people around him, looking at a child doing something stupid, made him feel a sudden sense of shame and fear. With that, Subaru held his breath and thought about going back to the alley.

???: “Wait.”

Someone grabbed Subaru’s arm as the latter stepped on the ground in a hurry.

His shoulders hitching, Subaru turned around; a short figure was grabbing his arm. It was a short boy with short, curly hair dressed in simple light clothing— no, his hair was not kept short, it only looked short because of the tight curls at its end.

Subaru’s eyes widened at the appearance of the boy, who looked about the same age as Subaru currently was. He then tried to open his mouth to ask why he had stopped him,

Boy: “Sorry.”

—The next moment, Subaru was flung away by the boy with a burning right eye.

Subaru: “—Eh?”

Overwhelmed by his spinning vision, Subaru had no idea what had happened.

The boy had suddenly thrown Subaru away. With a single upward movement of his arm, he had very easily thrown him into the air.

Subaru: “W-wahhh—!?”

He had run out into the street with enthusiasm so that no one aside from him would get hurt.

Why, how, those questions bounced around in his head, and he felt as if his insides were being wrung.

The ones who had been fighting Taritta had the same burning eyes as the boy. If that was the effect of Soul Marriage Abel had told him about, then Yorna had given him a portion of her power. To confirm this, he had jumped out, saying he would sacrifice himself.

All this was incomprehensible to Subaru, who was spinning and falling into the blue sky.

It was an apparent miracle that his body spinning with unusual force had not hit any of the surrounding buildings or decorations. Subaru didn’t even know if the boy hadn’t aimed him at anything.

However, Subaru was afraid of the obstacles that were passing by the edge of his vision at an incredible speed, so he fell into the blue sky, praying desperately that he wouldn’t hit anything— and then he suddenly stopped.

Slowly, Subaru’s thrown body reached maximum height, and was now falling headfirst towards the ground.

Subaru: “Ahhhhh—!”

The voice of the one who had left the ground now echoed, as it approached the ground again.

He didn’t know how high he’d reached, but he had to brace himself. But he couldn’t remember how to. In the first place, would he be able to manage to brace himself when falling from such a high place? Would he fall to the ground, and die with his whole body broken into pieces, his head crushed, his neck broken—

—Death seemed to be close at hand again.

Medium: “Al-chin!”

Al: “Gotcha!”

Shortly after, mixed in with Subaru’s own screams, he heard familiar strained voices.

And just like that, the sound of something stretched being slashed and the sound of several long thin objects falling down came together, and without knowing what they were, Subaru’s body hit the ground— Before that, he was caught.

Subaru: “Wah, wahhh, wahhhh... Wagh!”

A soft sensation caught him, but his momentum couldn’t be stopped, and Subaru’s body fell on the softness with quite a bit of force. Once he reached the edge of that soft sensation, his thrown body rolled on the hard ground, causing a moan and the taste of sand to spread in his mouth.

His body ached everywhere. But—

Subaru: “I’m, alive?”

At the fact that he had not died, Subaru let out a dumbfounded voice.

Once he managed to pull himself up, he finally realized what had happened— Al and Medium had saved Subaru with their quick thinking.

In order to catch Subaru as he was falling from the sky, they had jumped on a tent of a food stall on the street, detached its anchor and stretched it to make an improvised cushion.

Thanks to that, Subaru had not slammed into the ground, and his life had been saved. However—

Medium: “Ah, ouchhhh...”

Al: “Ahgh...”

The two people who had worked so hard to catch Subaru were not safe.

Subaru: “Ah, Al! Medium-san!”

As Subaru pulled himself up, within his field of vision were two figures lying in the street.

Of course, Al and Medium, influenced by the “infantilization”, could not perform like they usually would. They had set up a tent to catch the falling Subaru, and had been blown away by the crash.

And the bad news continued on—

Boy: “I was hoping that that would have been the end of it...”

The boy who had thrown Subaru away contorted his face in pain, as he said that.

Surveying Subaru, and then Al and Medium, also collapsed, he covered his face with his palms in anguish— Unable to completely cover them, the flame was still present in his right eye.

Subaru: “Y, ou...”

Boy: “It’s necessary. Because this city... Because we cannot lose her.”

Subaru: “—?”

Managing to pull himself up, he drew the boy’s attention to himself.

Though determined not to let him lay his hands on Al or Medium— The boy’s answer was outside of Subaru’s imagination and far from his understanding.

It was just that the boy was desperate. And there was something else that made Subaru’s heart sway.

Subaru: “You too...”

It was the same thing that had stuck with him when he had been struggling to think in the alley.

While Taritta was fighting to help Subaru and the others escape, the faces of those facing her, with one eye burning—

—They all seemed to have the same pained look on their faces as the boy did.

Boy: “I’m sorry. I’m not going to ask you to forgive me.”

Shaking his head, the boy slowly stepped in front of Subaru, erasing any trace of hesitation in his eyes and his expression.

Even if he tried to crawl back in an attempt to escape, he could not. His legs wouldn't move.

So he at least stared at the boy's face, trying not to look away, and noticed something.

There was something nicely peeking out of the side of the boy's head, from his curly hair— a small horn.

Seeing his white curly hair and horns, he thought he looked out of place, looked like a sheep.

After that, the boy with the burning eyes gave a large swing of his hand—

Subaru: “———”

Frowning and keeping his eyes open, Subaru watched, trying not to miss the boy's actions.

???: “Uuu—!!”

A blonde girl cut in front of Subaru, and, with a dull sound and the scattering of red blood, she was sent flying, whirling around much like a leaf.

Arc 7 Chapter 47 - Unperishing ■■

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 29, Chapter 4 “Unperishing ■■”, Parts 1-3

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Original Translation by Witch Cult Translations ([Ringo](#)) — [Complete](#)

Louis: “—Hk.”

Twirling and swirling, a petite frame whirled into the air with a feeble shriek.

The young girl slowly sprung from the ground, her momentum refusing to diminish, as she bounded a number of times towards the street’s edge. Colliding with the frame of the tent whose fabric had come undone, the lurched material crushed the young girl’s body beneath itself with a shrill note.

Subaru witnessed this spectacle, voicelessly.

He could not make excuses such as not being able to comprehend what had occurred in a matter of moments.

Even if it was true that he had not had the time to even stretch his hand out, all of what had transpired in a matter of moments had been definitely captured by these black pupils of his.

His mind utterly boggled, he had sprinted towards the hazardous street devoid of thought.

As per usual, he had been spotted by the enemy, being endangered, then Al and Medium sustained wounds in order to save Subaru, and at the same pace—

Subaru: “...Louis.”

Louis, who had stood before Subaru and shielded him with both her arms spread open, had been strummed like a gum ball.

The one responsible was the young sheepman, horns growing amidst his white hair. His arms were slender, not too different from Subaru's, but had thrown Subaru up to nearly ten meters in the air.

Louis had directly intercepted a single swing of the young boy's arm, subsequently getting blown away. He had noticed her blood scattering, so he could not possibly reckon she was unharmed.

Sheepboy: "Sorry."

Subaru's eyes followed Louis, buried beneath the tent's wreckage. His eardrums quivered due to the enfeebled apology, and reflected in Subaru's wavering field of vision was the figure of the young boy, arms upraised once again.

He couldn't do anything so skillful as to dodge.

To begin with, Subaru's own limbs had been mangled due to falling from a tall height, so he was not even able to move his body properly.

Therefore, despite Louis defending him and everything, he rendered it futile as well—

Medium: "—Subaru-chin!!"

Subaru: "Ah."

Medium: "Stand!!"

A shadow leapt towards him with astonishing momentum and hammered her fair legs into the young boy's shoulders.

As the young boy stepped back, his expression one of surprise, the one to have cut into that place was Medium, her long golden hair fluttering. Her face tinged with a shade of red, she accosted Subaru to stand up.

To Subaru, who had tumbled to the ground, rattling and trembling.

Medium: "Take care of Louis-chan!"

Yet, with no encouragement or consolation, Medium spoke to Subaru, and broke into a sprint.

Wielding the sole sword she had with both of her arms, with movements utterly separate from cool ones that appeared to be a dance, yet with all of her life, she attempted to pursue the young boy.

The young boy too put on a strong expression, seemingly surprised by her spirit rather than her strength.

Subaru: “Guhhhhh...!”

Whilst Medium persevered, Subaru used his now trembling limbs and did his best to stand up. Afterwards, he dashed towards the tent beneath which Louis was crushed.

Removing the parts of the collapsed structure one-by-one, he attempted to recover Louis who was trapped beneath the wreckage.

Subaru: “Louis, Louis! A-are you alive! Hey, Louis!”

Desperately calling, Subaru once again felt warmth well up within his eyes.

That bothersome warmth seemed to have been eagerly awaiting its time to come forth from the interior of Subaru’s countenance since earlier. Ignoring it, hurrying and hastening, he cleared away the scraps. And—

Louis: “...Uu.”

Subaru: “Louis!”

A frail groan resounded, and Subaru discovered Louis’s form, sullied by dust and debris.

Having gotten buried beneath the broken tent, Louis rolled up within the space created by the fallen brace, and barely managed to not get pulverized underneath.

That was relieving. But immense anxiety instantly followed his relief.

Subaru: “I can’t, move this...”

The fallen brace was about as thick as Subaru’s torso, refusing to move whether pushed or pulled. Even via the use of the principle of leverage, he couldn’t find a befitting weight as balance.

And whilst searching for a way to haul Louis out, he came upon something else.

—What was oozily sullyng Louis’s white robes was not dust, but blots of red.

Subaru: “...Ah.”

Struck with terror, his limbs turned cold, his thoughts froze.

This was what it meant to have lost the color of blood. It was not as though he had shed any blood, but he had no clue where the blood flowing within him had gone. Shouldn’t a different spot be warmed by flowing blood?

However, solely his heartbeats were loud enough to seem as though his heart would detonate.

Louis: “Aaa...”

Still leaking frail groans, the red blots on Louis’s robes spread.

His cold limbs unmoving, rather than assuming effort to remove the debris, he could not even comfort her by doing his best to remove it.

Subaru: “Louis, Louis...”

He continued to call Louis’s name, using his quivering voice.

His voice cracked, and he failed to do even this decently. His tongue went numb— no, Subaru’s heart was callously rejecting calling her name.

Come to think of it, Subaru had kept even calling Louis’s name to a minimum.

Ever since he had been hurled from the colossal Tower along with Rem, he had always placed Louis beside him. Subaru had always been vigilant towards her, shunned her, maltreated her.

Yet, never even once had Louis done anything harmful or oppressive towards Subaru.

He did not wish for Rem to despise him. He did not wish for his surroundings to dread him.

Fearing these things, Subaru had always refused to come in contact with Louis, and always ultimately deferred deciding what to do with Louis.

Why did he fear Louis so much?

His benumbed brain, his chilly limbs, his parched tongue, his heart verging onto erupting, did not let him understand.

He couldn't remember very well what Louis had done to him.

It seemed his memories had been befogged, in these moments, he was unable to open the drawer of reminiscences.

However, there was one thing clear to him, without needing to open that drawer.

That Louis had shed blood attempting to shield Subaru.

—That alone was a truth he could not forget, could not avert his eyes from.

Subaru: “Don’t, die...”

Louis: “———”

Subaru: “Don’t die, Louis! You can’t, you can’t die...! You can’t...!”

Pushing his now small body into the brace’s gaps, Subaru knelt beside Louis.

Instead of then hauling Louis out, he simply and unavailingly vocalized. Taking Louis’s hand, gripping it tight with both of his palms, he desperately articulated whilst imbuing it with a prayer.

Subaru: “Please don’t die...!”

Forgetting to even search for something he could do to prevent her from dying, he voiced an absurd wish.

To this trembling voice of Subaru’s, Louis’s eyelids faintly opened, and—

Louis: “—Ua, uu.”

A weak voice escaped her, as the young girl's pupils regained faint strength.



Medium: “Hiyaaaaah—— Hk!”

Waving a single one of her dual swords by gripping it with both her hands, Medium opposed the young boy before her.

Whilst putting up a strong act, the young sheepman, however, easily blocked Medium's strike with his hoisted arm—— Verbatim, intercepted the blade with his arm, and repelled it.

Medium: “Arghhh~, so solid! I can't cut through at all! So unfair!”

Since earlier, Medium had been slashing away with her sword with the entirety of her might, only to be thwarted by the young boy's burly body on each instance.

His skin, his hair, his fingers, his head, all parts of him were so solid that she had been completely brought to her knees.

Him not sustaining any attacks was also a problem, but aside from that——

Sheepman: “——Hk!”

Medium: “Dangerous!!”

The young boy's violently swung arm grazed past Medium and crashed into the ground, feeling tremors coming from the ground, a hole larger than the hammered arm was opened in the ground.

The stupendousness of the young boy's attack power also made her dizzy. The reason why Medium managed to avoid getting wholly smote by the attack was thanks to the interlude in the young boy's movements.

Medium: “Extremely sturdy, seems very powerful too, but his techniques are poor!”

It was as though he was a newborn who had taken birth into a large body, Medium pondered.

She had never seen a newborn who had taken birth into a large body, so she only contemplated what she sensed yet felt that annotation to be perfectly suited.

For now, all she had to do was to spar with that newborn, but—

Medium: “I need to hurry up, or others will gather here too...”

Attaining a flavor of mud upon licking her lips, Medium was scorched with the impatience to not overstay.

They had coincidentally dashed to a street with not many pursuers, but if they continued to be uproarious they would get immediately noticed and the young boy’s allies would assuredly all gather at this place.

If people bigger than the young boy or people with a good grasp on techniques were to arrive, then she may not be capable of crossing swords anymore.

Had she not been alone, then she could’ve at least had a plan of action, and yet.

Medium: “Al-chin! Are you listening, Al-chin!”

Medium raised her voice, whilst leaping and bouncing to the young boy’s large swings.

Medium was desperately calling for the veiled young boy crouched at the edge of her sight— no, for Al. On one hand, he was a child, in a condition that handling weapons was far worse for him than Medium, but she wished to rely on the possibility that there was a way to counter this dangerous situation aside from just herself.

Al: “———”

However, he did not respond to Medium’s implores.

It wasn’t as though he had hit his head and fainted when he got blown off, either. Al was conscious, and once had attempted to sincerely assist in combat.

At present, he had abruptly halted his feet and had knelt down, crestfallen.

Remaining crouched, Al was obstinately staring down upon his right hand through his veil—

Al: “...Wh, y?”

He whispered with a shudder.

As though he had let go of, or had lost what he was supposed to have kept within his hand’s grasp.

Medium: “Al-chin...!”

Gazing sidelong at Al who forbore to stand, diffidence was inserted within Medium’s innermost mind.

At that very moment, strength waned from her hands wielding a weapon, and Medium powerfully gritted her teeth.

—*This is how it’s always been.*

Once Medium’s own feelings withered, so did the strength in her body companionably. Therefore, Medium always conducted herself as positive, loud, upright.

If her feelings were bright and lively, then Medium could work to her best efforts. The reason why her older brother Flop was always cheering her on with a “Do your best!” was to push her on and support her as well.

However, Flop was not here. Nor anyone who would tell her to do her best.

Everyone had their hands full with their own problems, and Medium had also become small, hence she was unable to wield anything more than one sword, and was on the verge of losing to a tiny boy.

???: “—There they are!!”

Medium: “Ah.”

A voice echoed, further augmenting Medium’s diffidence.

As she dodged the young boy’s waved arm and shifted her positions, Medium widened her eyes. What was reflected within her vision, from the opposite side of the street, appeared enemy reinforcements with flames harbored in one eye.

The ferociously rushing men drew near Al's rear, who was knelt down. Even if she were to instantaneously rush towards that direction, she must evade the young boy in-between.

—I won't make it. They'll die. Al-chin, Subaru-chin, Louis-chan, all of them will.

Everyone will die.

Verging on dropping the sword she grasped, Medium desperately called for her older brother within her mind.

If only she once more had her older brother's voice, cheers, support.

However, the new troops approaching Al were far swifter than the reach of illusionary encouragement.

Al's small body, was mutilated by the hand stretching from behind—

???: “—Will you yet not move, fool.”

Before those sharp claws could reach Al, a leg stretching from the side kicked his shoulder away. Al's body toppled sideways, narrowly eluding the attack seeking to gouge his spine out.

And, the one to have undertaken this violent counteraction was a man with his face concealed by an oni mask.

Medium: “Abel-chin?”

His name spilled from her mouth, gaping wide in wonder, and Abel's senses turned towards her for a brief moment.

Feeling the heat of exchanging a glance in spite of the mask, Medium's shoulders slightly slumped. Abel, who had left it to Medium and the others to confront the young boy, now stepped forth into the battlefield himself.

He could not stand onlooking anymore, she might get scolded with these words.

She disliked being scolded.

On copious instances in the past, she had been scolded and hit. All the more when despite her small stature, Medium used to eat a lot. Getting hit, getting scolded, repeat.

Hence, upon gauging she would get scolded, her body curled up—

Abel: “Medium.”

Her name called, Medium slumped, dreading the reprimand that followed.

However, Abel ignored her fright, and resumed. Saying—

Abel: “—Make a proper effort.”

Medium: “———”

A brusque tone, dilating her eyes to the voice that quaked her eardrums, Medium powerfully grit her now-small teeth. Gritting, distorting her cheeks, making her gold hair flit.

Medium: “Mhm! I’ll do my best—!!”

Her back pushed by force surging to a nearly fictitious extent, Medium smote the young boy before her.

The young boy stepped back, startled by that attack, and she chased him, striking his chin up with her sword’s ridge bounding from below and kicked his defenseless build, trampling his stretched knees, and struck an identical kick to his head.

With Medium suddenly turning the tide, the young boy became one-sidedly defensive.

Whilst judging this to be akin to bullying, Medium brandished her fist and pounded again and again. In the midst of her punches, a voice was resurrected within her mind.

—*That’s right. Paying ‘em back twice the fold of what they gave you feels pretty great, right!?*

Those were the words of the benefactor who had rescued Medium and Flop out of harrowing circumstances.

The benefactor who had taught her how to fight, how to live; recalling those words, Medium smiled.

Smiling, she thought, “It doesn’t feel good to hit someone much either~!”.

Medium: “Hiyaaaaa!”

Thinking so, she thwacked a sweep of all her strength into the young boy’s head, and his small body was blown off.

An attack that would normally behead one from the side, was nothing more than a strike for the sturdy young boy. Even so, somehow finishing him off alone, she must head to assist Al and Abel—

???: “You spunky little...!”

Medium: “Auh! Oh no!”

Excessively concentrating on her battle against the young boy, she neglected having caution towards the opponent who drew from behind.

Her hair violently grabbed, Medium’s body was swiftly lifted. Feet suspended in the air, she failed to counterattack at once.

Medium: “Ugh-! Ah-, enough!”

Lurching her legs, tearing up from the pain of her hair being pulled, Medium looked back to see the one carrying her was a rhinoman giant larger than Medium’s unshrunk body.

Skin and flesh thicker than that of the young boy, Medium’s kicks amounted to nothing for him.

Medium: “Sorry! I can’t escape!”

Writhing and struggling, Medium inclined her head and earnestly hollered.

Upon looking, the kicked Al remained collapsed on the street’s ground and the one responsible, Abel, had been surrounded by the arrived reinforcements and cornered to a wall.

Medium too was aware it would be impossible for the delicate Abel to finish them all off. Thus—

Medium: “Abel-chin! Take Al-chin and run away!”

She wished for them to somehow aptly create a window and escape.

Upon Medium's desperate voice, the men surrounding Abel clogged the escape route as to block his line of sight. With that, one of the men— a middle aged oxman, approached Abel.

Oxman: "I'm sorry but we can't let you escape. Right here, you all will..."

Abel: "—You are an oxman, the one earlier was a sheepman."

Oxman: "What?"

Abel: "The ones surrounding the inn were all horned as well... anyone can comprehend upon grasping the conditions until now. It is the horned races that are aiming for us."

No fright saturated Abel's voice, surrounded and supposedly posed with a predicament. Rather, words transmitted from his overbearing conduct despite being surrounded perturbed the men.

—No, what was perturbing for them was not Abel's brazen attitude alone, but his remark itself as well.

Medium: "Hor, ned..."

Articulating so, Medium shifted her eyes and gazed at the rhinoman who clutched her hair.

The gigantic rhinoman's focus too was concentrated on Abel's comment just now. She discerned the presence of a single, stocky horn above the rhinoman's large nose.

Now that it was pointed out, she recalled the young sheepman from earlier as well as the multitude of people Taritta had lured back at the inn, all had horns as well.

Medium: "But, what about it!"

Abel: "Fool— Is that not the principal root of this situation."

Medium: "Huh?"

Abel replied, as though having heard Medium's outcry.

However, Medium could not see him from her side, and despite being told that was the reason, she failed to comprehend any of its significance. Rather than properly explaining such that she could understand, she wished for him to resume without her grasp on the matter. If not, at this rate——

Abel: “——You can try it.”

Oxman: “Eh?”

That was not a response to the outcry of Medium’s heart.

For certain, those words, enounced with such solemnity, had been asserted whilst he glared at the oxman standing at the vanguard of the men surrounding him.

The oxman widened his eyes and fixedly glared back at Abel. To the oxman’s reaction, Abel once again resumed,

Abel: “You can try, whether you can kill me.”

Oxman: “...Will there be anything difficult about chopping your slender neck?”

The man’s left eye flared scarlet as he stomped on the ground.

Even without the effects of Yorna’s Soul Marriage Technique, it would be a simple matter for the man’s bulky arm to shatter Abel’s neck.

And, the resolve to kill necessary for fracturing his neck, had already been attained by the men.

Heedless, Abel intrepidly crossed his arms, and pierced the opponent through the black pupils of his oni mask——

Abel: “The answer to whether it is easy or not, lies ahead of action. Thus, you can try. If you possess the caliber, flames shall extol you. However——”

Oxman: “H-however?”

Abel: “If you lack that caliber, flames shall scorch even your soul—— Now, what will you act upon.”

Oxman: “———”

So asserted Abel, hands crossed, whilst the oxman drowned in silence.

He was losing the psychological battle against the insouciantly standing slender man before his eyes. Of course, it would be the man's victory beyond a smidgen of doubt when it came down to brute force. Yet, what was the deal with his composed attitude.

Was the answer to that not conceived within the seemingly deceptive words avowed just now.

Abel: "You can try— Whether you can surpass the flames named judgement."

Oxman: "Guh, ugh, uuugh...!"

The pressed man quivered his bulky throat and groaned. The man was covered in copious sweat, tension straining his entire body, and not even his comrades reached out to him.

From the point of having seen Abel's eyes, they had been taken off the stage.

The qualification to respond to Abel's speech lay only with the man standing before him and nobody else.

A grating note of gnashed teeth echoed, echoed, echoed—

Oxman: "U-uoooh—!!"

With a note of cracking gritted teeth, the man raised both of his arms as though pressed by that ache.

An attack that, rather than breaking his neck, sought to crush Abel's body and life altogether. With a blow from the man's arms, thick like a log, Abel's slender frame would get smashed to a pulp.

Medium floundered in an attempt to escape her constraints, but to absolutely no avail.

Al remained collapsed, paying no heed to Abel's predicament either.

And Subaru and Louis as well were—

Medium: "—Eh?"

Louis had been buried under the collapsed tent, and Subaru subsequently rushed to rescue her. She could see Subaru crawl into the wreckage, and clasp Louis's hand.

Seeing the buried Louis faintly move, and then—

—The next instant, the two's form abruptly vanished from underneath the tent.

Louis: "Uu!"

That juncture, the vanished Louis shot through from directly below the oxman's chin, who had both his arms upraised.



Subaru seemed to be unknowing of what had occurred.

He had clung to Louis, who had been buried under the tent, slowly shedding blood. And struck her with arbitrary words, telling her to not die rather than comforting or rescuing her.

Subaru thought she had moved upon those words, and on the immediately subsequent instant.

Subaru's field of vision altered, as he tasted a sensation of the world being overturned.

Subaru: "Uh, eh."

Not anything like extreme speed or halting time.

Subaru had truly been moved to a separate location in the blink of an eye. That too—

Abel: "You..."

Abel uttered so, his breath halting ever-so-slightly upon Subaru's arrival before his eyes.

Abel leisurely reclined his spine on the wall, arms crossed; by his being and the presence of the men in their surroundings, Subaru verged on falling to his feet out of stupefaction.



Illustration from Volume 29, coloring by Norvak ([source](#))

His tears that had welled up out of disquietude for Louis now retracted, blocking his throat.

And when it came to Louis, who had eluded his mind due to this sudden phenomenon—

Louis: “Aa, uu!”

Oxman: “Goah!?”

Twirling her body, Louis pranced into the space between the men with the movement and agility of a pinball, striking the vitals of all, such as the head, torso and knees, compelling them to withdraw.

Widening their eyes to her ability and might, the men all simultaneously leaned backward and gaped.

And during the interval opened by the men’s astonishment and anguish, Louis mobilized herself onto the subsequent action.

Louis: “Uaau.”

Crossing the gap between the men, Louis escaped their encirclement. Her limbs on the ground like an animal, she pulled the ground from both of her hands as is and pared its surface.

An act like that of violently pulling a carpet spread on the floor— of course, a carpet couldn’t possibly be spread atop a street in the middle of a town. However, it seemed like the ground shifted.

The men consequently all lost their balance, and tumbled on the spot.

???: “Wha!? What’s, this kid...!”

Louis: “Au! Auau!”

???: “Shithead!”

Amidst the disbalanced men, solely a young deerman narrowly managed to stand firm; smacking his lips he then broke into a sprint in an attempt to seize Louis. Louis threw the ground’s surface she had pared mere moments ago at the young man. The moment the young man immediately scythed it aside with his arm, the ground frictionlessly returned to its former state.

In other words, became a wall of earth accompanied by befitting mass and texture.

Deerman: “Bugah!?”

Colliding head-on with the wall of earth, the young man inclined backwards after getting a taste of that counterattack.

Subsequently tearing down the ruptured wall of earth, Louis flew outwards and her soles captured the young man’s visage, and this time, the young man for certain toppled over with a bleeding nose.

???: “You little!”

Louis: “Uaau!”

Uprighting themselves with a delay, the men went over the young man’s fallen body and drew closer to Louis. However, the moment their fingers reached her, Louis erased her form yet again like an illusion.

The following instant, the young girl appeared atop a wall about two meters above, and pulled the wall’s surface identical to what she had done with the ground earlier, and proceeded to return it back.

The wall’s surface came detached together with its mass and solidity, and rained upon the men.

???: “UWAHHHH—!!”

Shrieks and bellows reverberated through the street, as the men endowed with immense strength were made sport of by Louis alone.

Subaru viewed this spectacle, slumped and stupefied.

Subaru: “L-Louis, that’s...”

Raising his arm with a trembling voice, Subaru cowered in terror towards the nightmarish spectacle transpiring before his eyes.

Nightmare, yes, a nightmare. This was, beyond a shadow of the doubt, the nightmare Subaru had feared.

Paring off the ground and wall per her will, teleporting short distances in the blink of an eye, demonstrating combat power on par to rare martial artists, Louis thrashed the men from next to next.

It was evident that was not transcendental might which the young girl possessed by birth— no, Natsuki Subaru was *au fait* with all up to even that power’s origin.

That was, that was, that was the power that must not be, the ■■²³ that must perish—

Abel: “I had reckoned she was no mere girl, I understand now.”

Subaru: “Eh...?”

Beside Subaru, who was yet cowering and capable of naught but watching the circumstance in a daze, so muttered Abel.

As he murmured whilst watching the same scene, Subaru’s eyes wavered, unknowing of his true intent. Keeping Subaru’s state by the edge of his sight, Abel pointed forward, towards Louis who was one-sidedly thrashing their pursuers,

Abel: “So this is the reason why you had that girl accompany you around.”

Subaru: “Y-you’re wro...”

He instantly sought to snarl at him in repudiation.

However, if he were to then be asked why he had Louis accompany him around, then he would fail to provide any answer. That was how it had been so far, and that was how it would be now as well.

Rhinoman: “Stop! You better listen or this girl will be— Gah!?”

Louis: “Auau!”

Beholding this, the rhinoman raised his voice in an attempt to halt the collapse of his comrades.

²³ Translation note from Witch Cult Translations: “It is difficult to carry the «■■» over to English, but for the time being, a few guesses can be made as for what two character word it is obscuring. The best guess for now would be «権能» (Authority). «暴食» (Gluttony), «記憶» (Memories) and even «ルイ» (Louis) are also valid guesses. Since no certain assumption can be made for now, I’ve decided to retain «■■» as is instead of guessing and changing the number of squares to the number of characters in whatever translated word/term it is supposed to mean.”

He attempted to take Medium, who was clutched within his gigantic arm, as a hostage but Louis's attack reached him before he could communicate his threat.

Louis warped for a few meters in distance, and knocked the man's head from both sides using both her arms with all her strength. His ears pounded by her palms, his eyes whirled and went white as he crumbled.

Medium: "Wah, kyah... L-Louis-chan?"

Louis: "Aauu."

Suddenly released, Medium tumbled to the ground as Louis jumped before her. Patting Louis's head, she surveyed the environs, staggered.

Within Medium's vision, all those who had gathered on the street were lying on the ground, collapsed.

Louis, all by herself, had trounced more than ten enemies.

Abel: "Yours and the clown's true nature has been exposed. Well, it is no trouble."

Subaru: "T-this makes no sense... what the heck's going on!"

Abel: "Do not create a racket. It shall lure the other men. You go and pick up the clown."

Abel jerked his chin, devoid of emotion towards having escaped his predicament, and gave his command.

Ahead of where he denoted was an immobile Al crouched on the ground. Fearing if he had sustained a terrible injury whilst they were not looking, Subaru hurriedly rushed to him.

Subaru: "A-Al! Hey, are you alright! Are you wounded..."

Al: "...I'm not, alright."

Subaru: "—! Are you wounded!? Where? We need to treat it immediately..."

Al: "That's not what I'm saying!"

Subaru: “—Hk.”

Having rushed to his side, Subaru jolted Al’s shoulders, at whom he yelled with a potent voice. His head hanging low, he elevated his shivering hand and tightly clenched his right palm.

Al: “—Useless.”

Subaru: “...T-that’s not.”

Al: “I’m useless. My present self’s, gonna die.”

Subaru: “—? What, does that...”

Mean, Subaru attempted to ask Al, his voice quivering.

However, Subaru’s doubt was intercepted by a distressed voice reaching from behind.

Medium: “Abel-chin! You mustn’t do anything cruel!”

Abel: “Remain silent. There are things that must be enquired.”

Medium: “But still...”

Medium’s emotional voice, to whom answered Abel’s calm voice. Turning around, it was to the edge of the street that the two had headed, fallen there was a young sheepman— the young boy who had thrown Subaru up in the air with all his might, when he had first arrived at this street.

The young boy awakened his body, a distinct terror on his countenance.

Understandable. He had not become smaller, but was a kid in accordance with his physicality. Having been utterly overwhelmed by adults, those adults surrounding him from all directions, and on top of that being looked down upon by a man masked with an oni’s visage, there was no way he would not feel terrified.

Abel would display show no mercy to the horrified young boy.

Seizing Medium's shoulder who attempted to stop him and compelling her to step back, Abel crouched before the young boy. The distance between their faces shortened, the flames ablaze in the fearful young boy's eye clouded his vigor.

And, Abel ignored the fearful young boy's attitude and hurled a question.

A question, concise and straightforward—

Abel: "The mediator of horned races who devised this affair— that girl who named herself Tanza, where is she hiding. Divulge it, swiftly."

So he enquired.

Arc 7 Chapter 48 - Purposes Entangling in the Demon City

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 29, Chapter 4 “Unperishing ■■”, Parts 4-6

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Edited Machine Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Original by Goldkills, Kiln, Translation checked by Averitius, MaskedBook) — [Complete](#)

Focusing on the sheepboy, Subaru’s eyes widened at Abel’s relentless questioning.

That was because the name weaved from his mouth was a far too unexpected one.

Subaru: “That young girl, Tanza...?”

The image of a deergirl in a *kimono* popped up in Subaru’s bewildered mind.

What was striking about Yorna’s attendant, the girl who’d shown up at the castle tower the previous day, was that she was very composed and unsociable, even though she was still a child.

Abel was asserting that the girl had been the one to plan this.

Subaru: “T-that doesn’t make sense! Why’d she do that to us... Bwha!”

Louis: “Uau!”

Once he raised his voice to hear Abel’s thoughts, Subaru was shocked by an impact and flipped over. Looking over at it, Subaru saw a smiling Louis on his back.

In a tremendous rampage, Louis had knocked down nearly ten opponents in the blink of an eye. Involuntarily, Subaru gulped because of the innocent-looking girl.

—Louis’s strength, during her rampage, was unmistakably the same thing he had seen at the Tower of Sand.

That power was not originally Louis's, but rather the very power stolen from someone else who had worked hard and honed it. In other words, she had used Gluttony's²⁴—

Subaru: "...G-get off of me."

Louis: "Au?"

Subaru: "Get the heck off of me!"

Pushing the shoulder of the little girl on his chest, Subaru forcefully raised himself up. And so, his momentum caused Louis to fall onto her butt— and then, coming into his view, was her stomach, covered in white fabric stained red.

Seeing that, he remembered that she was injured,

Subaru: "You're wounded! We need to get you treated...!"

Louis: "Au! Auu!"

In a hurry, he rolled up the girl's clothes to check the injured area. But, because it felt ticklish to Louis, she lashed out, trying to resist by pushing Subaru's face and neck.

Ignoring her resistance, he somehow managed to roll up her clothes and check the wound. He found no evident wounds, although there was a trace of oozing blood.

Subaru: "It's healed...?"

Certainly, there were traces of bleeding but no wounds.

That stumped him completely, and then Louis violently pushed the dumbfounded Subaru's chest with both hands. The answer to the question of what would happen if Louis struck Subaru for real, however, was demonstrated by the many figures lying on the street.

In any case—

²⁴ Translation note from Witch Cult Translations: "The sentence here cuts off, but given its structure (『暴食』の—), it's possible that it's cutting off just before the word «権能», which is used for «Authority»."

Abel: “—Answer me. Where is Tanza?”

While Subaru was making sure that Louis was okay, Abel’s interrogation continued.

The terrifying, high-pressure interview seemed to be working not only thanks to Abel’s gaze, but also due to Medium’s blade, as she was standing behind him as a threat. Even without the intention of doing anything, just standing behind Abel would have had an effect.

Indeed, as the boy looked between Abel and Medium in turn, he made a sound from his thin throat.

Sheepboy: “Ah...”

Abel: “This makes it the third time. Answer me. Do not presume that there shall be a fourth.”

It was a cruel tone of voice, so cold that it was as if it chilled Subaru to the bottom of his heart. Hearing that, the boy’s mouth twitched a few times, and then the fire returned to his eyes a little,

Sheepboy: “A-as if you don’t know! If it’s about where Tanza is, then you guys should...!”

Abel: “———”

Sheepboy: “You guys’ve done something to Tanza... That’s why! We’ve attacked you because of that!”

Following that biting remark, the boy’s arms reached out to Abel in front of him.

With reckless disregard for his own safety, his fingertips tried to grab Abel’s throat and crush it. But before he could reach him, a small palm pressed down on the boy’s forehead, and—

Louis: “Au!”

Just like that, the back of the boy’s head was slammed into the ground, causing him to faint.

Pitifully, a moan leaked out from the boy and he fainted. Rolling over, and he then let go of his consciousness.

Subaru: “L-Louis...”

Yet again, in the blink of an eye, Louis’s figure disappeared and reappeared elsewhere.

It was something she had demonstrated many times at the Tower of Sand, the short-distance warping used by Gluttony— watching her mastery of it, Subaru felt as if his heart was going to break.

The fact that she still had that power meant that she was still Louis— Louis Arneb.

The girl from that white world, who had separated Subaru from his heart, and tried to take away his soul completely.

After having mistakenly thought of his Return by Death ability as a blessing, she had dubbed Subaru as a monster.

Abel: “We need to find Olbart immediately.”

Without regard to the previous exchange that had nearly taken his life or, conversely, saved his life, Abel muttered while slowly standing up.

—Finding Olbart.

Subaru, of course, generally agreed with this approach.

Just, Subaru didn’t know why he had said that once again, at this moment. Plus, it came right after the boy had told them something about Tanza that made no sense.

Medium: “Al-chin, can you stand?”

Al: “...Y-yeah.”

Sheathing her weapon, Medium reached out to Al, who was crouching.

Al, his face hidden by a cloth, answered in such a terribly somber voice that, even though Subaru could not make out his expression, he could imagine that he’d gone pale.

Shelving his concern for Al, Subaru finally brushed off the dirt from his butt and stood up. Then he turned his face upward towards Abel,

Subaru: “What did you mean by what you said just now?”

Abel: “What are you asking about?”

Subaru: “That...! That the Tanza girl’s the mastermind, but that we should try to find Olbart-san anyway, and all that stuff! You know what I mean!”

Abel: “Hmm.”

With a tiny snort, Abel touched the cheek of his oni mask in a mocking manner.

Partly out of impatience and partly out of frustration, that gesture really got on Subaru’s nerves. So, Subaru flew into a rage and, taking a nimble leap, ripped the oni mask off Abel’s face.

Then, with a face that had not been exposed in a long time, Abel looked down condescendingly towards Subaru with disapproval.

Abel: “What in the world are you doing?”

Subaru: “That’s what I want to ask you! Don’t just figure it all out by yourself, explain it to me properly! We’re comrades²⁵!”

Abel: “—Comrades, you say?”

Subaru: “Uh...”

Subaru’s intensity rapidly decreased, being stared at directly by Abel’s true face.

Although he had called him “comrade” to his face, that expression might have offended Abel. To begin with, Subaru had some qualms about describing Abel as a “comrade”.

He regretted that he’d gone with the flow and spoken that. But he couldn’t voice that reflection, because it would be like apologizing.

Medium: “That’s right, Abel-chin. We’re comrades, so you have to explain it to us.”

Instead of Subaru, the one to speak was the one who’d made Al stand up, Medium.

²⁵ Translation note from Witch Cult Translations: “The Japanese word used here is «仲間», read «nakama». It has a bit of a complex meaning, somewhere between «friend», «companion», and «comrade».”

Putting her hands on her hips, her entire small body was being used to protest against Abel. In response to her straightforward words, Abel's dark eyes narrowed, and,

Abel: "The assassins at the inn and here, those people are all of horned races."

Subaru: "Horned... You mean people with horns. And what's with them?"

Abel: "—The horned races have a history of persecution. Because the horns resemble those of Witchbeasts, they were shunned in the past."

Subaru: "Oh..."

Abel's indifferent narrative caused Subaru to widen his eyes.

Having horns, and a history of being persecuted because of it— Such prejudice was very close to Subaru's heart, and therefore unforgivable.

Emilia had also been discriminated against in the past for similar reasons; because her physical characteristics and origin were similar to the Witch's, many people had harbored hatred for her.

And demi-humans as well as those of the horned races dealt with a similar past.

Subaru: "But why would those people want to attack us? I know people've been scared of their horns, but I don't get it."

Abel: "You may be a young child, but you are still required to use your head a little. For those with a history of being persecuted for having horns, this city... The way things are in Chaosflame is their salvation."

Subaru: "Salvation... that means a "safe haven", right?"

Abel: "—Yorna Mishigure never lets go of what lies within her bosom. She has even revolted for the sake of one dead deergirl."

Folding his arms, the Emperor, the target of the rebellion itself, spoke of the circumstances behind it.

The reason why Yorna, someone who had revolted many times in the past, had bared her fangs at the Emperor she served— was for the sake of one single person.

What Subaru thought upon being told this, was—

Subaru: “Then, she’s a good person...!”

Abel: “Fool. What a narrow, simple conclusion— Yorna Mishigure is a woman devoted to those who love her. And she holds no mercy towards those outside that circle.”

Medium: “Really~, but I think it’s normal to be kind to the people you like!”

Subaru: “I think so too.”

Agreeing with Medium’s and Subaru’s view, Louis raised her hands and voiced an “Au!”. Abel took one look at them with cold eyes, then let out a small sigh,

Abel: “What is paramount is the fact that the horned races, with their past history of being persecuted, have found peace in this city. And the existence of Yorna Mishigure is indispensable for maintaining that peace. In other words—”

Subaru: “In other words?”

Tilting his head, he waited for Abel to continue.

But for a moment, Abel looked at Subaru, his head still tilted, while gathering his words. Subaru did not understand the meaning of this, but Abel took several blinks’ worth of time before continuing.

Abel: “In other words, for those of the horned races, our presence is an intolerable enemy that shall rock the very ground on which they stand, as we seek the support of Yorna Mishigure for a full-scale rebellion against the Imperial Capital.”

Subaru: “Oh...”

After those words, Subaru finally understood the true meaning of the sheepboy’s words and actions.

At the time he grabbed Subaru's arm as he ran out into the street and threw him, the boy had looked pained— no, not only the boy, but all those who were attacking them looked pained.

Those were feelings of guilt for driving Subaru and the others away, and of fear that they would lose their place in the world. That was why the boy had apologized at the time he flung Subaru.

Subaru: "So these people have been putting in their utmost effort too..."

Abel: "Is that sympathy, or is it pity? Either way, you have no leeway for that. Don't forget the fact that these people have turned their hostility against us. Everything that tries to live and everything alive, both possess their own circumstances."

Medium: "Sheesh~, Abel-chin! The way you're talking is awful! Also, I still don't really get it, why did you ask these people about Tanza-chan? Plus, what about finding Gramps?"

Abel: "...From the way they were talking earlier, it must be true that they are unaware of Tanza's whereabouts. For some reason, they suspect that we have concealed her location from them. Why would that be?"

Subaru: "Why, that's... For what reason?"

Looking down at the unconscious boy, Subaru racked his brains over Abel's question.

Before Louis knocked him out, the boy had snapped at Abel for asking about Tanza's whereabouts. To Subaru, it seemed like there were no lies in the boy's attitude of fury.

So the boy, as well as his group, must have thought that Subaru's group had done something to Tanza.

Subaru: "So that's why they attacked us?"

Abel: "That is how it goes. But the fact that we have not harmed Tanza remains. Then where did that girl vanish off to? Moreover, where did the hundred-or-so people from the horned races appear from?"

Subaru: "From where? They were waiting outside, right?"

Abel: "On whose orders?"

And with that immediate response, Subaru was at a loss for words.

Letting his head work, he started to assemble a pillar of answers for Abel's questions. But before it could be assembled properly,

Al: "—That lil' miss must've instructed them in advance."

And so, from behind, Al stole the answer.

He had been in a state of being unable to speak just a while before. Subaru turned his head to the direction from which his voice came, calling him out with "Al...". Al's mood seemed like it had not returned to its usual state.

Al: "Sorry, bro, for worrying you... Well, things haven't gotten any better."

Abel: "Your mood has yet to improve? That too must be the effect of Olbart's technique."

Al: "...I don't disagree with that. I'd love to talk about it, but we should finish what we were talking about first. So, let's talk about Lil' Miss Tanza."

Waving his now-small hand, Al answered in a voice that consciously suppressed his emotion.

Al's condition was worrisome, but he was right, they were in the middle of a conversation— It was certain that Tanza had gathered all the people outside in advance.

Subaru: "Uhhh, well, so you're saying that Tanza gathered her horned comrades around the inn ahead of time and was planning on them attacking us? But, if that's the case..."

Medium: "Where'd Tanza-chan go?"

The question with which Medium completed Subaru's words was the answer that had not appeared in him just yet.

Tanza had appeared at the inn to deliver the instructions from Yorna, and should've gone straight back. Even though he could understand how she had arranged everything, the reaction of her comrades outside was weird.

At least, that Subaru's group had done something to Tanza was what the sheepboy had believed.

Al: "So her comrades mustn't have seen her safe and sound... No, they probably didn't see her come out of the inn in the first place."

Abel: "That too is reasonable. It could be that they did not attempt any radical measures until we left the inn, in light of the possibility that Tanza was inside talking to us."

Medium: "But! Where's Tanza-chan then—"

Medium, with wide eyes and her head in a state of turmoil, let out something resembling a scream.

However, Subaru could understand Abel's thoughts once they were so carefully ordered. Perhaps, this was what Abel was thinking. That was—

Subaru: "That girl... If Tanza isn't outside the inn, she's hiding somewhere— And that means Olbart-san's helping her!?"



—To take back Tanza, a group of people belonging to horned races had attacked Subaru's group.

However, since they had been waiting outside the inn since the start, they must've had a meeting beforehand on what they should do if something happened to Tanza.

And within that inn, the only possible conspirator for Tanza was—

Abel: "—None other than Olbart Dunkelkenn."

Al: "...It's also possible that the inn's employees worked together to hide her, y'know."

Abel: "Naturally, I am not blind to that possibility. But I have firm assurance."

Al: "Firm assurance?"

In response to Al's questioning voice, Abel nodded deeply.

Why was he convinced that Olbart and Tanza were conspiring together? That would be because—

Abel: “He took the trouble to challenge us to a mere child’s game of running and hiding. That is the sort of vicious plot the old man is fond of.”

Subaru: “Find me if you can~, like that?”

Abel: “Correct.”

Subaru couldn’t help but make a disgusted face at Abel’s affirmation as he corrected his posture.

Abel’s guess, based on the badness of Olbart’s character, was spot on. Yes, Subaru was also intuitively convinced of the reason for the disgusted look.

The fact that he had suggested “hide-and-seek” was itself a metaphor for hiding Tanza.

Subaru: “But if that’s why we were attacked, then it’s a *kimari*²⁶ violation!”

Abel: “Are you referring to the rule about not harming each other? He would get away with it by saying, «I did not do anything». Even more so if Tanza is in league with him.”

Subaru: “Guh... Such an unfair scheme...!”

Abel: “Therefore, the priority shall be to locate Olbart. Then, Tanza’s whereabouts shall be simultaneously disclosed. But if the plan is revealed, the pretext for playing “hide-and-seek” may vanish.”

He had now understood how the fact that Olbart and Tanza could be together had been discovered. But he didn’t understand the part on how that would be the end of the game of “hide-and-seek”.

His eyebrows furrowing, a frown formed on Subaru’s face. Now facing him, Abel snatched the oni mask from Subaru’s hand with violence.

Startled, Subaru exclaimed an “Ah!” as, in front of him, Abel put the oni mask back on,

²⁶ English flip. Means “rule” (決まり), originally “ルール” (rule).

Abel: “Olbart’s goal is to ascertain if we are worth negotiating with. He is more interested in this than in childish plays. Therefore, if we can unravel his true intentions, we needn’t go through the trouble of a contrived process.”

Subaru: “Ahh, okay, I think I get it...”

Abel: “—Is the extent of your intelligence becoming poor in earnest?”

To Subaru, who was barely following his explanation, Abel muttered so with a sigh.

He couldn’t counter Abel’s point. Subaru, too, was aware that his head was clearly out of whack. However, he wasn’t aware of to what extent.

Perhaps his thinking was shoddy, his words didn’t come out right, or he just wasn’t very smart.

Subaru: “I wasn’t even a smart guy to begin with...”

Abel: “As for your case, the issue is that you have lost your ability to comprehend and your creativity. The details of Olbart’s technique are unknown, but one theory would be that the body reflects the ups and downs of its own Od.”

Subaru: “T-the Od’s ups and downs...?”

Abel: “It means that there is a connection between the Od and the body, their growth and decay. So to speak, we can assume that Olbart has meddled with your... or rather, all of your Ods.”

Abel looked over at Subaru, Al, and Medium, whose bodies remained shrunk.

That explanation didn’t ring a bell to Subaru. As was the case with his broken Gate, which was used for magic, he had no real sense of the explanation about Mana and Od, whose existence he had originally been unaware of.

That was only true for Subaru, but not for—

Al: “—So, it’s because that old man was messing with our bodies.”

Subaru was surprised to hear Al grumble so hatefully.

Looking over to him, Al was touching his mask-covered forehead with trembling fingers. That he was clearly showing to be uncontrollably irritated often was evidence that he, too, was having psychological effects.

The mental capacity which they were able to have as adults was being lost as they became more childish.

Al: "That shitty geezer, I'm gonna get you for this...!"

Abel: "To do that, we need to find where this «abyss with a great view» is located."

Subaru: "Yeah... Speaking of which, we were going to head for a tavern."

With Al boiling with anger beside him, Subaru cut off his words there.

As a result of being forced to stay in the street, Taritta was acting as bait with the rest going separate ways. However, no explanation of the true purpose was given.

Why did Abel want to rush to a tavern?

Abel: "The basis of our hunt is numbers. Ideally, it should be someone that knows the land. However, it is possible that all the inhabitants of this city are siding with Tanza. Consequently, it would be better to utilize outsiders."

Al: "So you're targeting a bar where strangers might flock together. Sounds like an idea bro'd have."

Subaru: "Um, that's..."

He wanted to continue with "wrong", but then remembered that he'd looked for a bodyguard in Guaral.

That had happened when a man, Todd, had targeted him; just remembering him made Subaru shudder. Among the many ideas he had considered to save himself, he'd headed to a tavern, planning to hire a strong escort.

Unfortunately, the drunken swordsman he had hired that time was soon killed.

Subaru: “But you need money to get help, don’t you? We can’t find that kind of money just anywhere.”

Abel: “That concern is irrelevant. I have a reward.”

Having said that, Abel shook the bag he was carrying.

As he’d called it necessary when carrying it out of the inn, Subaru was curious about what was inside.

In response to the look in his eyes, Abel did not go as far as to open the mouth of his bag, but said,

Abel: “When leaving Guaral, I had Zikr open the City Hall’s treasury. This is the most efficient way to obtain collaborators. Not making use of it will not do.”

Al: “...That was a shrewd thing to do.”

Subaru: “But walking around with a lot of money while wearing an oni mask’s dangerous, and will make you stand out... Oh, I see.”

As he was saying this, Abel tapped his finger on the oni mask, reminding Subaru of his misplaced concern.

Since the oni mask had the effect of “cognitive disruption”, the idea that it “stood out” was an incorrect way of thinking to begin with. Since it had no effect on Subaru’s group, the difference between their actual situation and the reactions of the people around them was confusing.

Al: “So, we ain’t changing what we’re gonna do? We’re all gonna go to a tavern and look for someone to help us find that old dude?”

Abel: “—Yes, that was the original idea. However, things have changed somewhat.”

Subaru: “Things have changed, how so?”

Abel: “If Olbart and Tanza were behind this from the onset, they should be able to find a method to increase manpower quickly. While Olbart alone would have no influence in Demon City, Tanza’s addition makes it a whole other matter. That girl has the position of attendant to Yorna Mishigure.”

As Yorna held the highest position in Chaosflame, being Yorna's attendant would mean that person would be like a secretary. In other words, Tanza was the second most important person in the city, after Yorna.

Or rather, that meant that she could conduct herself as such.

Subaru: "If they really want to keep us reigned in, they'd put people around the taverns."

Abel: "There is no need to fall into an obvious trap. Though, there may be ways to force our way through."

During that conversation that made a change of plans necessary, Abel's gaze turned to the side as he spoke. Subaru followed his line of sight, and his cheeks tensed up.

Louis: "Uau?"

That was because Louis stood, at the place where line of sight of the oni mask was directed too, tilting her head.

Louis, who'd turned the tables on their attackers and at the end mercilessly knocked the sheepboy into unconsciousness, was combing her fingers feverishly through her own blonde hair beside Medium, who'd become attached to her.

Despite her overwhelming fighting power, there was no change in her very attitude of innocence.

This, in turn, sent a cold shiver down Subaru's spine.

Medium: "Oh, Louis-chan was amazing just now! I'm shocked that you were hiding abilities like that~."

Louis: "Auau."

Medium: "Hehehe, thanks for saving me."

In disregard of Subaru's state of mind, Medium stroked Louis's head, defenseless. The latter accepted that palm with calm, but Subaru's heart was pounding.

So Subaru immediately let out a "Wait!", even grabbing Medium's wrist.

Medium: “Wah, Subaru-chin?”

Subaru: “Errr, Medium-san, you shouldn’t get close to her...”

Medium: “—? Why? She saved me, right? She even saved you, Subaru-chin.”

Subaru: “Well, that might be true, but... However...”

Subaru was unable to express a reply to Medium’s innocent question.

In fact, her view was honest and correct. Louis had saved Subaru. She had not hesitated in protecting Subaru with her petite body, even at the cost of getting hurt.

Subaru had desperately pleaded, “Don’t die”, as well.

Al: “Come on now, tell us what’s up.”

Seeing Subaru’s clenched teeth, Al spoke in a low voice.

Subaru gasped and looked down at the gloomy eyes through his mask— He recalled that a few days ago, during the trip to Chaosflame, he’d kept Louis’s circumstances a secret from Al.

At that time, Subaru could not come to a decision on how to treat Louis, so he had put his answer on hold. However—

Al: “Come on, this isn’t a situation that can be overlooked with a smile anymore. It’s not just my concern, but a concern all of us have.”

Subaru: “———”

Al: “What secret are you keeping about that girl?”

His questioning gaze was so intense that Subaru reflexively sheltered Louis behind him.

It was because he did not know how Louis would react to that gaze, rather than because he was trying to protect Louis— no, Subaru didn’t know if that was true as well.

If there was one thing he could say, however, it was that he couldn’t deceive them any longer.

And Subaru's young, deficient brain could not even make up a lie that sounded plausible.

That was why—

Subaru: "She's, Louis is... the Sin Archbishop of Gluttony."

And so, all he could do was to clearly reveal the truth.



—The true identity of Louis Arneb.

It was a secret that Subaru had kept from Rem, who had lost her memories, and from everyone else they had met ever since being sent to the Vollachian Empire.

Subaru expected that the trouble that would result from the discovery of Louis's true identity as an Sin Archbishop, both concerning him and others, would be a lot— No, it was bound to be much worse than he could've expected.

That was why Subaru hid that fact from the world until this very moment—

???: "—Sin... Archbishop."

A faltering voice ruminated on the words, the facts that Subaru had revealed.

It would be no wonder if Al and Abel were astonished by that fact. It was only natural to be alarmed, to want to verify the facts, to shout out how ridiculous all that would be.

However, the one whose voice trembled first was neither that of Al, nor that of Abel.

???: "Louis-chan's, a Sin Archbishop..."

Louis: "Uu?"

Indeed, Medium was the one to let out a shocked voice.

Medium's blue eyes widened as she gazed motionlessly at Louis. Medium's gaze caused said Louis to tilt her head and make a silly sound, as if she had no idea what she was talking about.

And that was exactly the reaction that Subaru feared the most.

He'd thought optimistically that perhaps Medium— No, that perhaps the O'Connell siblings would take it in stride and laugh it off as nothing at all.

However, his optimism had been misplaced, as he came to realize that it had only been an idealistic dream.

Medium: "——"

That was the unmistakable and certain "fear" that flashed across Medium's eyes.

Al: "Bro, that joke ain't funny."

Subaru: "I-it's not a joke..."

Al: "If this ain't a joke, it's even less funny!"

Subaru, shocked by Medium's reaction, could not respond adequately to Al's words that followed.

Raising his voice, Al drew out the *dao* he was carrying on his back with violence. Of course, it was not something that a single tiny arm of a child could hold with ease, so the sword that had been pulled out had buried its tip in the ground.

Still, if he swung it using all his weight, it could still be used. Loaded with that sharp intent, Al's gaze turned to Subaru and Louis behind him.

Al: "You can't be right in the head, carrying a Sin Archbishop around. You haven't forgotten what happened in Pristella, have you?"

Subaru: "T-that's..."

Al: "Me and Priscilla... No harm was done to the Princess, but that's just happenstance. Your people and acquaintances got put through hell. One of the reasons why is that right there."

There was no way to argue with the anger in Al's voice, who leaned against the *dao* stuck in the ground.

Al was completely right. By all accounts, it was Subaru who was in the wrong. He should not have taken Louis with him, nor should he have let Louis run amok.

He should have revealed her true identity, tied her up, and held her captive, depriving her of her freedom.

But Subaru had not done that. Aside from that—

Subaru: "A-Abel...?"

He looked at Abel, wondering if the latter agreed with Al in his silence.

Now that Medium was afraid and Al was angry, Abel's attitude was the last bastion— and Subaru couldn't even tell for whom he was a bastion.

However, if everyone at this place chose to be hostile to Louis,

Subaru: "———"

For certain, Subaru could put a stop to this hesitation and start moving.

Abel: "I know not how they are handled in other nations."

Just before Subaru as he took a gulp, a man in an oni mask carrying a bag met his gaze head-on.

Black eyes met black eyes, and Subaru's chest was pierced by the cold gaze. His brain started shutting down, as if rejecting the words he should have waited for, and the content that was to follow.

That voice slowly penetrated into that numb brain of his. That was—

Abel: "In the Empire, those who serve the Witch for any reason whatsoever are executed."

A definitive declaration from an existence that stood at the pinnacle of the Empire, even though he had been ousted from his throne.



It was a verdict of execution that clearly asserted that they would never be able to see eye-to-eye.

The moment he heard this, Subaru tightly shut his eyes—

Subaru: “—Hk, Louis!”

Medium: “Subaru-chin!”

Just as he emotionally shouted her name, a small pair of hands went around Subaru’s waist.

Immediately after, Medium’s voice echoed like a cry, and Subaru’s legs left the ground and floated up into the air— no, Louis, who was attached to Subaru’s waist, leaped high up with Subaru.

Why, did he call out Louis’s name, what kind of meaning had been in there; Biting his molars, Subaru held back the tears coming to his eyes for some reason.

It just came to his mind.

Louis: “Uau.”

That he should not abandon this girl now, who was clutching him around the waist and was ooh’ing and aah’ing.

It wasn’t that he had returned the favor and saved her life because she had saved him. It wasn’t that Subaru mistakenly felt something like compassion and a need to protect her. It just came to his mind.

With the shrinking of not only his limbs but also the contents of his head, Subaru regretted that he had given an answer about this girl, who he didn’t know what to think of.

That was Subaru’s problem, something that had nothing to do with Rem or the many people they had met so far.

It was a problem that Natsuki Subaru absolutely had to face with all his might.

Al: “Bro! Get back here! Fucking—!”

Al, looking up, shouted at him, but Louis’s feet did not stop as she kicked off the wall and leapt away.

While hugging Subaru's back, Louis kicked the wall of the building facing the street and ascended to the rooftop, then moved on to the next street without any trouble, and the next one after that.

In Chaosflame, a city covered with scaffolding, in which jointed paths could be freely created, Louis's boundless lack of restraint was truly unrivaled.

Subaru: "Bwah!"

After a few more leaps, Subaru dismounted and got down on his hands and knees, taking repeated deep breaths. It was painful, not only to defy gravity so many times, but also to have Louis's slender arms tighten like a vise around his torso.

Louis, the person in question, peeked at Subaru's face from the side. The fact that Louis was so energetic was loathsome.

But, this was not the time for him to loath her face.

Subaru: "Shit, Abel and the others..."

That was the result of his own actions. To say that he'd just strayed from the others would be too obvious of a lie.

But had he stayed in that place, who knew what orders Abel would have given; judging from Al's reaction, he would not have let Louis off peacefully.

He could also say that not much could be expected from Medium's ability to defuse situations.

That said, he blamed his heart for not obeying and handing Louis over to them.

Louis: "Uau?"

Wiping his mouth with his sleeve, Subaru raised his head and saw Louis's blue eyes looking at him innocently.

Subaru's attitude of not caring at all about things such as hostility and fear directed at him made him feel like an idiot, for letting his mind go around in circles like this.

Subaru: “I’m an idiot. No, I am definitely an idiot.”

In fact, he was a big idiot.

Abel aside, it was idiotic to leave Medium and Al behind, and run away with Louis.

He had no idea what they were thinking or what they could do.

Subaru: “Still, if I make the decision now, I might regret it. This isn’t something a little kid should be deciding.”

The life and death of people, and ultimately the future of the Empire, were both very important matters, so he thought.

It was strange that such a big issue should be decided by a child of only about ten years old, subjected to the eyes of a ruthless adult— It was wrong.

Subaru: “I’m sure the original me could make the right decision. So...”

He must dispel this “infantilization” as soon as possible, and return from being the little boy Natsuki Subaru to the young man Natsuki Subaru.

That way, he would be able to fret over whether or not to deal with Louis, and give a reasonable answer to the decision his companions had reached, and attain a satisfactory conclusion.

To that end—

Subaru: “—Let’s find Olbart-san. I’m going to do everything I can, without relying on Abel and the others.”

Louis: “Aa, uu!”

Louis raised her head in response to Subaru, lifting both her hands in the air with a cheerful look on her face.

Looking down on the landscape of the Demon City from scaffolding up high, two small children breathed alongside each other, aspiring to find the *shinobi* head honcho who'd turned against the residents of Chaosflame and the ousted Emperor.

—Unexpectedly, Subaru and Louis were the *Oni* in the game of “hide-and-seek” and the ones being chased by the *Oni* in the game of “tag”.²⁷

²⁷ Translation note from Witch Cult Translations: “In the Japanese games of tag, which is normally called «鬼ごっこ» (onigokko) and hide-and-seek, the person who is «it», or in other words, the one doing the chasing/finding, is called the «鬼» (oni). You may recognize this as the word «鬼» used for Ram and Rem’s race.”

Arc 7 Chapter 49 - The Stars Aligned

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 29, Chapter 5 “The Stars Aligned”, Parts 1-3

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Edited Machine Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Original by Goldkills, Kiln, Translation checked by Averitius, PaperKaminari, MaskedBook) — [Complete](#)

Al: “Damn it! I can’t see them anywhere...!”

Looking up at the sky from the street, as his gaze swept over the numerous scaffolds, the masked figure of a boy— no, of Al, yelled as he stomped on the ground.

The unbelievable situation that had just occurred had spurred his frustration and made his heart boil with fury.

Absurd, that was all he could say about that turn of events.

Medium: “Subaru-chin, Louis-chan...”

On the other hand, in contrast to Al, his anger laid bare, Medium muttered so, her face downcast.

The young girl dressed like a dancer rolled herself into a ball, concerned for the two who had fled the scene.

However, the nature of the emotions in her murmur was complicated and confused.

It was difficult to say that it was only out of concern. It was undoubtedly related to the words Subaru had spoken before his disappearance.

Medium: “Louis-chan’s...”

Abel: “—A Sin Archbishop, he said.”

Medium: “—Hk.”

Upon finding the continuation of the words that had unintentionally leaked from her own lips, Medium’s eyes widened.

Disregarding Medium, Abel gazed upwards toward the sky, just like Al. He had put his mask back on and was no longer showing his face, so it was impossible for others to tell what he was thinking.

However, it was clear from his fingers tapping his crossed arms that this situation was not a welcome one, for him.

Medium: “Abel-chin, those two...”

Abel: “—Our priority is to get this situation under control. Our course of action remains the same. Unfortunately, the number of methods we possess has once more abated by one.”

To Medium’s feeble question, Abel returned an answer in a cold tone.

He did not mention Subaru and Louis explicitly. But it was apparent that Abel did not intend to rejoin them immediately.

Hearing this, Medium felt both anxiety and relief deep in her heart.

There was a feeling of worry regarding those two, as well as a feeling of relief for not having to also confront them.

She also felt horrified that she had been told something that should not even be said in jest, in a situation where it could not be laughed off as a joke.

Al: “You want to leave him alone? Bro, and particularly now, when he’s got the mind of a child!”

Abel: “So what shall we do? The situation we are in will not be any different. I shall warn you, if you and Medium are no longer useful, I shall need to leave you behind.”

Al: “Guh...”

Abel: “Do not presume you alone hold the right to choose who we ally with or not, clown.”

Unable to speak, Al wanted to join up with the stranded Subaru and Louis, but this was coldly rejected by Abel. However, Al's focus was only Subaru; Louis's existence was secondary.

Al's attitude regarding Louis, whose identity as a bomb had been revealed, was clear.

Al: "I can't leave bro and that brat together..."

As he muttered to himself, cupping his mouth, Al's hostility towards Louis was apparent.

Medium wished to complain about Al's attitude, but she herself could not come to a decision on her attitude toward Louis, and an uncharacteristic deliberation formed in that silence.

Abel: "-----"

Abel, glancing sideways towards the two, once again looked up overhead.

Their figures no longer visible, Subaru and Louis had jumped somewhere into the Demon City, as nary a trace remained of them in this jumble of a sight his gaze lay on.

Abel: "Fool."

The single word that escaped his mouth, was a mutter to nobody in particular.



—And so, while in this unprecedented situation, Subaru had gone on his own, separate from his friends.

It had been a spur-of-the-moment act, he really couldn't say it was a decision he had arrived at after properly thinking about the future.

Even so, there'd definitely be some regrets about that situation if he did make a decision in a hurry. All he could say with certainty was that he'd taken that action to avoid having regrets.

And now, Subaru was already "regretting" the decision he had made. Because—

Louis: “Au, uau!”

Subaru: “Stop it, Louis! That’s enough!”

Using a chokehold on Louis’s small body from behind, Subaru pulled her writhing body away. The one he pulled her away from, was a now-unconscious man who had pursued them before being straddled by Louis.

After parting with Abel and the others, they had managed to jump across the scaffolding in the city, and while looking for Olbart to restore the “infantilized” Subaru, the enemy caught up with them.

Apparently, the pursuers were aware of the appearance of the “infantilized” Subaru and of a target who had not visited the castle tower, Louis. It seemed Abel’s guess was correct.

In other words, Olbart and Tanza were accomplices, and the information they held was also passed to their pursuers—— those of the horned races.

As a result, Subaru, who was traveling alone with Louis, had been chased and almost caught——

Louis: “Uu!”

Louis’s fighting skills, which she had shown on the street, exploded, and their pursuers were quickly neutralized.

That in itself was a blessing. Even before his limbs had shrunk, Subaru’s fighting ability was a disappointment. He would be no match even against those of the city who didn’t know how to fight, because Yorna had given them a portion of her power through the Soul Marriage Technique.

However, the problem was that Louis would not stop attacking, even after she had neutralized their pursuers.

Louis: “Auu...”

Subaru: “Don’t «auu» me! If you do that, they’ll die! These people are just scared, that’s all. That wouldn’t be good at all!”

Louis: “Uu.”

Her legs flailing, Louis calmed down after hearing Subaru's warning.

He didn't know whether she understood what he had just said, but at any rate, she seemed to understand that Subaru was angry. Seeing this, Subaru tended to the fallen opponent.

As he had no first-aid kit, all he could do was to lay his head up high and wipe the bleeding wound.

Subaru: "...These people as well."

Louis: "Uau?"

Subaru: "They're desperate. They don't want their place in the world to be destroyed."

The young men, a sheepman and a deerman, who had been beaten up by Louis, were still in their late teens or early twenties, not much different from the original Subaru. The people around the inn, and the sheep boy who had thrown Subaru in the street, were all of varying ages, there was nothing that made them seem like friends.

But there was a definite connection. That being, the horns that grew on their heads.

Depending on the person, they could be different for having one or two horns, but a horn was a horn.

The influence it'd had on their lives was not something Subaru, who knew of Emilia's case, could scoff at.

Subaru: "I'm glad Rem isn't here, I guess."

As a member of the oni tribe, Rem had the characteristic horn that grew on her forehead.

Unlike those beastmen, the horns would not be grown out all the time, but as a someone from a horned race, it was possible she was not entirely unrelated to the situations they'd experienced in life.

Not like he'd ever heard something of the sort from Ram or Rem, though.

Subaru: "I don't think Ram'd give a crap of what anyone said about her."

Because Ram was the type to go her own way, no matter what the outside world had to say about her horn, it was certain that she would blow their words off with a snickering "Ha!".

With her strength that was not bound by race nor title, it was certain she would.

—Perhaps, such a girl could keep a level head upon finding out about Louis.

Subaru: "...I'm an idiot."

Louis: "Uau."

Striking his forehead with his fist, Subaru withdrew his shameful and selfish thoughts.

Seeing Subaru's gesture, Louis, who was crouching next to him, tilted her head.

Ram was not present. Emilia, and Beatrice as well, everyone was not present.

Even Rem, who was closest to him, was still in Guaral, far away from here— there was no time to comfort himself by relying on someone not present.

Subaru: "Anyway, it's bad if we stick around standing out. We need to hide quickly."

Honestly, considering his original plan, running and hiding would be a waste of time. Normally, he'd have to chase after the person running away and hiding.

And yet, Subaru had become the one being chased.

Subaru: "Maybe Abel won't look for us... I guess. He's probably angry, and might believe that finding Olbart-san's more important, I guess."

Louis: "Au."

Subaru: "Should we join up with Taritta-san? Taritta-san's being chased by a lot of people in a strange city... No, that's no good."

Placing his hand to his head, Subaru put on hold the idea of joining up with the clueless Taritta.

He didn't feel like he could successfully explain to Taritta why he was not with Abel and the others. He'd have to lie, but lying wouldn't solve the problem.

Medium was out of the question. Once Taritta found out that Louis was a Sin Archbishop, she would see her as dangerous, and distance herself from her, just as the others did.

Subaru: “I’m worried about Taritta-san, but I think Abel and the others might be looking for her over there.”

Right now, he didn’t want to join up with Abel and the others, from whom he’d just become separated.

Without an answer to how Louis should be handled, he thought it’d be more of the same with Abel and the others. Besides, he didn’t want to be hated by everyone for arguing with them like that again.

The past him, who had been unable to persuade everyone, also didn’t want to become hated.

Subaru: “Louis, let’s go. We need to find Olbart-san at «an abyss with a great view».”

Louis: “Uau.”

While saying this, Subaru linked hands with Louis and pulled her along to make her walk away.

He had no idea of where to go originally, but after she’d unveiled her power— the Authority of Gluttony, his anxiety became even greater. Therefore—

Subaru: “If you don’t want to die, stay close to me. I don’t want you to die either... now.”

Louis: “Aa, uu.”

Whether she understood or not, Louis nodded her head in acceptance. With that, Subaru let out a deep breath at the girl’s smiling face.

Two children, wandering around in a strange city, aimlessly trying to solve a riddle—

Subaru: “This makes me feel like I’m truly a missing child.”

That weak mutter was all he could muster.



—After that, Subaru and Louis’s chase sequence, as well as their escape, was complicated.

Probably because Subaru did not have a good grasp of the city’s layout, and because communicating with his companion was difficult, and genuinely because of Subaru’s bad luck.

At any rate, he was being chased around inside the Demon City. Unable to find this “abyss with a great view”, his time was running out with every moment that went by.

Subaru: “Louis! Stop fighting! Run, run, run, run!”

Louis: “Au! Uh!”

As Louis rushed out, Subaru stopped her by literally bumping her with all his weight.

He hopped onto her tiny back, forcing himself in a position of being carried by piggyback. Louis propped up Subaru’s body to keep him from being shaken off as she then leapt high to escape from the ones chasing them.

???: “Don’t let them get away!”

And the ones to shout that while chasing after them, were the horned beastmen patrolling the Demon City.

Apparently, their pursuers were really only those with horns. Regarding the inhabitants of Chaosflame, Subaru had seen many demi-humans without horns. It seemed that they had not been given the order to capture Subaru and Louis.

Subaru: “Seems like that Tanza girl doing this of her own free will...”

Tanza was a young deergirl, although she held something like the position of a secretary to Yorna, Subaru supposed there was a limit to how far she could make those under her command move.

As a result, there’d be no way to escape if all the inhabitants of Chaosflame were to become “it”. It seemed that the girl was also fighting on the edge of how much she could abuse her power.

Even then, they were being cornered plenty on that edge. From Subaru’s point of view, she could have even held back a bit.

Subaru: “Uh... They’re coming after us! Louis, don’t attack! We gotta get out of here!”

Louis: “Uu?”

Subaru: “Why not! The reason is, everything! Anyhow, this isn’t working!”

With Subaru on her back, stepping on window frames of buildings and protruding scaffolds, Louis did not seem happy with this escape decided upon by a single person, as she went *bounce-bounce* all over the city.

She looked as if she wanted to say that they’d win if she fought; Subaru protested this by tugging on her cheek.

Indeed, if Louis did fight, she might be able to defeat their pursuers.

However, if Louis were to fight, those following them might get killed. Hypothetically, even if she knocked them unconscious, there was no telling if Louis would stop her assault there.

Actually, just a short while ago, if Subaru hadn’t stopped her, Louis would’ve thrown their pursuers off the high scaffolding, dropping them to the ground below.

Louis had not seemed to have lost her almost infant-like innocence.

But, even with that innocence, the power of Gluttony had returned to Louis. Subaru dreaded that, as it seemed to be no different from the rampage of the original “Louis Arneb”.

If this Louis ever went back to being “Louis Arneb”—

Subaru: “—That’d mean that Abel and the others’ opinion is right.”

In that case, there was no need to run away from the street and no need to strain his relationship with Abel and the others.

The existence of the girl known as Louis, was something Subaru was required to worry about, strangely.

Which was why it was no good.

Subaru: “I won’t let you kill anyone else, any more.”

As long as Natsuki Subaru's eyes were black, he would not let that happen²⁸.

Louis: “—Au.”

Louis gazed forward quietly as Subaru tightened his hold upon her back.

It seemed she had retracted her complaining attitude from before for the time being, reconsidering doing what Subaru had suggested. For now, Louis tried to shake off the beastmen on their tails; bouncing and skipping repeatedly, she continued to run away as her golden hair whipped about. However—

Subaru: “So, stubborn...!”

Maybe it was natural, since the only effort they were making to shake them off was running away, but it was difficult to give the beastmen chasing them the slip. In addition to knowing the lay of the land, because of the flame in one of their eyes— because of Yorna's Soul Marriage Technique, the gap between them was shrinking, rather than growing.

Subaru: “If it goes on like this—”

They would get caught; as such Subaru bit down on teeth that were neither baby nor permanent.

It was at that moment.

???: “—You two, this way.”

Subaru: “Huh?”

Louis: “Au?”

Louis kicked off the wall with force, as she tried to trick the eye of their pursuers with sharp movements. Before they could see if what they intended had been fulfilled, a voice reached the two as they landed on the street.

²⁸ Translation note from Witch Cult Translations: “This is just a really emphatic way to write «No fucking way Subaru would let that happen».”

Taking a look at it, a young man with a thin face was beckoning Subaru and Louis to come over. There were no horns to be found on the young man's head at a quick glance, but that didn't put Subaru at ease right away.

Subaru: "Y-you're..."

Young Man: "You're being chased, aren't you? From the looks of it, those people seem to be preeettyyy~ serious. This is some friendly advice so it'd be nice if you could be good and hear what I have to say."

In response to Subaru's wary look, the young man beckoned to him with a friendly smile. Just like that, he used his hand to point out a cart on the road to Subaru and Louis, the two out of breath.

Specifically, he was indicating a gap between several barrels in the back of said cart,

Young Man: "Since you two have small bodies, you'll fit in there for sure."

Subaru: "B-but even if we hide there it doesn't mean..."

Young Man: "We don't have any more time. The alignment of the stars changes every moment. It's up to you, of course, to shun this alignment, or to accept it."

Subaru: "-----"

Young Man: "Hoooweeever~, I think it's in your best interest to come with me."

Waving his empty hands in the air, the young man laughed to show that he meant no harm.

Subaru hesitated quite a bit on whether he should trust that smile or not. But he was right, he didn't have much time to spend hesitating.

Therefore---



???: "They must've come this way!"

A group of bloodthirsty men appeared, searching for any sign of the missing fugitives. As they went along, they spotted a young man standing near a cart, leaning his back against a wall.

???: “Hey, you there! Did two kids come by here?”

Young Man: “Huh? Umm, you wouldn’t be talking to me, would you? I’m sorry, but I was just taking a break for a sec here...”

???: “Like I said, I was wondering if you’ve seen them during your break... Oh, forget it!”

The oxman, who had approached the cart with noisy footsteps, gave up because of the young man’s dismissive words. But that didn’t mean that the oxman had overlooked the cart near the youth.

He stopped questioning the young man, instead refocusing his attention on the cart.

Oxman: “Say, what’s the cargo?”

Young Man: “Well, what do you think it is? What kinda merchant do I look like?”

Oxman: “Tch.”

At the elusive young man’s words, the oxman clicked his tongue and glared at the cart. Then, grabbing a pile of barrels, he tipped the load effortlessly, his right eye burning.

With a loud bang, the setup of unbalanced cargo was thrown about. The stacked barrels swayed from one side to the other; if anyone had been hiding in the back of the cart, they would have been struck by the weight of the barrels.

Seeing this, the oxman took his hand off the barrel and,

Oxman: “Sorry for disturbing you.”

Leaving behind those words, he walked away from the scene with his companions.

Behind him, the young man called out with “Please fix the barrels!”. However, as the other part didn’t reply, the young man gave a shrug of his thin shoulders

Young Man: “Good griiief~, they were arrogant people, weren’t they? I dunno what to think of them.”

Talking to himself, the young man approached the cart on the deserted street. He crouched down to look underneath the cart instead of at the load. There—

Young Man: “You were right not to carelessly hide in the back of the cart. If you had hid there, every bone in your body would’ve been shattered by now. That would’ve been very painful, wouldn’t it?”

Subaru: “...Don’t say such scary things.”

Louis: “Uu.”

The young man made a dreadful remark in a light-hearted tone, with a smile on his face, as Subaru and Louis crawled out from the cart they had hidden under.

It was natural to think that, given the cart had been loaded with barrels, they’d be hidden there. Subaru, at first, did as he’d been told and tried to hide in the back of the cart, but as he’d had a bad feeling about it, he had decided not to.

Subaru: “But, since there was no time to run, I hid under the back of the cart.”

Young Man: “I think it was a very good decision. I’m not very good at lying, and I would’ve told him right away if he had questioned me a bit too roughly.”

Subaru: “...No problem, I wouldn’t have expected any different because you’re not one of us.”

Having been underneath the cart, clinging onto its wheels, Subaru patted the dirt off his hands and clothes, and then patted Louis’s equally dirty body.

Apparently, the pursuers had lost sight of Subaru and Louis, so he should be grateful to the young man for his help.

Subaru: “But, why did you help us?”

Young Man: “Why did I help? Hmmhm~, why, huh. Oh, how about the fact that I couldn’t stand to see children being chased?”

Subaru: “If you’re putting it as «How about», you definitely just made it up...”

Young Man: “Have I been found out?”

Faced by Subaru’s doubtful eyes, the young man stroked his head in an annoyed fashion.

He smiled bitterly, but from what Subaru could tell, he was not a demi-human. Not only did he have no horns, but he also had no animal-like ears, skin, nor claws.

That aside, this human being right now gave off the atmosphere of being from outside of Chaosflame.

Subaru: “You’re...”

Young Man: “Oh, whoops, I’m Ubilk. I can understand why you might wanna doubt me, but there’s not much I can say.”

Subaru: “What do you mean, there’s not much you can say?”

Ubilk: “The only reason I helped you two was because I thought it’d be a good idea.”

Laughing, the young man— Ubilk, ran his fingers through his ashen hair.

His gestures and good looks made Subaru think that Ubilk was a man with a proper job. Even his travel clothes, which appeared to be lightly worn, looked like they had been paid for with a fair amount of money.

Subaru thought that he was surely a merchant, because he was hauling a cart.

Subaru: “Is that what you’d call a merchant’s intuition?”

Ubilk: “A merchant’s... Oh, me? Hahaha, no. I’m no merchant or anything like that. And this cart isn’t mine either.”

Subaru: “Huh!? But, you told those people...”

Ubilk: “I never said I was a merchant. Of course, I also never said that this cart belonged to me. It’s just a cart that happens to be sitting here. It probably belongs to the store right there, doesn’t it?”

After those words, Ubilk pointed to the nearest store and said, “I wonder if it’s that one? Or maybe it could be that one?”. He was kidding, but he didn’t seem to be entirely joking.

In other words, it seemed that he'd really simply bluffed his way out of that pursuit.

Louis: "Uau."

Subaru: "Ah, yeah, I get it."

As he kept up with Ubilk's pace, Louis unexpectedly pulled on his sleeve.

Subaru, who was starting to wonder whether it was alright to stand still, reflected on his own carefree self who was being rushed by Louis.

Their situation hadn't gotten any better, even though they had shaken off their pursuers.

Subaru: "Well, thank you for your help, Ubilk-san. But you should think and act more seriously next time. I'm sure you're going to get into a lot of trouble because of this..."

Ubilk: "Whaat's~ that, are you worried about me? Do I look so unfortunate? I think I'm a pretty worldly man, but you seem to disagree."

Subaru: "No, not that I'm suspicious of you or anything, but we're in a hurry."

To tell the truth, he was suspicious.

In this case, the suspicion wasn't that Ubilk was necessarily Tanza and Olbart's spy, but rather that he could be a dangerous adult who was genuinely unrelated to them.

As the two of them, Subaru and Louis both, were just children as of now, dealing with suspicious adults was plenty scary.

If the other party were a dangerous adult, Subaru might not be able to stop Louis from beating him to a pulp. Dealing with dangerous adults was a bridge too far for children to deal with.

Subaru: "Well, we've got stuff to do, so let's keep it at that. Thanks for helping us."

With that, Subaru pulled Louis by the hand and quickly walked away after an expression of his gratitude. However—

Ubilk: “Please waaait~ a minute. Don’t be so curt, let’s help one another. I think the spirit of mutual aid’s a wonderful thing.”

As he said this, Ubilk used his long, slender legs to jog around Subaru, cutting him off.

Immediately, Subaru’s Suspicious-and-Dangerous-Adult Index rose, and Ubilk’s standing with him was put into question. Going into details, Louis’s grip on his hand tightened and she voiced an “Uu?”, as she could sense Subaru’s caution towards Ubilk.

A case such as Louis leaping out as soon as she had Subaru’s approval, for her to then beat Ubilk to the ground and stuff him into a barrel, was possible.

Subaru: “Ubilk-san, are you flexible?”

Ubilk: “Me? Well, in my old work experience, the more flexible my body was, the more I could handle, so I was a flexible person. But, what are you asking me?”

Subaru: “No, no, it’s nothing... Helping each other, is there something you want us to help you with?”

Ubilk: “Oh, noooo~, that’s not what I meant. The spirit of mutual aid was just a slip of the tongue, not a request for help. Ahaha.”

Subaru: “———”

Once again, the Suspicious-and-Dangerous-Adult Index had increased.

This time, in addition to that, he felt that a novel Adult Index aside from the Dangerous one, the Adult-He-Didn’t-Want-Anything-To-Do-With Index, had just been newly established.

Anyway, this was not someone he wanted to spend much time with.

Ubilk: “Hahaha... Whaaat’s~ this, the mood’s colder than I expected. This is the same feeling I get when I’m surrounded by everyone. They hate me. Do you hate me?”

Subaru: “If possible, I’d prefer not to...”

Ubilk: “Ohhh~, you’re an honest one. Well then, since you seem to be in a hurry, and since you’re honest, and I like honest people, let’s have a quick serious chat.”

Subaru: “—Hk.”

As Ubilk said this, he bent at the waist and brought his face closer to Subaru. Subaru’s head dropped as he gulped unwittingly, and Louis, stepping forward, put her hand out in front of him in response.

She then pushed on Ubilk’s cheek from the side, threatening him with an “Uu!”.

Ubilk: “Whooooops~, she hates me. I thought I had a good reputation with girls, but I guess it’s different if they’ve already got a companion.”

Subaru: “...Ubilk-san, it’d be best if you don’t make Louis angry. This girl, well, she’s more powerful than she looks.”

Ubilk: “I see, Louis-san’s her name, isn’t it.”

Ubilk nodded his head, and Subaru gulped at his response.

There was no problem with him knowing her name, but he knew that he’d given out information that he shouldn’t have. He didn’t want to give more information to someone without knowing what kind of adult they were.

Subaru: “Ubilk-san! You said it’d be a serious chat, yeah? If there’s nothing else, we should go!”

Ubilk: “—I wasn’t planning on walking about the streets today at all.”

Subaru: “What?”

Ubilk: “Foor~ some reason though, I found myself wandering around aimlessly, wondering if something was going on, based on a feeling I had. So I came here on a whim, and killed some time next to this cart. And then...”

Placing his fingers on his forehead, he slid them to the gentle corner of his eye, to his clear, white cheeks, then down to his sculpted chin. At the end, Ubilk snapped his fingers.

Subaru was visibly stunned, transfixed by his behavior, and Ubilk, whose smile deepened at his reaction, waved his snapping fingers from side to side,

Ubilk: “You two appeared by nimbly leaping over my head.”

Subaru: “-----”

Ubilk: “...Whaat’s~ this, perhaps that didn’t that resonate with you?”

Tilting his head, Ubilk looked in turn at Subaru and Louis, both of whom didn’t react.

Louis simply might not have understood what was being said, but not Subaru. After hearing Ubilk’s answer, Subaru just could not speak.

He wondered if there was some grand, far-reaching reason hidden in there.

Subaru: “So you were just out for a walk, resting, and then we came along?”

Ubilk: “Haaa~, you can say it that way too, I guess. Buuut~, I think I can also say it this way— I think all this is just the stars’ guidance.”

Subaru: “The stars’... fate, or something like that...”

Although it sounded very romantic, Subaru’s shoulders slumped.

It would’ve been romantic had it been spoken at the beginning of a story in which a man and woman met, but here there was a combination of the shrunken Subaru and the originally small Louis. And Ubilk, the weirdo.

This was not romantic at all.

Ubilk: “Are you amazed by me, perchance?”

Subaru: “Well, it’s alright. Even if Ubilk-san’s seriousness isn’t that serious, it doesn’t bother me so much because he’s a person I don’t want to see ever again.”

Ubilk: “You said some pretty harsh and hurtful things to me. That kinda sharpness is similar to that of my old friend’s.”

Subaru: “Ubilk-san, you’ve got a friend...?”

Ubilk: “Ahaha, that hurt!”

He couldn’t help but let out a rude, honest thought, but Ubilk didn’t seem to be offended.

For just a moment, he thought that there some sort of subtle, complicated feeling from Ubilk towards his friend, somewhere in his sentimental, straightforward and unserious attitude.

Ubilk: “Anyway, it’s by some kinda fate that we met here. Hmmm~, that’s it! I’m actually in the business of giving small consultations. What do you think, why don’t you ask me for counselling?”

Subaru: “Finally, there it is! No thanks... No, I heard on TV that way of answering’s convenient for scammers. I don’t want it!”

Ubilk: “I’m not a pushy salesman, and I’m not here to trick you, okay? I just wanna do my assigned role, thooo~.”

Subaru: “Your assigned role?”

Ubilk: “Indeed, there must’ve been a reason as to why I’m here today. It’s probably for the chance for you and Louis-san to consult me.”

Ubilk nodded repeatedly, crossing his thin arms and acting like he was the only one who understood.

Unfortunately, Ubilk’s conviction did not sit well with Subaru. It was simply that the Suspicious-and-Dangerous-Adult Index was gradually increasing in value.

He’d rather just leave Ubilk here and run away if possible. He felt that even though Ubilk had given the slip to their pursuers, he was now entangled with a more troublesome opponent.

Ubilk: “Oh, it’s no use trying to escape. liif- you try to run away...”

Subaru: “Then what?”

Ubilk: “I’ll shout, and tell the people who just came by where you two are. You’d be in trouble, right?”

Subaru: “We’d be in a lot of trouble...!”

If that were to happen however, he was willing to unleash Louis.

Of course, as he didn't want to let Ubilk die, Subaru would do everything in his power to stop Louis's rampage, but he was prepared to use her as his last resort if Ubilk wanted to call out to their pursuers. Besides—

Subaru: "I'm sorry, but you don't want to know what's going on with us. If you hear about it, you might get involved and I don't think you can do anything about it."

Even if Subaru and Louis did nothing, Tanza and her comrades might hurt Ubilk. If that happened, it'd be Subaru and Louis's fault.

His thoughts were that he couldn't involve Ubilk in such a situation. However—

Ubilk: "Oh, don't worry about it, I'll be alright. I said I'd give you a consultation, but I'm a consultant who's just fine without hearing any specifics."

Subaru: "There's something like that!?"

Ubilk: "Well, well, if you think you've been lied to, lend me your hand."

Subaru's concern was overshadowed by Ubilk's carefree smile as he gently took Subaru's hand.

Since his right hand was connected to Louis's, the hand taken was his opposite left hand. Surprised by the touch of Ubilk's slender, feminine fingers, Subaru hurriedly glanced at Louis.

Louis: "Uu."

Fortunately, Louis had not a temper short enough as to suddenly attack Ubilk, although she was staring at his movements.

But that meant that he'd have to watch over a situation that was much like a balloon that could burst at any moment, all while having to keep filling it with air.

Subaru: "Umm, Ubilk-san, I don't have much time, and neither do you...."

Ubilk: "Whaaat's~ that, you're suddenly making me nervous too— But I'm already done."

Subaru: “Huh?”

While he was anxious about Louis’s line of sight aimed at Ubilk’s thin neck, after urging him on, Subaru’s arm was released from Ubilk’s grasp.

Removing his hand, Ubilk gently turned his palm towards Subaru’s face and,

Ubilk: “—The answer you’re seeking’s already within you.”

Subaru: “———”

Subaru’s eyes widened due to those unexpected words.

At Subaru’s lack of understanding, Ubilk uttered “Ohhh-?”, and tilted his head.

Ubilk: “Maybe that didn’t ring a bell?”

Subaru: “It’s not that it didn’t ring a bell, it’s just that I don’t really understand what it means....”

The answer he was looking for was also vague.

He felt that it was similar to what fortune tellers used to say on TV back at his original world. It was a common phrase used to scam people by saying something that applied to anyone.

Subaru: “I don’t think there are too many people who aren’t looking for answers...”

Ubilk: “Hmmm~, I’m not talking about something as big as life itself. I’m sorry to say that I’m not a person able to see the movement of stars that well.”

Subaru: “Like a horoscope....”

Ubilk: “Maybe it’s the problem in front of you. You see, you were both being chased, right? That’s also a problem, isn’t it? What do you think about that?”

Subaru: “But, I know why those people were after me——”

Perhaps confident in his own ability as a counselor, Ubilk tried to get closer to the right answer by delving into Subaru’s inner thoughts.

He wasn't sure about it; it felt a bit like a scammer's trick, but once he took it seriously, there was a slight tug at Subaru's heart.

Subaru: "-----"

That tug seemed to be a very important one.

Of course, he didn't know just how much of what he felt in his small Subaru head could be believed. However, even if he didn't believe in the "thoughts" of a small Subaru, there should be room to believe in the "intuition" of a small Subaru, regardless of the size of the body.

The problem that Subaru was facing right now, was---

Subaru: "—«An abyss with a great view»."

Ubilk had pointed out that the answer was already in Subaru.

He wasn't trying to probe deeper into the kind of scam it was. But he felt it.

—That tug he felt, if he could rope it in, he should be able to find the answer he was looking for.

Louis: "Uau?"

Subaru: "I think I might've figured it out."

Louis looked into Subaru's face once he replied to her, whose shapely eyebrows distorted into a frown. With the sound of Subaru's voice, which had slightly regained its strength, Louis widened her blue eyes and then smiled happily.

Seeing the change in Louis's expression from the side, Subaru exhaled, then looked at Ubilk.

Subaru: "The consultation might've worked."

Ubilk: "Ohhh-, I'm glad. I'm relieved, too. If I'm gonna do this, I wanna do my job properly. Then?"

Subaru: "Yeah, I'll hurry. Thank you for everything, Ubilk-san— Let's go, Louis!"

Louis: "Auau!"

In response to Ubilk, who closed one eye, Subaru pulled Louis's hand and began sprinting.

He started to run as fast as he could, stopping only once. And upon looking back, he saw that Ubilk's eyes were widened, possibly because he hadn't expected Subaru's actions.

Subaru waved his hand at him, and,

Subaru: "Ubilk-san, I won't say anything bad about you, so just go back to your parents'! And so you don't seem so dangerous, behave yourself, and stop scamming people!"²⁹

With gratitude, that was all the self-serving "advice" Subaru could give him.



After that, he watched the boy and girl leave in a hurry.

Ubilk: "«Stop scamming people», that's a bit harsh."

That young man who had been left on his lonesome in the street— Ubilk, smiled and scratched his cheek with his finger.

It had been a strange time, but judging from the boy's appearance at the end, he felt that he had been able to help in some way, which made him feel a tug at his heart. And then—

Ubilk: "If I don't go back to my room as soon as possible, Kafma-dono'll be very displeased with me, and if something actually happens I'll be in trouble, so I gotta go back. But still..."

Once again, gazing towards the direction the children had left, Ubilk closed one eye. And—

Ubilk: "—I dunno what the stars desire, even though that comes with the duty of a Stargazer."

²⁹ Translation note from Witch Cult Translations: "Basically, Subaru's telling Ubilk to go back to his parents' home and quit the shady stuff."



Arc 7 Chapter 50 - A “Hole” With a Great View

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 29, Chapter 5 “The Stars Aligned”, Parts 4-6

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Edited Machine Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Original by Goldkills, Translation checked by MaskedBook) — [Complete](#)

After parting ways with the shady Ubilk, they’d stopped at a couple of small alleyways.

Surveying his surroundings by looking around, Subaru would make sure that no one was around. While he was naturally also carefully checking that that Ubilk wasn’t inadvertently following them,

Subaru: “—The answer’s within me.”

Louis: “Auu.”

Louis tilted her head as Subaru reflected on what Ubilk had told them.

With Ubilk having told them that he was working as an “counselor”, a job he didn’t understand the details of, Subaru’s impression of him as a conman didn’t go away at all, but he felt like his remark was rather on point.

Subaru really didn’t know whether Ubilk could see what he himself wanted or not, but—

Subaru: “...«An abyss with a great view», I think I’ve figured it out.”

Ubilk’s words, that the answer was within Subaru, had given him a hint.

They did not mean that the missing Olbart was secretly hiding inside Subaru’s body. It was a metaphor, and Olbart’s hint was also a riddle.

The answer to the riddle “behind the eyelids” was the room they’d started in.

So, naturally, the “abyss with a great view” was a riddle as well, and the answer must be in there somewhere.

And the answer Ubilk had given, that it was within Subaru—

Subaru: “My train of thought was that it’s a place I’ve been, but it’s not.”

Louis: “Auau?”

Subaru: “There aren’t many places in this city that I’ve been to. If you leave the inn out, there’s only Yorna’s Castle. But it doesn’t feel like an abyss. It’s not that at all.”

Louis: “Uu.”

Subaru: “Something like an abyss, what’s that supposed to mean?”

Olbart had given them the hint of “abyss with a great view”, but the expressions “a great view” and “abyss” were pretty much opposites to begin with.

A great view meant that there’d be a good vantage point. An abyss was a deep hole. Something like a hole with a view just didn’t add up.

So one of them was a lie. And since there was no possible lie in it having a good view, the only lie that could’ve possibly been told was about the abyss.

Subaru: “Things that are like an abyss, but aren’t an abyss...”

There was no such place in Chaosflame to which Subaru had been.

He was sure that the same went for Abel and the others who had not left the inn— Subaru was unsure of just how much Olbart knew about the Demon City, to begin with.

But he did not believe that Olbart had been able to go around much either. Because his duty was to accompany the false Emperor— Vincent, and to protect him.

So, as it was a city he didn’t know much about, it was a place that definitely was not convoluted.

"An abyss with a great view", as it'd been called, was not a place that existed only in Chaosflame. That was—

Subaru: "—Louis, we're going to higher ground."

Louis: "Uau?"

Louis was surprised at Subaru, who spoke so after shutting his eyes.

He did not think that what he'd meant had been understood. But as long as he could confirm that Louis, holding his hand, would follow him quietly, he wouldn't ask for anything more.

There wasn't much time left. Although he was worried that it might be wrong, there was no choice but to give it a try.

Olbart's hiding place was "an abyss with a great view", and the closest place to it—

Subaru: "—We need to get to the closest place to the sky."



Ubilk's "counselling", given in a one-sided conversation, had led Subaru to his answer.

"An abyss with a great view" was, put in another way, "a hole with a great view".

An abyss was not just a hole, it was a deep hole into which one could fall forever and ever. To speak of it further, it was a hole so deep that there seemed to be no limit to its depth.

And, as Ubilk had stated, Subaru had experienced it before.

And that'd happened not too long ago, in real-time.

Subaru: "On that street, when that boy threw me."

When Subaru had run out, completely out of his mind, a sheepboy had grabbed his arm. Having been hurled away while being apologized to, Subaru'd had a thought over and over again as he rose high towards the sky, spinning around in circles.

—That he was "falling" towards the blue sky.

Of course, taking into account what had happened, that was incorrect.

From the perspective of those around him, the real Subaru had simply been thrown high into the sky. But the person in question, Subaru, who had not known at the time which way was up and which way was down, had thought so.

He had thought he was falling towards the blue sky.

Falling into an endless, blue, bottomless "hole".

Subaru: "That's what the hole with a great view is... So it's the place closest to the sky in this city."

Subaru believed that was the place Olbart had been referring to as "an abyss with a great view".

So the idea was to aim for the highest place, but—

Louis: "Aa, uh!"

Whether she was aware of how Subaru felt or not, Louis, with a broad smile, pointed to a specific place.

As Louis cheerfully waved their joined hands and pointed into the distance with her free hand, Subaru covered his face with his own.

Not because Louis was fooling around, unable to follow what he'd said.

As a matter of fact, this time around was the only one in which Louis had understood Subaru's idea. She was pointing to the building that was nearest to the sky in the city of Chaosflame.

However, that same building was the cause of Subaru's concern.

Louis: "Uh!"

Subaru: “So you’re thinking the same thing, too...”

As Louis pulled on his hand with vigor, Subaru looked up towards the building she was pointing to—the Crimson Lapis Castle.

It was the castle of Yorna Mishigure and the tallest building in the Demon City. And, for the still-shrunken Subaru, it was also a place from which he’d certainly be dismissed at the gate.

In the first place, the purpose of playing hide-and-seek with Olbart had been to answer Yorna’s request to wait for her at the Castle—the order for that had been reversed.

Subaru: “But if we keep the badness of Olbart’s character in mind, then there’s a good chance that is a stunt he’d pull.”

Olbart also knew why Subaru and the others wished to go back to how they were before.

Having to go to the Crimson Lapis Castle at least once so that he could return to his original state, was the kind of trick Olbart, known as the “Vicious Old Man”, would likely use.

The problem was—

Subaru: “How do we get into the Castle...?”

He could no longer call himself Natsumi Schwartz with his “infantilized” and shrunken appearance. If this option existed in the first place, he would have rather put off the game of hide-and-seek with Olbart.

He couldn’t tell Yorna about the situation he was in. Especially because Tanza, Yorna’s attendant, was seemingly in cahoots with Olbart.

In that case, it appeared that it would be quite dangerous to approach the Castle.

Louis: “Uau.”

Subaru: “Yeah, I know... if Tanza’s hiding the fact that she’s cooperating with Olbart-san from Yorna-san, then she’s definitely acting of her own volition.”

It seemed to Subaru that there were relatively few of Tanza’s fellow horned demi-humans around the Crimson Lapis Castle.

If there had been a fuss in the Castle’s vicinity, Yorna would find out what was going on, no matter what. That wouldn’t be something to Tanza’s liking either.

Perhaps it would be better to snitch on Tanza for her mischievousness.

Subaru: “Waitwait, that’s too hasty. There’s always the chance that Yorna-san’ll take Tanza’s side. Or rather, it’s much more likely that she will.”

In a situation with two children, one of them beloved, the other one unknown, which one would be believed was a no-brainer.

No matter how he looked at it, the plan of telling Yorna what Tanza was up to, was one that should rather not be acted on.

But Subaru had a hunch that his feeling of the amount of enemies near the Crimson Lapis Castle being small was correct.

Subaru: “Best option’s to sneak into the Castle after all... Now we just have to pray that Olbart-san’s hiding there at the top. Louis, you got a sec?”

Louis: “Aa?”

Subaru: “That, *shunkan’idou*³⁰ of yours... it allowed me to fly with you, right?”

Staring into Louis’s blue eyes, Subaru posed that question.

The first time Louis had gone on a rampage in the street, she’d used a Blink to get out from under the collapsed tent, then teleported to another location as Subaru covered her.

At that moment, he’d felt something like the contents of his stomach being churned around, which was not something he wanted to experience again and again, but needless to say, it was very convenient.

³⁰ English flip. Means “teleport(ation)” (瞬間移動), originally “ワープ” (warp).

There seemed to be a limit to how far they could fly, though.

Subaru: "With that power, we can get inside the Castle. Can you use it properly?"

Louis: "Au!"

Subaru: "You sure? If it's just «probably», we'll have problems. If you don't know how to use it properly, you and I both will be in danger. So."

Louis: "Uu..."

Louis puffed out her cheeks in frustration as Subaru continued to push her. As she did, she tightened her grip on Subaru's hand, using more force,

Louis: "Uau."

Subaru: "—Hk."

Poof, in the blink of an eye, the scenery around them changed.

Because he had been focusing on Louis in front of him, Louis's appearance did not change. However, the scenery around her quickly changed from a dimly-lit alley to a brightly-lit street, to a room in a building somewhere, then to the roof of a building, and so on.

As if to prove that she had proper control over it.

Subaru: "I-I get it! I get it, enough! That's enough!"

Louis: "Auu."

Subaru: "I lose! I give up, I lose!"

Louis let the air out of her puffy cheeks and relaxed them like she'd won. Kneeling beside her, having gone through that horrifying experience, Subaru felt a chill run down his spine.

While holding hands with Subaru, Louis had performed at least five short-distance warps in a flash. Each time, the scenery around them changed. What a ridiculous experience.

It was entirely akin to a nightmare.

Subaru: “But, this will do... Uh.”

Louis: “Uu?”

Subaru: “Ouehhhhhk!”

As he tried to clench his fists, a surge of gastric juices immediately burned his throat. While still kneeling on the spot, Subaru spewed the contents of his stomach onto the ground in a grand display.

The short-distance warp and the feeling of having his internal organs being churned about were inseparable. But—

Subaru: “T-that’s convenient. With this... Ouehk.”

Louis: “Uuah.”

Still fighting the acidic urge rising inside him, Subaru glared at the Crimson Lapis Castle.

Next to him, Louis, wrinkling her nose, withdrew her hand for the first time, and waited for Subaru to finish vomiting from a distance.



—Pointing in the direction they should fly to, he squeezed Louis’s hand.

That was the signal that Subaru had taught Louis, to sneak into the Crimson Lapis Castle.

It was like training a puppy to do tricks, but in reality, it was not that simple.

He wasn’t going to treat Louis like a dog, or a puppy, which would’ve been much cuter. At least he wouldn’t have to be scared of who she might jump on and hurt badly at any moment.

It was necessary to be very careful when dealing with her.

Subaru: “*Tomare*³¹.”

Calling out quietly and pulling on her arm, he made Louis stop in place.

Subaru put his finger to his mouth, giving her an instruction with “Shhhh”. Louis did the same, putting her finger to her mouth and mimicked an “Uu”, then shut her mouth.

After checking the scene, Subaru kept Louis behind him and gently peeked around the corner at the end of the passage— About ten meters away, there was a strong-looking gatekeeper.

The gatekeeper, sitting dignified in front of the gate with his arms crossed, was a demi-human lizardman, his face resembling that of a lizard. His whole body was covered with blue scales, making him look very tough and cool.

He didn’t seem to be taking his job as a gatekeeper very seriously, because Subaru could see from a distance that he was opening his mouth wide, letting out a yawn. But it seemed unlikely that they could avoid him and make it through the gate. So—

Subaru: “Louis.”

He called Louis’s name to draw her attention to himself. Then, in front of her, Subaru pointed his finger at the wall for her to see— the stone wall that surrounded the Crimson Lapis Castle.

And with that, he squeezed Louis’s hand tightly.

Subaru & Louis: “———”

The next moment, Subaru and Louis’s bodies had leaped over the wall of the Castle, and entered the grounds of the Castle.

It was an infiltration that skipped the process of arguing with the gatekeepers and of breaking through them by force— He felt sorry for the guards, since even his childlike mind conscience was aware of it being cheating.

³¹ English flip. Means “stop” (止まれ), originally “ストップ” (stop).

No amount of tight security or vigilance would help in the face of Louis's teleport.

Maybe surveillance cameras could thwart their attempts, but no such thing existed in this other world. In a world where security had to rely on manpower, this instant warp was a complete cheat. Although—

Subaru: "We can't afford to be seen, we've got to be very careful..."

He could make excuses for anything provided it was outside the Castle or outside its grounds, but if they were found after entering the castle grounds, he wouldn't be able to come up with something.

Louis's short-range warp was also limited to two uses in a row. If used three times or more, it would definitely make the user feel sick to the point of throwing up, or worse, passing out.

What if someone found them, and Subaru passed out while escaping?

Subaru: "No one'd be able to stop this kid."

Louis: "Uu?"

Louis tilted her head innocently and looked at Subaru as it appeared that she didn't understand his concerns.

He would not let her kill anyone else, any more— That had been Subaru's vow, after taking Louis and running away.

The shrunken, young Natsuki Subaru could not come to a proper decision about Louis. So at least, he wanted to come to the best conclusion that his current self could.

That was the only way to keep Louis from taking someone's life.

Subaru: "...We can't just grab onto the outer wall and then jump while taking breaks, can we?"

His aim was the "abyss with a great view"; even if that was the top of the Castle, reaching it by solely relying on Louis's warp and climbing up from outside could prove to be difficult.

They would probably slip and fall down at some point, and no matter how stealthy and secluded they were, if they were climbing the castle walls, someone would notice them.

Not to mention that this was Yorna Mishigure's castle.

Subaru: "It'd be the absolute worst if Yorna-san found us."

On their way here, they'd been in many fights against the pursuers who'd taken in a part of Yorna's power via the Soul Marriage Technique.

Even though Louis was a powerful fighter, yet unskilled, they would be no match for Yorna, a member of the Nine Divine Generals.

What would happen to Louis if they were to fight?

If they were forced to fight Yorna, Subaru and the others would not be able to accomplish what they had come to the city for in the first place. It would be a huge blunder. He wouldn't even be able to face Rem.

Subaru: "There's no other option but to zip through the Castle while being careful."

Based on the experience of entering the Castle once the previous day, there were very few people on patrol inside.

Even when there were visitors, they'd been left alone in the waiting room. When no one was around, the security would probably be even more full of holes. The yawn of the gatekeeper was proof of this.

Although Subaru wondered if he could be so careless in the castle of the city's ruler.

Subaru: "—It's no use complaining about it, is it? We're already in here, after all."

Louis: "Uu?"

Subaru: "Yeah, let's go... Let's pray no one's on the other side of the wall."

Since they were castle walls after all, there was no way he'd be able to hear what was on the other side, even if he put an ear to the wall. So it was completely up to luck whether or not people would spot them when passing through the castle walls for the first time.

In his experience thus far, Subaru could not say that he was lucky. And yet---

Subaru: "...I don't see anyone."

They had not incurred the misfortune of being found all of a sudden in an almost deserted castle.

Subaru: "-----"

Looking to the left and then to the right, Subaru shielded Louis behind his back and peeked into a corridor of the Crimson Lapis Castle, which Louis and Subaru had safely slipped into with her short-range warp. He had not paid it any mind the previous day, but when walking on the wooden floor, he had to be very careful of the sound of his footsteps.

Also, if they were to encounter someone in the hallway, there was hardly any place to hide on either side.

If the need arose, they would have to warp into a different room without hesitation.

Subaru: "As long as we don't use it too many times in a row, we should be fine, I think."

He himself was unaware of what backlash Louis would bear, but if Subaru were to do one teleport at a time, with some space in between, he could probably tolerate it without throwing up.

In some cases, they should consider using the teleport, not just left and right, but upwards as well--- No, perhaps they should rather actively try to go upwards.

Subaru: "Would that result in less time wandering around here, as opposed to looking carefully for stairs? But if we go up too leisurely, we might be found by someone."

Of course, if Yorna lived in the Crimson Lapis Castle, she would always be present. And since she presided as the Lord of the Castle, the room in which she resided would be at the top.

Going to the top of the Castle meant getting closer to Yorna.

Subaru didn’t really get it, but there were people in the world who were experts in sensing the presence of others.

Even with Louis’s teleport, no matter how much he tried to suppress his breathing and footsteps, there were still some things he could not eliminate. How much of a disadvantage it was going to be, would be the coming challenge.

Subaru: “Anyway, we’re going to be as careful as we can. If we’re found—”

???: “—If you’re found, then what?”

That very moment, Subaru’s shoulders hitched in fright due to the bone-chilling voice coming from behind him.

The shock was also felt by the one holding his hand, Louis, her eyes widening in surprise. Subaru and Louis turned around with a snap. And there, was—

???: “It’s so cute to see children holding hands with each other. I can’t help but feel like my cheeks will form a smile against my will.”

The one person they should not have run into, the beautiful Yorna Mishigure, was standing there.



Subaru: “—Ah.”

No one was supposed to be there.

Up until a moment ago, there had been no one in the hallway aside from Subaru and Louis.

Yorna had appeared out of nowhere, even though she had not been there until just a bit ago.

This woman was the sort of being that held the kind of power that ridiculed the caution and care of ordinary people like Subaru, kicking all sorts of thorough preparations to the curb.

—One of this other world’s transcendent beings.

Yorna: "Either of your faces are unfamiliar to me."

Yorna looked down at Subaru and Louis's faces, and muttered so, the smoke rising from the *kiseru* in her hand.

She was dressed in the same glamorous *kimono* she'd worn at the top of the Castle the previous day. However, having only seen her sitting most of the time, he felt overwhelmed upon being faced with her standing in front of him.

Yorna was taller than him, partly because Subaru had been shrunk. Though she wasn't quite as tall as Medium, thanks to her tall-soled footwear, her line of sight was probably above that of Abel's

As he stared into her blue gaze at that height, his throat froze over.

Yorna: "There's no need to be so frightened. What brings you two to my castle?"

Subaru: "Uh..."

The tone of her voice was soft and flat, and the one being asked cursed himself for his stupidity.

Even though Subaru believed he'd snuck in with plenty of caution, he hadn't prepared a single excuse in case he was discovered. Short-sighted, that was exactly what he had been.

As expected, Subaru stammered, unable to say anything, and Yorna narrowed her almond-shaped eyes. He'd look suspicious if he went on without saying anything, his heart pumping so hard it was about to explode—

Yorna: "Are you perhaps here for Tanza?"

Subaru: "Huh...?"

Yorna: "The reason that brings you to the Castle."

Subaru's frozen throat made a cracking sound as she pointed that out.

It was completely unexpected that she'd be able to see through him to such a degree in the few seconds he had spent unable to say anything. At the same time, Subaru realized that his true identity had been discerned.

In only a single glance, the long journey to the Demon City and everything else had been for nothing. He thought he heard Abel's voice coldly dismissing him as a “fool”, inside his head.

Subaru's reckless endeavor ended here, with the illusion that his feet had lost their footing, and that he was plummeting headlong into the depths of regret—

Louis: “Uau.”

The feeling of his hand being squeezed tight stopped his consciousness from falling into complete darkness.

Without thinking, Subaru looked next to him and saw Louis standing beside him, looking at his face. Louis's blue eyes, trembling slightly were conveying that they— that Subaru's instructions had been that she could fly at any time.

The intense look in Louis's eyes was enough to restore Subaru's unsteady spirit.

Once he looked up, he saw that Yorna was quietly waiting for an answer to her question, not even trying to rush Subaru— It might still be too early to give up.

Yorna had asked if Tanza was the reason for Subaru and Louis's presence in the Castle.

That fit. But only half. To make up the other half, he would have to take a gamble.

Subaru: “Um, Yorna-san... Yorna-sama.”

Yorna: “What is it?”

Subaru: “Where's Tanza-chan?”

Yorna narrowed her eyes at Subaru's question, who had now found his resolve.

For a moment that lasted for less than a few seconds, Subaru experienced a state of mind like that of a rat caught by a fox. Most likely, the actual difference in power between him and his opponent was bigger than that of a rat and a fox.

Faced with such an opponent, the few seconds that went by seemed like an eternity. Before the silent Subaru and Louis, Yorna put her *kiseru* to her mouth and exhaled purple smoke from her lungs, then,

Yorna: "I'm sorry, but Tanza's out on an errand. It should be time for her to return soon..."

Subaru: "-----"

With Yorna's answer, Subaru squeezed Louis's hand slightly tighter. This caused Louis to look at Subaru, her eyes wandering to see if he was pointing anywhere.

He felt sorry for Louis's response, as that was not supposed to be her cue to fly. It was just that, the moment Subaru realized he'd won the gamble, he strengthened his grip.

He'd won the gamble, yes, he'd won.

Yorna's previous question was a sign that she hadn't seen through the true nature of Subaru and Louis's goal. Naturally, their true identity had also not been exposed.

It was a much simpler, gentler question.

In fact, after that answer of hers to Subaru, Yorna closed one eye and said, "Really",

Yorna: "I'm also worried about Tanza. Although devoting herself to me is fine, forgetting one's promise to friends isn't a good thing for a subordinate."

Subaru: "F-friends..."

Yorna: "She's a loyal child, isn't she? I've always told her that she can't always focus on me."

Remarking that, Yorna shrugged after giving a comment on Tanza's attitude.

Due to Yorna's words and gestures, Subaru raised his eyebrow in surprise.

The previous day, she was the malicious and unfathomable Empress of the Demon City that had shown herself atop the Castle.

That impression had done a one-eighty, because Yorna's current attitude felt like something completely different. That attitude was one that was more familiar and easier to understand, the feeling of an adult who cared for children.

As if to support this impression, Yorna let out a small exhale followed by a "Hmm",

Yorna: "Tanza does have some carelessness, but I can't wait for her to return— Let's wait for Tanza's return in my room."

With that, Yorna turned her back to them, and walked away slowly.

Despite the thick soles of her shoes, her graceful walk remained silent on the wooden floor, making him not believe his eyes at how sophisticated she was down to her toes.

Then, with Subaru fascinated by the mere sight of her walking, Yorna suddenly came to a stop in front of him,

Yorna: "Come along now. I'll show you the way."

Subaru: "Ueh...!? Yorna-sama will!?"

Louis: "Au?"

Yorna's unexpected kindness stunned Subaru. Louis tilted her head in surprise at Subaru's surprise, and Yorna, watching the two of them, gently put her hand over her mouth and smiled.

Not a mean one however, just a gentle smile.

Yorna: "This is my castle. Of course, it's my duty to entertain guests. And now that Tanza is out, there's no one to keep the two of you company."

Subaru: "Ah, umm..."

Yorna: "It's also the first time a friend of that child has come here. Now, come along with me."

Jerking her chin, Yorna commanded them to follow along. Following her gesture with his eyes, Subaru wondered for a second what he should do.

He suspected that this could be a trap, but quickly dropped the idea.

Because Yorna had no reason to lure Subaru and Louis into a trap. If she wanted to, she could subdue Subaru with a single finger and take out Louis with a couple.

In that case however, it meant that she really had volunteered to be their guide out of the goodness of her heart. That would be completely different from the impression Subaru had of the Yorna from yesterday, though—

Louis: "Uau."

As Subaru let the contents of his head whirl around and around, Louis tugged on his hand. Apparently, Louis had no objection to following Yorna.

Louis's reaction was the final push to get Subaru's feet moving.

Louis's ability to perceive danger was probably better than Subaru's. If Louis wasn't wary of Yorna, he didn't have to worry about her doing something to him anytime soon.

Yorna: "Children?"

Subaru: "C-coming!"

In response to Yorna's reiterated call to Subaru, he responded with a faltering voice and started walking. Yorna's eyes narrowed as she resumed her steps, keeping up with Subaru's short strides.

He wasn't sure if he should take this as good luck or not, but it was much better than being interrogated by her.

Yorna: "You children aren't from here, are you?"

Subaru: "Eh..."

Yorna: "Faces I haven't seen. You haven't received my «love letter», either."

Unfamiliar faces, faces she hadn't seen before, were the words she spoke. The expression "love letter" that followed was something Subaru had no idea about, so he nodded his head with a "Y-yes",

Subaru: "From out of town... with a scary grown-up, that is."

Yorna: "Scary grown-up... That sounds like a lot of trouble. Why are you with Scary Grown-Up-san?"

Subaru: "I-it's because..."

Subaru answered Yorna's question carefully, but with a certain amount of truthfulness.

In reality, the fact that he was working with the scary grown-up— with Abel, was very much a matter of chance. Perhaps it should be in the past tense, as in, "we had been working together".

It was hard to imagine that Abel would readily forgive Subaru for running away with Louis. To begin with—

Subaru: "I don't know if I should be forgiven..."

He didn't believe it was fair to blame him for not being able to decide on how to handle Louis.

Sure, he was sorry that that he had hidden Louis's true identity from them. But if this was the result of revealing the truth, then he'd been right to conceal it.

If there was anything to apologize for, it was that he'd been unable to hide it until the very end, and revealing it halfway through.

Yorna: "—Looks like you've got some complex feelings about it."

Then, Yorna suddenly slowed down and glanced back at him, tapping her finger on her brow. There was nothing wrong with the skin which the white finger was touching. She indicated not her own, but Subaru's brow.

There were probably wrinkles carved deeply into it, made by unanswerable thoughts.

Yorna: "A child shouldn't make such a gloomy face— I'll spank that scary grown-up for you."

Subaru: "Spank... Huh, Yorna-sama will?"

Yorna: “Fufu, I’m quite powerful, despite my looks.”

Yorna raised her sleeves and made them flutter about gently; at her words, Subaru had a vision of Abel being spanked and immediately shook his head sideways.³²

There was a gap in Subaru’s usual impression of Yorna, in that he felt that Yorna’s punishment wouldn’t be as cute as it sounded. Which came as a particularly big surprise.

Subaru: “I’m glad you’re worried about me, but I’m fine! I mean, he’s probably someone who’d see reason once you talked with him...”

Yorna: “Is that so? If he’s someone who’d see reason with just words, it’d be the best. But there are many people in this world who have trouble finding reason in talks, you know.”

Subaru: “—Yorna-sama.”

Yorna: “Yes?”

He wondered on whether to say anything or not for a moment, cutting his words off. Because of this, Yorna stopped in her tracks.

A mixture of things went through his head. Feeling bad for stopping her so many times, worry that Yorna would get angry if he told her what he wanted to say, his own thoughtlessness for blurting out what he did even though he knew it was a mistake.

Because he was smaller now, he felt that his ability to think and judge things were really decreasing.

However, the biggest problem seemed to be this impatience or lack of restraint, both in bringing Louis along and in sneaking into the Crimson Lapis Castle unprepared.

Although he’d hesitated to say this in that impulsive moment—

Subaru: “Well, Yorna-sama, you really are listening to what we say. It’s just that, I was sure that people of high status were scary...”

³² Translation note from Witch Cult Translations: “The word used here, «仕置» is particularly used in the context of «punishing a child». So we took some, ahem, liberties.”

Yorna: "Hmmm."

Realizing that he'd said something very rude, Subaru was unable to look Yorna in the eye while speaking. But upon hearing what Subaru'd said, Yorna giggled a teeny bit,

Yorna: "From the looks of it, you're not demi-humans either."

Subaru: "Ummm, yeah, that's right."

Yorna: "What does this city look like, from your point of view?"

Subaru: "This place..."

In response to that abrupt question, Subaru turned his gaze to a window in the corridor. The window high up on the wall was too tiny for Subaru to take a look outside through it, given his current height.

But he could tell there was a dim blue sky close-by.

Subaru: "It's amazing, it's such a busy city. There are so many sorts of people."

Choosing his words carefully, Subaru expressed his impressions as honestly as possible.

The impression of a busy city had been there from the very beginning. The appearance of the city as a mishmash of things piled up, as well as the variety of people living in it, all gave this impression.

To his eyes and ears, it gave him a strong impression of a hectic city.

Yorna: "You're a very honest child. It's pleasant to hear you say that."

Having heard Subaru's thoughts, Yorna's lips formed into a faint smile.

She then directed her gaze at the same window that Subaru was looking at— likely gazing at the outside view in a different way.

Yorna: "This city's full of people who have a hard time living in other places. Those that became insignificant outside the city, children with nowhere else to go... children that would go unnoticed, even if they raised their voices."

Subaru: "Even, if they raised their voices..."

Yorna: "If we don't lend an ear to the children who've reached the last place they can go to, then who will?"

As she spoke so with the *kiseru* in her mouth, an elegant glow flashed in Yorna's eyes.

Experiencing a sensation akin to his heart being stabbed, Subaru felt terribly ashamed of himself—
Now, after hearing Yorna's words, he found that his impression of her had changed drastically.

Tanza: "She is a loving woman. Loves her allies and hates her enemies— Lover of all things that reside in the Demon City."

That was what the little deergirl Tanza had said when he asked her about Yorna the previous day.

Subaru'd had no clue whatsoever as to what that meant at the time. Once Abel had told them about the Soul Marriage Technique, he'd wondered if the girl had meant its power.

But perhaps that wasn't what Tanza had meant, it was truly as she had said.

—It was, the answer to what Yorna Mishigure cherished from her heart.

Subaru: "I'm so sorry, Yorna-san..."

As soon as Subaru thought of this, Subaru couldn't hold back again and apologized.

Hearing Subaru suddenly apologize, Yorna smiled, exhaling purple smoke,

Yorna: "There's nothing to be sorry for. The reason why people in high positions always look scary is that if they didn't, they'd be scared too. There's also the logic, that people of high status wish to be feared."

Subaru: "People of high status, wish to be feared..."

What was that? He felt that he'd just been told something he would do well to remember.

And it seemed to be a way of thinking that maybe Yorna was no stranger to.

Yorna: “Don’t worry, I’m not one to do something as disgraceful as to get angry with a child over something like this. By a stroke of luck, I’m in a good mood.”

Louis: “Au?”

Yorna: “Yes, that’s right— There are signs that I might be about to get what I’ve wanted for a long time.”

Lowering the corners of her eyes, Yorna fluttered her sleeves around once more.

There was no trace of anger in her answer. As she had said herself, it was probably because she wasn’t the kind of person who dealt with children in a mature way, and more so because she was in a really good mood.

Perhaps the reason behind her good mood were the contents of the letter Abel had sent her—

Subaru: “———”

With that in mind, Subaru held back this time and thought carefully.

Yorna’s positive attitude toward the missive, and whether she kept her word or not, depended on whether Abel, Subaru, and the others could safely join her at the Crimson Lapis Castle.

But it was Tanza, Yorna’s attendant, who was interfering with Subaru and the others’ efforts.

From their earlier exchange, it was clear to him that Yorna really cared about Tanza.

If her own desires clashed with Tanza’s, which ones would Yorna choose? —Yorna, who had in the past defied the Emperor for the sake of someone else.

Once Yorna found out the truth about the situation, what would she do?

Yorna: “—You’re wrinkling your brow again, aren’t you?”

With a tap, Yorna put her finger between her eyebrows and pointed out Subaru’s distress. Following Yorna’s gesture, Louis also tapped her forehead.

Looking at Yorna and Louis’s appearances, Subaru let out a small sigh.

Maybe this too was a hasty idea.

But since he did not have the brains to think properly about whether it was the right or wrong thing to do—

Subaru: “Hey, Yorna-san, I need to ask something...”



—Over the roof tiles of the castle tower of the Crimson Lapis Castle, where red and blue brilliance mixed together, he laid his buttocks.

And so, while basking in the clear wind characteristic of this high altitude, he placed the gourd he kept in his breast pocket to his mouth. While quenching his thirst with alcohol, he rested his chin on his hand while the spectacle under his eyes unfolded.

???: “Kakakakka, what a superb view.”

Looking down at the unorganized streets of the city with various styles intermingling, an aged body’s throat rang.

His hoarse laugh was disturbed by the wind, disappearing into nothingness without reaching anyone. It was engulfed by the tumult of the Demon City, vanishing gradually every time the monstrous old man was amused.

He was fond of that which was chaotic.

The chaotic townscape, the melting pot of various races of demi-human, the motifs drifting to the left and right.

Even if something only meant that something else would fall into chaos, it would make him want to support it.

???: “It’s a bad habit of ol’ people ta scramble and eat whatever they can get their hands on. Anyhow—”

After taking a large gulp from his gourd, the old man wiped the alcohol spilling from the corner of his mouth with his sleeves and shrugged his shoulders. And so, still sitting cross-legged, he rotated his hips and turned around, raising an eyebrow.

It was a sight that would make an old man fond of chaos drool—

???: “Even if they reached where I’m at, they’re a way too unpredictable bunch, truly.”

In front of the monstrous old man who thus spoke, three figures were stepping atop the tiles of the roof of the castle tower.

???: “Found yooou~, Olbart-san!”

The one who was pointing at Olbart, was a young boy holding the hand of a young girl with blonde hair.

And standing behind them like a guardian was the Empress, the ruler of the Demon City.



Illustration from Volume 29, coloring by Norvak ([source](#))

Arc 7 Chapter 51 - The Demon City's Mistress

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 29, Chapter 6 “Love Cannot Be Bequeathed”, Parts 1-2

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Edited Machine Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Original by Goldkills, Kiln, Translation checked by PaperKaminari, [Ice/Ice_Occultism](#)) — [Complete](#)

A placid breeze bathed in light gently caressed Subaru's bangs.

While savoring the ticklish feeling, Subaru felt the touch of a girl's hand linked with his, and the breath of the tall, beautiful woman standing to his back.

The location they were in was the top of the Crimson Lapis Castle, above the large room on the top floor. He stepped onto the roof tiles of the Castle, the “place closest to the sky”, from which he could now view Chaosflame.

Subaru had led them to the place closest to an “abyss with a great view”.

Subaru: “Olbart-san, I think you're a real jerk.”

The hand not linked with Louis's beside him, the one that Subaru was pointing with, was being directed at a small old man sitting on the edge of the castle's roof.

Sitting cross-legged, spinning around on his rear, the monstrous old man— Olbart, put his mouth to the gourd in his hand, gulping down the alcohol within. And—

Olbart: “No way, boy. You're not hungry, are ya?”

Subaru: “...H-hungry?”

Olbart: “Yeah, that's right, ya hungry? After all, ya just woke up and had no time ta eat, did'cha? Yer hunger's got a lot ta do with both yer brain and yer body's functionin', ya know.”

While saying that and setting down his gourd, Olbart pulled out another package from his pocket. Before a slightly alarmed Subaru, Olbart gave a small “kakaka”, and unwrapped the package.

Wrapped in the package was a black, round object the size of a golf ball.

Subaru: “That’s...”

Olbart: “It’s called a ration ball³³, it’s portable food for us *shinobi*. One of these’ll last’cha a day and keep yer head and body in shape. Tastes awful, tho’.”

Plucking a ration ball from its wrapper with his fingers, Olbart waved it about as to show it off.

From the way it looked, it felt like it was emergency food made without taste in mind. It might be nutritious, but Subaru didn’t think he’d want to eat it.

Olbart rolled it around in his palm, and said,

Olbart: “I’ve been a *shinobi* since I was young, so naturally, I’ve been familiar with this since I was a wee lad. And every time I ate it while workin’, I thought ta myself, «Like the great ol’ men of my village, I wish I could just retire and not eat this stuff anymore».”

Subaru: “...Then, why not do just that? Olbart-san, you said you’re the head honcho of the *shinobi* village, aren’t you a big shot?”

Olbart: “Oh, you’re right. What I’m sayin’ is that, right now, I’m better and stronger than the ol’ men who used ta work me to death all willy-nilly... But somehow, I’m still eatin’ this stuff.”

With that, Olbart threw the ration ball that he’d been rolling in his palm into his mouth. He chewed and gulped down on his provisions, which the monstrous old man had described as not good.

After that, he opened his mouth to show that he’d eaten it all. Then,

³³ Translation note from Witch Cult Translations: “Ration balls, or «hyorogan» (兵糧丸), are portable preserved food said to have been eaten by *ninjas* from the Sengoku Period to the Edo Period in Japan.”

Olbart: "After all, ya can't break a habit, that's what I'm sayin'. This mess of food I put together without regard ta taste or appearance's the best food for me. Doesn't hearin' this make ya cry? No? Kakakakka!"

Olbart showed a toothy grin, causing Subaru to remember something eerie.

Unsure of what he was trying to tell him with the current conversation, Subaru thought this seemed to be something unrelated to his childish youth. However, it seemed it shouldn't be ignored in its entirety.

He felt that maybe it was Olbart's way of praising or complimenting him.

Yorna: "—Old Man Olbart, this is my castle, do you recall?"

After the conversation died down, Yorna Mishigure, the Empress of the Demon City, having come to the roof of the castle along with Subaru and Louis, spoke up at last.

Staring into Yorna's blue eyes, Olbart stopped laughing and said, "Yeah",

Olbart: "Of course, I know that. To be looked down on by the Lord of the Castle while sittin' on her castle's a nice feelin'. Doin' what'cha love's the secret to a long life."

Yorna: "That's quite the indulgent hobby for a man of your stature. I would've never thought you'd do something like this."

Olbart: "Ho, how's that so?"

Yorna: "It's only natural, isn't it? —It'd be insane to know this secret of longevity and still shorten your own lifespan."

Subaru could feel the heat from Yorna, who smiled seductively while putting her sleeve gently over her mouth. Yorna's anger was contained in her gentle gesture, and of course it was Olbart who it was directed to.

Olbart must have noticed Yorna's anger, but the monstrous old man remained seated on his haunches, throwing the next ration ball into his mouth from the package open on his lap.

Olbart: "So, why are ya three gettin' along again? A foxgirl and two lil' kids aren't friends in any way."

Yorna: "Unfortunately, unlike the Vicious Old Man Olbart here, I have no taste for teasing children and no reason to torture them. When it comes to children, it's only natural that I'd treat them with courtesy. What's more——"

Cutting off her words there, Yorna twirled the golden *kiseru* around her finger. Then pointing the tip of the *kiseru*, the part from which smoke trailed, at Olbart, she continued.

Yorna: "If I hear that Old Man Olbart has misled these children and deceived my attendant... as the mistress of this city, I'll do what I must."

Olbart: "Hoho, ho."

Gently stroking his chin, Olbart's amused eyes turned to Subaru and Louis.

Subaru nodded deeply, sensing the intent of his gaze.

Subaru: "I'm sorry, but I had to tell on you. It's not really a foul under Olbart-san's *kimari*. You had us get attacked too anyway."

Olbart: "Kakakakka! You're never at a loss for words, boy. But that's the right answer. I'm the one who sicced 'em on ya, so ta whine 'bout it if it's done ta me'd be pretty pathetic. But..."

Subaru: "But?"

Olbart: "Good work comin' up with that when yer mind's gotta be havin' trouble keepin' up as well. Are ya mayhaps from the Vollachian Imperial Family? You're a match for 'em in underhandedness."

Subaru: "Don't say such scary things..."

Considering only the hair color of Subaru and the current Emperor, Abel, they had a lot in common, but there were too many differences in other areas. Their facial structure and the length of their legs were proof of this.

In the first place, to say that his personality was as bad as that of those of the Vollachian Imperial Family would be slander. For example——

Subaru: "I always say thank you when someone does something nice for me."

Yorna: "And with a smile and a loud voice too. That's what a child should be like. I'm going to tell Tanza to follow your example. Anyway—"

Parting her lips, Yorna gave her evaluation of Subaru's naughtiness, then lowered the tone of her voice. After that her eyes narrowed, and the harmonious atmosphere came to an end. Because—

Yorna: "I can't rebuke my faithful servant without her being here to respond to me. Now, where did you hide her, Old Man Olbart?"

Yorna's question was the main reason why she'd come along.

Olbart: "——"

Feeling Yorna's tense pressure and its aftershocks directed at Olbart, Subaru firmly bit his lip and checked the sound of his own beating heart.

—Yorna had found Subaru downstairs, just inside the castle, and after getting to know Yorna's personality, which he did not the previous day, Subaru had taken another big gamble.

He told Yorna as much as he could about their situation and the "hide-and-seek" game that was happening here in Chaosflame.

Of course, Subaru did not mention Abel's true identity, and he didn't tell anyone that he and the others had been "infantilized" by Olbart. What was important was that Subaru and his friends were playing "hide-and-seek" with Olbart, and that Tanza was helping the latter.

In order to appeal to her as sincerely as possible and clear up her suspicions as she listened patiently, Subaru had decided to prepare himself to face the situation with all his might, and confided in Yorna about the situation.

And after hearing Subaru's appeal, Yorna thought it over for a while—

Yorna: "*—I'm not a woman who can determine whether the words of a desperate child are true or false.*"

Giving that answer, she then accompanied Subaru and Louis to the top of the Crimson Lapis Castle.

Subaru: "Honestly, I didn't think she was someone I could talk to so much, but..."

Louis: "Auau."

Subaru: "Yeah, I know."

Hearing Subaru's murmur, Louis shook the hand she was holding and pursed her lips.

In response, Subaru told himself that this was a stroke of luck that had come about from a bunch of coincidences turning up. If any of those factors were missing, this situation couldn't have been created.

That he had separated from Abel and his sinister designs.

That he had reached the Crimson Lapis Castle with the help of Ubilk's "counsel".

That he had been found by Yorna personally rather than by a guard.

That he had been together with Louis, not Al nor Medium.

And finally, that Subaru, the one most affected by the "infantilization", had taken a gamble.

The main reason why Yorna had listened to Subaru's words was because she'd seen no lie in them, and took them as a serious appeal from a child.

Just as there were grown-ups who wouldn't take children's words seriously and laughed them away.

Other adults would take them seriously because those words came from children, and because of that they would try to meet their expectations.

Subaru had not expected one of the Nine Divine Generals of the bloodthirsty Vollachian Empire to be one of the latter.

Subaru: "Who was it again that said Yorna-san's crazy..."

Perhaps an argument would be that she was treated that way because she didn't approve of Vollachia's mantra of "survival of the fittest".

At the very least, Subaru had no choice aside from thinking she did not, after being treated so nicely.

Yorna: "Old Man Olbart, I have two requests for you."

As she said this, Yorna gently held up two fingers.

Subaru couldn't say anything to step into the conversation between the transcendental beings that disregarded him. All he could do was to be aware of the touch of Louis's hand so that he could move if something happened.

The only way to escape from the rooftop area would be to teleport downstairs.

Olbart: "Those demands of yers, let's hear 'em for the time bein'."

Yorna: "First, you must return Tanza to me."

Olbart: "Oh, com'on, that's a bit unreasonable. I'm sure that girl's got her own ideas. If she didn't, she wouldn't've planned somethin' without tellin' ya, Your Highness."

Yorna: "—Silence."

Olbart admitted that he had an idea where Tanza was somewhere in the middle there, but his mocking voice was cut short by a single, sharp word from Yorna.

The serene power of that word was enough to change the atmosphere.

In fact, even Subaru, who wasn't the one the word was directed at, held his breath.

So Yorna, having silenced Olbart's chatter, brought the *kiseru* she was toying with in her hand to her mouth and slowly filled her lungs with purple smoke.

Yorna: "Unfortunately, I've got no intention of hearing Tanza's complaints or thoughts from anyone other than from her own mouth. And I don't think I'd be able to bear to hear it after I've traced them to the tongue of the Vicious Old Man."

Olbart: “Kakaka, seems no one likes me here.”

Yorna: “I’m sure down inside you know quite well why would that be, don’t you?”

Yorna smiled aggressively and tilted her head, her hair ornaments swaying noisily. Even the *kanzashi*³⁴ stuck in her luxuriously-tied hair and her adorned beauty seemed to Subaru to be Yorna’s weapons.

—People of high status wished to be feared.

Yorna had been the one to tell Subaru about this idea. Maybe it was not only about scaring people, but also about making them feel her beauty.

Yorna: “One more thing, the game you’re playing with these children, you must stop it.”

Olbart: “A game, huh? It’s a game, but a serious one.”

Yorna: “As I said yesterday in the presence of His Excellency the Emperor— I’d like the messengers to be left alone and, regardless of what His Excellency might do or say, they’ll be protected by me.”

—She would not let anyone touch Subaru’s group.

Unexpectedly, Yorna’s decision had been conveyed by Tanza’s own mouth. And as Yorna herself intended to abide by that decision, she was angered that her wish had been broken. In conclusion—

Yorna: “Within this Demon City, you wish to make an enemy of me?”

Olbart: “Ohh, scary, scary. You’re a scary lass... Oh, in a way, I didn’t interfere with anyone, let’s say that’s my excuse.”

Yorna: “That is *your* interpretation, isn’t it, Old Man Olbart? —Whose town do you believe this is, anyway? Do you think I’m a woman so open-minded that I’d laugh and pardon it?”

Subaru felt the air boiling, his entire body covered in goosebumps.

³⁴ Translation note from Witch Cult Translations: “Kanzashi (簪) are hair ornaments used in some traditional Japanese hairstyles, referring to a wide variety of accessories such as rigid hairpins.”

He got that Yorna was getting worked up as she reached the second half of her words. Of course, Yorna was not one to lack the self-discipline as to show that in her tone of voice and facial expressions.

But he understood. Because Subaru had seen many really angry people.

When people were truly angry, with their lives on the line, their emotions would flare. And that much would be visible by just being by their side. There was very, very raw anger there.

Louis: “Uu...”

Feeling similar to Subaru, Louis gave a small growl due to the alarming atmosphere spreading.

On their way here, Louis might have proactively attacked the people who were chasing them, but the two people here were Yorna and Olbart— people who were entirely different in strength from their pursuers.

It was an animal instinct, she probably knew that she couldn't win if she fought. Maybe she was worried about Subaru getting involved in the fight—

Subaru: “—Hk, Olbart-san!”

For a moment, Subaru felt his thoughts about Louis begin to soften, but he shook them off. With that momentum spurring him on, he called out Olbart's name as he and Yorna continued their stand-off.

Olbart, still sitting on the roof, deftly kept one eye focused on Yorna and the other on Subaru.

Subaru: “H-how are you doing that...?”

Olbart: “Kakakakka! Body control's the foundation of the *shinobi*. Ya can't be a *shinobi* unless ya can do different things with yer right hand and left hand, and yer right foot and left foot. What of it?”

Subaru: “Huh?”

Olbart: “Ya called me just now. I'm tellin' ya, I'm in the middle of the riskiest situation of my life. Ya shouldn't be sparin' attention to that.”

It seemed that, even though he hadn't changed his laidback attitude, Olbart was perfectly aware that this was a critical juncture. If that was really the case, then Subaru was grateful that he'd spare him the attention.

Subaru placed a hand on his chest, took a few deep breaths, and said,

Subaru: "Oh, why don't we call it even?"

Olbart: "...Mhm?"

Olbart, upon hearing Subaru's suggestion, opened his left eye wide. Drawing the attention of a single eyeball, Subaru raised his voice in frustration, "Like I said!",

Subaru: "We're even, we're even! Olbart-san, you tried to do something against the rules, and I told Yorna-san. Both are just as bad as each other, that's why we should..."

Olbart: "Quietly admit we're both at fault and leave it at, that's what ya wanna say?"

Subaru: "Oh yeah, yesyes! See, not bad, huh? We'll give Olbart-san what he wants, and that'll solve our problems!"

What Olbart desired was a secret of the Emperor, which was in Abel's possession.

Subaru didn't know the specifics, but if he could hand it over, it would make it easier to have Olbart withdraw. Originally, the "hide-and-seek" game was something like a test of wits, to see if the information could be believed.

Subaru: "We agreed on doing it three times, and we've only found you twice so far... Take it easy on us, though, we managed to get up to the top of the Castle."

Olbart: "Hmmm... By the way, you're the one who figured out this was my hidin' place? Not that other one, the oni-masked young'un?"

Subaru: "Y-Yeah, that's right. An idea about the «abyss with a great view» happened to come up in my mind... There was another spot I was thinking of too, though."

Perhaps Abel and the others were on their way there.

Even if they weren't right now, sooner or later, Abel's group would get to the answer and come to the Crimson Lapis Castle. Subaru had cheated with Louis's teleport skill and Ubilk's "counsel".

However, it might be easier to persuade Abel and the others about how to deal with Louis if they pulled off this achievement here. If it proved itself to be difficult, they could try to get Yorna on their side.

How Yorna would react once she found out about Louis's true identity was unknown, though.

Subaru: "Anyway! I wonder, Olbart-san. If you'd be willing to listen to my... No, to our suggestion."

Shaking his head and pushing away any negative thoughts, Subaru looked at Olbart.

The reason why Subaru had used "our", plural, was because he needed Yorna's cooperation in this proposal of reconciliation. If Yorna said she wouldn't forgive Olbart for luring Tanza into a devious scheme, Subaru's proposal, thought up with utmost effort, would be in vain. However—

Yorna: "——"

With one eye closed and the *kiseru* in her mouth, Yorna did not object to anything. Subaru thought the fact she hadn't opposed it meant that she respected his opinion.

Subaru was extremely, extremely grateful. He wanted to thank her so much.

He wished to not waste the trust and kindness that Yorna had entrusted to him.

Subaru: "Olbart-san."

Once again, Subaru called out Olbart's name, hoping for a compromise.

In response to Subaru's hopeful black eyes, Olbart picked up the gourd he'd settled down, using his fingers. Putting his mouth to the gourd, he slurped down every last drop of the alcohol therein,

Olbart: "Ya know, boy. I dunno if that's somethin' only the current you could come up with, or if it's somethin' even the past you would've come up with..."

Subaru: "——"

Olbart: “—I don’t like the idea of throwin’ away a game I’ve started halfway— This geezer’s a stubborn man, ya know?”

The monstrous old man laughed, and with that, he crushed the gourd in his hand, shattering it to pieces that fell onto the floor.

With a peal the debris danced, causing Subaru to gasp. Immediately afterwards—

Yorna: “An old man who won’t take the hand offered by a child, will mourn his own stubbornness.”

Yorna’s long legs swung down as she rushed forth, and with a roar, the tower of the Crimson Lapis Castle split in two.



Her foot, wearing a thick-soled *geta*³⁵, was raised up high, then slammed straight down at tremendous speed.

A moment later, the castle tower, being hit directly by her heel, bent, cracked, shattered and, after a beat, burst open with a thunderous roar as if it had exploded.

As the blown-off roof tiles flew up in the air and a thick cloud of smoke rose, Yorna, having dished out that immense strike, turned around at the epicenter of the explosion, the hem of her *kimono* waving gallantly.

In a single breath, Yorna had performed a jump and an axe kick in sequence, the consequence of their immense calamitous force being the partial destruction of the castle.

A single strike by Yorna’s heel had literally caused the keep to collapse, ruining the beautiful scenery of the Crimson Lapis Castle.

Subaru: “Whoaaaa—!?”

³⁵ Translation note from Witch Cult Translations: “*Geta* are traditional Japanese sandals that resemble flip-flops, which consist of a wooden platform raised by two or three «teeth». For more information, see [here](#).”

Seeing that sublime destructive power, Subaru crouched down with his head in his hands.

He'd not been caught in the destruction of the exploding castle by the skin of his teeth, but the incredible tremors nearly sent him tumbling off the roof.

However, Louis held him by the arm, stopping that from happening.

Louis: "Uau!"

Subaru: "Shit! Why's this happening...!"

He was pulled up by the tight grip on his arm, as he sat up, Subaru screamed with tears in his eyes.

The dancing cloud of dust had gone into his eyes, and because of that he had teary-eyes. Definitely not because that blockhead Olbart had rejected his proposal.

That also, was also rough obviously—

Subaru: "Yorna-san!!"

Yorna: "Stay back, don't get swallowed up in this. I'm not very good at holding back, I'm afraid—
Nevertheless."

Yorna, without looking back, responded to Subaru's call from behind her.

Cutting off her words there, Yorna pulled her stuck foot off the roof, brushed the dirt from the hem of her *kimono*, and looked up high—

Yorna: "As expected, he's a nimble one."

Directly above Yorna, flying in a whirling motion, blending in with the billowing smoke and debris, was a small shadow— Olbart's figure.

Basking in Yorna's gaze, Olbart let out a "Ha!" with a toothy grin, and said,

Olbart: "Thought we were supposed ta leave each other alone... So, anythin' goes now, right?"

Yorna: "I'm surprised you believe you can beat me in this city. If you've gone senile, then I recommend you relinquish your seat in the Nine Divine Generals to the younger generation."

Olbart: "Kakakakka! Nah, no can do. I'm gonna be the longest livin' member of the Nine Divine Generals."

One of them in midair and the other atop the roof, their lines of sight intersected, the pair exchanging their intentions to attack, and prepared themselves to go against each other.

Yorna put the *kiseru* to her mouth, and Olbart flipped around in midair— she exhaled a plume of purple smoke, into which Olbart kicked the sky and dove with the speed of an arrow.

Olbart: "—Hk!"

His eyes blazing, Olbart's sidekick collided head-on with the purple smoke Yorna had spread before her.

The smoke from the *kiseru*, which should be both weightless and not solid, received Olbart's foot and scattered the impact with a motion as if it was bending.

Seeing this, Olbart's smile grew,

Olbart: "Ooshya—!!"

His short legs spun at high speed, and ten, twenty kicks were unleashed with fierce vigor.

The purple smoke diffused the impact of one, two blows, but one after another the force of the kicks scattered it; at last, once the smoke finally cleared, it could no longer serve as a shield or armor.

Of course, that even just this could be done in the first place was completely nonsensical—

Olbart: "Interestin' thing ya got there. Don't have that written down in my book of techniques."

Yorna: "My regrets. It's a secret technique that can't be imitated by *shinobi* who can't love anyone."

The moment Olbart broke through the smoke, the figure of Yorna appeared beside him.

Leaping into the air, Yorna waved the fancy-looking *kiseru* in her hand, aiming for the back of Olbart's unguarded head.

It was too long and light to be considered a blunt weapon, however Olbart blocked it with an extremely rapid swing of his arm— or rather, with the *kunai*³⁶ held in his arm.

Along with a shrill screech, the *kunai* that Olbart had concealed in his sleeve shattered.

It must have been fashioned from appropriate materials of course, yet the *kunai* was broken and Yorna's *kiseru* was undamaged. What in the world was Yorna's *kiseru* made of?

Olbart: "Kakaka, the elderly should be treated with kindness. Don't'cha dare harass me, lass."

Yorna: "I don't deny that there are elders who should be treated with kindness. But, Old Man Olbart, you can't possibly be one of them. That being the case..."

Olbart: "Oh well, I'll just treat myself with kindness then."

While exchanging banter, they hurled lethal attacks back and forth at each other.

Yorna's slender arms and long legs delivered blows that, despite their beautiful appearance, were mighty enough to bring down even castle walls.

In comparison, Olbart's attacks were not as flashy, and were generally fending off Yorna's attacks and throwing in a little interference in between. However—

Olbart: "Ya don't need the power to collapse a castle to kill someone. Ultimately, one long needle to the forehead'll kill ya."

Yorna: "If so, give it a try."

Promptly after Yorna's quiet provocation, Olbart's cunning expression melted into the sky— No, he began moving at tremendous speed, too fast for the eye of a run-of-the-mill human to follow.

³⁶ Translation note from Witch Cult Translations: "*Kunai* are a Japanese tool that was originally used as a gardening and masonry tool, but is commonly associated to *ninjas* as a multi-use weapon. For more information, see [here](#)."

There was a famous boxer of yesteryear who was said to float like a butterfly and sting like a bee³⁷, and that was exactly what Olbart's battle style was, the half-demolished castle tower as his stage.

If one had to pick a more apt description for him, saying that he was combining flight like that of a fighter jet and a shot like that of a sniper rifle, might be more accurate.

Yorna: "You're a personage who flies about quite a lot. You're too roguish for your years."

Perhaps due to Olbart's leg strength, the tiles he stepped on detonated and, in the following moment, Olbart's figure materialized from somewhere else and dealt a blow to Yorna.

Yorna made good use of her superhuman reflexes to either catch it with her *kiseru* or dodge it. Both of them were transcendental beings, so much so that the fierce battle made Subaru forget to breathe.

Louis: "Au...!"

Next to Subaru, Louis, who was watching the same spectacle, made herself smaller, curling up her body.

At the beginning of the battle, at a time he could not bear the continued state of the situation, he had been anxious about Louis jumping out.

But, the battle between Yorna and Olbart was no longer of that caliber.

Whichever side won, there would be an enormous amount of devastation.

That too, was an outcome far from ideal for Subaru.

Subaru: "But what can I do? There's nothing I can do to stop it...!"

With such a flashy battle, and considering the castle tower was being smashed up so violently, people everywhere in the city were most likely aware that something was going on at the Castle.

³⁷ Translation note from Witch Cult Translations: "A reference to the iconic quote of the legendary boxer Mohammed Ali. The quote has a continuation, however: «his hands can't hit what his eyes can't see». And well, that's exactly what Olbart did here, can't hit someone if they «melt into the sky»."

If so, it was possible that the people of the city, who loved Yorna, would come in droves, or that Olbart's comrades, the false Emperor and his entourage, would make a move.

If that happened, it would be the beginning of a major war in the whole city.

That's not what Subaru wanted.

Even if they had come to invite Yorna to enter the great conflict for Abel's return to the throne, what tragedy would result from a battle brought about without enough preparations?

Olbart: "Shiihaaaa!!"

Raising a shrill cry, both feet of the spinning monstrous old man pierced the roof in front of Yorna. Immediately after, a shock traveled through the roof, causing an eruption beneath Yorna's feet and sending her body soaring high into the sky, resulting in a swap of their initial positions, between the one in midair and the one on the ground.

Olbart: "———"

As Yorna rose up into the air, *shuriken* thrown by Olbart came at her from all sides.

Subaru had no idea of when he had thrown them. Perhaps he had hurled them after Yorna was tossed in the air, or maybe he'd known that she would be flung there beforehand; but either way, there was no escape.

Up in the air, a *shuriken* made a brutal wound on Yorna's soft, fair skin— No,

Yorna: "You must understand. I am the ruler of this town, the leader of the Demon City."

As Yorna responded, all around her, the revolving blades of the *shurikens* were stopped in their tracks.

They were not halted by Yorna, who could move at extraordinary speed. Yorna didn't even have to move. What had stopped the *shuriken* were pieces of roofing tiles that shot upwards.

It was not due to an enormous stroke of luck.

Because, no matter how lucky a person was, more than ten *shuriken* coming at a person from all directions being blocked by tiles could not happen by chance alone.

Yorna gave a gentle shake of her arms, Subaru and Olbart both holding that within their line of sight, gawking at the scene.

Then, as her arms moved, the tiles that had blocked the *shuriken* swam in the air and then stopped in midair, forming a spiral staircase around her.

Leisurely, Yorna's thick soles used the tiles as steps, making her way down to the castle tower.

That scene was a display of illusions or perhaps psychokinesis. Of course, it could be called magic in other words, but it differed slightly from the magic Subaru knew.

Neither fire nor ice nor wind nor earth were being manipulated, the building parts themselves were.

Olbart: "Kah, you're a real pain in the ass, ya know that? So that's the magic trick Cecilus and Araki were talkin' 'bout? How'd'cha do that?"

Yorna: "I told you so. It's a secret technique that can't be done by *shinobi* who can't love anyone... I'm a woman who takes good care of things, despite my appearance."

With a smile, Yorna held the *kiseru* between her lips, then struck her now-free hands with a clap-clap.

As if on cue, a change occurred in the half-demolished castle keep— No, it was no simple change. It was a magic technique, one that distorted reality like a dream.

Subaru: "T-this is..."

The roof distorting beneath his feet, Louis hugged Subaru's arm as he gulped. While supporting her body, an aberrant event happened under Subaru's nose, as the half-demolished castle keep was restored before his eyes.

Little-by-little, the building repaired itself like a sped-up video of a wound being healed.

Combining Abel's guess about Yorna being a user of the Soul Marriage Technique and her words from earlier, a theory came to Subaru's mind about what happened.

It sounded very, very stupid, but Yorna Mishigure——

Subaru: “S-she’s using the same Soul Marriage Technique on the Castle as well...?”

Indeed, he could not help but at a loss of words by the ability showcase of the Ruler of the Demon City, a being literally out of this world.



Illustration from Volume 29, coloring by coolcollin007/SoupVEVO ([source](#))

Arc 7 Chapter 52 - Love Cannot Be Bequeathed

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 29, Chapter 6 “Love Cannot Be Bequeathed”, Parts 3-5

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Edited Machine Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Original by Goldkills, MaskedBook, Translation checked by [Taurace](#), MaskedBook) — [Complete](#)

—By using the Soul Marriage Technique on the Castle, her Od was being instilled into even inorganic substances.

This was the reality of the extraordinary phenomenon of Yorna, who was using the spiraling roof tiles as a foothold.

Abel had spoken of her Soul Marriage Technique being applied to the more than hundred people chasing after Subaru’s group like it was already something unusual, but that was not even the strange part.

If he assumed she was handing out part of her Od, even to her own castle and *kiseru*.

Subaru: “That seems extremely bad for your body...!”

In the first place, the act of handing over Mana to someone else was quite tiring in itself.

In fact, Subaru had firsthand knowledge of how difficult it was, as he would regularly exchange Mana with Beatrice, with whom he had a contractual relationship.

While in the Sand Sea, on their way to the Watchtower, for example, Beatrice had taken a lot of Mana from him, and even though it had been only the necessary amount, he’d gotten dog-tired.

Additionally, the risk of trouble occurring with his Od tied to Beatrice alone— in Yorna’s case, by simple calculation that risk was more than a hundredfold.

On top of that, she herself had the power to unfold a heck of a battle.

In reality, the fact that she was supposed to be dog-tired because she was sharing her power with everyone was, considering she had split the Castle with an axe kick, quite unbelievable.

Olbart: “Hahaa, you’re usin’ some strange skills. Geez, no matter how long I live, techniques I dunno come out one after the other, it’s a real headache.”

Yorna: “That’s the kind of fertile ground we live on, so there’s no point for you to lament it. From my point of view, Old Man Olbart’s skills are also troublesome enough... It’d be better to make you disappear.”

Olbart: “Kakakakka! I won’t be taken outta the picture so easily... Wuoh!?”

Olbart, laughing with his big mouth open, sprung backward in response to the hostility that followed that immediately.

Instantly, the roof beneath Olbart’s feet exploded, and roof tiles shot up from the impact from directly below. It was much like a reprisal for the previous attack that had launched Yorna.

And yet unlike Olbart’s single blow, Yorna’s attacks fired in rapid succession, as if hot on his heels.

Bang bang bang, with that sound, shockwaves chased after Olbart as he spun backward and hopped away. That had been accomplished by Yorna simply waving a supple finger of hers, using a roof tile fixed up in the air.

Olbart: “Yo! Ho! Huh! Take this!”

Yorna: “Old Man Olbart, you sure are a stubborn man.”

Olbart: “If ya got the impression they’re flies, ya dunno elderly opponents, lass. However——”

Cutting off his words there, Olbart twisted his body as he spun backward. As he did, with his back turned while in an upside-down position, the roof lifted like a wave to greet him.

Chased by shock waves from his front, and by surging waves of roof tiles from his back, he was being attacked on both sides—the sight of the castle tower surging like an ocean made Subaru want to doubt his eyes.

But doubting his eyes was what he'd want to do for what happened directly after that as well.

Olbart: “———”

As the roof tiles approached like a tidal wave, seeing that, Olbart kicked himself off the air itself, heading into the roof tiles of his own accord head-first.

Albeit it looked like a wave given its appearance, the tiles that made up the large wave had not lost their hardness and weight.

If he went in head-first, his whole body would be thrashed, his bones broken, and, in the end, his head would be tragically smashed. Without thinking, Subaru covered Louis's face as he hugged her, hearing her protest with a “Uu!”.

But that cruel outcome never came to pass.

Olbart: “Ain't I amazin' for bein' able ta put the technique of hidin' in the ground into use without preparation?”

At the moment of collision, Olbart plunged soundlessly into the waves of roof tiles as if he were diving into water, and jumped straight out the back of the surge of roof waves. Scraping the torn-off roof tiles with his heels, Olbart flashed a cunning smile showing his white teeth, acting as if it had been nothing special.

In fact, Olbart had yet to display the depth of his abilities.

On the other hand, Yorna might have already exposed what terrors the Soul Marriage Technique held, but,

Yorna: “Will you be able to achieve your goal while merely running away like that, Old Man Olbart?”

With composure, she looked down from the sky towards the monstrous old man, who had still not sustained an injury.

Both of them had shown only a fraction of their power. That alone was enough to prove that the Nine Divine Generals, the Empire's greatest warriors, held tremendous strength.

However, if the fight continued in that way, it could be presumed their even match would continue, as both sides would not give in.

Apparently, Subaru and Louis watching from the sidelines were not the only ones with this impression.

Olbart: "Good grief, that's a painful thing to hear. Tho', if the Third stubbornly holds out against the Seventh, well, it can't be helped that His Excellency'd be angered."

Yorna: "Then, what shall we do?"

Olbart: "Good question. Well, it's not like I've been runnin' 'round aimlessly either..."

Raising her shapely eyebrows, Yorna asked that of Olbart, who stroked his chin. As he rubbed it, the monstrous old man's cheeks twisted, his gaze turning in another direction.

Those glowing yellow eyes turned to the two children watching the battle from the sidelines—

Subaru: "—Hk."

Yorna: "Old Man!!"

Suddenly, Olbart's gaze sharpened and Subaru drew back.

Immediately afterward, Yorna, her eyebrows raised, kicked off the roof tiles, throwing herself furiously at Olbart. Once again, Yorna rained down intense strikes on Olbart, similar to those at the start. However—

Olbart: "It's 'cause of somethin' like that, that'cha haven't reached His Excellency even once despite so many rebellions."

Olbart spat that out, and a leg of his, incomparably shorter than Yorna's, sprung up. But, the sole of his shoe collided directly with the thick sole on Yorna's heel, sending shockwaves through the long hair of the two.

Yorna gnashed her teeth, Olbart clenched his own, and in a second the bodies of both were blown in opposite directions. Yorna and Olbart, each at the same time.

Then, as soon as he saw that there was a wide distance between them, Olbart plunged his left and right arms into his sleeves and then pulled something out— Between his fingers, there were round and black lumps, four in each hand.

Subaru: “Ration balls!?”

Olbart: “Ngh, looks like that, right? But, things’d get messy if ya ate ‘em— For ya see, chunks of Fire Magic Stones are tightly stuffed in ‘em.”

Hearing Subaru’s shriek, Olbart laughed and gave a grand swing of both his arms.

If his words were to be believed, those black balls were bombs. Propelled with an impact, they flew towards Yorna who was showing a large opening— No, that wasn’t it.

Olbart: “In the latest rebellion, that lot were the bunch we fought, right? I wouldn’t have used something like this against them, so it’s fresh, isn’t it?”

His cheeks distorted, Olbart threw the bombs over the roof into the open sky.

From the way he hurled them, it seemed there was no particular aim, and because of that, there was no doubt about it— For Olbart, a bomb just needed to fall onto a place with people. Only that—

Olbart: “I’ve heard it said that’cha and the folks of this city are awfully tough, but... Are ya tougher than the folks of my village were?”

Yorna: “—You lowlife!”

The size of the bomb was small, but the hidden power there-in was wholly unknown.

There was also the question of how many people in the city were under the effect of Yorna’s Soul Marriage Technique at the moment. In conclusion, leaving those bombs as they were would be far too reckless.

Yorna instantly drew that conclusion as well. Hence—

Yorna: “HaAAAAaa!!”

Stomping her foot hard enough to smash the roof, Yorna brandished her arm wide. Clutched in her hand, was the *kiseru* that had been used to attack Olbart.

At the same time, the smoke overflowing from the tip of the pipe traced the same arc as the full swing of her arm, and the mass of purple smoke flashed across the sky of Chaosflame like a horizontal slash.

—That mass of purple smoke had entirely caught the bombs scattered about.

Immediately afterward, the tremendous sound of chained explosions, thunderous booms and shock waves dyed the sky of the Castle. One of the explosions occurred near Subaru and Louis, blinding them and making it impossible for them to stand.

Subaru: “Kah—”

He faintly remembered seeing on the television or in a book that one should plug their ears and open their mouth when an explosion occurred.

As a result of failing to do both, Subaru’s body suffered great damage. His head was rocked, his vision was colored bright-red. That was how out of the ordinary Olbart’s bomb was.

Olbart was out of his mind to be carrying around so many of those things.

That he was going to scatter them all over the city without mercy was also clear—

Louis: “Uau!”

There was a shout, and Subaru’s shoulders were shaken by a small hand.

Upon taking a look, he saw Louis projected in his deep-red, obscured vision and noticed that her facial expression was changed. Her mouth quivering in terror, tears were welling up in Louis’s blue eyes.

Seeing that before his eyes, Subaru went to reply with “I’m fine”,

Subaru: “—Ah.”

—At the edge of his red field of view, he caught sight of Olbart appearing behind Yorna.

Subaru: “———”

As she was busy dealing with the bombs that had been thrown, her pose was still the same, having done a full swing of her *kiseru*. Olbart, having appeared right behind her, was about to draw his arm in, and loosen a strike of his hand being used as a sword.

His aim was the center of Yorna’s back; if this were a manga, it would be a situation in which her heart would be pierced with one blow.

If it truly would play out like something out of a manga, he didn’t know. But enough had been seen in the fight so far to know that both Yorna and Olbart were superhumans with manga-like powers.

If it continued unchanged, Yorna would die. So——

Subaru: “Louis——!”

Grabbing Louis’s hand that was on his shoulder, Subaru pointed towards Yorna and Olbart.

He’d told her the procedure in detail before entering the Castle, and Louis, setting it in motion, opened both her big round eyes—— the next moment, Subaru’s vision flickered, and the teleport happened. And so——

Subaru: “Ah.”

Before he could inhale once, Subaru leaked a dumbfounded voice.

The reason was simple, because even his blurry bright-red vision was taken away by a sudden warm feeling. Through that sensation, he understood that the cause for that was some kind of fluid that had been poured on his face without warning.

As he tried to wipe that sensation away with his arm, he noticed a sense of discomfort.

Louis’s grip was too light.

Olbart: “The hell was that just now? Ya weaklings are supposed ta be over there.”

The sound of Olbart's voice of curiosity made Subaru look up dumbfounded. Within his view was the monstrous old man, his head slightly tilted, shaking his hand vigorously.

Within Subaru's vision of red, an even redder arm waved with vigor.

Subaru: "Louis...?"

As he watched, Subaru called Louis's name, gripping her hand tighter.

He thought that they had to get out of that place at once. They would have to leap two times, maybe more. Perhaps he'd throw up, but that would be bearable.

He would bear it, so they had to get out of there, right now. Because of that—

Subaru: "Louis! We've got to hurry..."

Olbart: "Nah, sayin' somethin' that absurd's quite pitiful ta look at. There's nothin' left above her neck, is there?"

Subaru: "—Huh?"

Hearing those words spoken so indifferently, Subaru was not able to understand their meaning.

Perhaps him being smaller and his brain younger was why he didn't get them. He had been told something he didn't get, something his little brain didn't want to understand, and because of that.

And because of that, even if he were told that nothing of her head was left.

Yorna: "How dare... you do that!!"

Shortly after, with a shout of anger, something shot over Subaru's head, and Olbart jumped sideways to avoid it. An impact shaped like a straight line ran through the place where Olbart had been just before, and the newly-repaired castle tower was once again destroyed.

But Olbart was unconcerned by the sort of dreadful power in that blow,

Olbart: "Oh, scary, scary. But ya should be grateful, foxgirl."

Yorna: “What do you mean!?”

Olbart: “If it weren’t for the boy and lassie there, you’d be dead, ya know? Well, at this rate, it’s only a matter of time anyhow.”

Yorna: “———”

Shaking his upraised finger, Olbart continued in a carefree tone.

Yorna held her breath, and Subaru felt her attention going from the monstrous old man to himself. However, Subaru slumped on the spot, and the best he could do was pull Louis’s lifeless arm towards him.

Subaru: “Lou, is...”

His vision was red, and he couldn’t see Louis’s figure properly.

If that was because of the disorder of Subaru’s eyes, or because Louis’s figure had turned bright-red, he couldn’t even tell.

But there was one thing that could be said— Louis had died.

Even though Subaru had not found any answer on what should be done about her.

She had acted as she had been told to by Subaru, and as a result, she died.

Subaru, had let her die.

Yorna: “Child! Child, look at me!”

Suddenly, Subaru’s face cast downward was lifted by two hands clasping both his cheeks.

In front of him, in his red vision, was a beautiful woman’s face. The reason as to why he had not been able to tell it was Yorna at first glance was because the expression on her face was one of grief.

It was different from the confident face she had shown the previous day to Subaru and the false Emperor, and their respective entourages.

It was different from the kind face that had tried to treat Subaru and the others politely this very day.

Right now, Yorna's eyes were shaking as she stared at Subaru with a pained expression.

He finally understood the reason why, due to the reflection of Yorna's eyes before him.

Subaru: "—Ah."

Subaru dropped to his knees, with that face of his being in an awful condition.

His left eyeball had burst into bright-red, and his right one had popped out of its socket, held by a string. His eyeball had been pushed out of its orbit because of the impact of the explosion, which had not been dampened at all.

It was, like some special effects from a cheap-looking zombie movie, somewhat weird to look at.

Subaru: "Haaa."

Realizing his circumstances, Subaru's vision, solely that of his left eye, wavered as he let out an exhale. But Yorna's hands did not allow him to fall.

Yorna, moving her lips and staring into Subaru's face, spoke, "Child—",

Yorna: "—Love me. Right now."

With eyes looking straight ahead, she declared something utterly absurd.

To love, and to do it at this moment, was awfully absurd. In the first place, he didn't know what he should do specifically, and loving someone was no trivial thing to do.

He did believe Yorna was a nice person, and she was beautiful, but—

Yorna: "Child! If you love me, those wounds will also..."

Olbart: "Kakakakka! Oioi, that's one hell of a thing ta ask for, lass, for real. Not that I know much 'bout it, but love doesn't bud so easily, does it?"

Yorna: "Silence!"

Shouting out in anger towards Olbart behind her teasing her, Yorna's eyes were tinged with a deep hue.

Watching that happen near him, Subaru repeated faint breaths to prepare, as to accept the waves of pain slowly arriving.

Even if one of his eyeballs had burst, and one of them had popped out, he did not have fatal injuries.

Unlike Louis, he still had his head. He knew that, soon enough, deathly pain would flare up. He was sure he would scream and yell and cause Yorna plenty of trouble.

He didn't want to cause any more trouble—

Yorna: "Child."

One word was spoken, and Subaru's consciousness flickered up.

Then, much like an attack that made use of a gap of just one moment, Yorna's serious face approached his own.

Subaru: "——"

Yorna's lips, overlapped with Subaru's own.

A soft sensation hit his face, and he could feel her breath right up close. It took him a while to realize that he was being kissed.

Partly because he was younger, and partly because he didn't have much experience to begin with. His scarce memories were rather distant and he considered them to be very, very moving experiences, but this—

Yorna: "My lips aren't cheap. With this..."

The kiss ended, Yorna distanced her face, and she interrupted the words onto which she was clinging. However, Subaru vaguely understood what the words that were to follow would be.

What she wanted to say was— *Can you love me now?*

If Subaru were to love Yorna, the situation would change.

That was most likely the root of Yorna's power, or something like the origin of her strength. However—

Subaru: "There's a girl I like, so..."

On the other side of his bright-red vision, the face of the girl he liked, located in a distant place, emerged.

When he gazed at her smiling face, his heart would throb. Therefore, Subaru could not love Yorna.

He could not love her, and so, upon hearing that, Yorna's face tensed up in grave pain. It was difficult to look at that.

Olbart: "—Well, things don't always turn out so well with men and women."

In a moment, along with that voice filled with something like disappointment, Subaru's field of view changed completely.

Subaru: "——"

Yorna's face, which was right in front of him, disappeared, and all he could see was the sky being dyed red.

Similarly to Louis's teleport, his vision shifted quickly— No, it was different from Louis's.

If it were like Louis's teleport, the world would reflect something different, more vivid, in an instant.

But what was happening to Subaru at the moment was much rougher and cruder. His vision was spinning, and there was no interruption like there would be in a teleport, and he saw everything from the ground, ground that was a continuous plane.

Just above him was Yorna on her knees, and Olbart's form standing before her. Next to Yorna, was the body of a fallen girl, perhaps that of Louis.

There was one other thing, something, or someone, standing between Yorna and Olbart.

That was—

Subaru: “—Ah.”

—It was the body of the young Subaru, a child missing his head.

Olbart: “Good grief, it’s mentally tough ta kill a child. Well, physically it’s easier tho’, isn’t it?”

Yorna: “Old Man—!”

With a blood-curdling scream, Yorna’s body plunged into Olbart. He met it head-on, and the bodies of the two clashed, causing the Crimson Lapis Castle to rock violently.

It rocked, it cracked, it shattered, and once again the destruction spread and spread, and then, something happened.

From that point onward, Subaru did not understand what was happening.

He did not understand anything anymore. Without understanding anything, Subaru’s head bounced off the roof—

It bounced—



—Dark, he was dragged into a dark space.

???: “———”

It was an empty space; he had no hands or feet and was floating; it was incomprehensible, neither sky nor ground existed, drifting about, nothing shook, nothing resisted, nothing was experienced, nothing shuddered.

It was like he had been acquainted with it many times before, it was like this was the first time he laid eyes upon it.

It was like it was drifting away, it was like it was infinitely close.

Amidst the seemingly everlasting darkness, in the space completely dominated by darkness, there was an echo.

An echo, of weeping, of someone's crying voice, one that made his non-existing heart beat, of a voice.

???: "I love you."

Those, were words of love.

Like an appeal for love, a request for love, a plead for love, a deferment of love, the voice had requested love for love.

???: "I love you. I love you. I love you."

That accretion of love, originally, was supposed to be that of words filled with various emotions.

The likes of happiness, of anger, of sadness, of pleasure; the whirlpool of emotions was filled with that sort.

And yet, that which filled the love in this everlasting darkness, was nothing more than a single emotion.

*???: “I love you. I love you. I love you. I love you. I love you. I love you. I love you. I love you. I love
you. I love you. I love you. I love you. I love you. I love you. I love you—”*

Crammed among the entirety of those emotions, in the entirety of that whirling love, was only “sadness”.

Sadness, of sadness, of sad, that love sobbed, saddened by sadness.

Unceasingly, there was sobbing.

Unceasingly, the sobbing made him yearn for death just because he was listening to it.

Love was sadness, love was made of sadness, love was made of sad, love was saddening sadness.

While sobbing, while carrying out love on love, while saddened by sadness, they united at the terminus.

???: “—Where are you?”



Olbart: “I’ve heard it said that’cha and the folks of this city are awfully tough, but... Are ya tougher than the folks of my village were?”

Yorna: “—You lowlife!”

The whirling, spinning vision of red performed a rotation, and tense voices struck his eardrums.

One was that of an old man, and the other was that of a woman— he could understand they were Olbart and Yorna respectively.

He understood, but that was the only thing he could understand.

Subaru: “Huh...”

Yorna: “HaAAAAaa!!”

Immediately after letting out a dazed voice, there was a massive boom, and, stepping hard on the roof of the Castle, Yorna’s foot crushed it. At the same time, the golden *kiseru* in her hand was swung.

A large, horizontal, arcing blow from the *kiseru*, with tremendous speed and destructive power, spread a large plume of purple smoke across the skies of Chaosflame.

Subaru knew what it was for and what would happen next.

He knew, but it would happen before the knowledge he was aware of could catch up with reality.

—A bomb struck by Yorna’s purple smoke exploded, and a shockwave engulfed the area.

Subaru: “Gah—”

His whole body bathed by the same shock that had bathed it mere moments ago, Subaru's field of vision was dyed bright-red.

He thought he heard a small sound like something being split, and he immediately drew the connection to his reddened vision. The sound had been the bursting of his eyeball. Hence, Subaru's vision had turned red.

If so, before long, the other side of his field of vision would turn dark—

Subaru: "Ah, g-gyAHHHHHH—!!"

Covering his face with both hands, Subaru screamed as he was struck by two things, pain and "understanding".

He had gained "understanding". One of his eyeballs had been ruptured and the other one popped out. As long as his brain didn't want to understand, it was possible to ignore the pain.

But, if he knew what had happened to begin with, he would not be able to ignore the pain.

Subaru: "AAAAAGH! AGH, GYAHHHH!!"

Louis: "Uau! Uauu!"

A small body clutched Subaru, who had collapsed onto his back on the spot, wailing loudly.

His name was being called. He did not understand. His ears were burning, and his own voice was too loud. The pain, the gushing of blood, he could hear it. He did not understand whether it was blood flowing inside or outside his body. It hurt, it just hurt. It hurt it hurt it hurt it hurt, it hurt.

Somebody, help. I don't want pain. I don't like pain. I don't like, pain.

It hurt, it hurt because it hurt, it hurt because it hurt, because it hurt, it hurt it hurt it hurt it hurt it hurt—

Subaru: "Wa—"

Olbart: "Oioi, isn't that a bad idea?"



Illustration from Volume 29, coloring by Norvak ([source](#))

Subaru: “—Hk.”

Pain swirling around in his head, his red vision glazed over.

Right beside Subaru, there was a hand holding him down as he tried to roll around, but it was getting in his way. He wanted to scream louder, flail around more, and let the pain escape from his body.

No, it was his face that hurt. His eyes and his ears. So, if it hurt somewhere else, if this pain would go somewhere else.

Louis: “Uau! Auaa—”

Thud thud, he banged his head on the ground. A strong force pulled him up. Someone fastened their arms behind his back, making him unable to move. It hurt, he was afraid of being hurt. He hated it, he was scared, he was going to die.

Subaru: “Guh...”

Olbart: “Kakh, ya can’t be serious, foxgirl. What kinda body ya got that won’t die from that? So that’s what Cecilus was talkin’ ‘bout when he said he couldn’t lop off yer head?”

Yorna: “...There’s no way I’m going to reveal my womanly secrets to a lousy man who lays his hands on children.”

In the distance, someone was arguing. Caught between his own voice and the voice that was trying to hold him back, he couldn’t hear anything. He couldn’t understand. It hurt, everything was wrong.

Yes, everything was wrong. The red and the pain, everything was their fault. Everything was because of them.

Subaru: “It’s because of them...! That’s, that’s, that’s their fault! Not mine! Even though it’s not mine, uuuugh!”

Louis: “Uu!!”

Squirming and struggling, Subaru tried to push all of it somewhere else. What if he pushed everything to something else and was able to escape, what should he do if he could escape?

He would think about such a thing after he escaped. He would think about it after he escaped, so.

Olbart: “Wahwah, I can’t stand hearin’ the sound of children cryin’— Shuddup.”

Yorna: “Wait...!”

A woman’s desperate voice and an uninterested hoarse voice.

After hearing them, something approached with the sound of scraping. From behind his head, fastening their arms behind his back, someone hugged Subaru tightly.

But, being embraced by them did not help.

Because a bright-red, heated light swelled up again, engulfing Subaru and the rest.

He was swallowed, and the pain went away, and then—

Olbart: “I’ve heard it said that’cha and the folks of this city are awfully tough, but... Are ya tougher than the folks of my village were?”

Yorna: “—You lowlife!”

A moment later, again he heard the voices he had heard just a while ago, and hearing them again, his consciousness turned white.

Subaru: “Huh...?”

Immediately after everything was suddenly and abruptly cut off, the replay began anew.

Other colors returned to his bright-red vision, he felt the sound of the wind in his deaf ears, felt the warmth of the soft girl right beside him, and—

Yorna: “HaAAAAaa!!”

The voice of a vigorous woman was raised in volume, and a moment later, an arm was swung with tremendous force.

The trajectory of the swinging arm was already known to him.

—A series of explosions rang out, and a shock dyed his vision bright-red.

Subaru: “GYAHHHH—!!”

Covering his face and taking in the pain of his ruptured and popped-out eyeballs, Subaru collapsed back-first onto the roof, and yelled.

Louis: “Uau! Uau!”

Someone’s voice, seemingly crying, jumped onto his fallen body.

As he felt it, as he listened to the world drowned out by harsh sounds, as he lamented the pain and suffering, Subaru’s head was filled with tears, fear, and “why”.

Perhaps, he was dead. He was dead.

He knew death. It was very painful and cruel, it kept him away from this place. But then it returned him to this place immediately, and then he died; it was painful however, due to the red explosion.

Even knowing this, Subaru repeated in his mind, “Why?”.

—*This, isn’t it.*

Vaguely, a sensation rang in his head, almost pushing him away with pain and redness. But it was a feeling of absolute certainty that he could not let go of.

An eyeball burst, an eyeball popped out, his eardrums ruptured, he was crying out in pain, he would soon after this die in a horrible way yet again despite wishing that the pain would be kept at a distance. Along with tears, snot, drool, and the leakage of some urine, his frenetic head thought such.

Subaru: “Tihs³⁸, isn...”

Louis: “Uau! Au, uu!”

Subaru: “This isn’t, mine...”

³⁸ Translation note from Witch Cult Translations: “The misspelling is intentional.”

Arc 7 Chapter 53 - What Lies Beyond the Eleventh Second

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 29, Chapter 7 “What Lies Beyond the Eleventh Second”

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Edited Machine Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Original by Goldkills, MaskedBook, Translation checked by [Taurace](#), MaskedBook) — [Complete](#)

Olbart: “I’ve heard it said that’cha and the folks of this city are awfully tough, but... Are ya tougher than the folks of my village were?”

Yorna: “—You lowlife!”

He heard voices he’d heard many times before.

The hoarse voice of an old man, and an anger-filled voice of a woman. And then—

Yorna: “HaAAAAaa!!”

There was an impact, that of the roof tiles being stepped on by a foot with force, and the *kiseru* and purple smoke were swung furiously. Chaosflame’s sky was scythed by a sideward swipe, scythed, scythed—

—Once more, a series of explosions echoed, and that red, intense pain arrived.

Subaru: “Geh, GAHHHH—!!”

Louis: “Uau! Uau!”

The pain and shock of having an eyeball bursting and the other popping out made him collapse on the spot clutching his face. A light body jumped on him; he’d already known this would happen.

But although he knew it, he was not able to deal with it. There just wasn’t enough time.

Subaru: "Guhhhh! Agh, guh, UGHHHHH!"

A bright-red field of vision, a pain like that of his head being smashed, his soul crying out, "Why?".

All of these caused Subaru to waste the ten seconds of despair that came time and time again.

The pain prevented him from thinking, the loss that made the world turn red prevented him from seeing his environs. Even if it would swiftly fade away, three seconds were all it took for him to freshly savor the same pain all over again.

Pain, red, scary, why, death. Pain, red, scary, why, death. Pain, red, scary, why, death. Pain, red,
scary, why, death. Pain, red, scary, why, death. Pain, red, scary, why, death. Pain, red, scary, why,
death. Pain, red, scary, why, death. Pain, red, scary, why, death. Pain, red, scary, why, death. Pain,
red, scary, why, death— It was repeated endlessly.

He was going mad.

Olbart: “I’ve heard it said that’cha and the folks of this city are awfully tough, but... Are ya tougher than the folks of my village were?”

Yorna: “—You lowlife!”

Once more, the same voices could be heard. The pain and the redness ceased for only a moment.

But once more, he was so scared that his soul was torn to shreds, as he was going to taste the same pain.

Subaru: “AAaaah—!!”

He didn't want to hear anything. He didn't want to feel pain. It was, scaryscaryscaryscary.

He opened his mouth wide and screamed; screaming to the point of rupturing his throat. Because he didn't want to see anything, he closed his eyes and crouched down, his head in his hands.

And at the very next moment.

Subaru: “———”

Boom, the sound of an explosion resounded, and Subaru's small body was repelled, rolling away. The sound became distant, and his soul cowered in terror as the pain and the red once again arrived. However—

Subaru: “—Huh.”

That pain never arrived.

The pain of one of his eyeballs bursting and the other being popped out did not arrive. Although his hearing had been destroyed, the world had not reddened. What hurt him the most was his throat due to his loud scream.

Subaru: “Why...”

Louis: “Uau!”

Shortly after his stunned voice leaked out, a small body jumped at him.

It was Louis. She pulled on his arm, trying to get Subaru to stand up. But he could not, his knees had no strength, and he had not yet gotten an answer to his “why”.

His throat just tightened up and tears welled up in his eyes, happy to be away from that red pain, even for a moment. Unable to bear it any longer, he crouched and cried.

Yorna: “Chil—”

Olbart: “Oioi, isn't that a bad idea?”

Yorna: “—Hk.”

Far away from the crouching and crying Subaru, a battle of a whole other dimension continued— No, the scales had tipped grandly; within his blurry vision, he could see that the woman had fallen to her knees.

Yorna, her knees bent, and Olbart, standing to her back.

Olbart waved his blood-red right hand, raising his eyebrows in surprise as he gazed down at Yorna, bleeding from the corner of her mouth.

Yorna: “Guhk...”

Olbart: “Kakh, ya can’t be serious, foxgirl. What kinda body ya got that won’t die from that? So that’s what Cecilus was talkin’ ‘bout when he said he couldn’t lop off yer head?”

Yorna: “...There’s no way I’m going to reveal my womanly secrets to a lousy man who lays his hands on children.”

Striking her molars, Yorna replied to Olbart in a voice devoid of any loss in intensity. Upon hearing that, Olbart let out his usual loud laugh.

After that, he waved his blood-soaked sleeve,

Olbart: “Ya say some funny things. I’ll show ya what it really means ta lay yer hands on a child.”

Yorna: “Wait—!”

A black ball pulled out from his sleeve— a bomb was thrown and flew towards Subaru and Louis.

Louis quickly stepped in front of Subaru and tried to repel it, but it was too late.

The red light exploded in front of Subaru’s eyes yet again, and Louis’s whole body, having rushed in front of him, along with Subaru’s own, were both engulfed in light and once more torn apart—

Olbart: “I’ve heard it said that’cha and the folks of this city are awfully tough, but... Are ya tougher than the folks of my village were?”

Yorna: “—You lowlife!”

Once more, the same voices could be heard.



—The moment the red and the pain disappeared, he closed his eyes and raised a loud shout.

Having repeatedly experienced the red pain many and many times over, and having only managed to escape it a few times, this was the absolute rule Subaru had obtained.

No matter what, once the red and the pain arrived at the same time, there would be nothing Subaru could do about it. He could only cry, scream, and then, die.

And just when he'd think he was dead, once more he would hear those voices and suffer the red pain from the explosion.

Don't wanna do it anymore. Don't wanna. Because I don't wanna, because I'm begging, I'm scared.

Olbart: "I've heard it said that'cha and the folks of this city are awfully tough, but... Are ya tougher than the folks of my village were?"

Yorna: "—You lowlife!"

Once more, the same voices could be heard.

At that moment, the pain and the redness receded entirely, and the momentary relief seemed to drain all the strength from his body. Enduring it, he did what he had to do.

Subaru: "AAAAaah—!"

Squeezing his eyes shut, he opened his mouth wide and howled.

Although he could not hear because of his own shouting, Yorna was probably brandishing her *kiseru* with a wide swing, attempting to detonate the bomb thrown by Olbart.

So, soon afterwards—

Subaru: "—Hk."

Subaru's whole body was pushed by the roar and blast wave of the explosion, landing on his butt atop the roof. The corner of the roof tile bit into his butt, the pain so sharp that he felt like he was about to cry.

But he did not cry. No, he did not want to cry and make his vision go blurry. Because—

Subaru: “I can see...”

Fearfully opening his eyes, he could see just fine; they had not burst nor popped out.

As usual, his ears were not working, just ringing, and his throat was burning, but he did not experience that red pain. It was alright. It was good.

If he closed his eyes and shouted out loud, he would not have to suffer that red pain.

Louis: “Uau!”

Louis rushed over to Subaru, she seemed to be on the verge of crying from emotion. While he could finally see Louis’s face, her blue eyes were wide open as though worried about Subaru.

Without thinking, he hugged Louis’s body back and shouted, “I’m fine!”.

Louis: “Uu.”

Subaru: “I’m fine! It hurt, and it was red... Yeah, but, now, I’m fine...”

Anyhow, once the pain and the red disappeared, he would close his eyes and shout.

As long as he remembered that rule, he would never have to suffer. As Subaru hugged Louis’s thin body, he felt certain of this.

Olbart: “Nah, you’re not fine at all ya know, look. O’er here, o’er here.”

Immediately afterward, Subaru heard a horrifying voice and reflexively looked up.

As Subaru’s eyes widened, Olbart, wearing a smile of satisfaction, cast *shurikens* that drew irregular trajectories, flying towards Subaru and Louis.

The *shinobi*’s dark-colored dull weapons, glinting with a *shing*, were all aimed precisely at vital points.

Subaru: “Hii.”

Yorna: "I won't tolerate this sort of debauchery."

Subaru's throat tightened, and to his front appeared Yorna's back. She intercepted the trajectory of the oncoming *shurikens* with her *kiseru*, striking them down in their flying path altogether.

Simultaneously, the roof tiles on either side of Olbart rose, and then slammed into the monstrous old man with the force of a mousetrap or a flyswatter. However—

Olbart: "Kakakakka! What a flashy show, isn't that an amusin' technique!"

Olbart twisted his minute body to dodge the blow of the roof tiles.

Subaru used to believe that the bigger someone who labored in waging battle was, the stronger they would be and the wider the range of their attacks. However, Olbart's agility and quick wittedness defied that impression.

Olbart: "Well, I don't need this flashy stuff. Ultimately, a human bein' can be killed by a sharp needle ta the forehead."

Yorna: "Your words make my fox ears itch— So, how about this instead?"

Olbart: "Oh."

Olbart avoided the showy attack, but right after, Yorna struck the roof with her heel. Then, one-by-one, the roof tiles rose and began to float, revolving around in midair.

Drawing an extremely large spiral across the entirety of the roof, the circumference of the whirlpool narrowed towards Olbart at the center— Just like a tornado. And then—

Yorna: "Why don't you show me some of your *shinobi* techniques on how to escape from a place without an opening?"

Before she finished speaking, Yorna's outstretched hand squeezed tight.

Immediately after, the whirling tornado of tiles engulfed Olbart and compressed him into the center in one fell swoop. The tiles collided with each other relentlessly, and the sound of a fierce, all-crushing impact rang out.

Even a somewhat robust human body would not be able to withstand the pressure at the nexus of this fierce destruction. It would be crushed, with no chance of survival.

Louis: “Au...”

Witnessing the same thing, Louis too gasped at its exuberant destructive power.

In response to Louis’s reaction, Yorna quietly replied, “I’m sorry to have frightened you”,

Yorna: “I started all this on a whim of mine. I feel terrible about the way you look...”

Olbart: “Oioi, don’t’cha go thinkin’ we’re done here. I’m tellin’ ya, the fact that I’m still alive even tho’ I’m a geezer means it’ll take a lot ta kill me, ya know?”

Yorna: “—Hk.”

Just as Yorna was about to turn around, she heard that comment and her fox ears perked up. Taking a look towards it, the voice she’d heard had come from a whirlpool of roof tiles that had gathered at their center, crushing it— No, it had come from behind it.

Accompanied by a rattle, the voice that came from among the debris of the broken roof tiles was that of Olbart, unharmed despite the fact he’d been at the core of the vortex of devastation.

The monstrous old man waved his hand, smiling with a malicious look on his face,

Olbart: “Yo. And that’s the *shinobi*’s technique of escapin’ when there’s no openin’. Ya satisfied?”

Yorna: “—Old or decrepit, you are still a Nine Divine General, it seems.”

Olbart: “Kakakakka! That’s a terrible thing to say! First of all, I’ve been an ol’ man ever since I was chosen ta be one of the Nine Divine Generals, ya know? Even tho’ I’m old and decrepit, I’m still much stronger than most, and that’s why I was chosen. You however, lass, really need ta set yerself straight.”

Yorna: “Why’s that?”

Olbart tucked his waving hand into his sleeves and cocked his head, causing Yorna to frown.

In response to Yorna's question, Olbart continued, "Ya see",

Olbart: "If ya didn't have so many people ta protect, like the people of this city and the kids behind'cha, you'd be able ta handle me better."

Yorna: "—Hk."

Olbart: "You're fightin' 'cause ya wanna protect others, but you've become weaker 'cause of it. Yer priorities are all wack. That's why ya can't reach His Excellency, no matter how many times ya try, lass."

Olbart's yellow eyes seemed to pierce through Yorna to Subaru and Louis as he spoke.

In that moment, Subaru realized that they would once again be targeted. Perceiving this, he squeezed Louis's hand right away,

Subaru: "Yorna-san, Louis and I will be going away! Do your best!"

He felt terrible that he'd gotten Yorna into this situation, only to then run away.

But if Subaru and Louis were present, Yorna would have to fight to protect them as well as herself. Olbart would take advantage of the opportunity and, sure enough, she would be killed.

That'd be no good. He had to avoid that from happening. Somehow.

Subaru: "Louis!"

Shouting this, Subaru squeezed Louis's hand tight while pointing down towards his feet.

Making the connection between his touch and his instructions, Louis responded with her usual sound and a teleport happened.

Subaru and Louis's bodies teleported directly below where they were, to the interior of the Castle, and they found their feet on a wooden floor.

Confirming this, Subaru clenched his teeth.

Subaru: "Uh..."

There was a feeling like that of the contents of his stomach churning inside him, and his head swayed. For a moment, his red vision and his pain flickered, but the level to which they hindered him was incomparable to before.

Now that Subaru and Louis were gone, Yorna would be able to fight to her fullest—

Subaru: “—Hk, what!?”

Immediately afterward, there was the sound of an explosion occurring overhead, which triggered Subaru’s recent trauma.

A chain of tremendous roars from explosions followed, their shock reverberating through the roof and throughout the whole Castle, reaching Subaru and Louis. His knees came near to buckling involuntarily; desperately enduring that, Subaru looked up at the ceiling.

Although he couldn’t see it, it was most likely Olbart.

After all the bombs he had used, he was still carrying around even more.

???: “—Ah. Whoawhoa.”

Subaru: “Huh?”

In Subaru’s field of vision as he raised his eyes, a wrinkled face slipped through the ceiling and peeked down below.

Subaru’s breath hitched at the suddenness of it all, and then Olbart fell straight down, his face as well as his entire body slipping through the ceiling.

The old man was smiling meaningfully as he dropped from the ceiling,

Olbart: “Ya gave me the willies back there. I took ya as just a kid, I messed up, I messed up.”

Louis: “Uu!”

A moment later, Louis kicked out a thin leg at the approaching smiling face. But the monstrous old man responded with a short “Yo” and swung his arm, sending everything below her shin flying.

Spinning around, Louis's white foot flew, spraying blood, and causing her to scream.

Louis: "Ah, UUUU—!"

Then, wide-eyed at the sight of Louis screaming, Subaru tried to pull her closer to him, hoping that perhaps he could help her.

Whether it was for the sake of escaping or out of concern for the girl who was crying out in pain over the loss of her foot, he did not know.

But either way, he couldn't even manage to perform that fast action right.

Subaru: "Gaguh."

Just as he thought he heard a whoosh, Subaru's throat burned with more heat than when he'd screamed. The blood gushing out of his neck clogged his throat, rendering him unable to speak or breathe.

Olbart: "Can't let'cha get away from me, it'd be too much trouble. I'm sure yer head's enough ta get through ta that foxgirl."

Having said that, Olbart's finger then pushed on Subaru's forehead. Once he did, his tilted head fell forward and Subaru's head landed on his own crumpled knees.

His head was still attached by a small flap of skin from his neck; his now-dangling head touched his lap.

Olbart: "Just like an *idakikubi*³⁹."

Unable to laugh, a terrible joke was heard, then he became unable to hear anything. And then—

Olbart: "I've heard it said that'cha and the folks of this city are awfully tough, but... Are ya tougher than the folks of my village were?"

³⁹ Translation note from Witch Cult Translations: "«Idakikubi» (抱き首), is one of the many steps of *seppuku*, performed by someone besides the one who's cutting their own stomach open. This word references the act of nearly severing the neck entirely, leaving one piece of skin left, making the head of the one who has performed *seppuku* fall onto their knees."

Yorna: “—You lowlife!”

Once more, the same voices could be heard.

He knew what had to be done right away, and pulled Louis in close, so.

So, while he thought about it, the roar of an explosion echoed.

—His vision exploded into bright-red, and, once more, the pain engulfed Natsuki Subaru.



—The moment he heard the same voices, he covered his ears, closed his eyes, and yelled out loud.

That, was the principle of survival that Subaru had come to discover after repeating those ten seconds of despair tens of times.

However, he had yet to find any solutions to this puzzle beyond that.

Olbart: “I’ve heard it said that’cha and the folks of this city are awfully tough, but... Are ya tougher than the folks of my village were?”

Yorna: “—You lowlife!”

Olbart threw a bomb, and Yorna swung her *kiseru* to deflect it. A heavy impact, felt by his feet, made Subaru remember that he had returned and what he had to do, following his ingrained instincts.

He covered his ears, closed his eyes, screamed loudly, and then took the blow of the explosion.

He kept his ears plugged for the sake of his eardrums, he kept his eyes closed for the sake of his eyeballs; he did not know what the point of shouting loudly would be, but he always shouted when he was not in pain or when everything was red, so he could not imagine not shouting anymore.

He could not bear the thought of doing something a little different and experiencing the same pain again.

Once his timing was off, he would have to repeat the ten seconds of despair ten times or more, in order to get the same chance again.

He was done with it all. The pain, the fear, he was done with them both.

It did not get any easier at all. It always hurt. He was always scared. Beyond the pain, beyond the fear, death was always there. So—

Louis: “Uau!”

With his ears and eyes fine and dandy, he caught Louis’s body as she jumped on him.

He had managed to survive the first explosion intact again for the umpteenth time. The rest was a cycle of events, recalling what would happen next, so up first was—

Subaru: “*Shurikens*.”

Olbart: “Don’t think it’s over just yet!”

Simultaneously with hearing Olbart’s voice, he remembered.

The next moment, a storm of *shurikens*, not a single one possessing the same trajectory, came flying from all directions, raining down around Subaru and Louis.

If one were to be hit by any single one of the more than ten *shurikens*, they would become unable to move.

To stop them, Yorna tried to rush out—

Yorna: “I won’t tolerate this sort—”

Subaru: “Yorna-san! It’s fine!”

Stopping Yorna from dashing in with his palm, Subaru then pointed somewhere with his outstretched hand. Then, he squeezed the hand that was tied to Louis’s with all his might,

Olbart: “—The hell’s that!?”

A moment later, their field of vision was switched by the teleport that had occurred, and a *shuriken* stuck into the place where Subaru and Louis had been.

Olbart's eyes widened in surprise at what had happened and the lack of any warning signs of Louis's teleport. Indeed, Olbart did not know of it, Subaru and Louis had been keeping it a secret.

Subaru had escaped into the Castle using it. But as he had been killed by Olbart, who had chased him down—

Subaru: "Even if it's just once..."

Olbart could be caught off-guard.

And then, much to Olbart's surprise,

Yorna: "You're not allowed to look anywhere else—!"

Olbart: "Tch— Guah."

The soaring Yorna's fierce axe kick was driven into Olbart from directly above.

His immediate reaction was delayed, and the leg he raised to intercept the attack failed to reach it in time, causing Olbart's entire body to take the impact and fold in half. With that, the back of his head crashed into the roof, and with a resounding crash, Olbart's figure disappeared into the Crimson Lapis Castle.

Even Olbart should have sustained damage due to that powerful blow—

Olbart: "Kakakakka! Ouchie, ouchie!"

Subaru: "No way!?"

Just after Subaru shouted in joy that she had scored a critical hit, Olbart returned.

Opening a hole in the roof different from the one he had been knocked into, Olbart jumped out, teeth bared and his right arm stained vermillion with blood.

He had taken Yorna's heel with his arm, hence, it had been crushed out of shape like a dead branch.

Olbart was unfazed by the terrible condition of his arm, which made Subaru want to avert his gaze immediately. With his remaining left arm, he threw *shurikens*, simultaneously aiming at Subaru and Yorna in front of and behind him.

Of course, Subaru was unable to react. So Yorna flicked smoke at the attack approaching her own self with her *kiseru* and immediately wagged her finger, causing the tiles to rise, as to protect Subaru and Louis. And then—

Olbart: “Here, it’s ninety years old.”

As he said this, Olbart suddenly resorted to violence.

He stretched out his bloodied right arm and cut it off below the elbow with the *kunai* in his left hand, sending the arm flying towards Yorna, spraying blood.

Yorna: “———”

Faced with this, Yorna was forced to make a split-second decision.

In other words, she could either parry the flying arm or dodge it. However—

Olbart: “Too bad, either choice’s off.”

Yorna: “Guhh...!?”

Before she could act on her choice out of the options for the flying arm, a blast occurred beneath Yorna’s feet. There, was the hole that led to the floor below, into which the previous blow had knocked Olbart through.

From there a tremendous torrent of wind literally spouted, tearing through Yorna’s *kimono*.

Olbart: “It’s a basic principle of the *shinobi*. If ya gotta pick between right and left, then ya gotta pick up.”

Yorna: “You, cheeky old man...!”

Yorna's cheeks scrunched up as her *kimono* was ripped open by the blades of wind that engulfed her entire body. With things as they were, she stepped in, ignoring the bluff of the flying arm, and tried to rush towards Olbart.

As Yorna advanced towards him, Olbart took a breath and spoke, "Ah yeah",

Olbart: "When I said both options were off, I lied."

—In the next instant, Olbart's flying arm swelled from the inside and exploded.

Yorna: "—Hk."

Subaru: "Yorna-san!!"

Yorna's body was blown away by the explosion that occurred right beside her. With that, Subaru widened his eyes, and raised a yell from his hoarse throat, as her figure tumbled and rolled atop the roof.

The hole he had fallen into, the arm he had severed, all of those were traps to be used.

Ever since Subaru was first acquainted to the idea of *shinobi* as *ninjas*, he'd thought that they would be extremely troublesome opponents. But it had never occurred to him that they would be so "vicious".

Almost in sync with Olbart turning around, Subaru shuddered.

Subaru: "—Louis!"

Olbart turned around, and the moment he saw the ferociousness in his eyes, Subaru shouted.

Grasping Louis's hand tightly, he hoped that the timing on the second teleport would be such that there would be no interruption. He'd just point as far away from Olbart as possible to get some distance from him—

Louis: "Auau."

Louis's teleport occurred, and both their bodies moved in the blink of an eye.

Moving out of Olbart's line of sight, they'd move somewhere, a large distance away from Olbart. Since taking refuge within the Castle would not allow them to survive, there was nothing Subaru could do after escaping the initial explosion except to keep his distance, buy some time, and hope that Yorna would stop Olbart. And---

Subaru: "Eh?"

As Subaru tried to hold back his nausea, something hit him at the tip of his foot.

His eyes shot wide open upon seeing what had hit him. It was a small, round, black ball.

A black ball that he had seen so many times, throwing him into the depths of despair.

Olbart: "I've been watchin' ya for a while. You'll fly in the direction ya point. I still got no idea how ya do that."

That's why I threw the ball in the direction ya were pointin' at, and with that, Olbart shrugged his shoulders.

That gesture from the monstrous old man was asymmetrical, given he was missing one arm.

Louis: "Uau."

Once again, Louis called out to Subaru.

Immediately afterward, light overflowed from the black ball that exploded beneath their feet, scattering countless shards of glass-like things within, shredding, shredding, and shredding Subaru and Louis to tatters.

Blood splattered bright-red, and shards flew into Subaru's eyes and mouth, mutilating his entire body as the sharp pain engulfed him, dicing his limbs into bits.

Olbart: "Ya gotta eat it ta find out what's stuck in it. Isn't that interestin'?"

The pain, once more, was red, making him question his sanity.

Olbart: “I’ve heard it said that’cha and the folks of this city are awfully tough, but... Are ya tougher than the folks of my village were?”

Yorna: “—You lowlife!”

Once more, the same voices could be heard.

Subaru: “—Hk.”

The moment he heard it, Subaru plugged his ears, closed his eyes, and opened his mouth wide. No loud shout came out. Merely a raspy voice. Even so, the roar of the explosion, and the accompanying wind, rushed towards him.

Striking his whole body, he was knocked down on his butt onto the roof. He couldn’t follow his rules. He couldn’t scream. Afraid of the pain and the red that would come. He just—

Louis: “Uau.”

A light touch made him jump, causing Subaru to let out an exhale.

And so, he checked to make sure that his eyes and ears and the rest of his body were fine. His eyeballs and eardrums were fine, despite the fact that he had not made a loud voice. His voice had nothing to do with it. Maybe his mouth was the cause.

I don’t know. I don’t know, but—

Subaru: “Guuhhh...”

Hugging Louis, Subaru sobbed through clenched teeth, unable for the life of him to find a way to survive the explosion.

And because he was incapable of finding a way, he sobbed, he cowered, he was unable to move once more.

Olbart: “Wahwah, I can’t stand hearin’ the sound of children cryin’— Shuddup.”

Yet again, inevitable death engulfed Natsuki Subaru.



Again and again, he repeated cycles of red and pain, and at their end, experiencing a sense of helplessness, of pain and harshness and suffering and fear once more; he still could not reach it, even with this accretion.

Yorna: “—Love me. Right now.”

In his mangled state, how many times had he almost gotten help in this way?

Every time he was not able to act as he was being told, he felt sad.

Louis: “Uau! Uaau!”

Desperately pulling Subaru’s arm, Louis endeavored to somehow keep him alive, to keep him from dying.

That was why it was so painful every time they died before Subaru did.

Time and time and time and time again, ten seconds of death and despair.

In the red world, the only feeling that dominated was pain; a feeling of helplessness that, irregardless of how hard he tried, he could not reach the end, no matter how many times, he repeated it with no end in sight.

His mind, felt like it was about to break. His heart, felt like it was about to die.

This, was not Return by Death.

The thing surrounding Natsuki Subaru, was something apart from Return by Death.

He did not wish to believe that Return by Death was a mercy, not in the slightest.

But compared to these ten seconds and the endless accretion of loss, it was very much so.

—This was a loveless act, so much so that it seemed like there was love in Return by Death.



Olbart: “I’ve heard it said that’cha and the folks of this city are awfully tough, but... Are ya tougher than the folks of my village were?”

Yorna: “—You lowlife!”

Once more, the same voices could be heard.

Olbart’s aloof voice and Yorna’s strained voice.

The immediate pain and loss vanished, and Subaru returned for a brief moment, for just a few seconds, to a sky of blue and a body free of pain.

Brain numbing, throat raising a continuation of the scream before death, knees buckling.

Nevertheless, the conditioned reflexes already imprinted in his soul made Subaru shut his eyes, cover his ears, and leave his mouth open as he continued to scream.

Yorna: “HaAAAAaa!!”

Yorna, howling, swung her *kiseru*, and several bursts of flame were born in the skies above Chaosflame.

The hot air, shock waves, and the sound of the explosion washed over Subaru and Louis, but at this moment, no matter how many times he tried, he could not resist falling on his butt.

Louis: “Uau!”

Subaru fell on his butt, and Louis’s light body jumped onto him.

Accepting it, he hugged it tightly. That too, was already a conditioned reflex. Because he had died god-knows how many times, he absolutely missed the warmth of people. That was all it was.

He had no other reason. He did not, and so, he clenched his molars together.

Subaru: “After this...”

There would be no time for relief, for the next attack that would kill Subaru would come rushing in.

Olbart: “Don’t think it’s over just yet!”

Alongside his words, Olbart hurled *shurikens* at Subaru and Louis. That the blades coming from all directions were more than ten, and that their sharpness could easily slice through a child’s soft skin, he already knew.

He had already experienced being killed by *shurikens* many times. But to which pain they corresponded, he could not recall. There had not been a single painless death, so he did not know.

Yorna: “I won’t tolerate this sort of debauchery.”

During his confusion, Yorna cut in with her back turned to Subaru.

She swatted away the entirety of the *shurikens* with the *kiseru* in her hand, and then, as retaliation against Olbart, she made the roof tiles undulate and hit him with the castle from both sides, pinning him down.

Olbart: “Kakakakka! What a flashy show, isn’t that an amusin’ technique!”

Olbart used his agility to sidestep the attack.

Due to Subaru’s belated reaction, the situation was following the same pattern. But there was nothing Subaru could do in this situation, a situation he had already witnessed countless times.

When Yorna was about to be attacked and he tried to protect her, when he succeeded in escaping into the Castle, when he rushed at Olbart because his head was messed up, he had died all the same.

What if all paths, all actions, led to death?

Olbart: “Well, I don’t need this flashy stuff. Ultimately, a human bein’ can be killed by a sharp needle ta the forehead.”

Yorna: “Your words make my fox ears itch— So, how about this instead?”

Olbart: “Oh.”

Yorna responded to the provocation of the nasty Olbart, by striking the roof with her heel.

One-by-one, the roof tiles arose, and what emerged was a tornado of destruction swirling around the entire Castle. He knew it was awfully powerful, as well. But it could not defeat Olbart.

Subaru: “What should...?”

I do? He could not understand. He had a presentment that painful, scary things would arrive soon, once more.

Failure. How could it be avoided? The red world, the choir of pain.

Even if he wanted to help Yorna, he would be a burden to her.

Even if Subaru attempted to run away with Louis, they would be caught.

If only he had returned to an earlier point in time, he would never have gone to the roof with Yorna in the first place. If only he had left Yorna alone, if only he had not parted with Abel and the others, if only he hadn’t told them about Louis, Al, Medium, Taritta, if only he weren’t smaller, if only it were the original Subaru, Zikr, Flop, Mizelda, Kuna, Holly, Uakata, Priscilla, Rem, Rem, Rem, Rem, Rem—

Rem, he must bring her home, and yet here he was, dying.

If Subaru were left behind in a world where death was inevitable, what could he do but continue to die forever and ever, what could Natsuki Subaru even do?

Over and over again, death, pain, and a sense of helplessness overwhelmed Natsuki Subaru.

It felt like it was going to crush his heart and body, and then—

Louis: “Uau.”

Gently, the warmth of the young girl holding his hand was transmitted, and Subaru gulped.

The warmth, suddenly, made Subaru realize.

That, for Natsuki Subaru, it was impossible, but.

Subaru: “—If everyone else were here, what would they do?”



Pain, red, scary, why, death.

Pain, red, scary, why, death. Pain, red, scary, why, death.

Pain, red, scary, why, death. Pain, red, scary, why, death. Pain, red, scary, why, death. Pain, red, scary, why, death.

Ten seconds of despair, replayed time upon time upon time.

A never-ending hell of pain and helplessness accreted on top of one another, endeavoring to break Subaru’s mind again and again.

But after so many repetitions of those ten seconds of despair, he arrived at what laid beyond.

Pain, red, scary, why, death— Beyond that.

Instead, after those ten seconds of despair many more possibilities branched out, but there still was no answer to the question of what was the how through which he could escape the pain.

Once more, Subaru died over and over again. Many times, in repeated pain and suffering, he died.

Not one of them worked.

Subaru would always make Yorna sad, let Louis die first, then die as well.

—But there was a time that laid beyond the ten seconds of despair.

He would utilize all of that time.

And even if he used all of it, and ended up dying, he would once again reach beyond the ten seconds of despair, over to the eleventh second, and think for dear life.

—If everyone else were here, what would they do?

Olbart: “I’ve heard it said that’cha and the folks of this city are awfully tough, but... Are ya tougher than the folks of my village were?”

Yorna: “—You lowlife!”

Once more, the same voices could be heard.

At that moment, Subaru covered his ears, closed his eyes, and opened his mouth to endure the explosion. The roar and the impact of the explosion assaulted his whole body; unable to resist it, he fell on his bottom.

Immediately, a small body jumped at him, shouting, “Uau!”. Catching it, he hugged them back as if to reassure them, and while doing so, he contemplated.

—If everyone else were here, what would they do?

Subaru: “———”

Subaru had become smaller.

His arms and legs had grown shorter, and the contents of his head had most likely become those of a child as well.

If he were the original Subaru, he could have done many things and come up with many more ideas. But the original Subaru was not here. So, he could not come up with a way to fix this.

As such, then this problem could not be solved by Natsuki Subaru as he was currently. That was why—

Subaru: “If everyone else were here...”

Up until now, they had encountered many problems and made many mistakes, but, together, they had overcome them in their entirety, and made it this far.

Now, Subaru was completely alone. He was in the Empire, where he knew almost no one.

However, there was something within Subaru, that he had received from everyone.

Subaru: "If everyone else were here..."

What would they do?

Otto, Garfiel, Roswaal, Frederica, Petra, Clind, Annerose, Meili, Puck, Ram, Beatrice, Emilia, what would they do?

Subaru: "If everyone else were here..."

What would they do?

Julius, Anastasia, Eridna, Ricardo, Mimi, Hetaro, Tivey, Reinhard, Felt, Rom-jii, Tonchinkan, Al, Priscilla, Wilhelm, Felix, Crusch, Liliana, Shaula, what would they do?

Subaru: "All of them are so strong."

He wanted everyone who could fight Olbart to cheer him on from behind.

It was not the turn of those people who seemed able to handle Olbart's cunning and his absurd little tricks as well. *I'm sorry. Thank you. I love you all.*

Subaru: "They can use magic."

The current Subaru could not possibly imitate everyone capable of helping Yorna.

He wanted to do something, to not become a burden to Yorna, a kind person. But, at this juncture, it was not healing magic's turn. *I'm sorry. Thank you. I love you all.*

Subaru: "If so..."

What about imitating everyone who never gave up and was able to do their utmost till the bitter end?

Why not imitate everyone who was able to use everything in their possession to try and go beyond these ten seconds of despair, go beyond the eleventh second, and go even further beyond?

Yorna: "I won't tolerate this sort of debauchery."

A *kiseru* was waved, and the *shurikens* closing in on Subaru and Louis had been flicked away with a shrill rapport.

As that happened, the tiles on either side of Olbart rose and pinned the monstrous old man down in an attempt to crush him.

Subaru: “———”

As he watched the fight between Yorna and Olbart, he thought for dear life.

Hadn't he died many times already, over and over again? Hadn't he witnessed this scene many times already? Even if it had become hard to remember, he could remember the pain, couldn't he?

Just the thought of it froze his body in horror. His heart shriveled, his soul became frightened.

It was as if the very existence of Natsuki Subaru was freezing over. But——

Louis: “Uau.”

The heat transmitted from the hand that held Subaru's own would not let him freeze to death.

And because he would not freeze to death, he would be able to remember everyone.

There was no way to interrupt Yorna and Olbart's fight.

Even if he wanted Yorna to win, Subaru and Louis, being Olbart's targets, would get in the way. The battle had already started, and this affair would not develop further without one of them being victorious.

Perhaps, it always ended with Olbart winning, and Subaru and the others dying.

So, would it be enough that Subaru and Louis just survive?

Emilia: “That's probably reaaally wrong, too. I mean, Yorna has to be kept safe, too.”

Otto: “There must be a better way.”

Garfiel: “Don't'cha stop thinkin'.”

Ram: "Truly a fool."

Roswaal: "Giving up here would be a joooke~."

Frederica: "Assuredly, everything will be fine."

Petra: "Everybody's here for you."

Meili: "You wouldn't want to be in pain, would yooou?"

Clind: "All battles must be settled. Inevitable."

Annerose: "There has to be an opening."

Beatrice: "We're going to find that opening, I suppose. That's, the key to victory, in fact."

Subaru: "The key, to victory."

For whom? Of course, for the one fighting.

Then, which one of them was fighting, Yorna or Olbart—

Subaru: "No."

Louis: "Uu?"

Subaru: "Nononono, NO—!"

In front of Louis, twisting her neck around, Subaru shouted in a loud voice.

No, I was wrong. I love all of you. So that's why—

Subaru: "The one who wins—"

Once again, the red light and pain spread before his eyes, and then—

Olbart: "I've heard it said that'cha and the folks of this city are awfully tough, but... Are ya tougher than the folks of my village were?"

Yorna: “—You lowlife!”

Once more, the same voices could be heard.

The moment he heard them, Subaru covered his ears, closed his eyes, and crouched down with his mouth open. Immediately afterward, the sound of an explosion and a shock wave smashed against his whole body, but this time he did not fall on his bottom.

In an instant movement, he removed his hands from his face and raised his head. And from there—

Louis: “Uau.”

With concern for Subaru, Louis jumped at him with a worried look on her face.

Catching Louis in front of him in his arms, Subaru took action right there. And,

Subaru: “Thanks.”

Louis: “Uh?”

As he looked towards his front, the words Subaru had spoken went over the surprised Louis’s head completely.

The pain of his whole body being burned, of his bones being exposed, of his internal organs being mangled, was lingering still. He felt like he was going to scream, cry, and roll around if were he to not control himself. However—

Olbart: “Don’t think it’s over—!”

As he said this, Olbart was just about to throw the *shurikens* he’d pulled out of his sleeves.

Olbart’s eyes met those of Subaru head-on.

The eyes of the Vicious Old Man, someone devoid of mercy even in reaping the life of children. And the teary eyes of a child who had experienced despair many times, still struggling to hold back the tears.

As if he had seen something in those eyes, Olbart turned to him, the glint within his yellow eyes becoming even more intense.

He was not just aiming for Subaru as a tool to get Yorna's attention.

To murder Natsuki Subaru, the Vicious Old Man unleashed *shurikens* from his hands.

Shurikens with no trick to them flew.

Subaru's eyes couldn't perceive the threat, but he could feel them closing in on him; and so he thrust his lifted finger straight towards his front—to Olbart.

If everyone else were here, what would they do?

Thinking for his dear life of what everyone else would feel, he'd had a thought.

No matter how tattered he was, being plagued by the feeling of powerlessness, failing utterly, everyone placed faith in Subaru.

Regardless of how shameless, how unsightly the way he'd died was, in pain, with harshness, fear, crying, screaming, wetting himself, everyone placed faith in Subaru.

I love all of you.

Up on the top of the Crimson Lapis Castle, was this game to reach past the ten seconds of despair, and the eleventh second beyond that, and further on, dying over and over again; *and, the one who wins is—*

—The one who wins is always you, Master!

Subaru: "Louiiiiis—!!"

Pointing to Olbart, he called out the name of the girl at the end of the linkage of warmth.

Then, he squeezed Louis's hand tightly and forcefully— instantly, the world changed.

Olbart: "—What the!?"

The opponent he was supposed to kill with his *shurikens* disappeared, causing Olbart to shout in astonishment.

That was an illegal technique, one outside Olbart's understanding that went wholly unnoticed by the cautious *shinobi*. The sole way to outsmart Olbart was the first use of this teleport, as he would be able to respond the second time it were employed.

And Subaru, who was teleported by Louis's power and flown—

Subaru: "AHHHHHH—!"

Olbart: "Huoh?"

Resolutely, Subaru clung to the back of Olbart's head, that was right in front of him.

He clung to the small old man in a desperate attempt to survive, not letting go of him, clutching at his gray hair with all his strength. The moment of the teleport was unexpected to the point that even Olbart was unable to react to being grappled.

The small Subaru did his best to cling to the old man, who was not much taller than him.

Naturally, Olbart tried to pull him off of himself, and Yorna, suddenly awestruck, tried to run over to them.

Olbart: "Whoa! T-the hell's that! Boy!?"

Yorna: "Children! Get away now! Old Man Olbart's..."

Olbart's arm grabbed Subaru's hair and tried to pull him down forcefully. Although she wished to stop that, Yorna feared meddling in that attempt, delaying her move.

Taking little notice of the pair's reactions, while desperately clinging onto him, Subaru raised his voice—

Subaru: "—My win!"

And, shouted.

Olbart: "—What?"

At that moment, Olbart's hand loosened as he tried to pull Subaru away, and Yorna's eyes went wide, and looked over at him, wondering what she had just said.

Not paying attention to the reaction of the adults around him, Subaru clung on tightly to Olbart, refusing to let him go.

Subaru: "My win... It's my win! It's Olbart-san's loss! Isn't it!?"

Olbart: "But, what are ya sayin'..."

Subaru: "You said we only needed to do it once!"

Olbart: "Huh?"

As the energy he was putting in to shake him free petered out, Subaru finally raised his face and spoke to the back of Olbart's gray head in front of him. Sobbing both tears and leaking snot from the excitement and his racing heart, Subaru's throat twitched.

Subaru: "T-the game of tag! In hide-and-seek, we were supposed to find you three times... But in tag, we were supposed to catch you once..."

Olbart: "———"

Subaru: "That's why! It's my win! I caught you! This game's my win! Olbart-san, Yorna-san, you both lost to me! That's why, it's my *ween*⁴⁰——"

He thought to himself, that he was saying some absurd reasoning.

In the first place, Subaru and the others had been the ones to choose to play hide-and-seek as opposed to tag. To do something such as suddenly changing the rules of the game of tag was unfair.

It was unfair, but he still couldn't come up with any other method. Besides——

Subaru: "It was Olbart-san who cheated first..."

⁴⁰ Translation note from Witch Cult Translations: "The misspelling is intentional."

Olbart: “——”

Subaru: “S-so that’s why, I’m telling you, i-it’s my win——”

Little-by-little, the tears and runny nose that came pouring out of his eyes became unbearable, and his voice became raspy.

Despite that, Subaru poured strength into his clinging arms, not letting go of his sly victory. He had caught Olbart and won the game of tag. He had won.

Yorna: “——What will you do now, Old Man Olbart?”

Suddenly, Yorna asked that of Olbart, who had fallen silent.

Glancing over, Yorna relit the tip of her *kiseru* and let out a plume of fresh purple smoke. Her appearance as she took it into her lungs was as beautiful as before she started fighting.

Still, depending on Olbart’s answer, she would be willing to fight for and protect Subaru and Louis, with whom she had little to no connection.

And that wasn’t the last of Olbart’s troubles.

Louis: “Uau! Aa, uu!”

Olbart: “Thaaat hurts.”

While Subaru was still clinging to Olbart, Louis, who had travelled with him, stomped on Olbart’s foot. Louis glared at Olbart, her round eyes narrowed to their fullest.

In response to Subaru’s complaint, Yorna’s question, and Louis’s glare, Olbart was silent for a moment, then violently scratched at his own head. And then——

Olbart: “I’m the one who said he didn’t like the idea of throwin’ away a game he’s set in motion halfway thro’. Didn’t expect it ta be abused this way.”

Yorna: “——Is that your answer, Old Man?”

Yorna’s words were quiet, her eyes lowering to meet Olbart’s.

Nothing happened. Because Olbart had plopped down on the spot, sitting cross-legged. With Subaru clinging onto his back, Olbart, flashed a toothy grin and said,

Olbart: “Kakakakka! Anyone can see I’ve lost. If I said somethin’ like whether I win or lose doesn’t matter, then I wouldn’t be a *shinobi*, I’d be an animal.”

After saying that, Olbart slapped his knee with his hand with “I lost I lost!”, looking up at the sky.

Under the blue sky, atop of the beautiful, slowly-mending castle, one second, two seconds, beyond the ten seconds of despair, from the eleventh second onward, the future was quietly, surely, being etched—

Subaru: “It’s, my wiiiiiiin...!”

Subaru’s nose went *sniff-sniff*, and while sobbing he continued raising complaints.

Listening to Subaru clinging to his back, Olbart let out a “Kakakakka!”, and smiling,

Olbart: “If ya keep sayin’ that, I’m gonna get angry— Shuddup.”

And so, he tapped Subaru’s forehead with his hand.



Illustration from Volume 29, coloring by Setowi ([source](#))

Arc 7 Chapter 54 - The Utopia of Chaosflame

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 29, Chapter 8 “The Utopia of Chaosflame”

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Edited Machine Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Original by Goldkills, Kiln, SapphireComet,
Translation checked by MaskedBook, [Ice/Ice Occultism](#)) — [Complete](#)

Subaru: “Uh, ugh, uhh... Hk.”

Olbart: “Yeah, yeah, the snivellin’ brat’s cryin’, you’re such a handful, ya know.”

Sniffing his nose, Subaru was unable to stop his crying fit. With the boy latched to his back, Olbart gave a shrug of his shoulders, with nothing else to do but scratch at his cheek with a finger.

—It had been a dreadful, dreadful experience.

Those ten seconds of despair that had happened to Subaru, and the eleventh second that followed after overcoming that despair— to get here, just how many deaths had he experienced?

Through despair and heartbreak, it was a miracle that his worn-down spirit seemed to not have completely vanished.

But after such a hellish experience, he had finally reached the end.

Louis: “Uauu.”

Clinging to Subaru’s arm as he cried without end, Louis groaned.

Not that she’d had the same experience as Subaru, that of trial-and-error repeated more times than he could count, but Louis had suffered the same fate as Subaru many times over, having lost her life.

Jumping onto Olbart’s back in order to reach such a flimsy victory, would not have been possible without her presence.

Subaru: “I... Really, I don’t get you.”

Louis: “Uu.”

Subaru: “But without you, it wouldn’t have been possible... Thank you.”

Those were the feelings in Subaru’s heart, albeit in a complete chaotic mess.

He knew that Louis was guilty of various things, he knew in what way he and her were connected. He knew it, yet he was still overflowing with feelings of gratitude

And, it was not only Subaru’s gratitude that was overflowing.

Louis: “Ua, uh...”

Subaru: “Louis?”

The dam’s burst was sudden.

Having heard Subaru’s faltering words of gratitude, tears slowly welled up in Louis’s big round eyes, then trickled down her cheeks in the blink of an eye.

Pling-pling, tears fell down Louis’s cheeks, with such momentum that she did not know how to halt their course.

Subaru: “Louis, you’re crying, you’re really crying...”

Louis: “Uu, uu!”

Louis herself knew she was crying, yet did not attempt to stop or wipe away the tears that streamed down her face. All the while, she remained clung on to Subaru’s arm with a desperate look; one would have expected her to stop so she could wipe away her tears.

Subaru: “Your face, wipe it, you idiot, idiiiot...”

Seeing Louis cry like that, Subaru, who had tried to soothe down his emotional swings, was likewise on the verge of it himself. The tears that had been shed, the visible sobs, were by now innumerable.

It was like the pair made up of him and Louis would, at this rate, be crying forever and ever, without being able to stop---

Yorna: “---Well done, you did your best, you two.”

Subaru: “Ah...”

Yorna: “However much you cry isn’t an issue. I’ll allow you to do it, as the Lord of this Demon City.”

Long arms extended from behind Subaru and Louis, and tenderly embraced them.

The warmth and softness of those words made Subaru’s eyes widen in surprise, he became entranced by the beautiful profile near him. With long eyelashes, vermillion lips, and glimmering azure eyes that put one at ease, no matter the troubles and suffering; it was so sublime that it enthralled those who laid eyes upon it.

He already knew what type of person the owner of those eyes was.

Therefore, he knew that in her words and warmth both, there was kindness devoid of anything untoward behind it.

Because he knew that even if he entrusted everything to them, he would be forgiven.

Subaru: “Uh, guh... ah, uh, AAAaah!”

Louis: “Uau... Uauhk, ua, uh, uau...!”

Yorna: “There, there... Children have the privilege to cry, the privilege to cling onto an adult’s chest. It’s okay if you use my bosom, you may weep as many tears as you need.”

Looking up, tears flowed down Subaru’s face once more. Louis embraced Subaru as he was.

Holding them both together tenderly in her arms, Yorna patted their small backs. All the while, at that moment, at the end of the battle that had unfolded up on the castle tower of the Crimson Lapis Castle---

Olbart: “I dunno what kinda face I should be makin’ here ‘cause all this is happenin’ on my back.”

Yorna: “Silence.”

With that, the boorish interruption from the monstrous old man was shushed by the Lord of the Demon City.



Yorna: “So, how do you explain yourself, Old Man Olbart?”

Olbart: “Explain myself? Did I make any excuses? You’re the one who attacked me ‘cause of yer mood, right, foxgirl?”

Yorna: “———”

Shortly after Subaru had cried his eyes out, this time, they would have a calm conversation— so he’d thought, when the castle tower was abruptly engulfed by a precarious atmosphere.

Needless to say, the cause was the aloof and unapologetic one, Olbart.

Sitting on the roof, picking at his ear canal with the tip of his pinky,

Olbart: “I kinda did what I was told, yeah? Well, I did try ta use a few loopholes, but look, that boy called us even, aight?”

Subaru: “Ugh... B-but, that’s...”

Olbart: “Now now, ya should listen ta me, boy— ’Cause whatever ya say, I’m the one who’ll have the most ta gain. Kakakakka!”

Subaru stammered as Olbart opened his mouth open wide and roared with laughter.

In fact, Olbart was right. If Subaru were to argue against Olbart’s misuse of the rules here, it would turn into a no-holds-barred situation that ignored the rules as a result, probably making them unable to defeat the *shinobi* Olbart in any sort of manner.

Olbart had plenty of hidden techniques, and did not hesitate in dragging others into it. Since coming to the Empire, Subaru'd had more than enough experiences to know that such opponents were the number one in toughness.

Subaru: "Olbart-san, you sound similar to one of the scariest bastards I know..."

Olbart: "Really? In that case, ya should definitely kill me. I'm no decent fella, and will be a serious pain in the ass."

Yorna: "In that case, Old Man Olbart, you must agree with me that I should stop you from breathing here."

Olbart: "Oioi, that's a lotta hate for me. Well, that's only natural."

The air was tingling, ripe with tension, but this was due to the one-sided hostility that Yorna had unleashed.

Olbart, the party it was directed at, was no longer in a fighting stance. Of course, this was just for show, and he could turn the switch back on in an instant.

Nevertheless, it was natural for Yorna to be angry, as Subaru held strong anger towards Olbart as well. However, there was a big reason as to why he could not act on that anger.

That was, because of his shrunken limbs, and his head that was not functioning properly.

Subaru: "Olbart-san, about the technique that's being used on us..."

Olbart: "Oh yeah, that's right. Of course, ya can't fix it if I'm dead. No, there might be another way, but I've never seen anyone do it."

Subaru: "I knew it...!"

Olbart: "Well, it's like an insurance policy. It's supposed ta be a secret technique back at my village, so basically, we deal with the dead bodies without leavin' any traces so that they don't come ta light."

Quite indifferently, Olbart spoke some disturbing words.

At the same time, Subaru congratulated himself for having walked a really dangerous tightrope.

Even if Yorna defeated Olbart, and the old man died, the “infantilization” that had befallen Subaru and his friends would have remained unresolved. His state would always be that of being Natchuki Subawu.

Just thinking about it made Subaru shudder.

Yorna: “I don’t know the details, but I’ve heard that you’ve treated these children in a cruel way.”

Yorna looked at Olbart as she put the *kiseru* in her mouth and filled her lungs with purple smoke.

When asking her for help, Subaru had given her as much honest information as he could, but he left out the nitty-gritty details of their situation. That included the fact that Subaru had been shrunk due to the influence of Olbart’s technique.

Once Olbart dissolved the “infantilization”, Subaru would return to his original body.

Once that happened, he would do his utmost to apologize and ask Yorna for forgiveness— Of course, he didn’t think that’d be enough to completely reverse her impression of the situation.

He would like to think that Yorna was the kind of person who would see reason with just words.

Yorna: “Old Man Olbart, you’ve conceded defeat in your earlier match, right?”

Olbart: “Yeah, I admit it, I admit it. For sure, it’s a complete loss. At least, I’m lucky I didn’t die losin’. But I didn’t think I’d lose.”

Yorna: “It was unexpected that you’d lose?”

Olbart: “I thought it’d definitely be the boy’s boss who’d gimme a good challenge.”

Paying no heed to Subaru’s concern, Yorna and Olbart proceeded with their conversation. Yorna whispered, “Boss”, quoting Olbart, and gently, sliding her hand into her *kimono*,

Yorna: “The sender of the missive, right? I’ve been looking forward to meeting him, but...”

Suddenly, Yorna cut off her words and narrowed her eyes at Olbart.

Olbart tilted his head at the sharpness of her gaze and uttered, “What is it?”

Olbart: “There’s nothin’ scarier than bein’ stared at by a beautiful woman. What’s the hubbub?”

Yorna: “For crying out loud! I told Tanza to deliver a message to all the messengers, for them to come to the Castle— Well, where’s Tanza off to?”

The air quickly chilled, to the point that Subaru felt like he was going to choke.

Yorna’s anger was always unleashed when harm was done to a resident of the city, or a child. This was even more so in Tanza’s case, who met both requirements by being a resident of the city and a child.

Nevertheless, Subaru suspected that Tanza had conspired with Olbart to prevent his own party from meeting Yorna. He would have to be careful how he approached this. However—

Subaru: “I also thought Tanza was with Olbart-san. But she’s not... Right? Is she hiding under some tiles or something...”

Yorna: “The Castle’s insides are much like my own. There’s no chance I’d miss someone entering or hiding within it.”

Subaru: “R-right. Yorna-san’s technique is amazing...”

Hearing Yorna’s self-assured answer, Subaru flinched at her unusual nature.

After wincing, Subaru realized that he and Louis had trespassed the Crimson Lapis Castle via the teleport, and that Yorna had found them immediately afterward.

At that time, Yorna had stated that she was walking through the Castle and found them by chance, but he guessed that was just a ruse. Truth was, she had noticed that Subaru and Louis had abruptly appeared in the Castle and moved to catch the intruders.

Perhaps the reason why she had not captured them right away, and instead treated Subaru and Louis as Tanza’s friends, was because she had not been able to decide how to treat the two of them, Subaru and Louis, who were so young.

After all, ever since they had first met, Yorna had been protecting them.

Subaru: “———”

The more he came into contact with Yorna’s personality, the more intense were Subaru’s feelings of doubt on whether he should involve her in the great battle of the Vollachian Empire.

The same went for his feelings towards the people living in Chaosflame, the so-called “horned races”, who had obstructed Subaru’s group along the way.

They wanted to protect the safe haven they had finally found, after so much suffering and ostracism.

Could Subaru’s group blame them for wanting to resume their peaceful lives? Especially considering their Lord cherished them.

—What was the difference between this, and the world desired by the girl Subaru liked?

Subaru: “———”

In silence, Subaru looked down from the castle tower, at the disorderly townscape of the Demon City.

A city where everything was chaotic, intricate, in a horrible mess, and without a sense of unity. Upon first arriving at this city, he had been bewildered by its disorder.

But after meeting Yorna and the people of this city, even if for a short time, Subaru had one thought.

Here, there was freedom.

There was freedom here, no need for a person to submit to someone, unbound by anyone. Ergo, one could express themselves as they wished, this overflowing chaos going undenied by anyone.

It was free, equal, and fair.

It seemed to him that a somewhat ideal picture of the future had been illustrated here.

Was it really the right thing to do, to pry Yorna away from such a place?

Yorna: “Old man, answer me. Where’s that girl, Tanza?”

Paying no heed to Subaru’s internal conflict, she continued to question Olbart.

Tanza was not inside the Castle. He'd like to believe that Olbart didn't have a technique to make a person small enough to put them in his pocket.

Olbart: “No need ta have such a scary look on yer face, I’ll tell ya what I know. The only reason I made a deal with that deergirl was ‘cause I had just the right conditions to use her for the match.”

Yorna: “—Where is she?”

Yorna's repeated questions were driven into Olbart, expressing that there was no need for superfluous talk.

In response, while tilting his head, Olbart turned his gaze towards the land surrounding the Castle—towards the Demon City, as if he were taking in the superb view,

Olbart: "It's not that hard ta guess. I'm an outsider, ya know? There's only so many places where I can hide a single girl."

That was his response.



—Just as Olbart had cracked under Yorna's questioning, a little bit earlier.

Within the Demon City of Chaosflame, in one of its inns.

Neither was it large, nor was it very ornately decorated— However, in fact, the walls and interior of the building were robustly constructed, and seldom did a sound ever pass through.

In Chaosflame, this was the only place where the atmosphere was so different from the rest of the city, prepared as an unlikely contingency as accommodations for VIPs.

The room that became the setting was a spacious one, said spaciousness resulted from its interior design being that of three rooms with their walls removed as to join them together. Even within the people that used this travelers' inn, only a handful of them held the standing to be able to stay in such a spacious room.

There were no high-quality furnishings, no numerous works of art to delight one's eyes, and no sort of fine alcohol available to soothe one's palate, as many of the people who made use of this inn were of an utilitarian sort.

In a sense, this inn's standing within Chaosflame was different.

The Demon City, with its popular name of "Land of Unlawfulness", was worthy of being a symbol of "freedom". Despite its chaotic existence, under Yorna, the Ruler of the Demon City, the inhabitants of Chaosflame were remarkably unified in their will.

For those who shared a common vision, who did not tolerate foreign invaders, who had no mind to give mercy to those with their own troubles, there was no need for the kind of preparations that this inn offered. Certainly—

???: "—The people of the Empire must be strong, that is the core tenet that this city of demons has overturned."

???: "Ah..."

???: "To some extent, governance is left to city leadership. But there are limits— Is it because they do not know their limits, that they operate like this?"

As a man with crossed arms inquired this, the girl of small stature stiffened her cheeks and kept silent.

The man to question that of her, donning an outfit that combined red and black, his face concealed by an oni mask, was Abel. The demi-human girl bearing antlers opposite to him, wearing a beautiful *kimono* with her arms put through its sleeves, was Tanza.

In this city a face-to-face between two people with a presumably hostile relationship was happening.

—Nay; to be more precise, Abel and Tanza were not the only two meeting face-to-face.

???: "You all, you have stepped in here knowing what kind of place you are in...!"

Abel: "———"

???: "Answer me! Depending on your response, not a bone of yours will remain!"

Yelling so, was a man with dark skin reddening with wrath, General Second-Class of the Imperial Army, Kafma Irulux. Those words were directed at Abel, who had marched into the room, and the boy and girl who accompanied him.

He had nothing in his outstretched hand, but he had no need for a weapon. Any armaments were literally nestled within Kafma's own body.

That he would not leave any bone remaining was no mere declaration of a threat, but the truth.

—Because that was the true value of Kafma Irulux, the Fighting Insect General.

???: "Oi, Abel-chan, you serious?"

That voice, visibly strained with strong vigilance, came from a masked boy just before Kafma and his vigor; Al. He carried on his back a weapon he could not handle, the *dao*, and once he spoke, Abel glanced back at him, and,

Abel: "You, how many times shall you inquire that before you make up your mind?"

Al: "I'm asking that question again and again because, after you strolled, the jury's still out on it. I mean, this is insane! Shit, I dunno why I followed you either...!"

Abel: "It should be obvious— The current you is too much of a coward to be alone."

Al: "Guh... Hk."

Unable to speak further, Al was incapable of getting out any words beyond that. It was a reaction that revealed instantly that Abel had hit the bullseye. Yet the fact that Al could not even argue with him made it evident that he himself was aware of this.

For some reason, Al was currently no longer able to keep his composure for even a walk down the street.

???: "Abel-chin."

Another companion, Medium, called out to Abel to protest on the behalf of Al, who was at a loss for words.

Medium, who walked alongside Abel with much effort, was protecting the now-useless Al; however, her facial expression appeared to have somewhat of a strong gloom to it.

All of this and more, had happened after becoming separated from Subaru and Louis midway through.

Medium: "I don't think that's a very nice way to put it."

Abel: "Do you think, in this situation, we shall reach a mutual understanding with roundabout words? You and that clown both should be more conscious of the situation. One erroneous move, and, just as declared, not one bone shall remain."

Medium: "All the more reason! You shouldn't talk like that, it's no good!"

Abel: "——"

Medium: "'Cause you talk like that, Abel-chin, Subaru-chin and Louis-chan..."

She refused potently once, but afterwards her words tapered off.

That was inevitable, due to Medium's own nature. Albeit she wished to blame Abel for all the problems that had arisen, she was far too compassionate to do that.

She understood clearly that her own attitude and gaze had been the factors that had driven Subaru and Louis to the brink. That, in turn, was likely a result of the education her brother had given her.

In any case, Al and Medium both were dysfunctional.

Abel: "Ergo, we do not intend to quarrel either. Put down your arm, Kafma Irulux."

Kafma: "Are you... insane? You did not answer my question, just being stubborn in trying to follow your own will. With that conduct, do you believe yourself to be a king?"

Abel: "—You are not far off the mark."

Kafma: "You—!"

Kafma's eyes became bloodshot, his anger, as someone with high loyalty towards the Emperor, reaching its limit.

By chance, Kafma came half a step short from coming into contact with the truth regarding the true nature of Abel's identity. That was the strength of the effect of "cognitive disruption" held by the oni mask obtained in the Shudraqian village.

In rough terms, with the exception of those whom the wearer intended to reveal his true identity, and those already possessing absolute certainty regarding the true identity of the one donning it, no one was able to see beyond the effects of the mask. In other words---

Kafma: "Enough, I cannot take any more of this farce of bringing kids along! Regardless of what happened yesterday..."

???: "---Calm down, Kafma Irulux."

Filling his arms with strength, the tattoo patterns on Kafma's arm writhed. That impulse of his was stopped dead in its tracks by a voice behind him.

Kafma's eyes widened as he turned around; there, at the back of the room, the figure of a good-looking man sporting onyx hair was located, sitting leisurely in an armchair.

With black hair and black eyes, his dignified and exceptionally well-defined face was as if it saw through anything and everything in its path, unwavering in front of those uninvited guests.

Truly, Abel was impressed with how well the "mask" had been made.

Paying no heed to Abel's admiration, the handsome man in the back looked at each of the three, Abel included,

???: "There is no hostility within them. At least, in these circumstances."

Kafma: "But, Your Excellency! The insolence of this person, to not display their face before Your Excellency, not to speak that a feeling of reverence is not being displayed altogether, is that of a scoundrel's! Moreover, coming along with children..."

???: "What about it?"

Kafma: "No, coming with children in tow, makes very little sense...!"

Kafma, unable to hide all his pronounced bewilderment, fought his anguish as he rubbed his temples.

To begin with, the man named Kafma had a bad habit of taking things too seriously. It was one thing to take things in earnest, but it was another to add to the room's worry.

With his excess of seriousness as pretext, he had rejected a position as one of the Nine Divine Generals for feeling himself unworthy— Henceforth, barring his character, he was the owner of ability on par with that of the Nine Divine Generals.

Even if no one had fallen victim to Olbart's wily ways, and even if Taritta had accompanied them to this place, fighting a proper battle with Kafma as an opponent was an impossibility.

But on this point, the battle was in favor of Abel and his team. That was—

Abel: "I apologize for disturbing your sleeping quarters, but my business is with the girl there. At the present moment, I have no intention of bothering myself with you."

Girl: "Na... Hk."

???: "Ho. This one does talk up a big game before me. I shall commit that face and that voice to memory. Even more so if you truly are related to the envoy we happened upon at the castle tower yesterday."

Abel: "Hmm."

Snorting, Abel touched the chin of the oni mask while his opponent stared back at him— the one who Subaru had labeled a false Emperor, and whom Abel knew as Chisha Gold, now assuming the form of Vincent.

Right beside Abel, Al and Medium carried complex frowns. The pair, as they were excluded from the effects of the "cognitive disruption", were witnessing an exchange of words between Vincents possessing exactly the same voices.

The disguise of the White Spider, Chisha, was flawless.

With his voice and his conduct, there was no one else in the world that could perform a substitution of Vincent Vollachia as skillfully as Chisha Gold.

Rather, even contradictory thoughts such as him being more like Vincent than Abel was, could arise. However—

Abel: “I have heard about how you responded to my subordinates. For the stern Emperor of Vollachia, you have been considerably magnanimous in forgiving the disrespect of an impudent woman.”

Vincent: “Even so, I am not enough of an eccentric to deal with people who do not know their place. But, if I properly recognize their relative value, they shall be treated accordingly. At any rate—”

Vincent responded to Abel’s sarcasm, and once there was a pause in the former’s words, their gazes intersected in midair, then their lips moved simultaneously.

Abel & Vincent: “—The people of the Empire must be strong.”

Indeed. That was the philosophy of the Sacred Vollachian Empire, their symbolic way of life.

The answer, from the ones fit as Emperors of Vollachia, that dealt adequately with those who had displayed a will to oppose them, could be said to be nothing but a magnificent one indeed.

Even if Abel had been asked the same question, he would have given the same answer.

No matter what laid within his heart.

Vincent: “Kafma, that girl there?”

Kafma: “Yes. Master Olbart requested of me to keep her at the inn... Said Master has since gone out into town, and has yet to return.”

Vincent: “I see.”

Kafma responded with an awkward look on his face, and, nodding at his reply, Vincent’s gaze now turned to Tanza.

The little girl, a tiny being in the corner of the room, let out an “Ah” as she attempted to devote herself to her duty and at least conceal herself, but her shoulders trembled at the sight of the one looking down from the pinnacle of the Empire.

Tanza's reaction could not be described as neither timid nor frightened. Vincent, taking that in as inevitable,

Vincent: "Olbart's involvement, yesterday's agreement with Yorna Mishigure. In addition, the one associated with yesterday's envoys has appeared looking for you, no less. I get the sense of the overall picture."

Tanza: "I-I..."

Vincent: "Excuses are unnecessary. Of course, Olbart shall relay to me what happened in your stead, as I am not your master. Additionally, neither am I your enemy."

Tanza: "Ah..."

Vincent: "Once you have initiated a battle, it is fine to fight it to your utmost earnestness, till the very end. Hence whether your destiny is to burn or not, remains your decision."

Indifferently, Vincent declared to Tanza that he would not provide any further protection.

If one were to believe, however, that this had made Tanza feel the despair she had abandoned, that would be a mistake.

Tanza: "———"

Dwelling in Tanza's round eyes was the same light, perhaps the same flame of determination, the same beacon that dwelled at the time she had decided to take on that battle, that challenge.

That Tanza's life, as someone belonging to the horned races, had never been peaceful nor cheerful in the least, was a simple, yet plausible guess for Abel. Not to mention that, on the matter of the deerpeople from Chaosflame, that race had been the root cause for a rebellion raised by Yorna Mishigure previously.

Rather, it would not be surprising if Tanza herself was related to any of those casualties.

Tanza: "Vincent-sama, I apologize for the inconvenience. However, this occasion was not brought about by Yorna-sama, I was the one who orchestrated it."

Vincent: “As I said just now, excuses are unnecessary. The facts, I shall inquire of Yorna Mishigure. You may cease speaking yourself.”

Tanza: “Yes. Thank you very much.”

Tanza rectified her posture, then proffered a deep bow towards Vincent. Once she looked up, Tanza’s gaze then turned towards Abel and the others.

Unlike the gaze directed at Vincent, this one was clearly hostile.

Al: “—Hk.”

Due to that girl’s aura, Al’s throat rasped, despite his attempts to restrain himself.

He was a coward to the extreme, but it was also true that that aura was loaded with such fighting spirit that it made him feel pressure. And so, one could only imagine what circumstances had led her to torment herself this much. All of this—

Tanza: “—Please, do not bring Yorna-sama into this war. She is a kind woman, who will surely fight for the sake of the weak masses, no matter how hurt or worn down she may get. Such a thing, I could never overlook. Yorna-sama is everything to me.”

Medium: “Ah...”

Tanza: “Please, please grant this favor. Please...!”

With a small tremor in her words, Tanza’s plea caused Medium to widen her eyes.

It seemed that, to Al and Medium, Tanza’s motives had been unexpected. By far, the goal of the residents who had attacked them on their way here was maintaining the situation of the people of the horned races.

If they lost the protection of Yorna Mishigure, they would lose the safe haven that was the Demon City of Chaosflame, and would resume the long hard days of traveling in the wilderness. That was their fear.

That sentiment was probably held by a considerate portion of the residents of the Demon City.

But on the other hand, the likelihood that the feelings of most of the Demon City's residents favored Tanza was something Abel was well aware of.

And what convinced him of that, was that the Soul Marriage Technique had spread across the people of the city.

That was a secret technique that could not be formed by one-sided feelings.

If the residents loathed it, the mechanism that tied a vast number of people together would have driven them to madness; but since that was not the case, it only provided definite confirmation for the thoughts Abel had carried from the start.

Abel: "Yorna Mishigure shall be the one to decide. Bowing your head towards me shan't make a difference."

Kafma: "—Hk, you."

For some reason, Kafma's anger flared up at Abel's response, the latter with arms crossed.

There was most likely no direct relationship to Tanza, but likely the man held some amount of affection for the girl due to her youth. In that respect, by and large, this was a man who could be described as being of the same ilk as Yorna.

And in regard to the true essence of the Demon City alone, that which was visible to Tanza, was not to Kafma. Hence, she kept her head down and continued.

Tanza: "No, she is not. It is not Yorna-sama's decision to make, it is yours."

Abel: "——"

Tanza : "Yorna-sama's heart is vast and deep, she is a kind person... and, we attendants can only gaze at that unbelievably far dream, unable to help. The means to grant that dream, you must possess them, surely."

Abel: "...The missive for Yorna Mishigure, are you aware of its contents?"

Tanza: "No."

Having shaken her head, Tanza denied Abel's suspicions. However, Tanza ceased shaking her head in front of him, instead casting it downward with a terribly fragile expression on her face,

Tanza: "Still, I understand— Ahh, to witness Yorna-sama with the face of a maiden, for the first time."

Abel: "The face of a maiden, is it."

Tanza: "Yorna-sama, responds to the love directed at her. But for her to show that appearance of a maiden-in-love to someone... The reason would be no less than the answer to that letter."

Abel: "Yorna Mishigure would not refuse, so you interfered. Therefore."

Tanza: "—Yes. All of it was my plan."

With her head sunken deeply, Tanza confessed to her plot.

All of it was not correct. Undoubtedly, Olbart must have had a hand in Tanza's scheme, and distorted it to something more vicious.

However, Tanza intended to take responsibility not only for what she herself had started and what her will had led her to do, but also for whatever part Olbart had been involved in.

It was all too—

Abel: "—Beautiful."

And so, an inaudible voice took form only within someone's mouth, and went unheard by anyone.

Naturally, it went unheard by all; not even by Tanza, who bowed her head, nor by Al and Medium, both on-guard, nor by Kafma, who held back his anger, nor by Vincent, who rested his hand on his chin.

Abel: "I have a grasp regarding your participation. But, how does this matter?"

Tanza: "—How, why..."

Abel: “Even after divulging your heart of hearts, you could continue your scheme if you desired. Even if you are beheaded, the residents of the Demon City shall still target my group— No, if you are beheaded in the first place, Yorna Mishigure’s cooperation shall not be obtained.”

Tanza: “———”

Abel: “Or perhaps, having your own head lopped off was a measure you were willing to take?”

Casting her gaze downwards, a slight tension ran up Tanza’s neck. Having observed this, Abel was convinced that Tanza had left the option of taking her own life on the table.

Suffice to say, it was well thought-out— Although there were a few things to ponder over until it could be put into action.

Al: “So you were gonna put your life on the line... You’re one hell of a girl.”

Medium: “No way! I won’t let you, ever! You won’t let her, will you, Abel-chin?”

At the revelation of the extent of Tanza’s resolution, Al was at a loss for words, as Medium probed Abel.

In case Abel voiced something contrary to her feelings, while the posture that Medium would adopt was something to be considered, it was a thought that may be regarded as meaningless.

Abel: “I should have already spoken such. If her own death is one of the measures she was willing to take, then taking her life would fulfill those plans. Unfortunately, I hold no interest in partaking in such schemes.”

Medium: “Abel-chin...!”

Abel: “People should die in a more efficient manner.”

Medium: “Abel-chin...”

A pawn that operated according to their own agenda was a nuisance, regardless of whether they were one’s own camp or the enemy’s.

Taking that into account, the being known as Tanza was a poison beyond their control. However, unless one was steeled to drink said poison, one would be unable to introduce stronger poisons.

Having made his decision, Abel fixed his gaze on Tanza, sitting on the floor, and said,

Abel: "I have no intention to take your life. But, I shall order you to call off the orders you gave your brethren."

Tanza: "...So then, about my earlier request."

Abel: "To not bring Yorna Mishigure into this war, hmm? —That is impossible."

Tanza: "—Hk!"

Abel made a clear, definitive statement, and Tanza was rendered speechless.

From her point of view, it was the announcement of a future event that she wished would not pass, even if that meant that she had to sacrifice her own life. However, that was Tanza's misconception. And it was a hopelessly mistaken desire. Because—

Abel: "Even if I had not shown up, Yorna Mishigure would have been engulfed in the maelstrom of war. That is the position she has taken, making it unavoidable."

Tanza: "What in the world do you see..."

Abel: "I shan't speak to others of what is reflected in my eyes. However, I have measures for any possibility. No matter how it appears to those around me."

While responding to the quivering Tanza, his eyes trained on her own, Abel abruptly took his gaze off the girl.

Instead, his dark eyes turned towards the silent Vincent, stock-still at the back of the room. Now sitting atop the throne of the Emperor, was the false Emperor, Vincent Vollachia.

No matter what motivation he'd had to topple him from his position—

Abel: “My way of being remains unchanged. There is no altering that. My path towards retreat has been burnt down, a single path exists— You would do well, to sear this into memory.”

Vincent: “—I shall keep that in mind.”

To Abel’s words, Vincent quietly replied.

That was all it took to inflame the atmosphere of the room, which lent the illusion of rising temperatures. In fact, everyone, with the exception of Abel and Vincent, were still, sweat beading on their foreheads.

Abel: “Girl, Tanza, raise your face.”

After the standoff between the new and old Emperor, Abel called upon the girl who regretted her lack of strength. Slowly, the girl raised her head with tears welled up in her eyes, as Abel sighed.

Abel: “From the onset, I did not call upon your mistress with the intention of wasting her. Her use requires thoughtful consideration, valuable assets must be made use of optimally— People should die in an efficient manner.”

Tanza: “...Can I place trust in you in that regard?”

Abel: “Even if you do not believe me, that shall not change what I must do.”

Tanza attempted to cling onto her budding hopes, but that not-so-gentle response extinguished them.

Behind him, Al applied the back of his hand to his forehead, and Medium let out a sigh. However, after a brief hesitation, Tanza nodded her head.

Tanza: “Okay, I understand... Please, regarding Yorna-sama...”

Abel: “To fulfill that request, there are steps to be taken by your side. As it stands, I cannot merely stroll around this city.”

Al: “Yeah, that’s right. That’s what we came here for in the first place.”

Upon hearing the condition presented by Abel, Al seemed more lively as he spoke.

Presently, Al harbored fright for just about everything; it was possible to say that, for him, it was certainly a matter of life-or-death. It was imperative to get those chasing Abel and his allies, who were following Tanza's call to action, off their backs.

Tanza: "But, how did you know I was here?"

Abel: "I made my decision with the fact it was Olbart's doing in mind. Another possibility I considered, was that of him hiding in the Crimson Lapis Castle, but given the deployment of the pursuers, the matter of distance took precedence."

Tanza: "—Ah."

Abel: "Above all, you need to back off, for there are many lives currently in danger."

Taritta was being hunted by a hundred people, and they had pretty much been separated from Subaru and Louis as a result.

Neither of them had their lives guaranteed, as long as they continued to be pursued by such hordes. Of course, Abel, alongside the powerless Al and the Medium at half-strength who accompanied him, were no exception.

In order to continue the match against Olbart, Tanza's capture was a top priority.

Tanza: "...It is my loss, I guess."

Abel: "That much is obvious. But, there is no need to feel shame."

Tanza: "Eh...?"

Abel responded only that much to Tanza's sole muttered word, then turned his back to her.

Without hearing an answer beyond that, Tanza blinked her eyes open in surprise. A voice then called out, "Girl", to Tanza's back,

Tanza: "Vincent, sama..."

Vincent: "As that one has spoken, there is no need to be ashamed."

Tanza: “B-but, I...”

Vincent: “Lost. But, that means you threw the gauntlet— Just as I hoped.”

Tanza: “———”

Vincent spoke those words while looking on at a distance, his chin resting in his hand, which caused Tanza to widen her eyes. However, as she lowered her head, the corners of her eyes slowly pooled with tears.

While she cast her eyes downwards, shedding tears, those drops softly, gently fell, and,

Tanza: “Yorna-sama, I apologize... I was, immature...”

And so, in a tearful voice, she apologized to her beloved master.



And so, with a tearful Tanza behind them—

Al: “With this, can we assume that the attackers will back off for the moment?”

Abel: “Yes. Of course, it is possible Tanza’s crying is part of a scheme against us...”

Medium: “No way! That absolutely can’t be!”

Medium, cheeks puffed out and in an imposing stance, lashed out at Abel’s concern.

At that menacing look, Abel closed one eye and traced his finger across the forehead of the oni mask.

Abel: “So, it seems there has been no improvement in your condition, right?”

Al: “Guh...”

Abel: “If you become useless, I shall have no choice but to discard you mercilessly. Albeit you are Priscilla’s clown, do not believe that it absolves you. Keep that in mind.”



Illustration from Volume 29, coloring by Floating ([source](#))

Al: “I, get it... It’s not like I wanna be like this forever.”

Receiving that glare and a cold-hearted judgement, Al responded through gritted teeth.

There was no power in the voice of his response, Al’s fear had not abated. But regardless of Al’s physical and mental state, he would now be able to walk around.

Medium: “Then all that’s left is to resume the search for Gramps... Err, or would it be better to look for Taritta-chan? Or...”

Abel: “If the goal is to regroup, it would be ill-advised for us to act; Taritta’s eyes would find us much faster than we could find her. As for those fools...”

Medium: “H-hmm...”

Abel: “—In any case, we shall stick to our plan of looking for Olbart. If we do, we shall find them in the process of looking for Olbart. That is, if we succeed in finding «an abyss with a great view».”

Folding his arms, Abel murmured so, which made Medium widen her eyes in surprise with an “Huh?”.

Medium: “By any chance, Abel-chin, do you know where Gramps is hiding?”

Abel: “I have a guess on the second hiding place, at the very least. Crimson Lapis Castle.”

Al: “W-what are you saying? You mean, in that Castle?”

Abel: “Tanza’s reaction. When I brought up the subject of the Castle, she rapidly averted her eyes; Tanza herself was hiding in a traveling inn, but she must have known about Olbart’s hiding place as well. Although, it is not certain that she even had an inkling about the third hiding place.”

The procedure for Olbart and Tanza’s cooperation was that after Tanza delivered the message, Olbart would propose a game to Abel’s group. Then, after they discovered the first hiding place right behind them, the logical step was for Olbart to go outside and accompany Tanza to the traveling inn.

Of course, considering that Tanza could be apprehended, it was possible that Olbart had Tanza accept false information.

Abel: “The trick of hiding out in the Crimson Lapis Castle is also something to Olbart’s liking.”

Medium: “...Hm, I see. Well, we should go to the Castle as soon as possible.”

Al: “Yeah. We need to see that geezer immediately to get our bodies restored... If our bodies are restored, we should be fine. Same goes for bro and that pipsqueak if that happens.”

Clenching his fists tightly, Al grumbled this as if he were praying for it, as if he were cursing Olbart.

Al, having lost his mental capacity due to his own body having been shrunkened, held extreme hostility towards the sort of relationship between the disappeared duo of Subaru and Louis.

When it came to him, he would like to get Subaru to how he was before as soon as possible, to ponder over a normal decision regarding Louis. However, Abel was doubtful that Natsuki Subaru would make a normal decision upon returning to his original body— And before that.

Abel: “No matter what your thoughts may be, I have no intention of letting Olbart’s technique be undone so simply.”

Al: “Huh?”

Medium: “Eh?”

Abel: “To be precise, I shall not interfere with either you or Medium. However, I have no intention of allowing the technique on Natsuki Subaru to be dispelled for a short while. It would be best to keep him in that state for the time being.”

Upon hearing Abel’s plan, the two were left astonished, their eyes and mouths wide open.

Then, after a pause,

Al: “Q-quit fucking about! The fuck’s up with that? You didn’t say anything like that before!?”

Incensed, Al, his voice trembling with anger, grabbed Abel’s collar— or rather, as he could not reach it due to his height, the belly section of Abel’s clothes was grabbed, lashing out at him.

However Abel, his countenance unphased by that powerless threat, replied with “It is as I stated”,

Abel: "For now, I shall have him remain as-is, in his infantile form, for a while."

Al: "Bastard..."

Medium: "Is that related to why you were bullying Subaru-chin?"

Exerting more pressure, Al inched closer towards him, while Medium grabbed his shoulders from behind. As she posed that question, she stared fixedly at Abel.

Upon her inquiry, Abel quietly exhaled,

Abel: "I do not recall bullying him, or any other low-level behavior of the sort."

Medium: "Call it whatever you want! But, Abel-chin, you were trying to scare Subaru-chin on the way here, to get him to say something! Is it because of that?"

Abel: "-----"

Medium: "That's so unfair! If there's something you wanna hear, just ask and they'll usually tell you! It's because of something like that..."

Abel: "—Unfortunately, there is no way that shall happen."

Hearing the quiet, serene emotion in his voice, Medium could not help but stumble over her words, letting out only a "Eh?".

Giving a sidelong glance to Medium's surprised face, Abel brushed off Al's arm that was gripping him with ease, and spoke,

Abel: "My thoughts have nothing to do with the wickedness that Medium suggests. It is merely a necessary thing."

Al: "Necessary!? What the hell!? Why just bro... What about me and Lil' Miss Medium!"

Abel: "You do not meet the requirements. You possess one arm, and Medium's hair and eye color are the reasons for her."

Al: "Wha...!?"

Not grasping the meaning of that statement, Al's anger grew more and more intense. Medium, too, was left with a face that betrayed her lack of understanding of the true nature of Abel's intentions, while a surprise of different origin still remained on her face.

And, Abel's bottom line was---

Abel: "Even though the situation remains unaltered, the pieces are falling into place. Henceforth---"

Through his oni mask, Abel gazed out the window of a room in a traveling inn. Towards the outside, his eyes reflecting the Crimson Lapis Castle.

It was a gesture to stare at something far more symbolic than the Castle itself; and, in fact, Abel stretched his hand straight out as if to grasp something that could not be reached.

Abel: "---You shall accompany me, Natsuki Subaru. Blown by an unopposable wind, into the midst of war."



Olbart: "That's why that deergirl's with His Excellency."

Subaru: "-----"

Olbart answered calmly, sitting cross-legged with his short arms crossed. Hearing his astonishing answer, Subaru was simply left dumbfounded.

He was not surprised because it was outside the realm of his imagination, however.

Subaru: "I thought she'd be at their inn, in case she wasn't in the Castle..."

Olbart: "Oh, ya thought of it. Well then, boy, ya gotta have a terrible personality. Ya sure ya don't have some of that Vollachian Imperial Family blood in ya after all?"

Subaru: "That's really creeping me out, so don't say that..."

It was perhaps Olbart's comedic style, but not a single one of his jokes were really funny. As always, the person in question let out a "Kakakakka!". In fact, he appeared to be in a good mood, which was probably the secret of his long life.

Paying no mind to others, not allowing stress to build up, laughing quite often; he was the very example of it.

Subaru: "There's a saying in my hometown, that ill weeds grow apace."

Olbart: "Oh, a proverb, is it? What's it mean?"

Subaru: "Something like, the more you're hated, the longer you live."

Olbart: "Kakakakka! Well, I don't have an excuse for that. Ouch."

Louis: "Au!"

Louis's angry fist struck Olbart, who was laughing hysterically at the meaning of the saying. Though it was a simple smack on the shoulder, the effort put into just touching it had led to this scene.

Perhaps Olbart, as a member of the most powerful of the Empire, would deal with the smack however he wished, were it anything akin to hostility or murderous intent.

In that sense, Subaru's move in using Louis's teleport as a playful touch of pursuit rather than an attack had been the correct option. Yes, he should be proud of himself.

Yorna: "Anyway, I now know where Tanza is... I heard that the residents of the city have been very unkind to you and the others, and I apologize for that."

Subaru: "Huh, no, Yorna-san, stop it please! There's nothing to be sorry about!"

Louis: "Uu!"

Yorna bending her knees on the spot in apology caused Subaru to be flustered. Even Louis jumped up involuntarily at the significance of having Yorna bow her head.

In fact, Yorna had taken him seriously, had not backed down at all against Olbart, and had tried to help Subaru again and again, and so on and so on—

Subaru: “Uh...”

Yorna: “—? What’s the matter, child? Your face is so red.”

Subaru: “No, well, I just remembered some things...”

As the situation calmed down and the pain and suffering that had been pouring down like a nightmare receded, Subaru was reminded of the many times Yorna and him had exchanged a kiss, in those repeated moments of pain and suffering.

That memory had not remained in Yorna’s memory, and Subaru was not in a position to remember the feeling of the kiss itself, so he only remembered it as an event that had happened.

Still, honestly, he admired and liked Yorna a great deal for her willingness to kiss him in order to make it so he’d like her, just so a dying child could be saved.

And because of that—

Subaru: “I don’t want you to get mixed up in this.”

An increasingly stronger resistance to bringing Yorna into the fray, to bring her into a war that would destabilize the entire Empire, was welling up within Subaru.

He was unsure if this was only because he had been made younger, or if he would think differently once he was back in his proper body.

But even if Subaru thought differently after returning to his original body, he would not believe that what Subaru felt and thought in this young body would be wrong, either.

Because if that was the case—

Louis: “Uau?”

Subaru: “I don’t want to leave the answer regarding you to someone else completely, even if that person’s my grown-up self.”

The question of what to do with Louis, the young girl who held his hand, was a question that Subaru’s mind was not able to answer.

If they joined Abel and the others, that was definitely an unavoidable subject. However, at the end of those ten seconds of despair, there was one thing that Subaru could not help but feel.

—He did not wish to kill Louis or to permit Louis’s death, that much was clear.

Yorna: “The restoration of the Castle will have to wait. First, I’ll go to see Tanza.”

Subaru: “Ah... Yorna-san, um, about Tanza...”

Don’t be too harsh on her, but from Subaru’s point of view, that was difficult to say.

Even if he believed that she had her own agenda and thoughts, Subaru had not heard them. It was just that—

Yorna: “It goes without saying that I’d never scold her without asking her to explain herself. Moreover, if that girl’s been overcome by her own feelings, I’d be to blame as well.”

Subaru didn’t need to worry; the Mistress of the Demon City knew what she had to do.

Because she was exactly like this, was probably why a great deal of people, Tanza included, adored her.

Subaru hoped that if she would not suddenly become cold once he returned to normal, if possible.

Subaru: “I might cry if that happens...”

That was rather, seriously heartbreaking to imagine. Sincerely, he hoped it wouldn’t come to pass.

Anyhow, if Yorna could convince Tanza, the residents who had been chasing Subaru and his friends would withdraw. Subaru’s critical second step would start from there. But—

Subaru: “—There’s nothing scarier than dying.”

He told himself that, after going through such a horrifying experience, things were okay.

On top of that, Subaru also wanted to get out of the Castle with Yorna—

Olbart: “Wha, waitwait, boy. Why don’t I turn ya back? Or do ya like yerself better now? I don’t particularly mind if so.”

Subaru: “Oh, sorry, no, of course not. I’ll turn back, I’ll turn back, I’ll turn back alright. I mean, I’m getting used to being in this form, but I’m going to have trouble finding things to wear.”

Olbart: “Kakakakka! Ya got a lotta nerve worryin’ ‘bout that.”

Olbart called out to his back, and Subaru stepped on a roof tile and spun around.

In fact, although his body had been shrunk only for a few hours, he had exceeded the total number of deaths up until now, and so this became the body he had lived and died with the most.

He didn’t want to say it was because of that, but his small body felt like a bad omen, so if he could get back he’d like to get back to his normal size sooner rather than later.

Right now, the only thing that scared him was the possibility that his views might change abruptly, but—

Subaru: “Don’t worry, Louis. I’m going to face you properly.”

Louis: “Uau... Au.”

Louis cast her head down after Subaru’s words, but then she gave a deep nod. Subaru pushed on Louis’s forehead with a finger, directing her towards Yorna.

Louis’s back struck her, and Yorna took her in.

Yorna: “Child, what is Old Man Olbart doing...”

Subaru: “Hm, I don’t fully trust him, but I’d like to think that he’s at least got just barely enough humanity left in him to follow the logic of victory and defeat.”

Olbart: “Oiii-, I can hear ya, ya know.”

Subaru: "I know that, that's why I'm saying it."

Subaru smiled wryly in response to Olbart's teasing. To Subaru's answer, Yorna narrowed her eyes as she hugged Louis tightly.

Yorna: "If you understand that, then I have nothing else to say. I haven't been told what'll happen exactly, but this child and I will be watching you."

Louis: "Uh!"

Subaru: "Hmm, okay. Well, you know, I hope you'll be on good terms with me after this, Yorna-san."

Yorna: "—? Child, you're quite the worrier, aren't you?"

Being sent off by Yorna smiling at him and Louis's cheerful face, Subaru went to Olbart's side. Standing up, Olbart patted himself on the lower back, and spoke,

Olbart: "You're talkin' crap again. Oh geez, let's get this over with."

Subaru: "Yeah... Uhh, is it going to hurt?"

Olbart: "Did it hurt when ya shrank down? Then, that's the answer!"

Giving a brief answer to Subaru's hesitant question, Olbart's outstretched hand gently touched Subaru's solar plexus.

Abel had conjectured that Olbart's "infantilization" technique interfered with the Od, and perhaps that Od resided somewhere around the heart.

At the same time, a memory came back to Subaru's mind. The previous day, he had indeed received a painless blow from Olbart as he fled from the keep right beneath where he was currently standing.

Subaru's "infantilization" had occurred, with the interference of his Od as a trigger.

Only a few hours had passed since his body had been shrunken, but it felt like that had been the biggest struggle he'd faced since coming to the Empire. Although, ever since he'd been in the Empire, he'd been struggling to begin with.

Even including the time outside of the Empire, those ten seconds of despair were some of the greatest—

Subaru: “Oh, speaking of which...”

Suddenly, Subaru remembered something he had been attempting not to think about.

Those ten seconds of despair, that seemingly hellish cycle of rebirth and death, were a far cry from the Return by Death that Subaru had come to know.

What had brought this about, and what had happened to Return by Death, the Authority that resided in Subaru?

???: “*Found you.*”



—Everything that happened in that instant, was incomprehensible for all those who were present.

Olbart: “Ugh.”

Along with those words, Olbart withdrew his outstretched right hand in an instant.

But, too slow. Olbart’s wrinkled right hand, from the wrist onwards, vanished.

And then—

Yorna: “Chil—”

Louis: “Uau!!”

Her eyes widened in shock, Yorna pulled Louis into her arms and jumped backwards a great distance, hugging the girl struggling to break free.

Immediately afterwards, pure dark flooded Yorna and Louis's field of vision, and, in one fell swoop, swallowed the castle tower, the upper parts, and the middle parts of the Crimson Lapis Castle, famous for its majestic and bright brilliance.

And then—

Kafma: "Your Excellency! That is..."

Vincent: "——"

From a distance, looking at the scene outside the window, Kafma, at the side of the Emperor he served to protect, and harboring a sharp fighting aura, felt as if all the bugs in his body shivered in terror.

In the meantime, Vincent had stood up, turning his sharp gaze towards the Castle dyed in black, allowing his deliberate thoughts to flow with all the peace in the world. And then—

Tanza: "That's, the Castle... Yorna-sama..."

Al: "Ah, ahhh, AHHHHHHH—!"

Medium: "Al-chin!?"

In a daze, the children stared at what had happened bug-eyed, in absolute shock.

Tanza feared for her master, who remained in the Castle; and Al, at the damage dealt to the city, screamed louder than anyone in the city— no, louder than anyone in the world.

Medium dashed over to him and supported Al's shoulders. She stared at Abel as if clinging on to him in this inexplicable situation.

And then—

???: "Myyy- oh my, how should I put it... This might be, a small bit I didn't gaze."

Taritta: "You—"

A hellish world devoid of love; that, he knew.

That his own self was still loved; that, Natsuki Subaru knew.

However, at the same time, that not all forms of “love” should be something to be affirmed, that he also should know.

Exactly because of his ignorance, there would be retribution.

Exactly because of his ignorance, of why everyone dreaded it, ran from it.

—It morphed into a sable shadow, swallowing all things, cheering while destroying.

Cheering for reuniting, for coming together, for embracing, for being tied, for this predestination, for this forward march.

Cheering for confession, for regret, for suspicion, for its mysteriousness, for exaltation, for devotion.

A hellish world devoid of love, that he knew.

If he were to arrive at a world with love, what sort of hell would it be?

Subaru did not understand. He understood naught.

If there was something he could say, in this situation inexplicable to anyone, there was only one thing.

The utopia of those ostracized, the Demon City of Chaosflame.

—The ruin of this utopia, was brought about by the causality of none other than Natsuki Subaru.

Character Pages

Re: Life in a different

The only ability

...returns by the

Jorna

魔都カ
守護者として



Tanza

魔都カオスフレーム周辺の
出身者で、鹿人の半獣人。





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